

Cedarfield After Dark

A companion guide for adult readers of Harlan Coben's The Stranger (2015), for solo readers and book clubs.

Fan-made. Use alongside your own copy.

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Contains 56 chapters. Each chapter begins on a new page, so you can stop where you are without reading ahead.

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How to use this guide

Read a chapter of the novel first, then turn to that chapter here. Every chapter has the same parts:

- **What happens**: a summary in fresh words and a scene-by-scene list, to refresh your memory or catch what you missed.
- **Thirty questions**: moving from what happened, to how it's written, to what it means. Six are marked for book clubs because they start real disagreements.
- **Three close-reading exercises**: each tells you where to find the passage (chapter and scene, since page numbers differ by edition) and walks you through it step by step.
- **Ninety activities**: nine for each of the ten rooms, each taking 15 to 60 minutes, with a box to tick.
- **Six cross-room projects** with checklists, **three essay or writing prompts**, and **nine further readings**, all of which are real, published works.

You don't need to do everything. A book club might take two marked questions and one project per meeting. A solo reader might choose one room and follow it through the whole book. A student might work through all three close readings.

The website version adds interactive tools (sixty of them), a spoiler guard that hides later chapters, painted rooms with ambient sound, a narrator called Dot, hidden curios, seven secret rooms behind riddles, and a commonplace book that collects your notes.

A note on quotations

In copyright (© 2015 Harlan Coben). This companion quotes nothing from the novel; every summary and prompt is written fresh, and passages are cited by chapter and scene so you can find them in any edition.

The rooms of Cedarfield

The guide is organised as a walk through an invented New Jersey town at night. Each room is a place from the novel's world and a way of reading.

American Legion Hall

Main room · your ledger. Where it starts. Set your chapter, check your ledger, collect what you have found, and talk to Dot.

Draft night. Folding chairs in a circle, neon beer signs, a sticky bar, and a stranger who knows something.

Adam's Law Office

Close reading & style. Read like a lawyer reads a contract: slowly, for what each sentence is doing. Prose rhythm, voice, point of view, chapter endings.

A four-storey glass box on Midland Avenue, Paramus. One desk lamp still on after everyone has gone.

Room 233, Cedarfield High

Themes & ideas. Secrets, surveillance, the suburban dream, parenthood, money, trust. Track the ideas the novel keeps returning to.

A 1970s school gone grey, aqua trim fading. Corinne's homeroom, with a substitute at the desk.

Town Hall Records Room

History & the author's life. Coben's New Jersey, the internet of 2015, eminent domain, youth sport, and the real history behind the fiction.

Dented filing cabinets, a wall clock that runs fast, and the ranking that made Cedarfield proud.

Public Library Stacks

Sources & influences. What this novel is in conversation with: Ibsen, Hawthorne, Conan Doyle's blackmailer, suburban fiction, and Coben's own shelf.

Modern library, quiet aisle, one flickering tube. Somebody has left a mythology book open on a cart.

The Turnpike

Setting & geography. Bergen County to Beachwood, Ohio, to a lake past the Delaware. Maps, distances, places and what they mean.

Toll plaza lights at 2 a.m. Every journey in this book leaves a record somewhere.

The Lacrosse Field

Philosophy & ethics. Is it right to tell? What do we owe family versus everyone else? Weigh the novel's dilemmas with real ethical tools.

New turf under floodlights. Parents in folding chairs, fathers with crossed arms, a referee everyone is shouting at.

The Incident Board

Writing craft. How a Coben thriller is built: braided strands, short chapters, planted clues, misdirection and the turn.

A corkboard in a station back office: photos, index cards, red string, a coffee ring.

The All-Night Diner

Art & music. Seventies cover-band songs, Springsteen, suburban photography, night painting. Make the book's soundtrack and colours.

Chrome, vinyl booths and a jukebox that only plays the seventies. The coffee is free if you look tired enough.

The Price Kitchen

Food & making. What people eat in this novel says who they are. Cook it, make things, and talk about it at the table.

A granite island the colour of strong coffee, homework spread across the table, every light in the house left on.

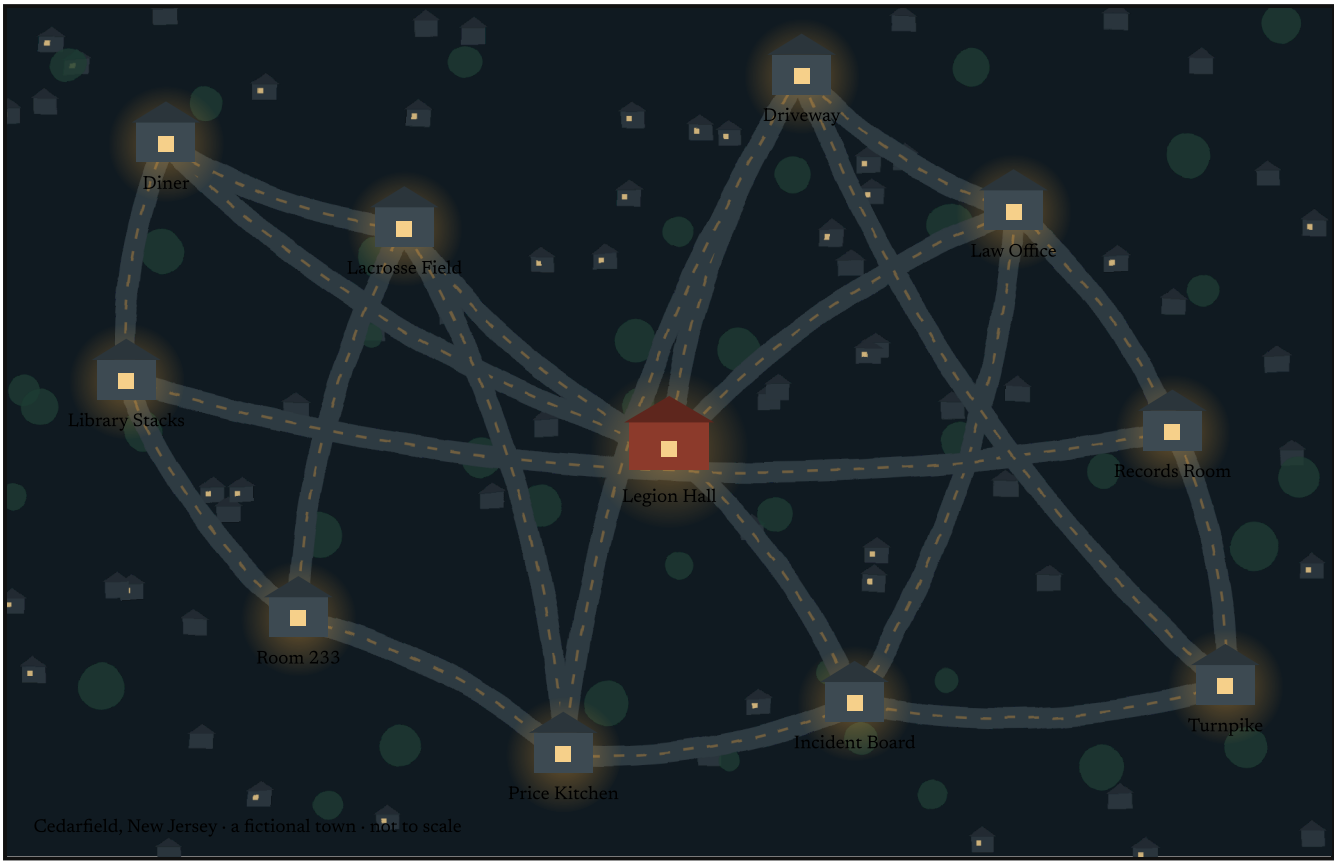
The Dark Driveway

Reflective journal. Sit in the car before you go inside. Your private journal, predictions, moods and the letters you would never send.

Adam's car in the driveway, engine off. Upstairs, both boys' windows glow.

Map of the town

Cedarfield is fictional. Lit buildings are rooms; roads show which rooms open onto each other.



Which room for what

- **Law Office**: Close reading & style. Next door: Legion Hall, Records Room, Incident Board, Driveway.
- **Room 233**: Themes & ideas. Next door: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Price Kitchen.
- **Records Room**: History & the author's life. Next door: Law Office, Library Stacks, Turnpike.
- **Library Stacks**: Sources & influences. Next door: Records Room, Room 233, Diner.
- **Turnpike**: Setting & geography. Next door: Records Room, Driveway, Incident Board.
- **Lacrosse Field**: Philosophy & ethics. Next door: Legion Hall, Room 233, Price Kitchen, Diner.
- **Incident Board**: Writing craft. Next door: Legion Hall, Law Office, Turnpike, Price Kitchen.
- **Diner**: Art & music. Next door: Legion Hall, Library Stacks, Lacrosse Field.
- **Price Kitchen**: Food & making. Next door: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board, Driveway.
- **Driveway**: Reflective journal. Next door: Legion Hall, Law Office, Price Kitchen, Turnpike.

Chapter 1 of 56 · told through Adam

1. Draft Night

What happens

The novel opens with a confession about memory. Adam Price, a lawyer and father of two, will later try to tell himself that his life came apart slowly, but the narration catches him in the lie at once: he knew from the first sentence a stranger spoke to him that something was over. We are in the Cedarfield's American Legion Hall in New Jersey, a wealthy commuter town whose bankers and fund managers like drinking cheap beer under neon signs because it lets them play at being ordinary guys.

It is draft night for the boys' lacrosse league, the evening when fathers decide which fourth-, fifth- and sixth-graders make the travel teams. Adam is only here because his wife, Corinne, the league's treasurer, is at a teachers' conference in Atlantic City. A thin young man in a baseball cap, pale and earnest with startling blue eyes, sidles up to him at the bar and tells him, in a voice that sounds almost kind, that he never needed to stay with his wife. Two years ago Corinne told Adam she was pregnant; then she miscarried. According to the stranger, none of it was real: the test, the sonogram, the growing belly were all fakes, bought to win him back.

Adam pushes back with what he saw with his own eyes, and the stranger knocks each item down before he can finish. He offers a way to check, a charge on the family credit card under an odd name, and then, as the league president, Tripp Evans, calls the fathers to their folding chairs, he leans close and suggests Adam test whether his two sons are really his. Then he is gone, leaving Adam with the sensation of a bomb whose timer has started.

Scene by scene

1. The narrator admits that Adam's later version of events, that it all fell apart gradually, is itself a lie.
2. Setting: the American Legion Hall, Cedarfield's rich men slumming at a sticky bar under beer neon.
3. A gaunt young man in a cap tells Adam he didn't have to stay with his wife.
4. Draft night explained: fathers choosing travel teams, Adam standing in for Corinne, the league treasurer.
5. The stranger claims Corinne faked a pregnancy and a miscarriage; he rebuts the test, the sonogram and the belly.
6. Tripp Evans, league president and former Madison Avenue ad man, calls the meeting to order and notices Adam's face.
7. The stranger names a credit-card charge as proof and calls himself a kind of liberator.
8. A parting suggestion: get DNA tests on the boys. The stranger leaves.

Who's here

Adam Price	Lawyer, husband, father of two boys; standing in for his wife tonight.
The stranger	Young, thin, blue-eyed, baseball cap, a hint of a tattoo; speaks gently and with total conviction.
Corinne Price	Adam's wife, lacrosse-board treasurer, a teacher; away at a conference.
Tripp Evans	President of the lacrosse league, a former advertising executive and a likeable host.

Thirty questions

1. What do we learn about Adam from the fact that he is standing in for his wife tonight?

2. How does the stranger describe himself, and what does his choice of role suggest about how he sees his work?
3. List everything the stranger claims was faked. How does the order of the list increase its force?
4. Where is Corinne, and why does it matter to the plot that she is away?
5. What job does Tripp Evans hold in the league and what did he do before?
6. What proof does the stranger offer, and why might he choose something Adam can check alone, at home?
7. The chapter opens by catching Adam in a lie he will tell himself later. Why might Coben begin a novel about deception this way?
8. How does the narration describe the American Legion Hall and the men in it? What tone is it taking toward Cedarfield?
9. Look at how the stranger speaks: gently, earnestly, almost kindly. Why make him sympathetic rather than menacing?
10. The chapter uses the image of a ticking bomb. What does that image promise the reader about the shape of the book?
11. Notice how the stranger anticipates Adam's objections before he finishes them. What does that tell us about how often he has done this?
12. Why does the stranger's final suggestion, about the boys, land harder than everything before it?
13. How long is this chapter? What does its length do to your reading speed and your expectations?
14. The fathers drag folding chairs into a circle. What other circles, rings or closed groups might the novel be interested in?
15. Who has the power in this scene, and how does it shift between the opening and the close?
16. **Is it ever kind to tell someone a painful truth they did not ask to hear? Does motive matter?** [book club]
17. **If a stranger told you this about your partner, would you check the evidence that night? Be honest.** [book club]
18. Adam is a lawyer. How might that profession shape the way he takes in an accusation?
19. What does the stranger seem to want? List three possibilities and the evidence for each.
20. **The stranger says Adam should be grateful. Under what circumstances, if any, could he be right?** [book club]
21. Why set the opening at a children's sports draft rather than, say, a bar in the city?
22. What does the phrase "living the dream", which the town will soon use, mean before anyone has said it here?
23. Which detail about the stranger's appearance would you remember if you had to describe him to the police?
24. **How does Coben make the reader complicit, so that we also start to suspect Corinne?** [book club]
25. What do you predict Adam will do in the next hour? Write it down before you read on.
26. **Is a lie about a pregnancy worse, the same, or less bad than other lies inside a marriage? Why?** [book club]
27. **The stranger suggests one lie implies others. Is that a fair inference about people?** [book club]
28. What is the effect of starting in the middle of a crowd, with an intimate secret delivered in public?
29. What does this chapter withhold from us that a different novelist might have told us straight away?
30. If you had only this chapter, what genre would you say the book belongs to? What made you think so?

Close reading

1. The lie in the first lines

Find it: Chapter 1, the opening paragraph: Adam's later account of how his world broke, and the narrator's correction.

1. Read the opening paragraph twice, once quickly, once slowly.
2. Mark the moment where the narration contradicts what Adam will later tell himself.
3. Note who is speaking: is this Adam, a narrator close to Adam, or someone looking back from after the events?
4. Write one sentence describing how the paragraph handles time (now, then, later).

Why does a novel about secrets open by showing its own hero deceiving himself? What contract does that make with the reader?

2. Rhythm of an accusation

Find it: Chapter 1, the middle: the exchange in which Adam lists what he saw (test, sonogram) and the stranger answers each item.

1. Find the run of short lines of dialogue where Adam offers evidence and the stranger dismisses it.
2. Count the words in each line. Where are the shortest?
3. Notice what the stranger adds that Adam has not mentioned.
4. Read it aloud with a partner, one taking each part, and note where the tempo quickens.

How does the shape of the dialogue, call and swift reply, do the work of persuasion before the content does?

3. The sting in the tail

Find it: Chapter 1, the close: the stranger's parting suggestion and his exit as the meeting begins.

1. Locate the final suggestion and the line that follows it.
2. Compare the stranger's tone here with his tone at the start.
3. Look at how the scene ends: who moves, who is left standing.
4. Note the image the narration uses for what has just happened to Adam.

Why save the cruellest suggestion for last, and why leave Adam with no chance to respond?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Read the first paragraph like a cross-examination transcript. The narration impeaches its own witness, Adam, before he has said a word. Note the comic precision of the social description, the beer neon and the bankers slumming, and how quickly it gives way to short, punched dialogue. Style here is pace: long observant sentences for the room, short ones for the wounds.

- [ ] **The first-sentence audit** (25 min) Copy the novel's first sentence in your notebook by hand. Then write three alternative openings for the same scene: one starting with the stranger's words, one with the setting, one with Adam's feelings. Which does the most work and why?

- [ ] **Dialogue tempo map** (30 min) Draw a line down a page. On the left, write Adam's lines in this chapter as one-word summaries; on the right, the stranger's. Mark which lines are questions. What pattern emerges in who asks and who answers?
- [ ] **Free indirect style hunt** (30 min) Find three sentences where the narration slips into Adam's own voice (slang, sarcasm, private judgement) without quotation marks. Rewrite each in a neutral narrator's voice and compare what is lost.
- [ ] **The ticking image** (20 min) Track the bomb-and-timer image. Note where it appears and how it is phrased (in your own words). Write a paragraph on why a cliché can be effective when used knowingly.
- [ ] **Social satire in a sentence** (25 min) Choose the sentence that best mocks Cedarfield's fathers. Identify the techniques: specific brand names, comparison, irony. Write your own sentence satirising a group you belong to, using the same tools.
- [ ] **Description of a stranger** (20 min) List every physical detail given about the stranger. Sort them into "would help identify him" and "tells us how to feel about him". What is the balance?
- [ ] **Reading aloud** (30 min) Read the whole chapter aloud, timing yourself. Then reread one paragraph slowly, pausing at every punctuation mark. Note where the prose wants to speed up.
- [ ] **Point-of-view swap** (40 min) Rewrite the chapter's final exchange (about 150 words) from the stranger's point of view. What does he notice about Adam that Adam can't see about himself?
- [ ] **Register sampling** (25 min) Find one example each of formal diction, slang, and comic exaggeration. Write a short note on how Coben mixes registers to sound like a smart, wry suburban man.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Every major idea of the novel is introduced in a single bar conversation: secrets inside marriages, the gap between a town's polish and its private lives, the ethics of telling, and whether a lie about the past changes the meaning of the present. Ask what the stranger thinks truth is for.

- [ ] **Concept map: the secret** (30 min) Draw a map with "the secret" at the centre. Branch out to who knows, who might know, who is affected, and what they stand to lose. Add to it as you read.
- [ ] **Kindness versus truth** (25 min) Write two columns: reasons the stranger's act could be kind, and reasons it is cruel. Then write a paragraph deciding which column is longer and why.
- [ ] **Theme sentences** (20 min) Write three one-sentence theme statements the novel might be about, each a claim not a topic (not "secrets", but "secrets protect the keeper more than the kept-from"). Revisit them at chapter 10.
- [ ] **The dream as setting** (30 min) Find every detail that signals wealth or status. What do these say about the life Adam stands to lose? Write 200 words on how a setting can be a theme.
- [ ] **Spouses as a team** (20 min) Adam will soon describe marriage as being on the same side. List what makes a married couple a "team" and what makes them two individuals. Where does the stranger strike?
- [ ] **Who is the stranger?** (15 min) Brainstorm ten possible identities for the stranger, from the plausible to the absurd. Rank them by evidence from this chapter only.
- [ ] **Lies inside lies** (30 min) The chapter opens with a lie Adam tells himself and centres on a lie Corinne allegedly told him. Write about the difference between self-deception and deceiving others.
- [ ] **Public and private** (20 min) The secret is told in a crowded room. Make a list of times in your life when private news arrived in public. How did the setting change it?
- [ ] **Prepare a seminar** (40 min) Choose two questions from the chapter list and plan a 20-minute discussion: an opening question, two follow-ups, and a closing question that connects to your own lives.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

The American Legion, founded in 1919, runs halls across America that serve as cheap bars and civic meeting rooms. Placing wealthy fathers in one is social comedy with a history: the novel was published in 2015, as youth travel sports and suburban affluence both boomed in northern New Jersey, where Coben himself grew up.

- [ ] **The American Legion** (30 min) Research when and why the American Legion was founded, and what its local posts are for today. Write a paragraph on why Coben might set a rich town's draft night there.
- [ ] **Coben's New Jersey** (30 min) Read a short biography of Harlan Coben from a reliable source. Note where he grew up and studied. List three ways his own background might show in Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Youth travel sports** (35 min) Look up how US youth "travel teams" differ from town leagues. Make notes on cost, time and who can afford them. How does this explain the fathers' intensity?
- [ ] **Lacrosse's origins** (40 min) Research the Indigenous origins of lacrosse, including the Haudenosaunee game. Write 200 words on what is lost or changed when a sport becomes a suburban status marker.
- [ ] **2015 context** (30 min) Make a timeline of the year 2013–2015: smartphones, social media, online privacy debates. Mark what a reader in 2015 would have taken for granted that a reader today might not.
- [ ] **Advertising men** (25 min) Tripp is a former Madison Avenue ad man. Read about the culture of New York advertising agencies. Note how persuasion as a profession might colour a character.
- [ ] **Atlantic City** (20 min) Research Atlantic City's history as a resort and conference town. Why is it a believable place for a teachers' conference and also slightly comic?
- [ ] **Publishing history** (20 min) Find the novel's first publication details: date, publisher, and where it reached on bestseller lists. Note where it sits in Coben's run of standalone thrillers.
- [ ] **Name auction** (15 min) Read the acknowledgments at the end of your copy (they don't spoil the plot) to learn how some names in the novel were chosen. Note which names you meet in chapter 1 and 2.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

An outsider arrives with a truth that will blow a family apart: this is the plot of Ibsen's The Wild Duck (1884), in which an idealist insists a household must live in truth. The title also nods, perhaps, to Camus, and the epigraph to Eliot. Keep a list of older stories this one is rewriting.

- [ ] **The Wild Duck** (40 min) Read a synopsis of Ibsen's The Wild Duck. Compare Gregers Werle, who insists on revealing the truth, with the stranger. Write down two parallels and one difference.
- [ ] **Title echoes** (30 min) Look up three other works called The Stranger or with "stranger" in the title (Camus, Highsmith's Strangers on a Train). Note what the word does in each.
- [ ] **The epigraph** (25 min) Find the epigraph at the front of your copy and its source in Eliot's choruses from The Rock (1934). Write in your own words what the lines warn about and how they fit chapter 1.
- [ ] **Domestic suspense** (25 min) List five novels you know in which a marriage hides a secret. What does each reveal first: the secret, or the fact that there is one? Where does The Stranger sit?
- [ ] **A blackmailer's ancestors** (45 min) Read Conan Doyle's "The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton" (1904). Note how Holmes judges a man who trades in secrets. Keep it in mind for later chapters.
- [ ] **Hawthorne's veil** (40 min) Read Hawthorne's short story "The Minister's Black Veil". Write about how a visible secret changes a community's behaviour.
- [ ] **Opening lines compared** (30 min) Collect the first sentences of five thrillers you own or can find in a library. Compare how many begin with a claim about time or memory, as this one does.

- [ ] **Oedipus and the urge to know** (30 min) Read a summary of Sophocles' Oedipus the King. What links a hero who insists on knowing with Adam, who now cannot stop himself from checking?
- [ ] **Your own source list** (15 min) Start a running list of works this novel reminds you of. Add one entry per chapter with a single sentence on why.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Cedarfield is invented, but it is modelled on the wealthy commuter towns of Bergen County. Atlantic City, a couple of hours south at the shore, is the excuse for Corinne's absence. Map the distance between where she is and where the secret surfaces.

- [ ] **Locate Cedarfield** (30 min) Cedarfield is fictional. Using a map of Bergen County, NJ, pick three real towns it might be modelled on. Justify your choice from details in the chapter.
- [ ] **Draw the hall** (25 min) Sketch a floor plan of the American Legion Hall from the chapter: bar, dartboard, chair rack, door. Mark where Adam and the stranger stand. Why does space matter here?
- [ ] **Shore and suburb** (15 min) Measure the distance between northern New Jersey and Atlantic City. How long a drive is it? What does the distance mean for how quickly Corinne could be reached?
- [ ] **Status geography** (20 min) Make a list of the markers of a wealthy US suburb (schools, sports facilities, lawns, cars). Find which are already present in chapter 1.
- [ ] **Night setting** (30 min) Write 150 words describing a community hall you know at night, borrowing the novel's method: one physical detail, one social observation, one wry joke.
- [ ] **Commuter towns** (30 min) Research how many residents of a typical Bergen County town commute to Manhattan. How does commuting shape a town's rhythms and relationships?
- [ ] **Insider and outsider** (20 min) Map who belongs in this room and who doesn't. Note what physical or behavioural signs mark the stranger as an outsider.
- [ ] **A sense of season** (15 min) Find clues to the time of year. Why might spring suit a story about the surface of suburban life?
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (20 min) Start a map of the novel you will add to every chapter, with pins for each new place and a note of what happens there.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

The stranger frames himself as a liberator. Is telling an unrequested truth a gift, an assault, or both? Separate the act (disclosure), the motive (unknown), and the consequences (not yet visible). Most ethical judgements of this chapter quietly assume answers to all three.

- [ ] **The right to know** (40 min) Write a short argument (300 words) for the claim that Adam had a right to this information. Then write the strongest objection.
- [ ] **Motive matters?** (30 min) Imagine three motives for the stranger: money, revenge, principle. Does the moral quality of telling change with each? Explain using one example.
- [ ] **Kantian test** (30 min) Apply Kant's idea that you should act only on a rule you could will everyone to follow. Could "tell people the hidden lies of their spouses" be such a rule?
- [ ] **Consequences ledger** (30 min) List the possible good and bad consequences of the stranger's visit for Adam, Corinne, the boys and the stranger. Weigh them. What can't you know yet?
- [ ] **Privacy and marriage** (30 min) Is there a sphere of privacy inside a marriage? Write about what, if anything, spouses may keep from each other.

- [ ] **Draft-night ethics** (20 min) The league uses rankings to choose children. Identify where fairness and favouritism might already be in play, even before chapter 2 shows us.
- [ ] **Gratitude and harm** (30 min) The stranger says Adam should thank him. Write a dialogue in which Adam explains why he can't.
- [ ] **Veil of ignorance** (30 min) Using Rawls' thought experiment, would you agree to a world in which strangers can reveal spouses' secrets, if you didn't know whether you'd be the deceiver or the deceived?
- [ ] **Personal stance** (20 min) Write a private paragraph: is there something you would rather never know? Why?

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A classic hook: a hidden past revealed in the first scene, a credible messenger, a checkable clue, and an escalation at the exit. Notice what Coben withholds: the stranger's name, his source and his reason. A thriller runs on what the reader wants to know next.

- [ ] **Hook anatomy** (30 min) Break the chapter into four beats: situation, disruption, escalation, exit. Write one line for each. Then sketch the same four beats for an original story of your own.
- [ ] **What's withheld** (20 min) List every question the chapter raises but doesn't answer. Rank them by how badly you want to know. This is the engine of the next 55 chapters.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (20 min) Make index cards for each concrete clue (names, a billing name, timing). Pin them up; you'll connect them as you read.
- [ ] **Messenger design** (25 min) Why is the stranger young, thin and gentle? Write down what would change if he were a menacing older man or a woman. Which version is scariest?
- [ ] **Exit lines** (25 min) Compare the chapter's last line with the endings of three short chapters from any thriller. What are the common moves?
- [ ] **Pacing by length** (15 min) Estimate the word count of chapter 1 and compare with chapters 2 and 3 when you get there. Start a chart; length is a pacing tool.
- [ ] **Scene from the bar** (45 min) Write a 250-word scene in which a stranger tells someone a secret in a public place, using the same structure: claim, objection, proof, sting.
- [ ] **Withholding vs cheating** (20 min) Discuss: when does a thriller's withholding become unfair to the reader? Note a rule you'd apply as a writer.
- [ ] **Characters by function** (15 min) Assign each character so far a story function (protagonist, catalyst, host, absent centre). Who is the absent centre?

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Picture the scene as a painting: harsh bar neon, a room of men in matching white T-shirts and caps, one figure who doesn't belong. Think about colour as character. What colour is the stranger? What colour is Cedarfield?

- [ ] **Neon palette** (45 min) Paint or collage the Legion Hall at night using only four colours. Pick them to express the mood of the scene, not realism.
- [ ] **A portrait of the stranger** (30 min) Draw the stranger from the description. Leave out his face, or obscure it under the cap. Notice how the description protects him from being seen.
- [ ] **Bar soundtrack** (25 min) Make a five-song playlist for a suburban dads' bar night. Then add one song that would play in Adam's head after the stranger leaves.
- [ ] **Hopper study** (25 min) Look at Edward Hopper's Nighthawks (1942). Write a paragraph comparing its isolation-in-company with Adam's position at the bar.

- [ ] **Group portrait** (20 min) Sketch the circle of folding chairs from above as a pattern. What does a circle mean as a social shape?
- [ ] **Typography of a secret** (20 min) Design a one-word title card for this chapter in a typeface that expresses dread. Explain your choice.
- [ ] **Cover thumbnail** (30 min) Sketch three cover ideas for the novel based only on chapter 1. Keep them original: no film stills or existing covers.
- [ ] **Sound of shock** (20 min) Describe, in 100 words, the sound inside Adam's head after the stranger leaves, using musical terms (tempo, dynamics, silence).
- [ ] **Photograph the ordinary** (40 min) Take three photographs of an everyday public place near you at dusk. Choose the one that looks most like a story is about to happen.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Food is barely present, only bottles of beer, but drink is doing social work: rich men choosing a working-class beer to perform belonging. Consider what your own town drinks when it wants to look unpretentious.

- [ ] **Unpretentious drinks** (30 min) Make a list of drinks and foods that signal "regular guy" in your culture. Prepare one and talk about why it has that meaning.
- [ ] **Bar snacks** (40 min) Make a simple bar snack (spiced nuts or popcorn) for your book group and use it as an icebreaker: everyone shares one place they act like someone they're not.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (45 min) Start making the treasurer's ledger notebook from the Maker's bench tool: fold and stitch the first signature.
- [ ] **Draft-night list** (20 min) Write a "scouting report" in neat ranked handwriting for an imaginary team of your own friends. Notice how ranking people feels.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Begin the secrets box (Maker's bench). Write chapter 1's secret on a slip in your own words and seal it inside.
- [ ] **Kitchen conversation** (30 min) Over a meal, ask: if a stranger told you a secret about someone you love, would you check? Note the range of answers.
- [ ] **Recipe of a scene** (20 min) Write a "recipe" for this chapter: ingredients (characters, setting, a secret), method (steps of the scene), serving suggestion (what it leaves you hungry for).
- [ ] **Menu for the book club** (20 min) Plan the menu for the first meeting, with something from a bar, something from a family kitchen, and something nobody can identify.
- [ ] **Hands-on hall** (45 min) Build a quick model of the hall from a shoebox: bar, chairs, door. Use it to block out where everyone stands.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Sit with the bomb image. Before you read on, note how you felt toward Corinne after these few pages, and toward the stranger. You'll want this first impression later.

- [ ] **First impressions** (15 min) Write a paragraph on what you think of Corinne, Adam and the stranger right now. Seal it in your journal; reread at chapter 30.
- [ ] **The bell you can't unring** (30 min) Write about a time you learned something you couldn't unlearn. How did it change how you looked at someone?
- [ ] **Where were you?** (25 min) Recall a moment when news reached you in an ordinary place. Describe the place in detail: what you remember and what you don't.

- [ ] **A letter you might send** (30 min) Draft a note to someone you trust telling them a hard truth gently. Notice what you choose to leave out.
- [ ] **Body check** (15 min) Note how you physically felt reading the stranger's accusations. Where did you feel it? Thrillers work on the body. Then write 100 words on why a story about a marriage can produce a physical response.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Write down what you think the credit-card charge will show and what Adam will do next. Add your reasoning and the one detail you are basing it on, then seal it in the Prediction log.
- [ ] **Self-deception** (30 min) The chapter opens with Adam lying to himself. Write honestly about one story you tell yourself about your past.
- [ ] **Trust inventory** (20 min) List the people whose word you'd accept without checking. What earned it?
- [ ] **Reading ritual** (15 min) Decide where, when and how you'll read this book. Set up the ritual, log it, and write a short paragraph on how setting (bed, train, bath) changes the way a thriller feels.

Cross-room projects

The Secret Ledger

Rooms: Room 233, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Set up a notebook with columns: secret, keeper, who knows, status.
- [ ] Enter chapter 1's secrets.
- [ ] Pin the clues from chapter 1 on your incident board.
- [ ] Write a private journal note about your first reaction.
- [ ] Commit to adding one line per chapter.

Cedarfield, Mapped

Rooms: Turnpike, Records Room, Diner

- [ ] Choose a real Bergen County town as a stand-in for Cedarfield.
- [ ] Research its demographics and school rankings.
- [ ] Paint a night map of your Cedarfield.
- [ ] Pin the Legion Hall and Atlantic City.
- [ ] Write a caption for the map in the novel's wry voice.

Opening Lines Workshop

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Incident Board

- [ ] Collect ten thriller first lines.
- [ ] Classify them: memory, action, voice, setting.
- [ ] Analyse chapter 1's first lines in that frame.
- [ ] Write three openings for a story of your own.
- [ ] Share and vote with your group.

The Ethics of Telling

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Read a short extract or summary of Sissela Bok on secrets.
- [ ] Apply the five ethical lenses to the stranger's visit.
- [ ] Hold a ten-minute debate.
- [ ] Write a private reflection on a truth you were glad, or sorry, to learn.

Book Club Night One

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Room 233

- [ ] Plan a bar-snack menu.
- [ ] Make a short playlist for arrival.
- [ ] Pick the two book-club questions.
- [ ] Assign each member a character to watch.
- [ ] Agree on the reading pace.

Sources Shelf

Rooms: Library Stacks, Records Room, Law Office

- [ ] Find the epigraph source and its date.
- [ ] Read a synopsis of The Wild Duck.
- [ ] Note one parallel in a paragraph.
- [ ] Add both to your reading shelf.
- [ ] Write the parallel into your commonplace book.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: The first chapter of The Stranger opens with a lie that its hero will tell himself. Argue how this self-deception prepares us for a novel about the lies we tell others.
2. Essay: Is the stranger a villain, a messenger or a moral agent? Using only chapter 1, build a case for one reading and acknowledge the evidence against it.
3. Creative: Write the same scene from Corinne's point of view at her conference, at the moment the stranger is speaking. She doesn't know yet. What is she doing?

Further reading

- *The Wild Duck*, Henrik Ibsen (1884). An outsider insists a family must live in truth; compare the cost.
- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). Holmes' verdict on a man who trades in secrets frames the stranger's moral position.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). The classic philosophical study of when concealment and revelation are justified.
- *The Stranger (L'Étranger)*, Albert Camus (1942). Another "stranger" whose title is a judgement; set the two side by side.
- *The Rock (choruses)*, T. S. Eliot (1934). Read the choruses the epigraph comes from, in a library edition.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben's breakout standalone: an ordinary man, a past that won't stay buried.

- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). The suburban marriage as a performance that cracks.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). A contemporary marriage thriller built on who is lying to whom.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). The sociology of "front stage" and "back stage" selves: a key to Cedarfield.

2. The Last Pick

What happens

Adam chases the stranger outside and is too late. The young man slides into the passenger seat of a grey Honda with New Jersey plates; the driver is a young woman with long blond hair who, under a streetlight, meets Adam's eyes with something like pity. Then Adam goes back in, because the draft is starting and his son's place on a team is the reason he came.

Corinne has left him a ranked list of every sixth-grade boy in her immaculate handwriting, so Adam only has to cross names off as they go. The house teams are picked; then four men sit down to fill the travel squads, where the real status lies. The head coach, Bob Baime, whom Adam privately calls Gaston after the preening cartoon villain, wants Jimmy Hoch on the B team over two boys with higher scores, citing Jimmy's parents' divorce. Adam, still reeling, refuses to let it go. He argues the numbers, then mocks Bob's supposedly perfect marriage, and the room goes quiet. Bob invokes his authority as head coach and wins; Adam leaves once he knows Ryan is on the A team.

At the bar, the police chief Len Gilman, who pours drinks to keep down drunk driving, hands him a beer. Tripp Evans joins him and explains the real reason for Jimmy's pick: Bob has been out of work for over a year, and Jimmy's father is the headhunter trying to place him. Tripp, a cheerful amateur philosopher, talks about how far people will go to protect their families, how ordinary decent employees let corporations hurt strangers, and how lucky they all are to be living the dream. Money, he says, is the root of all evil. Adam, thinking of the stranger and the wife who is away, answers that it isn't the root of all of it.

Scene by scene

1. Adam runs outside; the stranger leaves in a grey Honda driven by a young blond woman who looks at Adam with pity.
2. Back inside, Adam uses Corinne's ranked list to draft the house teams in a daze.
3. Background: Ryan must make the A team; Thomas was left off years ago because his parents weren't involved enough.
4. Bob "Gaston" Baime pushes Jimmy Hoch onto the B team over higher-ranked Logan and Jack, citing a divorce.
5. Adam objects with the scores, then with sarcasm about Bob's marriage. The assistant coaches look at the floor.
6. Bob pulls rank as head coach. Adam confirms Ryan is on A and leaves the circle.
7. At the bar, Chief Len Gilman serves beers; Tripp Evans tells Adam about Bob's job loss and the headhunter father.
8. Tripp's speech on protecting family, corporate cover-ups and money. Adam's reply: not all evil.

Who's here

Adam Price	Rattled, combative, fighting the wrong fight.
Bob "Gaston" Baime	Head coach and vice-president of the lacrosse board; loud, vain, out of work.
Tripp Evans	League president, genial suburban philosopher.
Len Gilman	Cedarfield police chief who tends bar at the Legion to prevent drunk driving.
The blond driver	A young woman in the grey Honda who looks at Adam with concern.

Ryan & Thomas Adam's sons, offstage: a sixth-grader who must make A, and a sophomore once left off.

Thirty questions

1. What does Adam notice about the car and its driver?
2. How has Corinne prepared Adam for the draft, and what does her list tell us about her?
3. Why does Adam care so much that Ryan makes the A team?
4. What reason does Bob give for choosing Jimmy Hoch, and what is the real reason?
5. Why does the police chief work behind the bar?
6. What does Tripp say about the car company employees, and what is his point?
7. The blond driver looks at Adam with pity. What does that single glance change about how we see the stranger?
8. **Is Adam right about the numbers, wrong to make the argument, or both?** [book club]
9. Why does Adam pick this fight tonight, of all nights? What is he really angry about?
10. How does Coben make Bob Baime comic and unpleasant at once? Find two techniques.
11. Adam nicknames Bob after a cartoon villain. What does name-calling do for Adam, and what does it cost him?
12. **Tripp says nothing here is pure. Is he describing Cedarfield, or human nature?** [book club]
13. How do the assistant coaches behave? What does their silence say about power in groups?
14. Adam left public defence for better-paid property law to pay for "the dream". What do we learn from that one sentence?
15. Compare how Corinne ranks boys on paper with how Bob ranks them by favour. Which system is fairer?
16. **If you were in the circle, what would you have said?** [book club]
17. What does the chapter suggest about parents who volunteer in children's sport?
18. Tripp asks what limits you'd break to keep your family safe. Why might the author plant this question so early?
19. **The mother lion image: is protectiveness a virtue that becomes a vice? Where is the line?** [book club]
20. Notice the shift from comedy in the draft to philosophy at the bar. How does the change of tone work?
21. What does "living the dream" mean when Tripp says it? Is he sincere?
22. Adam's final remark disagrees with Tripp. What else besides money might be a root of harm in this book?
23. How does a list of children's numerical scores become a moral battleground?
24. Which character in this chapter would you most trust? Least? Why?
25. **Is it hypocritical for Adam to be there only to protect Ryan's interests while attacking Bob for protecting his own?** [book club]
26. What is the effect of the chapter delaying Adam's reaction to the stranger's news and filling the time with a sports draft?
27. Find the moment Adam almost calls Bob "Gaston" aloud. What does the near-slip show?
28. How does the novel use the police chief's presence to make the town feel small and watched?
29. **What would the fathers in this room think if they knew what the stranger had just said to Adam?** [book club]
30. Write down one prediction about Tripp Evans and one about Bob Baime.

Close reading

1. A face in a passing car

Find it: Chapter 2, opening: the car leaving the lot and the driver's look under the streetlight.

1. Locate the short paragraph describing the car and its driver.
2. List the concrete details given (car, plates, hair, expression).
3. Find the single word that names her expression.
4. Notice what Adam does next and how quickly the scene cuts back inside.

Why does a glance of pity from a stranger unsettle Adam more than hostility would?

2. Argument as character

Find it: Chapter 2, middle: the B-team argument from Bob's announcement to his claim of final authority.

1. Mark each move Adam makes (numbers, a question, sarcasm about marriage).
2. Mark each move Bob makes (sympathy, rank, appeal to experience, minimising).
3. Note where the narration describes bodies: teeth, fists, chins.
4. Identify the turning point where Adam stops being reasonable.

What does the structure of this quarrel tell us about each man, and about what Adam is really fighting?

3. The suburban philosopher

Find it: Chapter 2, close: Tripp's speech at the bar about protection, corporate harm and money.

1. Summarise Tripp's argument in three steps in your own words.
2. Find his examples: what kinds of institutions does he name?
3. Notice how Adam responds: jokes first, then a serious reply.
4. Look at the last exchange and who gets the final word.

Read as a manifesto, what values does Tripp's speech reveal, and how comfortable should we be with them?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Coben stages an argument the way a trial lawyer might: evidence first, then rhetoric, then a cheap shot. The narration's nickname for Bob, borrowed from a cartoon, sets the comic register, while short dialogue lines keep the pressure up. Watch how sarcasm becomes Adam's style of evasion.

- ☐ **Moves in an argument** (30 min) Make a two-column table of every move Adam and Bob make in the B-team argument. Label each move (logic, emotion, authority, ridicule). Who uses which, and when?
- ☐ **Nickname study** (25 min) List every time the narration calls Bob "Gaston". Then rewrite one paragraph using only his real name. What changes in tone and judgement?
- ☐ **Gesture as meaning** (25 min) Highlight every bodily detail in the argument (teeth, fists, chin). Write a paragraph on how Coben uses gesture to show aggression without telling.

- [ ] **The pity glance** (30 min) Write 150 words expanding the moment of the driver's glance, slowing it down. Then compare with the original's brevity. Why is less more?
- [ ] **Tripp's voice** (35 min) Find three features of Tripp's speech (folksy phrases, rhetorical questions, examples). Write a short monologue by Tripp on a different topic in that voice.
- [ ] **Comic precision** (20 min) Find the funniest line in the chapter. Explain, technically, why it's funny (surprise, exaggeration, deflation).
- [ ] **Narrative compression** (20 min) Notice how the house-team draft is summarised in a few lines while the last B-team pick gets pages. Chart which events get the most words.
- [ ] **Dialogue tags** (20 min) Count how often Coben uses "said" versus other verbs ("pronounced"). Why does he make Bob "pronounce"?
- [ ] **Retell for a newsletter** (30 min) Write the B-team decision as it would appear in the league's cheerful email newsletter. Then note what the official version hides.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Fairness versus favour, numbers versus judgement, and the question that will hang over the whole book: what limits would you break to keep your family safe? Tripp's little lecture introduces the idea that decent people do harm when their own interests are at stake.

- [ ] **Fairness frameworks** (30 min) Define merit, need and loyalty as principles for selecting a team. Apply each to Jimmy, Logan and Jack. Which principle does the chapter seem to favour?
- [ ] **The dream, defined** (25 min) Write a definition of "living the dream" as Tripp uses it, then a second, critical definition as the novel might mean it by the end.
- [ ] **Protecting one's own** (25 min) Find three examples in the chapter of people protecting their own interests. Rank them from most to least excusable.
- [ ] **Money and motive** (20 min) Tripp says money is behind evil; Adam disagrees. Brainstorm other motives the novel might explore (shame, love, status, fear).
- [ ] **Volunteers and power** (35 min) Research the role of parent volunteers in local sports clubs. Write about how unpaid power can still corrupt.
- [ ] **Group silence** (25 min) The assistants say nothing. Write about the bystander effect and a time you stayed silent in a group.
- [ ] **Gender roles** (30 min) Bob sneers that Adam is "just" his wife's substitute. Discuss what the chapter shows about masculinity in Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Debate prep** (30 min) Prepare both sides of "Jimmy Hoch should be on the team" for a five-minute debate.
- [ ] **Theme tracker** (15 min) Add "protection" and "fairness" to your theme statements from chapter 1 and connect them in a sentence.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Youth sport in affluent American suburbs became intensely competitive in the 2000s, with travel teams, private coaching and college recruiters. Tripp's reference to car-industry cover-ups echoes real recall scandals of the 2010s; his misquoted proverb comes from the New Testament.

- [ ] **Travel-team economics** (35 min) Look up typical costs of US youth travel lacrosse (fees, travel, equipment). Write a short report on who can afford to play.
- [ ] **The headhunter** (25 min) Research what executive recruiters do and how they work. Why would a recruiter's goodwill matter to an unemployed executive?

- [ ] **Long-term unemployment** (35 min) Find statistics on long-term unemployment among professionals in the US after the 2008 financial crisis. How does this context shade Bob?
- [ ] **Recall scandals** (40 min) Read about a real automotive recall scandal of the 2010s from a reputable news source. Note what was known, by whom, and when.
- [ ] **The misquotation** (20 min) Look up the actual wording of the "root of all evil" line in a translation of 1 Timothy 6:10. Write about the difference between money and the love of money.
- [ ] **Police in the community** (30 min) Research the idea of community policing. Is a chief serving beers to prevent drunk driving good policing, or a conflict of interest?
- [ ] **Sports parent research** (30 min) Find one study or reputable article on parental behaviour at youth sports. Note one finding to bring to your group.
- [ ] **Coben and sport** (20 min) Find out which Coben series features a sports agent and why sport recurs in his work.
- [ ] **Rankings as history** (30 min) Look up the history of standardised testing and rankings in US schools. How does a culture of scores shape a town?

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Arthur Miller's All My Sons (1947) is the classic drama of a man who justifies harming strangers to protect his family business. Tripp's bar speech is a suburban rehearsal of that argument. Bob, the job-hunting father, belongs to the world of Death of a Salesman.

- [ ] **All My Sons** (45 min) Read a synopsis or a scene of Arthur Miller's All My Sons. Compare Joe Keller's defence with Tripp's speech.
- [ ] **Death of a Salesman** (35 min) Read about Willy Loman. List three ways Bob Baime echoes him and one way he doesn't.
- [ ] **The cartoon villain** (20 min) Watch or recall the Gaston song in Disney's Beauty and the Beast. What exactly does Adam's nickname accuse Bob of?
- [ ] **Suburban satire** (40 min) Read the opening of Tom Perrotta's Little Children or Richard Ford's The Sportswriter. Compare their view of suburban fathers.
- [ ] **Sports in fiction** (25 min) List three novels or films where a youth sports team carries a story. What do sports let writers show about communities?
- [ ] **Parables of protection** (30 min) Find a myth or folk tale about a parent who does wrong to protect a child. What does it suggest?
- [ ] **Nonfiction pairing** (40 min) Read an excerpt from Hilary Levey Friedman's Playing to Win on competitive childhood. Note one idea that illuminates the draft.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add All My Sons and one other work to your running source list with a sentence each, then write a short paragraph on which of the two speaks more directly to Tripp's bar speech.
- [ ] **Character types** (25 min) Identify a "type" for each character (blowhard, sage, fixer). Find a classic novel where each type appears.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The parking lot opens onto a town of streetlights and exits; the stranger's car vanishes towards the road. Inside, the hall is mapped as a circle of chairs and a bar: two zones of power. Sketch where each conversation happens.

- [ ] **Hall and lot** (20 min) Extend your floor plan of the Legion Hall to include the parking lot and exit. Mark where the stranger's car left.

- [ ] **Two circles** (20 min) Draw the circle of house-draft chairs and the smaller circle of travel-team selectors. How does the geometry of a room show hierarchy?
- [ ] **Town of exits** (15 min) On your Cedarfield map, mark the main road out. Where might the grey Honda be heading?
- [ ] **Wealthy and struggling** (25 min) Note any signs of economic difference among the fathers. Place them on a status map of the town (big houses, smaller houses).
- [ ] **Town institutions** (25 min) List the institutions already present: Legion, police, schools, sports league. Draw them as buildings on your map.
- [ ] **Night streets** (30 min) Write 150 words from inside the grey Honda as it leaves the lot. What does the town look like to outsiders?
- [ ] **Sports geography** (30 min) Find how travel teams move around a state for tournaments. Map a plausible weekend circuit from a Bergen County town.
- [ ] **Local landmarks** (20 min) Invent three local landmarks for Cedarfield in the novel's style and add them to your map.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 2 pins and notes to your running map.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is it wrong to use discretion for a struggling child? Is it wrong when the discretion secretly serves an adult's job hunt? This chapter isolates the difference between partiality that is kind and partiality that is corrupt.

- [ ] **Merit or mercy?** (35 min) Write 300 words deciding whether Jimmy should get the place, then 150 more considering what you'd think if you learned about the headhunter.
- [ ] **Hidden motives test** (30 min) Does an act become wrong if a selfish motive is concealed behind a kind one? Apply to Bob, then to a real-world example.
- [ ] **The protective instinct** (30 min) Evaluate Tripp's claim that anyone would kill to save their child. Is that a moral claim, a psychological one, or a threat?
- [ ] **Corporate ethics** (35 min) Tripp says the car executives were nice, normal people. Discuss the idea of the "banality" of institutional harm.
- [ ] **Sarcasm as ethics** (25 min) Is Adam's mockery of Bob's marriage justified by Bob's hypocrisy? Write an argument either way.
- [ ] **Consistency check** (25 min) Is Adam consistent? He's there to protect Ryan. Write a paragraph on when partiality is acceptable.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Use the Five ethical lenses tool on the B-team decision.
- [ ] **Role-play the circle** (30 min) In a group, replay the selection with a different outcome. What would it have taken for the assistants to speak?
- [ ] **Personal ledger** (20 min) Note a time you received or gave an unearned advantage. How did it feel then, and now?

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The chapter delays the emotional fallout of chapter 1 by dropping Adam into a different conflict. That displacement is a craft move: it shows character under stress and plants three figures (Bob, Tripp, Len) who will matter later.

- [ ] **Displacement scene** (30 min) Explain in a paragraph why the author delays Adam's reaction to the stranger. Then outline a story of your own using the same trick.

- [ ] **Plant list** (20 min) List every character or fact introduced here that you suspect will return. Pin them on your board.
- [ ] **Dialogue run** (45 min) Write a 300-word argument between two parents over a team selection, giving each a hidden motive the reader only half sees.
- [ ] **Comic relief or not?** (20 min) Mark the comic moments. Do they release tension or increase it?
- [ ] **Secondary character economy** (30 min) How many characters are introduced, and how does Coben make each memorable in a line? Imitate the technique for three invented neighbours.
- [ ] **Chapter endings** (15 min) Compare the endings of chapters 1 and 2. One is a bang, one is a quiet line. Which works better for you?
- [ ] **POV discipline** (20 min) We only see what Adam sees. List what a different narrator might have told us here.
- [ ] **Motif placement** (15 min) Note where the "protect your family" idea is planted. Predict how it will pay off.
- [ ] **Clue board** (15 min) Add the car, the driver and Bob's job loss to your clue board. For each, write what it could mean in two different stories.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Bob gets an imaginary soundtrack, a cartoon villain's anthem in Adam's head. Music as mockery. Think about the songs we assign to people we dislike.

- [ ] **Villain's anthem** (25 min) Write a short comic jingle (your own words) that plays in your head when a pompous person walks by. Notice how it changes how you see them.
- [ ] **The glance** (40 min) Paint or draw the blond driver's face in a passing car under a streetlight. Concentrate on the light.
- [ ] **Sports-parent portraits** (30 min) Make a caricature sketch of a sideline parent type. Keep it kind enough that they might laugh.
- [ ] **Colour of the circle** (20 min) Choose a palette for the draft circle (fluorescent, beige, white T-shirts). Compare with the chapter 1 palette.
- [ ] **A cartoon's afterlife** (20 min) Write about why Disney villains become shorthand in adult speech.
- [ ] **Bar photography** (30 min) Look at photographs of small-town bars by any documentary photographer. Describe one that matches the Legion.
- [ ] **Soundtrack builder** (15 min) Pick a song for this chapter in the Soundtrack builder and justify it.
- [ ] **Storyboard** (35 min) Storyboard the car leaving in six frames as if for an original film.
- [ ] **Typography of power** (25 min) Design the team list as a printed sheet. How would typography make the B-team look second-class?

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Beer again: here it is poured by a cop, shared between two men, and clinked in a show of friendship. Who buys whom a drink, and who controls the tap?

- [ ] **Beer and status** (40 min) Host a tasting of two cheap and two craft beers or alcohol-free beers. Discuss what people signal with what they drink.
- [ ] **Team snacks** (25 min) Make a simple orange-slice and granola tray, the classic youth-sports snack, and talk about the parent duties that come with a team.
- [ ] **Ranked list** (15 min) Write a ranked list of your favourite foods in perfect handwriting, then try to justify swapping one up for a "personal reason".

- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (20 min) Continue your ledger notebook: add a page listing who owes what to whom in chapter 2.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask at dinner: have you ever been passed over for someone with connections?
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Bob's secret to your box on a slip in your own words, and on the back write who you think would be hurt most if it came out.
- [ ] **Bar mats** (30 min) Make simple coasters from card with the town's fictional crest. Use them at your next book club.
- [ ] **Recipe of a quarrel** (15 min) Write a recipe for an argument (ingredients: tiredness, pride, a witness).
- [ ] **Hands-on draft** (40 min) With friends, run a mock draft of invented players using score cards. Notice how quickly favouritism appears.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam is ashamed and defiant at once. Think about a time you won an argument you shouldn't have started, or lost one you should have won.

- [ ] **Wrong fight** (25 min) Write about a time you picked a fight to avoid feeling something else.
- [ ] **Pity** (20 min) How does it feel to be pitied by a stranger? Write about a time it happened to you.
- [ ] **Protective instinct** (25 min) Who would you protect at someone else's expense? Write honestly and privately.
- [ ] **Mood check** (15 min) Rate your sympathy for Adam with the Mood dial, then write a paragraph on the moment in the draft argument where your sympathy shifted.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Write three predictions about Tripp Evans: one hopeful, one sinister, one dull. Note the evidence for each and log the likeliest.
- [ ] **Nicknames** (20 min) Write about a nickname you gave someone and what it said about you.
- [ ] **Letter to Logan** (20 min) Write an imaginary note to Logan, the boy who didn't make the team.
- [ ] **Living the dream?** (25 min) List what "the dream" means in your life. Which parts did you choose?
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session, then write 100 words on where you were when you read the B-team argument and how the setting coloured it.

Cross-room projects

The Draft Tribunal

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Incident Board

- [ ] Summarise the three boys' cases in neutral terms.
- [ ] Apply merit, need and loyalty principles.
- [ ] Run a mock tribunal in your group with roles.
- [ ] Record the verdict and dissent.
- [ ] Pin the outcome to your incident board.

Protecting Your Own

Rooms: Library Stacks, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Read a synopsis of All My Sons.
- [ ] List Tripp's arguments in chapter 2.
- [ ] Compare the two in a page.
- [ ] Write a private reflection on your own protective lines.
- [ ] Revisit after chapter 32.

Cost of the Game

Rooms: Records Room, Turnpike, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research travel-team costs.
- [ ] Map a tournament weekend.
- [ ] Budget it as a family.
- [ ] Discuss who is excluded at your next meal.

Voice Workshop

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Diner

- [ ] Analyse Tripp's and Bob's speech patterns.
- [ ] Write a monologue for each.
- [ ] Read them aloud to the group.
- [ ] Give each a theme song.
- [ ] Note how voice creates character.

The Pity Glance

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the car paragraph.
- [ ] Paint the driver's face.
- [ ] Write the moment from her side.
- [ ] Reflect on being pitied.

Town Institutions Map

Rooms: Turnpike, Records Room, Room 233

- [ ] List institutions in chapters 1–2.
- [ ] Draw them on your town map.
- [ ] Research each real-world counterpart.
- [ ] Annotate who holds power in each.
- [ ] Add one sentence on how each could hide a secret.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse how chapter 2 uses a children's team selection to explore adult self-interest. How does the B-team argument comment on the larger story of chapter 1?

2. Essay: "Nothing here is pure." Evaluate Tripp Evans's worldview as presented in his bar speech, and argue whether the novel invites us to share it.
3. Creative: Write the draft scene from Bob Baime's point of view, including what he knows that Adam doesn't.

Further reading

- *All My Sons*, Arthur Miller (1947). The drama of a decent man who harms strangers to protect his own.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A father undone by job loss and the image of success.
- *Playing to Win: Raising Children in a Competitive Culture*, Hilary Levey Friedman (2013). Sociology of competitive childhood in affluent families.
- *Game On*, Tom Farrey (2008). Journalism on the high-stakes world of US youth sport.
- *Little Children*, Tom Perrotta (2004). Suburban parents behaving badly, comically and sadly.
- *The Sportswriter*, Richard Ford (1986). A wry male narrator in a New Jersey suburb.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). How class shapes children's organised activities.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). A clear introduction to fairness, merit and what we owe one another.
- *Deal Breaker*, Harlan Coben (1995). Coben's first Myron Bolitar novel, set in the world of sport.

3. Novelty Funsy

What happens

In the dark parking lot Adam sits in his car without moving. Corinne texts, eager for news of the draft. Bob Baime knocks on the window for a show of no hard feelings, and Adam can't resist a jab about his job hunt. Adam drives the 2.6 miles home (Corinne measured it with her odometer when she took up running) to a house with every light burning and Jersey, the border collie, ecstatic at the door.

Looking at his sons, Adam fights the stranger's poison. Thomas, the sophomore, is his double down to an oddly long second toe. Ryan, asleep with a fantasy novel on his chest, looks like his mother. Adam reflects on all the lessons about stranger danger they gave the boys, and on a time he read Thomas's private messages and regretted it. He tells himself a lawyer's rule: don't trust your gut, do the research. On the shared family computer he finds the charge on the "business" credit card from just over two years ago, $387.83 to a company called Novelty Funsy. He remembers asking about it; Corinne said it was classroom decorations the school would repay. Online the name returns nothing at all.

He phones the card company. A representative explains that some merchants bill under discreet names and promises a detailed receipt by email. Thomas interrupts: he needs a ride to a friend's house for practice shorts, and wants to drive on his learner's permit. At Justin's, his mother Kristin Hoy, a maths teacher at Corinne's school and a competitive fitness model who trains with Corinne, chats at the car window. On the way home Thomas jokes about her; Adam's phone buzzes with the bank's email. The billing name belongs to a website called Fake-A-Pregnancy.com.

Scene by scene

1. Adam sits frozen in the dark lot; Corinne texts asking how the draft went.
2. Bob knocks for a handshake; Adam needles him about the job search.
3. Adam texts Corinne that Ryan made A; she promises to call.
4. Home: every light on, Jersey the dog, Thomas who looks like Adam, Ryan asleep who looks like Corinne.
5. Reflections on stranger danger, and on Adam's guilt about once reading Thomas's messages.
6. The shared computer: browser history, then the business Visa and a $387.83 charge to Novelty Funsy.
7. No search results; a call to the card company and a promised itemised receipt.
8. Thomas needs a lift for practice shorts; Kristin Hoy at the door; jokes on the drive.
9. The email arrives: Novelty Funsy is Fake-A-Pregnancy.com.

Who's here

Adam Price	Trying to be a lawyer about his own marriage.
Thomas Price	Sophomore, looks like Adam, new learner's permit, mayor-of-the-town charm.
Ryan Price	Sixth-grader, rule-follower, reader, looks like Corinne.
Jersey	The border collie, always ready to go out.
Kristin Hoy	Maths teacher at Corinne's school, competitive fitness model, Corinne's training partner.
Bob Baime	Apologises in the lot, stiffens at the job jab.

Thirty questions

1. What does Adam do in the parking lot before he drives home?
2. How far is the drive home, and how does Adam know?
3. Which son does Adam think looks like him, and which like Corinne?
4. What did Corinne say the Novelty Funsy charge was for?
5. Who is Kristin Hoy, and what is her connection to Corinne?
6. What does the bank's email reveal?
7. **Adam says listening to your gut means being fooled with more certainty. Do you agree?** [book club]
8. Why does the chapter dwell on the house lights being left on?
9. How does the irony of "stranger danger" lessons work in this chapter?
10. Adam once read Thomas's messages. Why include this story now?
11. **Was Adam wrong to read his son's messages? Was he right not to confront him?** [book club]
12. What does the shared family computer represent in this household?
13. Why does the chapter make us wait for the email by inserting the drive to Justin's?
14. How does Coben write the teenage voice? Find two lines that sound authentic.
15. Thomas finds Kristin annoying. What does the chapter suggest about how teenagers judge adults?
16. Notice how Adam treats the card representative's jargon. What does it say about his mood?
17. What do Corinne's texts reveal about her eagerness and her priorities?
18. **Adam asks whether finding out Ryan wasn't his would change his love. What do you think the honest answer is for most parents?** [book club]
19. How do the "business" and "personal" credit cards reflect the way this marriage runs?
20. **Why might discreet billing exist? Is it a service or a cover?** [book club]
21. What small details show Corinne's personality even though she's absent?
22. How does Adam use humour to manage his fear? Find an example.
23. **Is Adam investigating or snooping? Where is the line?** [book club]
24. What does the dog add to this chapter?
25. Describe the domestic geography: who is where in the house and what are they doing?
26. How does the chapter build to its final reveal? Map the steps.
27. What does the name Novelty Funsy suggest, and why is it a clever cover?
28. Kristin's fridge pictures: what do they suggest about how she sees herself?
29. **Which line in this chapter would you underline, and why?** [book club]
30. Predict: will Adam confront Corinne tonight, tomorrow, or later? Why?

Close reading

1. Looking for yourself in a child

Find it: Chapter 3, early: Adam looking at Thomas on the stairs and then at Ryan asleep.

1. Find the two moments where Adam studies each son.
2. List the physical features he notices in each case.
3. Find where his thoughts turn to the stranger's suggestion.
4. Locate the sentence where he steps back from philosophising.

How does the chapter make the most ordinary parental act, looking at your child, feel suddenly dangerous?

2. The ethics of the shared screen

Find it: Chapter 3, middle: the home-office nook and the memory of reading Thomas's Facebook messages.

1. Identify why the family computer was put in a public room and why it moved.
2. Summarise the Facebook episode in three sentences.
3. Find Adam's conclusion about what he should have done.
4. Connect it to what he is about to do with the credit card.

How does this flashback prepare us to judge Adam's investigation of his wife?

3. Comedy before the blow

Find it: Chapter 3, close: the drive back from Justin's and the email's top line.

1. Read the exchange between Adam and Thomas about Kristin.
2. Note how Adam tries not to laugh while disapproving.
3. Find the moment the phone vibrates.
4. Look at how the final reveal is formatted on the page.

Why place a joke immediately before the worst news of the chapter?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Adam's legal mantra, do the work, do the research, gives the chapter its procedural rhythm: one check, one result, next step. Watch how the prose alternates domestic comedy (teen code, the dog at the door) with forensic steps, so the reveal lands mid-laugh.

- ☐ **Procedure as prose** (25 min) List each investigative step Adam takes. Write a paragraph on how a procedural structure creates suspense even in domestic scenes.
- ☐ **Teen code** (20 min) Find the "teen code" jokes. Write three more in the same format from your own household or memory.
- ☐ **Free indirect fatherhood** (30 min) Identify two passages where narration becomes Adam's private voice about his sons. Rewrite one in first person. Which is more intimate?
- ☐ **The reveal on the page** (25 min) Notice how the final email line is set apart. Experiment by rewriting the ending three ways (mid-paragraph, as dialogue, as a single word). Compare effects.
- ☐ **Representative voice** (20 min) Analyse the card representative's speech. How does Coben make a minor character comic in two lines?
- ☐ **Kristin in description** (25 min) List every adjective used for Kristin. What attitudes (Adam's, the narrator's, the town's) are mixed in?
- ☐ **Rhythm of interruption** (20 min) Map where Adam is interrupted in this chapter. Write about how interruption builds tension.
- ☐ **Parenthesis and asides** (20 min) Find asides and parentheses. Do they slow or speed the reading?
- ☐ **Paraphrase drill** (15 min) Paraphrase the chapter's key reflection on gut instinct in under twenty words without using any of the original phrasing.

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Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Privacy and surveillance inside a family: the public computer, the read messages, the parental lessons about strangers. The chapter quietly asks whether Adam's search of his wife's purchases is different in kind from reading his son's messages.

- [ ] **Privacy map** (25 min) Draw concentric circles: self, marriage, children, town. Place each privacy breach in the chapter in a ring.
- [ ] **Gut versus evidence** (35 min) Write a short essay on when intuition is reliable. Use Adam's claim as your starting point.
- [ ] **Stranger danger** (35 min) Research the history of "stranger danger" education. Most harm to children comes from known adults. How does this fact resonate with the novel's title?
- [ ] **Paternity anxiety** (30 min) Discuss, in a group or in writing, why the stranger's suggestion about the boys hurts so much, and whether biology should matter to fatherhood.
- [ ] **Household systems** (20 min) Analyse the family's "business" and "personal" cards as a symbol of how they divide life. What systems run your household?
- [ ] **Surveillance spectrum** (25 min) Rank: shared family computer, reading messages, checking card statements, tracking apps. Which are acceptable?
- [ ] **Theme sentences** (15 min) Update your theme statements with "privacy". Draft one new claim.
- [ ] **Women's bodies** (30 min) Kristin's body is constantly assessed by men and boys. Discuss how the chapter presents this and whether it critiques or reproduces it.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (30 min) Pick the two book-club questions and plan a 20-minute discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

By 2015 most US families did banking online and many shared one household computer. Discreet billing names, which hide what was bought on a statement, were a standard feature of online retail. This is the technology that both protects and betrays Corinne.

- [ ] **Discreet billing** (25 min) Research how and why online retailers use alternative billing names. Write a short factual note.
- [ ] **Teen driving in NJ** (20 min) Look up New Jersey's graduated driver licensing rules for teenagers. Was Thomas legal?
- [ ] **Family computers** (30 min) Find articles from the 2000s advising parents to put computers in family rooms. How did smartphones change this?
- [ ] **Fitness competitions** (25 min) Research the WBFF and fitness-model competitions. What do they judge?
- [ ] **Riordan and myth** (20 min) Find out when the Percy Jackson books began and why Greek myth is popular with children.
- [ ] **Online banking history** (20 min) When did online banking become mainstream in the US? Find a statistic.
- [ ] **Children's privacy law** (30 min) Read about COPPA, the US law on children's online privacy (1998). Who does it protect?
- [ ] **Learner's permits** (20 min) Compare teen-driving rules in two US states or two countries.
- [ ] **Coben on parenting** (25 min) Find an interview where Coben talks about parenting and technology.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Poe's "The Purloined Letter" hides a secret in plain sight, as Corinne hid a $387.83 charge among household bills. Coben's own Hold Tight (2008) asks whether parents should spy on their children's computers.

- [ ] **The Purloined Letter** (40 min) Read Poe's story. Write a paragraph comparing hiding in plain sight with a discreet charge on a bill.
- [ ] **Hold Tight** (30 min) Read a synopsis of Coben's Hold Tight. Compare its parents' spyware with Adam's reading of messages.
- [ ] **Percy Jackson** (30 min) Read the first chapter of a Percy Jackson book. What does Ryan's reading suggest about him?
- [ ] **Fathers in fiction** (30 min) List three novels where a father doubts a child's paternity. How does each resolve it?
- [ ] **Domestic noir** (20 min) Read a definition of "domestic noir" (a term popularised in the 2010s). Note which features chapter 3 shows.
- [ ] **Teen voice** (25 min) Compare Thomas's dialogue with a teenager in another novel you know.
- [ ] **Solove** (35 min) Read a short excerpt from Daniel Solove on reputation and privacy online.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works to your running list, each with a paragraph explaining the connection to chapter 3.
- [ ] **Poe's Dupin** (20 min) Note how Dupin reasons in Poe's story. Compare with Adam's "do the research".

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Count the geography: 2.6 miles from the Legion to home, four blocks to Justin's. Cedarfield is small enough to measure with an odometer and to drive with a learner's permit. Smallness is safety and surveillance at once.

- [ ] **Measured town** (20 min) Mark the 2.6-mile route from the Legion to the Price house and the four blocks to Justin's on your map.
- [ ] **House plan** (30 min) Sketch the Price house as described so far: stairs, bedrooms, the "home office" nook, the front door.
- [ ] **Commercial strip** (15 min) Note the shops mentioned (coffee-and-ice-cream combo, petrol station). Add them to your map.
- [ ] **Suburban night** (30 min) Walk or drive your own neighbourhood at night and note which houses keep every light on.
- [ ] **Atlantic City distance** (15 min) Estimate how quickly Corinne could drive home from the shore if she wanted to, and what it means that she doesn't. Write a paragraph on distance as a measure of emotional reach in the novel so far.
- [ ] **Kristin's house** (20 min) Imagine and sketch the Hoy house from Thomas's description.
- [ ] **Map of trust** (20 min) Overlay your map with who trusts whom. Draw lines.
- [ ] **Learner route** (15 min) Plan a learner driver's safe route around a suburb. What makes a route "safe"?
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 3 to your running map with pins for the house, Justin's and the route home, and annotate each with the scene it hosts.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Snooping for safety, investigating for truth, invading privacy: the chapter draws three lines and lets Adam cross them. Is he justified in searching joint accounts? Does the earlier Facebook episode make him a hypocrite or a wiser man?

- [ ] **Snoop or investigate?** (35 min) Write a 300-word argument on whether Adam is entitled to search his wife's old charges.
- [ ] **Parental privacy** (20 min) Use the Dilemma scale tool on reading a teenager's messages.
- [ ] **Kantian check** (25 min) Could "parents may read children's messages when worried" be a universal rule?
- [ ] **Care ethics** (25 min) How would care ethics weigh Thomas's privacy against Adam's fear?
- [ ] **White lies to children** (25 min) Adam tells Ryan the email hasn't gone out. Is a white lie to a child ever right?
- [ ] **Gut and judgement** (20 min) Is acting on intuition a moral failing if you could check the facts?
- [ ] **Teasing and respect** (20 min) Thomas mocks Kristin. Where is the line between teenage humour and disrespect?
- [ ] **Biology and love** (30 min) Write a reasoned paragraph: does genetics matter to fatherhood?
- [ ] **Court of one** (25 min) Write a verdict on Adam's conduct tonight as a judge would.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A textbook escalation ladder: a text, a charge, a dead search, a phone call, a delay, a reveal. Coben inserts a mundane errand to stretch time, and ends on a website name formatted like a slap.

- [ ] **Escalation ladder** (20 min) Draw the six-step ladder of this chapter's investigation and note how long each step takes on the page.
- [ ] **Delay devices** (35 min) List the devices Coben uses to delay the reveal. Use two of them in a scene of your own.
- [ ] **Character in a line** (15 min) Pick three minor characters and identify the single line that defines each.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Add Novelty Funsy, the business card and the classroom-decorations excuse to your board. Connect each with string to anything from chapters 1–2 and justify each link.
- [ ] **Reversal** (40 min) Write a 250-word scene where a character checks an alibi and finds it false, ending on the evidence itself.
- [ ] **Pacing chart** (15 min) Add chapter 3's length to your pacing chart and compare the number of scenes per chapter so far. Write a note on how Coben speeds up and slows down.
- [ ] **Joke placement** (20 min) Find where humour sits relative to dread. Plot them on a line.
- [ ] **Kristin as plant** (15 min) What might Kristin know? List three possibilities.
- [ ] **POV limits** (15 min) What does Adam not notice that a reader might? List anything you caught.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A suburban house at night with every light left on is one of the novel's images. Painters from Hopper to Crewdson used lit windows to suggest lives on display and secrets inside.

- [ ] **Every light on** (45 min) Paint a suburban house at night with every window lit. Leave one dark.
- [ ] **Dog portrait** (25 min) Draw Jersey blocking the door.
- [ ] **Photograph a screen** (20 min) Photograph a glowing screen in a dark room. What mood does it set?
- [ ] **Brand names** (30 min) Collect the brand names in this chapter. Make a collage that captures Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Mood colours** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool for chapter 3, then paint a small swatch card of those colours and title it.
- [ ] **Sound sketch** (20 min) Describe in 100 words the sounds of the house at night: computer hum, dog, shower.

- [ ] **Fitness imagery** (25 min) Look at how fitness-competition photography poses bodies. Write a short critical note.
- [ ] **Song for the drive** (15 min) Pick a song for the four-block drive with Thomas and one for the moment the email arrives. Write about the contrast.
- [ ] **Typeface for a fake** (30 min) Design a logo for a fictional "discreet" company. What fonts suggest innocence?

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

The kitchen is offstage tonight but the house's routines are everywhere: the dog's water bowl, the bedtime rules, the practice shorts. Domestic logistics are the texture of the "dream".

- [ ] **Family logistics board** (25 min) Make a kitchen whiteboard of a family's week: practices, homework, dog walks. Notice how full it is.
- [ ] **Daddy-eggs preview** (25 min) Try the Mustard-and-Parmesan Scramble recipe card in preparation for chapter 5.
- [ ] **Household rules** (20 min) Write the house rules you grew up with (bedtimes, screens, lights). Share at dinner.
- [ ] **Practice kit** (15 min) Lay out a teenager's sports kit and discuss the parental labour behind it.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Add a page for the Novelty Funsy charge: date, amount, explanation given, truth.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you check your partner's card statements if a stranger told you to?
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Corinne's "classroom decorations" cover story to your box in your own words, along with how plausible it would have sounded to you at the time.
- [ ] **Password card** (20 min) Start the family password card project from the Maker's bench.
- [ ] **Dog treats** (40 min) Bake simple dog biscuits (oats, peanut butter, banana) in honour of Jersey.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam stares at his phone in the dark car as though the text hides a message. Most of us have read a message too many times looking for what isn't there.

- [ ] **Rereading messages** (20 min) Write about a message you reread looking for hidden meaning.
- [ ] **Your double** (25 min) Who in your family looks like you? Write about what resemblance means to you.
- [ ] **Privacy you took** (25 min) Write privately about a time you looked at something you shouldn't have.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread and trust in Corinne for chapter 3, then write a paragraph explaining the gap between your two numbers.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict what the website will show in chapter 4 and how Adam will react. Log it with your reasons.
- [ ] **Lights on** (15 min) What does a house with every light on mean to you: safety, waste, love?
- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (25 min) Write a note to Thomas from his father about the messages he read.
- [ ] **Gut check** (20 min) Recall a time your gut was wrong. What did you learn?
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session and write about the moment in the chapter where you most wanted to stop reading, and why you didn't.

Cross-room projects

Family Privacy Charter

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Price Kitchen

- [ ] List the privacy breaches in chapters 1–3.
- [ ] Discuss which are justified.
- [ ] Draft a household privacy charter.
- [ ] Share it at a family or club meal.
- [ ] Revisit after chapter 20.

Paper Trail

Rooms: Records Room, Incident Board, Law Office

- [ ] Research discreet billing.
- [ ] Map Adam's investigative steps.
- [ ] Write a forensic note on the charge.
- [ ] Pin it to your board.

Hidden in Plain Sight

Rooms: Library Stacks, Law Office, Diner

- [ ] Read Poe's "The Purloined Letter".
- [ ] Close-read the computer scene.
- [ ] Design a "discreet" logo.
- [ ] Write a paragraph connecting the three.

Fathers and Resemblance

Rooms: Driveway, Room 233, Diner

- [ ] Close-read Adam watching his sons.
- [ ] Discuss biology and fatherhood.
- [ ] Draw or photograph a family resemblance.
- [ ] Write a private reflection.

House at Night

Rooms: Diner, Turnpike, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Sketch the Price house plan.
- [ ] Paint it at night.
- [ ] Write a sound portrait.
- [ ] Make a family logistics board.

Teen Voice Lab

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Collect Thomas's lines.
- [ ] Analyse "teen code".
- [ ] Write a scene with a teenager.
- [ ] Read it to a teenager if you can and ask what rings false.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 3 frame Adam's investigation of his wife through his earlier invasion of his son's privacy? Discuss what the novel suggests about surveillance inside families.
2. Essay: Analyse the role of humour in building suspense in chapter 3, with reference to at least three moments.
3. Creative: Write the representative's side of the phone call: what she sees on her screen and what she thinks Mr Price is hiding.

Further reading

- *The Purloined Letter*, Edgar Allan Poe (1844). The classic story of a secret hidden in plain sight.
- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Coben's novel about parents monitoring a teenager's computer.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). How online information shapes private reputations.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). A family's silences, and what children don't say to parents.
- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). A developmental psychologist on what parenting is for.
- *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman (1985). The science of detecting lies, and its limits.
- *Lying*, Sam Harris (2011). A short argument that even white lies corrode trust.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). A family novel of secrets and generational disappointment.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). A novel about a world where privacy is treated as theft.

4. Gag Gifts

What happens

Back in the home-office nook, Adam opens the website. Fake-A-Pregnancy.com sells, in cheerful pink, a pregnancy test that always reads positive, silicone bellies in sizes for each trimester (and for twins or more), and customised ultrasound printouts with a hologram for a few dollars extra. Everything is framed as a joke for parties, with a small-print warning against using the products to deceive. Adam, who has seen every human weakness in his legal career, finds this one somehow worse. He tries to remember whether Corinne's test looked like the one on screen, and recalls one difference: with their sons she told him at the door, but this last time she wanted him present when she took it.

In their bedroom the ordinary objects of a marriage seem suddenly fragile: Corinne's novel and magazine on the night table, the reading glasses she won't wear in public, the charger, a box of hair dye. They both love Springsteen; at concerts Adam dances like a fool while Corinne stands and watches the stage. Corinne calls from the conference bar, anxious because he didn't pick up earlier. A man laughs loudly in the background. She asks about Ryan and Bob and warns him to be nice to Bob for Ryan's sake. He ends the call.

Adam remembers the pregnancy itself: when the boys were fourteen and ten, a surprise given Adam's low sperm count and their careless contraception. They had never actually discussed having no more children. He looks up home DNA tests, almost orders one, and stops in case someone opens the parcel. He lies down in Corinne's scent and lets the quiet house close over him.

Scene by scene

1. The website: pink branding, "gag" framing, a test that is always positive.
2. Silicone bellies by trimester; testimonials from women with innocent-sounding reasons.
3. Fake sonograms with custom doctor and hospital names and an optional hologram.
4. Adam remembers Corinne taking the test with him at home, unlike her first two pregnancies.
5. The bedroom: her book, magazine, glasses, hair dye; their shared love of Springsteen and different ways of listening.
6. Corinne calls from the bar; a man laughs nearby; she reminds Adam to handle Bob carefully.
7. Memory of the surprise pregnancy two years ago, and Adam's low sperm count.
8. He searches for a DNA test, decides to buy one in person, and lies down in the quiet house.

Who's here

Adam Price	Outraged at the website, then forced to face what it means.
Corinne Price	On the phone from Atlantic City: anxious, practical, warm, focused on Ryan.
The site's testimonials	Women who say they bought fake bellies for adoption, surrogacy, or a joke.

Thirty questions

1. What three main products does the website sell?
2. How does the site justify its products?
3. What was different about how Corinne told Adam of this pregnancy?
4. What does Corinne want to talk about on the phone?
5. Why doesn't Adam order a DNA test online?
6. What did the Prices assume about having more children?

7. **Is the site's "gag" framing a lie? Who is it lying to?** [book club]
8. Why does Adam find this website particularly depressing?
9. **How do the testimonials complicate our judgement? Are any of their reasons sympathetic?** [book club]
10. What does the detail of Corinne wanting Adam present for the test suggest, if the stranger is right?
11. The narration catches Adam using outrage at the website to avoid something more obvious. What is he avoiding?
12. Describe the bedroom objects. Why does the camera linger on them now?
13. **How do Adam and Corinne listen to Springsteen differently? What does that say about their marriage?** [book club]
14. Why does the man's laugh in the background matter to Adam, and to us?
15. Why does Corinne insist Adam be nice to Bob?
16. Adam hangs up abruptly. Is he punishing her? Protecting himself?
17. What role does Adam's low sperm count play in how he understood the pregnancy?
18. **They never discussed not having more children. What else might a long marriage leave undiscussed?** [book club]
19. How does technology make deception easier here? Could Corinne have faked a pregnancy without the internet?
20. The house seems "made of eggshells" (paraphrase). Which other images of fragility appear?
21. Is Adam right to wait rather than call Corinne out tonight?
22. Why does the novel describe hair dye and grey hairs here?
23. What does buying a DNA test in person rather than online reveal about Adam's fear of exposure?
24. **Would you feel more betrayed by a fake pregnancy or a fake miscarriage? Why?** [book club]
25. What does this chapter add to our picture of Corinne before we properly meet her?
26. How does Coben balance satire (the website) with grief (the miscarriage)?
27. What is the effect of ending with Adam lying in her scent?
28. Is the website itself a character in this book?
29. **If you were Adam, what would you have said on the phone?** [book club]
30. Predict: will Corinne deny it? Write your guess and why.

Close reading

1. Reading a sales pitch

Find it: Chapter 4, opening: the website's product pages and their small print.

1. List the products in the order Adam encounters them.
2. Note each piece of marketing language Adam reports and his reaction to it.
3. Find the disclaimer and paraphrase it.
4. Identify where Adam's sarcasm turns into recognition.

How does the chapter use the website's cheerful voice against itself?

2. A marriage in objects

Find it: Chapter 4, middle: the bedroom inventory and the memory of Springsteen concerts.

1. List every object on Corinne's side of the bed and in the bathroom.
2. For each, write what it suggests about her.
3. Find the concert memory and summarise how each of them behaves.
4. Notice where the chapter connects these objects to fragility.

What portrait of Corinne emerges from objects alone, and why does Adam see her this way tonight?

3. Two years in a paragraph

Find it: Chapter 4, close: the phone call from the conference and the memory of the pregnancy.

1. Read the phone call and note who leads the conversation.
2. Find the background sound and Adam's silent reaction.
3. Read the backstory of the surprise pregnancy.
4. Note the final image of the chapter.

How does the call make Corinne both sympathetic and suspect in the same moment?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The chapter is built on reported marketing copy. Coben paraphrases the site's exclamation-heavy voice and lets Adam's dry asides puncture it, then slows into a still life of the bedroom. Notice the change from satirical inventory to tender inventory.

- ☐ **Paraphrase the pitch** (30 min) Write your own version of a sales page for an absurd product in the website's voice. Then add a disclaimer. What does the exercise show about tone as a cover?
- ☐ **Sarcasm inventory** (20 min) Collect Adam's sarcastic asides. What emotion is each one hiding?
- ☐ **Still life** (30 min) Write a 200-word "still life" of a bedside table that tells a reader everything about its owner without naming a trait.
- ☐ **Tone shift** (20 min) Mark where the chapter turns from comic to tender. Write about the sentence that does the turning.
- ☐ **Backstory placement** (25 min) Notice the backstory of the pregnancy comes late in the chapter. Rewrite the chapter outline with it first. What changes?
- ☐ **The phone as stage** (25 min) Analyse the phone call as a scene with an unseen set (the bar). How does the author build the space by sound?
- ☐ **Free indirect anger** (20 min) Find passages where the narration takes on Adam's anger. Rewrite one neutrally.
- ☐ **Repetition** (15 min) Find any repeated words or phrases. What do they emphasise?
- ☐ **Chapter in three sentences** (15 min) Summarise the chapter in exactly three sentences, then in one. What survives?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

What does it mean when deception becomes a consumer product? The website turns lying into shopping and wraps it in the language of jokes and privacy. The chapter also raises questions about unspoken agreements in marriage.

- [ ] **Commodified deception** (30 min) Write an essay paragraph on how the internet turns private lies into products.
- [ ] **Unspoken agreements** (25 min) List unspoken agreements in a long relationship (children, money, holidays). Discuss which ones are dangerous to leave unspoken.
- [ ] **Grief and fakery** (25 min) Discuss the ethics of faking a loss. Why does the fake miscarriage feel worse to many readers?
- [ ] **Attention economy** (30 min) Connect the site's promise that pregnancy puts you at the centre of everyone's attention to the idea of social attention as a currency.
- [ ] **Objects and identity** (20 min) Choose five objects from your own bedside and write what they reveal.
- [ ] **Shame and secrecy** (20 min) Why does Adam want to buy the DNA test in person? Discuss shame as a driver of secrecy.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "attention" to your theme list and draft a claim connecting it to secrets.
- [ ] **Responsibility debate** (30 min) Prepare a five-minute debate: the website is as guilty as Corinne.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion around the two most contentious questions.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Prank and novelty pregnancy products were genuinely sold online in the 2010s, usually with disclaimers. Home paternity tests have been available over the counter since the 2000s, though courts require lab-supervised samples.

- [ ] **Novelty and liability** (30 min) Research how US sellers use disclaimers to limit liability. Write a short explanation.
- [ ] **Home paternity tests** (30 min) Find out how home DNA paternity tests work and why courts require chain-of-custody tests.
- [ ] **Springsteen's New Jersey** (30 min) Read a short biography of Springsteen. Note why he matters to New Jersey identity.
- [ ] **Miscarriage facts** (20 min) Look up how common early miscarriage is (reputable medical source). How does this fact make the lie plausible?
- [ ] **Fertility** (20 min) Research male factor infertility briefly. How common is a low sperm count?
- [ ] **Prank culture** (25 min) Research the history of novelty and prank products in American culture.
- [ ] **Teacher conferences** (15 min) Find out what professional conferences for teachers typically involve.
- [ ] **Real Simple** (15 min) Look up when Real Simple magazine was founded and its ethos.
- [ ] **Online reviews** (30 min) Investigate how fake testimonials work online and how regulators treat them.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The fake pregnancy has literary ancestors: false heirs and pretended confinements in Victorian sensation fiction such as Wilkie Collins. Modern readers may think of Gillian Flynn's Gone Girl, where a staged pregnancy is a weapon.

- [ ] **Gone Girl** (30 min) Read a summary of Gone Girl. Compare its fake pregnancy plot device with this one.
- [ ] **Sensation fiction** (35 min) Read about Wilkie Collins and Victorian sensation novels. What did they do with secrets and false identities?
- [ ] **Born to Run** (40 min) Read a chapter of Springsteen's memoir. Find a passage about New Jersey towns.

- [ ] **The Husband's Secret** (30 min) Read a summary of Moriarty's novel. How does a single hidden document change a marriage?
- [ ] **Still lifes** (25 min) Look at a Dutch still-life painting. Compare its objects-as-meaning with the bedroom inventory.
- [ ] **Satire of commerce** (25 min) Find a short satire of advertising (any author). Compare its techniques with Adam's asides.
- [ ] **Ekman on lies** (30 min) Read an excerpt of Paul Ekman on how people detect lies. Could Adam have noticed?
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works to your running list, with reasons.
- [ ] **Myth of false heirs** (25 min) Find a myth or legend involving a false pregnancy or swapped child.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Atlantic City is present only as noise down a phone line, a bar and a man laughing. Distance turns sound into suspicion. The bedroom, by contrast, is mapped in detail.

- [ ] **Sound map** (20 min) Draw a sound map of the phone call: what Adam hears from Atlantic City.
- [ ] **House rooms** (20 min) Add the master bedroom and bathroom to your house plan.
- [ ] **Shore at night** (25 min) Write 150 words imagining Corinne's conference bar.
- [ ] **Pharmacy geography** (15 min) Note where Adam plans to buy the test. Why is a local shop riskier in a small town?
- [ ] **Delivery risk** (20 min) Map who might see a parcel arrive at the Price house. What does that say about privacy in suburbs?
- [ ] **Two years ago** (15 min) On a timeline, mark the pregnancy, the miscarriage and today.
- [ ] **Concert geography** (20 min) Look up famous Springsteen venues in New Jersey and add one to your map.
- [ ] **Bedroom layout** (15 min) Sketch the bedroom from Adam's position on the bed.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 4 notes and pins to your map.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Who is responsible for a lie told with a product: the seller, the buyer, or both? Moral philosophers distinguish between doing harm and enabling it. The disclaimer is the site's attempt to shift responsibility onto the customer.

- [ ] **Seller or buyer?** (30 min) Use the Five ethical lenses on the website's responsibility.
- [ ] **Lies and harm** (35 min) Is a lie that "worked" (kept a marriage together) still wrong? Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Consent** (25 min) Did Adam consent to the marriage he was living in? Discuss deception and consent.
- [ ] **Testimonials** (25 min) Are lies to friends about adoption or surrogacy privacy, or deception? Write about the difference.
- [ ] **Secret testing** (25 min) Is testing your children's paternity without telling your spouse justified?
- [ ] **Ring of Gyges** (20 min) Use the Ring of Gyges tool: would people buy these products if their names were attached?
- [ ] **Small print** (20 min) Is a disclaimer honest if nobody reads it?
- [ ] **The phone call** (20 min) Should Adam have spoken up? Argue both ways.
- [ ] **Verdict** (20 min) Write your provisional verdict on Corinne with the reasons you would need to change it.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

This chapter is mostly investigation and memory, no new plot event except a phone call. Yet it deepens stakes by showing what Adam stands to lose and plants a remembered detail, the test taken in front of him, that changes how we read the past.

- [ ] **Memory as clue** (40 min) The remembered test detail functions as a clue. Write a scene where a character remembers a small oddity that changes everything.
- [ ] **Sound clue** (15 min) The man's laugh: red herring or clue? Pin it and justify.
- [ ] **Exposition handling** (20 min) How does Coben deliver the pregnancy backstory? List techniques.
- [ ] **Stakes** (15 min) List what Adam stands to lose, as shown in this chapter.
- [ ] **Quiet chapters** (20 min) Why does a thriller need a chapter without action? Compare with a film's quiet scene.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Add the test-in-front-of-Adam detail and the laugh to your board.
- [ ] **POV restriction** (20 min) What would we learn if we heard Corinne's side of the call?
- [ ] **Plant a product** (25 min) Design a fictional product that could hide a secret in your own thriller.
- [ ] **Chapter ending** (15 min) Compare this soft ending with chapter 3's hard one.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Springsteen, the shared love: two ways of being an audience. Concerts as a picture of marriage, one partner lost in the music, the other watching closely.

- [ ] **Concert painting** (40 min) Paint two figures at a concert: one dancing, one still.
- [ ] **Pink branding** (30 min) Design a deliberately sickly-sweet web banner. What colours and fonts sell a lie as a joke?
- [ ] **Springsteen listening** (30 min) Listen to a live Springsteen recording. Notice when you'd dance and when you'd watch.
- [ ] **Bedside still life** (30 min) Photograph or paint your bedside table as a still life.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool to choose colours for this chapter.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Choose a song for Adam lying in the dark and explain it.
- [ ] **Hologram** (25 min) Research how security holograms work; sketch one for a fake document.
- [ ] **Sound of a bar** (20 min) Record or describe ambient bar sound. Why is a stranger's laugh so loud on a phone?
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add one idea from this chapter to your Cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food in this chapter, only the cosmetic objects of a shared bathroom: toothbrushes, hair dye. Domestic intimacy is measured here in the bathroom, not the kitchen.

- [ ] **Comfort food** (40 min) Cook something you'd make the night after bad news and talk about comfort food.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Add a page listing the products and prices from the site as Adam might record them.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Adam's secret (the DNA test plan) to your box.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask at dinner: what do couples never discuss but should?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (40 min) Begin the two-faced portrait project from the Maker's bench.
- [ ] **Gag gifts** (20 min) Talk about prank gifts in your family. When does a joke become a lie?
- [ ] **Bathroom shelf** (15 min) Write a list of what your bathroom shelf says about you.

- [ ] **Recipe for suspicion** (15 min) Write a recipe: one memory, one sound, one product.
- [ ] **Bake for a club** (45 min) Bake something pink and deliberately over-the-top for your book club, as a joke about the website.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam lies down and lets the house's gentle sounds overwhelm him. Think about the night after bad news and what the quiet sounds like.

- [ ] **The quiet house** (20 min) Describe your home's sounds at night. Which ones comfort you?
- [ ] **Unspoken** (25 min) Write privately about something you and a partner or family member never discussed.
- [ ] **Smell and memory** (20 min) Write about a scent that makes someone present.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread and trust for chapter 4 and explain the gap in a paragraph.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Write how you think the confrontation will go and log it.
- [ ] **Ways of listening** (20 min) Are you a dancer or a watcher at concerts? What does that say about you?
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (20 min) Write the message Adam might type and delete.
- [ ] **Shame** (20 min) Write about something you bought in person to avoid it being seen online, or vice versa.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session and note the line you'd most like to discuss.

Cross-room projects

Anatomy of a Product Lie

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Records Room

- [ ] Close-read the website pages.
- [ ] Research disclaimers and liability.
- [ ] Debate seller versus buyer responsibility.
- [ ] Write a one-page verdict.

Portrait in Objects

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the bedroom inventory.
- [ ] Photograph or paint your own bedside still life.
- [ ] Write a 200-word still life of a character.
- [ ] Reflect privately on what objects reveal.

The Springsteen Session

Rooms: Diner, Records Room, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Read a short Springsteen biography.
- [ ] Listen to a live track together.
- [ ] Discuss dancing versus watching as a picture of marriage.
- [ ] Serve a New Jersey-diner snack.

Unspoken Agreements

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] List the Prices' unspoken assumptions.
- [ ] List your own.
- [ ] Discuss at table which are risky.
- [ ] Write a private note.

Sensation and Suspicion

Rooms: Library Stacks, Incident Board, Room 233

- [ ] Read about Victorian sensation fiction.
- [ ] Compare with the fake pregnancy.
- [ ] Pin the remembered test detail to your board.
- [ ] Write a theme claim on fakery and attention.

DNA and Doubt

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Research home DNA tests.
- [ ] Debate secret testing.
- [ ] Write about biology and parenthood.
- [ ] Revisit after chapter 9.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: "Deception as a consumer product." Analyse how chapter 4 presents Fake-A-Pregnancy.com and what it suggests about the internet's role in private lies.
2. Essay: Through objects, sound and memory, chapter 4 builds a portrait of Corinne in her absence. Discuss how that portrait shapes our judgement of her before she appears.
3. Creative: Write the conference-bar scene from Corinne's side of the phone call, including who is laughing behind her.

Further reading

- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). A marriage thriller in which a pregnancy is used as a weapon.
- *The Woman in White*, Wilkie Collins (1859). Victorian sensation fiction built on false identities and secrets.
- *The Husband's Secret*, Liane Moriarty (2013). A single hidden document unsettles a marriage and a community.
- *Born to Run*, Bruce Springsteen (2016). Springsteen on New Jersey, family and the music the Prices share.
- *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman (1985). What liars give away, and why most of us miss it.
- *The (Honest) Truth About Dishonesty*, Dan Ariely (2012). Experiments on how ordinary people justify small dishonesty.
- *Mating in Captivity*, Esther Perel (2006). On desire, security and secrecy inside long relationships.

- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). The ethics of lying in private life, including "harmless" lies.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). How online businesses profit from what we do in private.

5. Daddy Eggs

What happens

Morning brings the official email: Ryan has made the A team. Ryan, undemonstrative like his mother, hides his smile and asks to go to a friend's after school. Adam makes "Daddy eggs" (scrambled with milk, mustard and Parmesan), a dish Ryan once declared babyish and has revived on his coach's advice about protein. Watching him eat, Adam tries and fails to picture his son at six. He slept well, as he usually does; he has always prided himself on letting go of what he can't control, and now he wonders whether that is wisdom or just blocking.

At a pharmacy he finds the paternity tests by the counter. The box claims a startling percentage of tested "fathers" turn out not to be; he drops it and leaves with toothpaste and gum. After the gym he drives to his office in Paramus, where his paralegal Andy Gribbel, a bearded seventies-cover-band singer nicknamed the Dude, drags him into a comic argument about the old ballad "Please Come to Boston": Adam thinks the woman who keeps refusing to move is the problem; Gribbel defends her. Adam's work is eminent domain. His current client, Mr Rinsky, is resisting a town that wants his house for a redevelopment, and Adam is holding a "nuclear option" in reserve. Through it all, Adam recalls the lesson he learned at fourteen, when his father died suddenly: the world goes on regardless of your private disaster.

Coming home, he finds Corinne's minivan already in the drive, covered in town and team stickers. Thomas has an away game; Corinne is taking him. Adam watches her and remembers how they met, as idealistic young volunteers training in Atlanta to teach reading abroad, bonding in a bar over the early deaths of their fathers. Early in their marriage he was a public defender and she taught in Newark. When Thomas came, she chose this town and this house, and Adam took a well-paid private job to afford them. The dream is delicate, he thinks; you don't smash it lightly. In the kitchen he picks up Thomas's scattered algebra homework and tells himself to tread gently.

Scene by scene

1. Ryan makes the A team and asks for Daddy eggs, provided they aren't called that.
2. Adam wonders whether his calm is healthy compartmentalising or simple denial.
3. At the pharmacy he reads the paternity-test box and flees with decoy toiletries.
4. Gym, then the office in Paramus. Gribbel and the "Please Come to Boston" debate.
5. The Rinsky case: a town and a developer want an old man's house. Adam has a "nuclear option".
6. Memory: his father's sudden death when Adam was fourteen, and the indifference of the world.
7. Home: Corinne's minivan is back. Thomas needs a ride to an away game.
8. How Adam and Corinne met in Atlanta; how she chose the town and he changed jobs.
9. Algebra homework on the kitchen table. Tread gently.

Who's here

Ryan Price	Reserved, rule-following, pleased in private.
Andy Gribbel	Adam's best paralegal: older, bearded, laid-back, sings in a seventies cover band.
Mr Rinsky	An elderly client fighting to keep his house in Kasselton.
Corinne Price	Home early; first seen in person, still beautiful to Adam.
Thomas Price	Heading to an away game.

Adam's father Died suddenly of a heart attack when Adam was fourteen.

Thirty questions

1. What are Daddy eggs, and why has Ryan started eating them again?
2. What does the paternity-test box claim, and how does Adam react?
3. What is Adam's area of law, and what is the Rinsky case about?
4. What do Adam and Gribbel argue about?
5. How did Adam and Corinne meet?
6. Who chose the town and the house?
7. **Is Adam's calm healthy compartmentalising or denial? What's the difference?** [book club]
8. Why does Adam fail to picture Ryan at six?
9. Why does Coben include the comic song debate on this of all days?
10. **Could the song argument be read as about Adam's marriage? How?** [book club]
11. What does Adam's father's death teach him about the world, and how does it apply now?
12. The stickers on the minivan: what do they say about the family's identity?
13. What does Corinne's brief hesitation at the door tell Adam?
14. **Adam says he wanted Corinne happy partly because the details didn't matter to him. Is that generosity or passivity?** [book club]
15. Why did Adam leave public defence? What did he gain and lose?
16. What did each of them want from life when they met? Did either get it?
17. **How does the chapter define "the dream" now? Is it Adam's or Corinne's?** [book club]
18. Why does the narrator mention the "dead spot" storefront in town?
19. What do Gribbel and Rinsky add to the novel beyond comedy?
20. Is it significant that both Adam and Corinne lost fathers young?
21. Why buy decoy toiletries? What adolescent memory does it echo?
22. How does the chapter balance the mundane and the dreadful?
23. Thomas winces at "playdate". What does the moment show about the family's banter?
24. **Is "tread gently" good advice for Adam? What would you do?** [book club]
25. How does the chapter move us from Adam's inner life to his public role and back?
26. What does Adam's relationship with Gribbel tell us about him as a boss?
27. **The world doesn't care about our private disasters. Comforting or cruel?** [book club]
28. What does the algebra homework add to the final image?
29. Which character introduced here do you expect to matter most later?
30. Write a prediction about the Rinsky case.

Close reading

1. Ordinary morning, extraordinary dread

Find it: Chapter 5, opening: breakfast, Daddy eggs, and Adam's reflection on sleeping well.

1. Find where Adam almost forgets the stranger.
2. Note the description of the eggs and their history.
3. Locate the reflection on compartmentalising versus blocking.
4. Find the failed attempt to picture young Ryan.

How does a breakfast scene become a meditation on memory and denial?

2. A comic argument with a hidden subject

Find it: Chapter 5, middle: the office conversation about the 1970s ballad.

1. Summarise each man's position on the song.
2. Note how Adam's rant escalates.
3. Find Gribbel's final counterpoint about practicalities.
4. Consider what Adam might be arguing about underneath.

What does Adam's irritation with the woman in the song reveal about his state of mind?

3. Whose dream?

Find it: Chapter 5, close: the memory of meeting Corinne and the choice of house.

1. Trace the sequence from Atlanta to Newark to Cedarfield.
2. Note each decision and who made it.
3. Find the phrase in which the dream is described as delicate (paraphrase it).
4. Read the final image of the homework.

How does the backstory complicate our sense of who owns the life Adam is afraid to lose?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Two modes alternate: interior reflection in long, qualifying sentences, and quick-fire comic dialogue with Gribbel. The comic set piece about a song is a classic Coben move: a bit of fun that is secretly about the character's situation.

- ☐ **Comic set piece** (40 min) Analyse the song argument line by line: setup, escalation, reversal, button. Then write a comic argument of your own about a song that is secretly about a relationship.
- ☐ **Long and short** (20 min) Find the longest and shortest sentences in the chapter. Write about what each is used for.
- ☐ **Interior monologue** (25 min) Rewrite the "blocking" reflection as a short poem in your own words. What does compression reveal?
- ☐ **Exposition disguised** (20 min) How is the couple's backstory delivered? Identify the trigger that sets off the memory.
- ☐ **Free indirect humour** (25 min) Find three wry asides about suburbia. Imitate them about your own town.
- ☐ **Character in dialogue** (20 min) Write five lines of Gribbel dialogue on a new topic, keeping his voice.
- ☐ **Repetition of "dream"** (20 min) Track every use of the dream idea so far. Write about how the word gains weight.
- ☐ **Pharmacy scene** (25 min) Rewrite the pharmacy scene as pure action with no thoughts. Compare with the original.
- ☐ **Final image** (15 min) Write about the effect of ending on homework rather than on Corinne.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Denial, delicacy, and whose dream it is. The chapter asks whether a family's life can belong more to one partner than the other, and whether keeping the peace is love or avoidance.

- [ ] **Compartmentalising vs blocking** (30 min) Define each. Write about how to tell them apart in your own life.
- [ ] **Whose dream?** (25 min) Make a two-column list of what Corinne wanted and what Adam wanted. Discuss what that imbalance means for the marriage.
- [ ] **Father loss** (30 min) Both lost fathers young. Discuss how early loss might shape a person's craving for security.
- [ ] **The indifferent world** (35 min) Discuss the idea that the world doesn't notice private tragedy. Find a poem that treats this theme (Auden's "Musée des Beaux Arts" is a famous example) and compare.
- [ ] **Masculinity and providing** (25 min) Adam changed careers to provide. Discuss pressures on men to earn in this novel so far.
- [ ] **Ideals and compromise** (25 min) They met as idealistic volunteers. Trace what happened to their ideals.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "ownership of the dream" to your theme statements.
- [ ] **Song as argument** (20 min) Discuss: can art help couples argue indirectly?
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion using the two book-club questions marked here.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Eminent domain is Adam's field: the government's power to take private land for public use with compensation. After the Supreme Court's Kelo v. New London decision (2005) the issue became politically charged, especially when land was handed to private developers.

- [ ] **Kelo v. New London** (35 min) Read a reliable summary of the 2005 case and its aftermath. Note three consequences.
- [ ] **Dave Loggins** (20 min) Look up the song's history and chart performance. Does knowing it change the debate?
- [ ] **Public defenders** (30 min) Research typical public defender caseloads and salaries compared with private practice.
- [ ] **Newark schools** (30 min) Read about Newark public schools' history. Why might a young idealist teach there?
- [ ] **Literacy volunteering** (25 min) Research international literacy charities and volunteer teaching programmes.
- [ ] **Bergen County** (25 min) Find facts about Bergen County: population, wealth, transport.
- [ ] **Sudden cardiac death** (20 min) Read a reliable health page on sudden cardiac death in middle-aged men.
- [ ] **Pharmacy DNA claims** (35 min) Investigate the statistic printed on paternity-test boxes. What does research actually say about rates of misattributed paternity?
- [ ] **Route 17** (20 min) Look up the history of Route 17's retail strip in Bergen County.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The marriage-as-trap theme of Richard Yates's Revolutionary Road meets Richard Ford's wry New Jersey suburbanite. Gribbel's cover band takes us to the seventies AM radio that shaped Adam's generation.

- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (40 min) Read the opening of Yates's novel. Compare the Wheelers' move to the suburbs with the Prices'.
- [ ] **Independence Day** (35 min) Read a passage from Richard Ford's novel. Compare its narrator's voice with Adam's.
- [ ] **Auden's Musée** (30 min) Read Auden's poem "Musée des Beaux Arts" in a library edition. Compare its view of suffering with Adam's memory of his father's funeral.

- [ ] **Stoicism** (30 min) Read a short passage of Epictetus on what is in our control. Apply it to Adam.
- [ ] **Pinkhouse** (40 min) Read the opening of Jeff Benedict's Little Pink House about the Kelo case.
- [ ] **Cover bands** (20 min) Read about cover bands and nostalgia culture. Why the seventies?
- [ ] **The Big Lebowski** (15 min) Look up the Dude as a cultural icon. What does Gribbel's nickname tell us?
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add Revolutionary Road and Little Pink House to your list.
- [ ] **Marriage stories** (25 min) List three novels where one spouse chooses the house and the other regrets not choosing.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The geography of a day: home, a pharmacy on a familiar road, Route 17's mattress shops, a glass office in Paramus, home again. Then the long arc from Atlanta to Newark to Cedarfield: a life measured in moves.

- [ ] **Day route** (25 min) Map Adam's day: home, school drop-off, pharmacy, gym, office, home.
- [ ] **Paramus pin** (15 min) Add Paramus and Kasselton to your map, with a note on each.
- [ ] **Life map** (30 min) Make a second map of Adam and Corinne's life: Atlanta, the condo off I-78, Newark, Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Dead storefront** (30 min) Find a "dead spot" storefront in your town and write its history.
- [ ] **Glen Rock** (15 min) Locate Glen Rock and estimate drive time from a Bergen County town.
- [ ] **Lawns** (20 min) Compare the Prices' lawn with the neighbours'. Map lawn status on your street (kindly).
- [ ] **Mattress stores** (25 min) Notice the narrator's joke about mattress stores. Count chain stores on a route near you.
- [ ] **Garage** (15 min) Note why the Prices park in the drive. Add the overstuffed garage to your house plan.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 5 pins.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Adam's philosophy of letting go has Stoic roots: concern yourself only with what is in your control. The chapter tests that philosophy against a problem that is entirely within his control to investigate.

- [ ] **Stoic test** (35 min) Is Adam's letting go a Stoic virtue or a vice? Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Provider ethic** (25 min) Is it admirable or problematic that Adam changed careers to fund Corinne's dream?
- [ ] **Property rights** (30 min) Use the Eminent domain casebook tool and write your verdict on the Rinsky house.
- [ ] **Deference in marriage** (25 min) When is deferring to a partner's wishes generous, and when is it abdication?
- [ ] **Decoys** (20 min) Is buying decoy items a lie? Discuss small social deceptions.
- [ ] **The world's indifference** (25 min) Do we have duties to notice others' hidden suffering? Discuss.
- [ ] **Dilemma scale** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale on letting go.
- [ ] **Lawyerly ethics** (25 min) Adam has a "nuclear option". What limits should lawyers observe in fighting for a client?
- [ ] **Personal reflection** (20 min) Write privately about something you chose not to see.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A breather chapter that does serious structural work: it introduces the Rinsky subplot, Gribbel, Corinne's physical presence, and the couple's history. Count how many future threads are seeded.

- [ ] **Subplot launch** (25 min) How is the Rinsky subplot introduced? Write about why thrillers need a second plot line.
- [ ] **Seeds** (20 min) List every new thread seeded in this chapter and predict which pays off.
- [ ] **Reveal pacing** (20 min) Corinne appears in person for the first time. Why so late?
- [ ] **Backstory test** (20 min) Remove the backstory paragraph. What does the chapter lose?
- [ ] **Comic counterweight** (40 min) Write a scene that uses comedy to frame dread, about 300 words.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Add the "nuclear option" and the early return to your board.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Open the Strand braid tool and note the new strand.
- [ ] **Dialogue economy** (15 min) Find the line where Corinne's hesitation is signalled. How little does it take?
- [ ] **Chapter ending** (15 min) Compare this "tread gently" ending with earlier endings.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A 1974 ballad becomes a debate about relationships. Songs carry arguments people can't have directly. The minivan's stickers are folk art of suburban identity.

- [ ] **Song study** (25 min) Listen to "Please Come to Boston". Write your own verdict on the debate.
- [ ] **Sticker art** (25 min) Design a car-sticker collection for your own family. What do they declare?
- [ ] **Seventies set list** (20 min) Compose a set list for Gribbel's band and explain the order.
- [ ] **Morning light** (40 min) Paint the breakfast scene in morning light, contrasting with the night palette so far.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Office portrait** (25 min) Draw Gribbel with his boots on the desk.
- [ ] **Minivan** (30 min) Draw the minivan with its stickers as a portrait of a family.
- [ ] **Soundtrack builder** (15 min) Pick a song for the Atlanta meeting memory.
- [ ] **Cover idea** (25 min) Sketch a cover based on the stoop image.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Daddy eggs: a dish a child outgrew and returned to for practical reasons. Food carries family memory, and the inability to picture the younger child at the same table is the chapter's ache.

- [ ] **Daddy eggs** (30 min) Cook the Mustard-and-Parmesan Scramble from the Recipe cards and discuss family dishes that children outgrow and return to.
- [ ] **Protein shake** (15 min) Make the peanut-butter shake and talk about rewards after effort.
- [ ] **Family dish history** (25 min) Write the history of one dish in your family.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (20 min) Add a page for the Prices' big decisions and who made each.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the near-purchase of the test.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who chose where you live?
- [ ] **Kitchen table homework** (20 min) Lay out a "homework" table still life and photograph it.
- [ ] **Storage riddle** (15 min) Visit the Kitchen's riddle door if you've read this far. The answer is in this chapter.
- [ ] **Making: password card** (25 min) Finish the family password card project.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam stands on the stoop watching his wife and son drive off. Think about a time you watched your own household from outside, as if it were someone else's.

- [ ] **Letting go** (20 min) Write about what you let go of easily and what you can't.
- [ ] **Picturing childhood** (20 min) Try to picture a family member as a child. Write what you can and can't see.
- [ ] **Watching from the stoop** (20 min) Write about watching your family leave.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate your feelings for chapter 5.
- [ ] **Loss** (30 min) Write privately about a loss that taught you the world goes on.
- [ ] **Whose life** (25 min) Write about which parts of your life you chose and which you agreed to.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict how Adam will raise the subject, and when.
- [ ] **Letter to young Adam** (20 min) Write to Adam at fourteen.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Whose Dream Is It?

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] List decisions in the Prices' backstory.
- [ ] Read the opening of Revolutionary Road.
- [ ] Write a comparison.
- [ ] Reflect on your own choices.

The Rinsky File

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Turnpike

- [ ] Research Kelo v. New London.
- [ ] Map Kasselton and Cedarfield.
- [ ] Use the Eminent domain casebook.
- [ ] Open a file for the case to update later.

Song as Argument

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Room 233

- [ ] Listen to the ballad.
- [ ] Close-read the debate.
- [ ] Write a comic argument of your own.
- [ ] Discuss what the debate is really about.

Family Recipes

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Driveway, Diner

- [ ] Cook the scramble.
- [ ] Write a family dish history.
- [ ] Paint the breakfast table.
- [ ] Share at your book club.

Letting Go

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Read Epictetus on control.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write a private reflection.
- [ ] Discuss whether Adam's calm is a strength.

Two Lives in Maps

Rooms: Turnpike, Records Room, Diner

- [ ] Map Adam's day.
- [ ] Map the couple's life.
- [ ] Research Newark and Bergen County.
- [ ] Paint a combined map.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Discuss how chapter 5 uses a comic interlude (the song debate) and domestic detail to deepen the novel's central tension.
2. Essay: "The dream is delicate." Analyse the backstory of Adam and Corinne's marriage and argue whose dream Cedarfield represents.
3. Creative: Write the scene in the Atlanta bar where Adam and Corinne first met, in the third person, without using any dialogue from the novel.

Further reading

- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). A couple, a suburb, and ideals traded for a house.
- *Independence Day*, Richard Ford (1995). Richard Ford's New Jersey estate agent reflects on a family life.
- *Little Pink House*, Jeff Benedict (2009). The true story behind Kelo v. New London and eminent domain.
- *Evicted*, Matthew Desmond (2016). On losing a home, and why a house can be a whole life.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Research on what keeps marriages stable, including avoidance.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A father, a house, and the price of the dream.
- *American Pastoral*, Philip Roth (1997). Philip Roth's New Jersey father who believes in the American dream.
- *Mating in Captivity*, Esther Perel (2006). Security and desire, and why long marriages go quiet.

- *Crabgrass Frontier*, Kenneth T. Jackson (1985). The history of American suburbanisation.

Chapter 6 of 56 · told through Adam

6. The Away Sideline

What happens

At Thomas's away game the Cedarfield parents gather on one sideline. Corinne stands next to Kristin Hoy; Tripp Evans and a knot of fathers watch with folded arms like a security detail; Bob Baime smirks beside his cousin Daz, who runs CBW, an expensive corporate investigation firm. Bob persuaded the lacrosse board to pay CBW for coaches' background checks, work that could be done cheaply online. Corinne is in a quiet panic because Thomas isn't starting, and Bob's son Pete, supposedly still recovering from a concussion, has taken his place.

When Thomas finally goes on, Corinne relaxes enough to flirt with Adam, a rare playful moment that makes him wonder why now. He notices the diamond studs he gave her on their fifteenth anniversary at a Chinese restaurant, which she never takes off except to sleep and swim. Could a woman who treasures that symbol fake a pregnancy? He watches the parents watching only their own children, and reflects that what once seemed like love now looks like obsession. The fathers howl at the referee over penalty calls; the loudest is the normally mild Cal Gottesman, whose son has suddenly become a college prospect.

Becky Evans, Tripp's endlessly cheerful wife and mother of five, joins Corinne to marvel that a freshman goalie has already committed to a college. Becky and Corinne have known each other since childhood in Cedarfield; Corinne was the one who had to leave. Adam drifts off to stand alone, between the mothers and the fathers. Watching Corinne, he realises that knowing her so well is exactly why the stranger's story rings true. Then Thomas scores a beautiful goal, and Adam feels both his duty to keep his sons happy and safe and a certainty that luck and chaos will defeat him.

Scene by scene

1. The away sideline: Corinne with Kristin, fathers in a cluster, Bob with cousin Daz of CBW.
2. Background: Bob had the board hire Daz's firm for coaches' background checks.
3. Corinne panics because Thomas isn't starting; Bob's concussed son Pete is.
4. A mother shouts at her son; the novel notes that every parent hears that tone in others but not themselves.
5. Thomas goes on; Corinne relaxes and flirts; Adam notices the anniversary diamond studs.
6. Parents watching only their own children: love or obsession?
7. The fathers rage at penalties, led by the newly zealous Cal Gottesman.
8. Becky Evans and Corinne gossip about a freshman's college commitment; they are old friends.
9. Adam stands alone; Thomas scores; Adam feels luck and chaos closing in.

Who's here

Corinne Price	Anxious about Thomas, playful for a moment, watched closely by Adam.
Kristin Hoy	At Corinne's side in very little clothing.
Bob Baime & Daz	Bob smirks; his cousin Daz owns CBW, a high-end investigation firm paid by the league.
Pete Baime	Bob's son, starting despite a concussion.
Cal Gottesman	Mild insurance salesman turned sideline zealot as his son Eric rises.
Becky Evans	Tripp's cheerful wife, mother of five, Corinne's childhood friend.
Tripp Evans	The fathers' natural centre.

Thirty questions

1. Who is Daz and what does his firm do for the league?
2. Why is Corinne upset at the start of the game?
3. What are the diamond studs and when did Adam give them?
4. Who leads the fathers' complaints at the referee?
5. How do Becky and Corinne know each other?
6. What happens at the end of the chapter?
7. **Was it a conflict of interest for the board to hire Bob's cousin?** [book club]
8. Why does Corinne's playful moment make Adam suspicious rather than happy?
9. What does the proverb about not seeing your own flaws say about the parents, and about Adam?
10. **Is watching only your own child love or obsession? Where is the line?** [book club]
11. Why does Adam stand halfway between the mothers and the fathers?
12. What does the chapter suggest about gender roles on the sideline?
13. How is Becky Evans described? Why might Adam distrust relentless cheerfulness?
14. Why does the chapter mention a freshman committing to college?
15. How does Coben use the anniversary studs as a symbol?
16. Corinne's childhood: "not so lucky" to have left town. What does that hint?
17. **Adam says knowing her so well is why the story rings true. Explain the paradox.** [book club]
18. What does Pete Baime playing despite a concussion say about Bob's priorities?
19. How do the fathers behave as a herd? Have you seen this behaviour?
20. **Does Adam's silence during the abuse of the referee make him complicit?** [book club]
21. Why end on luck, randomness and chaos?
22. How is Kristin seen through Adam's eyes? How might she see the scene?
23. What do the four mesh chairs with two cup holders each tell us about Corinne?
24. What would you say to Cal Gottesman if you stood next to him?
25. **Is the youth-sports world here a satire, a tragedy or a realistic portrait?** [book club]
26. Why does the chapter describe the parental "ping" of disappointment in a mother's voice?
27. How does the chapter show Corinne's focus as both admirable and frightening?
28. What do we learn about Tripp's status in the town?
29. Which detail here might matter later? Pick one and say why.
30. **If you could follow one other person on this sideline for an evening, who and why?** [book club]

Close reading

1. A social map in a paragraph

Find it: Chapter 6, opening: the sideline groupings and the introduction of cousin Daz.

1. List each group on the sideline and where it stands.
2. Note the comparisons used for the fathers.
3. Find the details about CBW and why it was hired.
4. Notice the narrator's tone toward Bob and Daz.

How does the opening paragraph map power and alliance in the town?

2. An object that argues

Find it: Chapter 6, middle: the anniversary studs and the memory of the restaurant.

1. Find where Adam notices the earrings.
2. Summarise the anniversary story.
3. Note what Corinne does with them daily.
4. Read the question Adam asks himself afterwards.

Why does Adam use the earrings as evidence about his wife's character, and is that reasoning sound?

3. Joy shadowed by doom

Find it: Chapter 6, close: Thomas's goal and Adam's reflection on luck and chaos.

1. Read the description of the goal play by play.
2. Find Adam's reaction to Thomas's controlled celebration.
3. Locate the turn from protection to chaos.
4. Note the season named in the last line.

How does the ending convert a moment of triumph into foreboding?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The narration works by cluster and comparison: fathers compared to a protection detail, Kristin's outfit turned into a punchline, a parent's voice caught in its tone of disappointment. Note how the observational comedy suddenly drops into Adam's long, looping meditation on the spotlight parents shine on their own children.

- ☐ **Simile hunt** (25 min) Collect every simile and comparison in the chapter. Rate each for freshness. Rewrite the weakest.
- ☐ **Group portrait in prose** (35 min) Write a 200-word description of a sideline, PTA meeting or office party that maps its social groups as this chapter does.
- ☐ **The long sentence** (25 min) Find the long sentence about parents' spotlights. Diagram its clauses. Why does it need to be long?
- ☐ **Dialogue as gossip** (20 min) Analyse the Becky–Corinne exchange. What does gossip reveal about the speakers rather than its subject?
- ☐ **Flirtation** (15 min) Look at how the brief flirtation is written. How does Coben signal rarity?
- ☐ **Object as hinge** (20 min) Write a paragraph tracing how the earrings move the chapter from present to memory and back.
- ☐ **Narratorial judgement** (20 min) Find moments where the narration judges characters. Is it Adam's voice or a separate one?
- ☐ **Tone mapping** (25 min) Colour-code the chapter for comedy, tenderness, dread. Where are the transitions?
- ☐ **Last line** (15 min) Rewrite the chapter's ending without the season. Does it lose anything?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Love that narrows into obsession; knowing someone so well you can imagine their worst; a town that rewards those who never leave. The chapter quietly moves the novel's theme from one secret to a culture of watching.

- [ ] **Obsessive love** (30 min) Write about the line between devotion and obsession in parenting, with examples from the chapter.
- [ ] **Nepotism** (20 min) Define nepotism and cronyism. Find both in chapters 1–6.
- [ ] **Insiders and returners** (25 min) Discuss how towns treat those who never left versus those who came back.
- [ ] **Herd behaviour** (30 min) Research social conformity (Asch's experiments). Connect to the fathers' chorus.
- [ ] **Cheerfulness** (20 min) Is relentless positivity a mask? Discuss with reference to Becky.
- [ ] **Knowing someone** (25 min) Explore the paradox that intimacy makes betrayal more believable.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "watching" and "belonging" to your themes.
- [ ] **Luck and agency** (20 min) Discuss whether the novel believes in control or in chance.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion around the nepotism question.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Early college recruitment of high-school freshmen was a real controversy in US lacrosse in the 2010s; governing bodies later restricted early contact. The Croatian proverb is a folk version of the Gospel saying about the mote and the beam.

- [ ] **Early recruiting** (30 min) Research the controversy over early college recruiting in US lacrosse in the 2010s.
- [ ] **Concussion protocols** (30 min) Find the standard return-to-play protocol for youth concussions. Was Pete's return plausible?
- [ ] **Background checks** (25 min) Research how youth sports organisations run volunteer background checks and what they cost.
- [ ] **The Diamond District** (20 min) Read about Manhattan's Forty-Seventh Street jewellers.
- [ ] **Proverbs** (20 min) Find the Gospel passage about the mote and the beam (Matthew 7). Compare with the Croatian proverb.
- [ ] **Sideline behaviour** (20 min) Find a youth-sports organisation's code of conduct for parents.
- [ ] **Lacrosse penalties** (15 min) Look up common lacrosse penalties and their lengths.
- [ ] **Boston College lacrosse** (15 min) Find out when BC's lacrosse programme became prominent.
- [ ] **Suburban childhood friendships** (30 min) Find research on how class changes friendships among children.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Liane Moriarty's Big Little Lies (2014) is the great novel of school-gate social hierarchy. Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" shows a community in friendly unison doing something terrible. Consider both as companions to the sideline.

- [ ] **Big Little Lies** (45 min) Read the first chapters of Moriarty's novel. Compare the school-gate world with the sideline.
- [ ] **The Lottery** (30 min) Read Shirley Jackson's story. Discuss communal behaviour and the cheerful surface.
- [ ] **Suburbia** (25 min) Look at photographs from Bill Owens's Suburbia. Pick one that matches this chapter.
- [ ] **Asch** (20 min) Read a summary of Solomon Asch's conformity experiments.
- [ ] **Dare Me** (20 min) Read about Megan Abbott's novel of cheerleaders and competition.
- [ ] **Game On** (35 min) Read a chapter of Tom Farrey's Game On.
- [ ] **Sports parent essays** (25 min) Find an essay by a parent reflecting on sideline behaviour.

- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add Big Little Lies and The Lottery to your list.
- [ ] **Matthew 7** (15 min) Read the mote-and-beam passage and write a modern paraphrase.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

An away game in a neighbouring town: Cedarfield parents bring their tribe with them, staking a sideline as territory. The neighbouring towns of Bergen County compete in schools and sport as much as on the field.

- [ ] **Sideline map** (20 min) Draw the sideline: who stands where, sun direction, chairs.
- [ ] **Neighbouring towns** (20 min) Map Bergen County towns that might play each other.
- [ ] **Childhood map** (20 min) Mark Corinne's childhood Cedarfield and where she had to move.
- [ ] **Becky's route** (20 min) Imagine Becky's daily Durango route with five children. Map it.
- [ ] **College map** (15 min) Map the colleges mentioned so far.
- [ ] **Diamond route** (15 min) Trace the route from Cedarfield to the Diamond District.
- [ ] **Restaurant** (15 min) Place the anniversary restaurant on your map.
- [ ] **Away territory** (20 min) Write about how fans claim space at away games.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 6 pins.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Partiality is the moral topic here. Most ethical theories allow special duties to our own children; few allow us to harm others' children to serve ours. The concussed Pete starting is the test case.

- [ ] **Partiality** (35 min) Write 300 words: when is it right to favour your own child?
- [ ] **Concussion ethics** (25 min) Is a parent who plays an injured child to win wrong? Argue.
- [ ] **Bystander** (20 min) Is Adam's silence at the abuse of referees a moral failure?
- [ ] **Nepotism** (30 min) Use the Five ethical lenses on hiring cousin Daz.
- [ ] **Dilemma scale** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale on watching only your own child.
- [ ] **Cheerfulness as virtue** (20 min) Is sustained cheerfulness a virtue or a performance? Discuss.
- [ ] **Evidence of character** (25 min) Can one object (the earrings) be evidence of honesty? Discuss reasoning from character.
- [ ] **Luck** (30 min) Moral luck: are we responsible for outcomes chance decides? Read a summary of Bernard Williams on moral luck.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a time you were in a herd.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

CBW is introduced in passing, wrapped in a joke about nepotism. Thriller writers often hide important information inside comedy or character colour. Pin it.

- [ ] **Hidden info** (35 min) Write a scene that hides a crucial fact inside a joke.
- [ ] **Cast management** (20 min) Count the characters on the sideline. How does Coben keep them distinct?
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin CBW, Daz and the hiring decision.
- [ ] **Foreshadowing** (20 min) Find the foreshadowing at the end. Rewrite it more subtly.
- [ ] **Sports scene craft** (20 min) How does Coben make a game readable for non-fans?
- [ ] **Secondary arcs** (15 min) Track Cal Gottesman: what change is shown in a few lines?

- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Use the Suspicion meter for everyone on the sideline.
- [ ] **Group dynamics** (35 min) Write the same game from Kristin's viewpoint.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add this chapter to your pacing chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A sideline at dusk: folding chairs, sunglasses, uniforms in away colours. Picture it as a photograph by Bill Owens, whose Suburbia (1973) caught the rituals of American family life with deadpan affection.

- [ ] **Sideline painting** (45 min) Paint the sideline at dusk, focusing on body language.
- [ ] **Photograph a crowd** (30 min) Photograph spectators (with permission) and study their gazes.
- [ ] **Earring design** (25 min) Design a simple piece of jewellery that stands for a commitment.
- [ ] **Chant** (15 min) Write a sideline chant and analyse its herd psychology.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the goal.
- [ ] **Caricatures** (25 min) Draw the "Secret Service" fathers.
- [ ] **Spotlight** (30 min) Draw a field in darkness with a single spotlight on one child.
- [ ] **Owens study** (15 min) Write a caption in Owens's deadpan style for a photo of the sideline.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food, but the chairs with two cup holders each are a detail of suburban provisioning. What do our accessories say about how we expect to spend our time?

- [ ] **Sideline snacks** (30 min) Make a sideline snack pack and list the unwritten rules of team snack duty.
- [ ] **Folding chair talk** (45 min) Bring folding chairs to a garden or park and hold your book club there.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Add the CBW expense to your ledger.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the nepotism to your secrets box.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: have you been a sideline parent? What did you shout?
- [ ] **Anniversary dinner** (40 min) Plan a Chinese takeaway night with fortune cookies; write your own fortunes about the book.
- [ ] **Making: coasters** (40 min) Make the lacrosse-mesh coasters project.
- [ ] **Recipe card** (15 min) Write a recipe for a "sideline parent".
- [ ] **Team sheet** (15 min) Write a team sheet for your book club with positions.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam stands alone between the mothers and the fathers and, at the very moment his son scores, feels certain that chance will defeat him. Have you had that feeling at a moment of happiness? Sit with it here.

- [ ] **Spotlight** (20 min) Write about a time you could only see your own child, or your own self.
- [ ] **Rare moments** (20 min) Write about a rare playful moment with someone you love.
- [ ] **Alone between groups** (20 min) Write about standing between two groups and belonging to neither.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust and sympathy.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict a role for CBW.
- [ ] **Chaos** (20 min) Write about how you cope with things you can't control.

- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (20 min) Write the note Adam might leave on Thomas's pillow after the goal.
- [ ] **Childhood friends** (25 min) Write about a childhood friend you lost when you moved.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Sideline Sociology

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Diner

- [ ] Map the sideline.
- [ ] Research conformity experiments.
- [ ] Photograph a real crowd.
- [ ] Write a short sociological report.

The CBW Thread

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Records Room

- [ ] Pin CBW to your board.
- [ ] Research background-check services.
- [ ] Debate the nepotism.
- [ ] Note what CBW could know.

Objects of Commitment

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the earrings passage.
- [ ] Design a commitment object.
- [ ] Write about one of your own.
- [ ] Discuss objects as evidence.

Partiality and Fairness

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Read a short piece on special obligations.
- [ ] Debate the concussion case.
- [ ] Discuss at table.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Insiders and Leavers

Rooms: Turnpike, Room 233, Library Stacks

- [ ] Map Corinne's childhood moves.
- [ ] Discuss returners.
- [ ] Read a suburb novel opening.
- [ ] Write a theme claim.

A Book Club Outdoors

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Room 233

- [ ] Bring folding chairs.
- [ ] Pack sideline snacks.
- [ ] Choose two questions.
- [ ] Pick a playlist.
- [ ] Note who sits where.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 6 use the youth-sports sideline as a microcosm of Cedarfield's values?
2. Essay: Analyse the paradox that knowing Corinne well makes the stranger's claim more believable to Adam.
3. Creative: Write the game from Becky Evans's point of view, keeping her cheerful surface and letting the reader see beneath it.

Further reading

- *Big Little Lies*, Liane Moriarty (2014). Parents, social ranking and secrets at a school gate.
- *The Lottery*, Shirley Jackson (1948). A friendly community doing something terrible in unison.
- *Suburbia*, Bill Owens (1973). Deadpan photographs of 1970s American suburban life.
- *Game On*, Tom Farrey (2008). How youth sport became a high-stakes industry.
- *Dare Me*, Megan Abbott (2012). Competition, loyalty and secrets among teenage girls.
- *The Virgin Suicides*, Jeffrey Eugenides (1993). A suburb watching a family it cannot understand.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). On American community life and its changing forms.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Performances of self in public places, like a sideline.
- *Playing to Win: Raising Children in a Competitive Culture*, Hilary Levey Friedman (2013). Why affluent parents invest so heavily in children's competition.

7. The Cone of Honesty

What happens

Thomas scores the winning goal with seconds left, and Adam leaps and shouts in pure joy, catching himself in the hypocrisy of a man who disapproves of over-invested sports parents. Corinne takes Ryan home to start dinner; Adam waits in the high-school lot for the team bus, because insurance rules forbid parents from driving players straight from away games.

Cal Gottesman corners him. He noticed Adam's disapproval of his referee-baiting and explains, with the zeal of a convert, that research by a University of Chicago economist shows home advantage comes mostly from referees unconsciously favouring the home crowd; so at away games, he says, shouting at officials restores balance. Adam, tired, finally says what he thinks: it's a game, the sportsmanship pledge exists for a reason, and decorum is worth losing a game or two. Thomas emerges walking tall. In public he is modest and generous with credit; in the car and at home he relives every play, and Adam treasures this family "cone of honesty" where the boys can speak freely.

Dinner is a perfect family scene: marinated skirt steak, Thomas holding court, Corinne telling a funny story about a drunk colleague in Atlantic City and lecturing the boys that she never gambles. Adam feels it as a film montage of a happy family with a bomb ticking under the table. When the boys go upstairs, Corinne's smile drops and she asks what's wrong; she has read him as easily as he thought he read her. He delivers the blow: did you fake your pregnancy?

Scene by scene

1. Thomas's game-winning goal; Adam's unguarded joy and his awareness of hypocrisy.
2. Waiting for the team bus at the high school.
3. Cal Gottesman's lecture on referee bias and home advantage; Adam's reply about decorum.
4. Thomas walks out with a winner's posture; the drive home and the "cone of honesty".
5. Family dinner: skirt steak, the Atlantic City story, the boys teasing their mother.
6. Adam feels the scene as a montage with a ticking bomb beneath it.
7. The boys go upstairs; Corinne asks what's wrong.
8. Adam asks whether she faked her pregnancy.

Who's here

Adam Price	Joyful, hypocritical, finally direct.
Cal Gottesman	Insurance salesman, sideline theorist, father of a rising defenseman.
Thomas Price	Modest in public, exuberant at home.
Corinne Price	The family's storyteller and moralist at dinner; then the one who reads Adam's face.
Ryan Price	Rapt listener.

Thirty questions

1. Why must Adam wait at the high school instead of taking Thomas home?
2. What does Cal argue about referees, and what source does he cite?
3. How does Adam answer him?

4. How does Thomas behave in public versus at home?
5. What story does Corinne tell at dinner?
6. How does the chapter end?
7. **Is Cal's reasoning sound? Does good evidence justify bad behaviour?** [book club]
8. Adam calls himself a hypocrite for celebrating. Is he?
9. What is the "cone of honesty", and why does Adam treasure it?
10. **How does the cone of honesty contrast with what is happening in the marriage?** [book club]
11. Why include Corinne's lecture about gambling?
12. How does the dinner scene work as a "montage"? What is the effect of that cinematic comparison?
13. **Corinne reads Adam as easily as he reads her. What does this reveal about long marriages?** [book club]
14. **Why does Adam choose this moment to ask?** [book club]
15. **Is asking directly the right approach? What alternatives did he have?** [book club]
16. What does Thomas's modesty in public say about the values his parents have taught?
17. Cal says lawyers work the judge too. Is Adam's profession different?
18. Why does Coben repeat the ticking image?
19. How does the chapter make us like this family just before it breaks?
20. What would Corinne's face look like when she hears the question? Imagine it.
21. **Is decorum worth losing for? When?** [book club]
22. How do sports and family dinner mirror each other as performances?
23. How does the narration handle time between the game and the question?
24. What does the skirt steak tell us about this family?
25. What does Cal's glasses-pushing add to his characterisation?
26. What do the boys' teasing of their mother show about the household?
27. Is there a "cone of honesty" in your own life? With whom?
28. How much does Adam's certainty depend on evidence, and how much on instinct?
29. Rewrite the final question in three different ways. Why does the original phrasing work?
30. Predict Corinne's first words.

Close reading

1. A lecture as characterisation

Find it: Chapter 7, middle: Cal's explanation of home-field advantage in the school lot.

1. Summarise Cal's argument in three steps.
2. Note his gestures and verbal tics.
3. Find Adam's reply and its key value word.
4. Identify how the exchange ends.

How does Coben use a lecture full of real research to show us a man who has lost perspective?

2. The cone of honesty

Find it: Chapter 7, the drive home and the description of Thomas at home.

1. Find the description of Thomas's walk.
2. Note the shift once the car pulls away.
3. Locate the phrase describing family as a safe space.
4. Compare with what Adam is withholding.

Why place this celebration of family honesty just before a confrontation about lies?

3. The montage and the bomb

Find it: Chapter 7, close: dinner and the question.

1. List the beats of the dinner conversation.
2. Find the cinematic comparison and paraphrase it.
3. Note when Corinne's smile disappears.
4. Read the final line by itself.

How does the chapter make the final question feel inevitable and shocking at once?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The chapter has three movements: triumph, lecture, dinner. The last is written as Adam watching his own life on film. Notice how a one-line final paragraph, a single question, carries the weight of seven chapters.

- ☐ **Three movements** (20 min) Divide the chapter into its three movements and give each a title. Write about how their order builds pressure.
- ☐ **Lecture parody** (30 min) Write a short lecture by an enthusiast on a hobby, using Cal's structure: question, wrong answers, one finger raised, the answer.
- ☐ **Cinematic prose** (30 min) Find the montage passage. Rewrite it as a shot list for a film. What does the prose do that film can't?
- ☐ **One-line endings** (15 min) Collect the one-line endings so far. Rank them.
- ☐ **Free indirect pride** (15 min) Find where the narration shares Adam's pride in Thomas. How is it marked?
- ☐ **Comic and serious** (20 min) Find where humour stops. Write about the threshold.
- ☐ **The question** (20 min) Write the question in five ways. Analyse why the blunt version works.
- ☐ **Teen joy** (20 min) Rewrite Thomas's car monologue as reported speech. Compare.
- ☐ **Echoes** (20 min) Find echoes of earlier chapters (ticking, the hunchback proverb). Write about how repetition binds a novel.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Honesty inside the family is celebrated (the cone of honesty) at the precise moment it is about to be tested. Also: whether winning justifies conduct, and whether evidence can launder bad behaviour.

- ☐ **Honesty at home** (25 min) Write about the cone of honesty as an ideal of family life. Is it realistic?

- [ ] **Means and ends** (25 min) Debate Cal's position: does evidence of effectiveness justify behaviour?
- [ ] **Hypocrisy** (25 min) Is all parenting a little hypocritical? Discuss with examples.
- [ ] **Performance of happiness** (20 min) Discuss the family dinner as performance.
- [ ] **Moralising parents** (20 min) Corinne moralises; the boys mock her. Discuss parents as moral teachers.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "honesty inside families" to your theme list.
- [ ] **Turning point** (20 min) Write about why this question is the novel's first turning point.
- [ ] **Reading faces** (20 min) Discuss how well spouses can read each other.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion around the Cal question.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Tobias Moskowitz and L. Jon Wertheim's Scorecasting (2011) is real and argued that referee bias toward home crowds explains much of home advantage. Later studies during crowdless pandemic seasons tested the idea; results were mixed but generally showed reduced home advantage.

- [ ] **Scorecasting** (30 min) Read a review or summary of Scorecasting. Note its main claims.
- [ ] **Crowdless games** (35 min) Research findings on home advantage during crowdless sports seasons of 2020–21.
- [ ] **Youth sports insurance** (20 min) Find out why leagues require players to travel on team buses.
- [ ] **Sportsmanship codes** (20 min) Find a real youth-league parent code of conduct.
- [ ] **Gambling in Atlantic City** (25 min) Read a short history of legal casino gambling in Atlantic City (from 1976).
- [ ] **Skirt steak** (15 min) Look up skirt steak and why it suits marinating.
- [ ] **Lacrosse positions** (20 min) Learn the positions and the "X" behind the goal.
- [ ] **Referee abuse** (30 min) Find statistics on referee shortages linked to abuse in youth sport.
- [ ] **Montage in film** (20 min) Read about the montage technique in film history.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Family dinners on the brink are a literary staple: think of the Lamberts in Jonathan Franzen's The Corrections or the tense meals of Celeste Ng. Coben compresses the form into a page.

- [ ] **The Corrections** (40 min) Read the Christmas dinner chapter or a summary. Compare family dinner dynamics.
- [ ] **Everything I Never Told You** (35 min) Read the opening. How does a family dinner hide what is missing?
- [ ] **Scorecasting** (40 min) Read a chapter of the book itself.
- [ ] **Sports morality** (25 min) Find a classic essay on sportsmanship.
- [ ] **Family dinner poems** (20 min) Find a public-domain poem about a family meal.
- [ ] **Dinner scenes in film** (15 min) List three films with a family dinner before disaster.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works to your running list.
- [ ] **Little Fires Everywhere** (25 min) Read about the Richardsons' family life. Compare.
- [ ] **The confrontation scene** (25 min) Collect three confrontation scenes from novels you know. What do they share?

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Two lots and a kitchen: the away field, the school parking lot where buses return, the home table. Notice how insurance rules shape where families can be.

- [ ] **Bus route** (15 min) Map the team bus route from Glen Rock to Cedarfield High.
- [ ] **School lot** (15 min) Sketch the high-school parking lot where parents wait.
- [ ] **Kitchen plan** (15 min) Add the kitchen island to your house plan.
- [ ] **Home and away** (25 min) Write about the geography of home and away in sport and in marriage.
- [ ] **Atlantic City** (15 min) Add the Atlantic City conference to your timeline.
- [ ] **Neighbour Cal** (15 min) Note where Cal lives relative to the Prices (later chapters will clarify).
- [ ] **Map of joy** (15 min) Mark places where joy happens in the novel so far.
- [ ] **Map of dread** (15 min) Mark places where dread happens.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 7.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Cal's argument is consequentialist (it helps the team); Adam's is about character and example. Their exchange is a mini-seminar on ethical theories.

- [ ] **Consequences vs character** (35 min) Write 300 words staging Cal versus Adam as consequentialism versus virtue.
- [ ] **Home-field simulator** (20 min) Use the Home-field simulator and write what it shows.
- [ ] **Dilemma scale** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale for referee abuse.
- [ ] **Honesty duty** (30 min) Do spouses have a duty to tell each other everything? Write an argument.
- [ ] **White lies** (20 min) Corinne's "I never gamble" may be true. Discuss parental moralising as honesty or performance.
- [ ] **Confrontation ethics** (25 min) Is confronting directly kinder than investigating secretly?
- [ ] **Children present** (20 min) Is it right to wait until the children leave? Discuss shielding.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam asking the question.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a time you asked a question you were afraid of.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The chapter ends with the story's first direct confrontation, delayed for seven chapters. The delay itself is a design choice: we have been made to wait as Adam has.

- [ ] **Delayed confrontation** (40 min) Write a scene with a long-delayed confrontation and end on the question.
- [ ] **Mirror scenes** (20 min) Find how the game and the dinner mirror each other.
- [ ] **Minor character function** (15 min) What plot function might Cal serve later? Pin him.
- [ ] **Stakes reminder** (15 min) Why remind us of the family's happiness right before the break?
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin Corinne's ability to read Adam.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate this chapter's ending in the Tension curve tool.
- [ ] **Dialogue run** (20 min) Write the next five lines of dialogue before reading chapter 9.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Notice the next chapter switches strand. Predict why.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to your pacing chart.

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The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Adam imagines his family dinner shot by a slow, circling camera, the way a film shows a happy family just before it breaks. Picture the shot: warm pendant light, faces caught one by one. What music would play under it, and on which line would it cut to silence?

- [ ] **Dinner painting** (45 min) Paint the family dinner from above, a still moment before the question.
- [ ] **Montage music** (20 min) Choose music for the montage and the exact moment it should cut.
- [ ] **Goal sketch** (30 min) Draw Thomas's goal in three panels.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack builder** (15 min) Pick a song for the car ride home.
- [ ] **Cal's portrait** (20 min) Draw Cal pushing his glasses up.
- [ ] **Kitchen light** (25 min) Photograph a kitchen at dinnertime from outside the window.
- [ ] **Silent film** (20 min) Write intertitles for the dinner as a silent film.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a dinner-table idea to your cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Skirt steak, a family favourite, served buffet-style from the island; wine for the adults. The meal is a picture of the dream, which is why it's the right place to break it.

- [ ] **Skirt steak** (60 min) Cook the Marinated Skirt Steak recipe card for your group.
- [ ] **Family storytelling** (30 min) At dinner, have each person tell a short funny story, as Corinne does.
- [ ] **Who clears?** (15 min) Discuss the table-setting/clearing rule in the Price house. What are your house rules?
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the dinner as a ledger entry: what was shared, what wasn't.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add a slip for what Adam carried to the table.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: is there a cone of honesty in your home?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (40 min) Work on your two-faced portrait: the dinner face and the after-dinner face.
- [ ] **Wine pairing** (15 min) Discuss what wine (or alternative) suits a dinner with a secret.
- [ ] **Recipe of a montage** (15 min) Write the recipe for a perfect family evening.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam sits through a happy family meal with a question in his mouth. Have you ever sat at a table knowing something nobody else did, laughing on cue? Write about what the waiting felt like, and what made you finally speak or stay silent.

- [ ] **Unguarded joy** (20 min) Write about a time you couldn't contain joy for someone else.
- [ ] **Carrying a secret to dinner** (25 min) Write privately about sitting through a meal with a secret.
- [ ] **Being read** (20 min) Write about someone who reads you instantly.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread before the question.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict Corinne's response.
- [ ] **Courage** (20 min) Write about the courage it takes to ask a direct question.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (20 min) Write what Adam might have written instead of asking.
- [ ] **Family film** (20 min) If your family life were a montage, what would be in it?
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Referees and Reason

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Room 233

- [ ] Read about Scorecasting.
- [ ] Run the Home-field simulator.
- [ ] Debate Cal versus Adam.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

The Last Supper Before

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Law Office

- [ ] Cook skirt steak.
- [ ] Paint the dinner.
- [ ] Close-read the montage.
- [ ] Write a paragraph on dinner as stage.

Cone of Honesty

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Close-read the drive home.
- [ ] Discuss honesty at home.
- [ ] Write privately about your own cone.
- [ ] Apply the ethical lenses to the question.

Delayed Confrontation

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Library Stacks

- [ ] Chart the delay across chapters 1–7.
- [ ] Collect confrontation scenes from other novels.
- [ ] Write your own.
- [ ] Rate tension.

Sports Parents Panel

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research referee abuse.
- [ ] Find a code of conduct.
- [ ] Hold a panel discussion over snacks.
- [ ] Draft your own code.

Faces

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Law Office

- [ ] Draw Corinne's face before and after.
- [ ] Write about being read.
- [ ] Close-read the moment the smile drops.
- [ ] Discuss.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse the structure of chapter 7 and how its three movements (game, lecture, dinner) build toward its final question.
2. Essay: "The cone of honesty." Discuss how the novel presents honesty within families at this point, and how this chapter sets up irony.
3. Creative: Write Corinne's thoughts during the dinner, from the moment Adam walks in to the moment she asks what's wrong.

Further reading

- *Scorecasting*, Tobias J. Moskowitz & L. Jon Wertheim (2011). The real research behind Cal's argument about referees.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). A family dinner as the stage for buried tensions.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). A family meal that hides what everyone isn't saying.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). How couples raise hard subjects, and why the opening matters.
- *Lying*, Sam Harris (2011). Why honesty is worth the discomfort, even at home.
- *Game On*, Tom Farrey (2008). Parents, coaches, and the culture of winning in youth sport.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). A polished family's life when a stranger arrives.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). A clear guide to ends, means, and moral reasoning.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Coben on parents, teenagers and the rush to judgement.

8. Red Lobster, Beachwood

What happens

The point of view jumps to the stranger. He and Ingrid, the young blond woman from the car, have spent nearly two hours at a corner table in a Red Lobster in Beachwood, Ohio, outside Cleveland, nursing cocktails and watching four women at a long lunch. Their target is Heidi Dann, forty-nine, big-hearted, with a laugh the stranger has come to like. They know her life in detail: married twenty years to Marty, a vacuum-cleaner sales executive who travels to Arkansas to sell to Walmart; three children, the eldest, Kimberly, a freshman at NYU; a job on department-store makeup counters.

The stranger has a creed: if a house's foundation is rotten, you demolish it rather than paint over it. He believes it, but he admits he never stays to watch the rebuilding, or to check whether anyone was left inside. Ingrid offers to do this one alone; he refuses. She is there because a young man approaching a middle-aged woman alone in a car park looks wrong, whereas a couple doesn't.

In the lot, Heidi sees them and knows before he speaks that her life is about to change. He launches straight in, the way he has learned to: a website called FindYourSugarBaby.com, where supposedly wealthy men negotiate monthly "arrangements" with young women, contracts specifying days and fees. Heidi, calm and sharp, does the maths and braces for news about her husband. It is not Marty. It is Kimberly, who is paying her way through college with several such arrangements, one man for each day of the week.

Scene by scene

1. Shift to the stranger's point of view: a Red Lobster in Beachwood, Ohio.
2. He and Ingrid watch a lunch of four women; their target is Heidi Dann.
3. Dossier details: Marty's job at a floor-care company, the three children, Heidi's makeup-counter work.
4. The stranger's creed: demolish a house with a rotten foundation. His admitted blind spot.
5. Why Ingrid is along: a couple approaching a woman looks harmless.
6. The bill, the hugs, Heidi walks to her car alone.
7. The approach: the stranger leaps straight into the sugar-baby site.
8. Heidi assumes it is her husband.
9. The reveal: it is her daughter Kimberly.

Who's here

The stranger	Twenty-seven, honest-faced, uneasy with his role but committed to it.
Ingrid	Young, blond, keeps pulling her hair back; kind and pragmatic.
Heidi Dann	Forty-nine, warm, quick, a good hugger with a contagious laugh.
Marty Dann	Heidi's husband, a vacuum-cleaner sales VP (offstage).
Kimberly Dann	Their daughter, an NYU freshman (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. Where are the stranger and Ingrid, and who are they watching?
2. What do they know about Heidi's family?
3. Why does the stranger bring Ingrid?
4. What is the stranger's "rotten foundation" belief?
5. What website does he tell Heidi about?

6. Whom does Heidi assume the news is about, and whom is it actually about?
7. Why might Coben switch to the stranger's point of view now, just after Adam asks his question?
8. **The stranger says he never stays to see if anyone was left in the house. What does this admission reveal?** [book club]
9. **Why does the stranger like Heidi? Does liking her make what he does better or worse?** [book club]
10. How does the chapter make the stranger sympathetic? Does it succeed?
11. What does the bill-splitting scene tell us about each woman?
12. Heidi knows before he speaks. Why might people sense bad news?
13. Why does the stranger launch straight in without preamble? Is that kind?
14. Heidi does the maths on the monthly fee. What does this show about her?
15. Why is the twist (the daughter, not the husband) so effective?
16. **Is what Kimberly is doing any of her mother's business? She's an adult.** [book club]
17. How does the novel present the sugar-dating site? Neutrally? Critically?
18. What does the stranger's team seem to have access to?
19. Why does the stranger refer to people he approaches as "victims"? (He uses the word.)
20. **What ethical difference is there between telling a husband about a wife and a mother about a daughter?** [book club]
21. How does Ingrid differ from the stranger in manner?
22. The stranger's demolition metaphor: list its strengths and weaknesses as a moral argument.
23. Is Heidi a victim here, or a beneficiary of the truth?
24. **How does this chapter change your view of what happened to Adam?** [book club]
25. What does the chapter not tell us about the stranger's motives?
26. Why set the scene at a casual chain restaurant?
27. Notice the ages: the stranger is twenty-seven, Heidi forty-nine. Why does age matter in this approach?
28. What do you predict Heidi will do next?
29. **What would you do if you were Heidi?** [book club]
30. Which parts of this chapter make you uneasy? Why?

Close reading

1. The creed and its blind spot

Find it: Chapter 8, early: the stranger's reflection on demolishing houses with rotten foundations.

1. Find the metaphor and paraphrase it.
2. Find the sentences that qualify it (what he doesn't do).
3. Note the verbs: believe, understand, live.
4. Find his discomfort with his own role.

How does the novel use the stranger's own metaphor to raise doubts about him?

2. Character by payment

Find it: Chapter 8, middle: the lunch table and the bill.

1. List what each woman ordered.
2. Describe how each pays.
3. Find the stranger's response to Heidi's payment.
4. Note how he describes her hug.

How does the chapter build our affection for Heidi before her life is upended?

3. Delivering devastation

Find it: Chapter 8, close: the conversation in the car park from his opening line to the final revelation.

1. Mark each stage: introduction, explanation, negotiation details, Heidi's assumption, the reveal.
2. Note Heidi's responses at each stage.
3. Find where Ingrid speaks for the first time.
4. Read the last line aloud.

How does the scene's structure exploit Heidi's (and our) assumptions?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The point of view jumps to the antagonist, or the catalyst. His interiority is spare and self-justifying. Notice how the restaurant details (congealed scampi, a manhole-sized platter) keep comedy alive in a scene of devastation.

- ☐ **POV switch** (25 min) Write about the effect of shifting to the stranger right after chapter 7's cliffhanger. Then outline how a film might cut here.
- ☐ **Antagonist interiority** (20 min) List what the stranger tells us about himself and what he avoids saying.
- ☐ **Comic details in tragedy** (20 min) Collect the comic food details. Write about why comedy here makes the ending hurt more.
- ☐ **The approach** (30 min) Rewrite the car-park scene as a script with stage directions only.
- ☐ **Assumption trap** (40 min) Analyse how the reader is led to assume Marty is the subject. Write a scene of your own that sets a similar trap.
- ☐ **Metaphor test** (20 min) Extend the stranger's demolition metaphor in a paragraph, then break it.
- ☐ **Dialogue economy** (15 min) Count Ingrid's lines. What does a single line do?
- ☐ **Dossier voice** (20 min) Find the passage summarising the Danns. How does Coben deliver research without a data dump?
- ☐ **Last-line study** (15 min) Compare the endings of chapters 7 and 8. Why do they rhyme?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

The stranger's philosophy is now explicit: truth demolishes rotten houses. The chapter also opens the novel's scope: this is not about one marriage, but about many secrets kept online.

- ☐ **Truth as demolition** (30 min) Write an argument for and against the stranger's metaphor.

- [ ] **Adult children** (25 min) Discuss what parents are owed by adult children, and vice versa.
- [ ] **Commerce and intimacy** (30 min) Discuss the sugar-dating site's claim that all relationships are transactions.
- [ ] **Victims?** (20 min) Discuss whether the stranger's word "victim" is accurate.
- [ ] **Scale** (20 min) How does the novel change by revealing this is a pattern?
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "transaction" to your themes.
- [ ] **Women's friendship** (20 min) Discuss the lunch group as a portrait of friendship.
- [ ] **Ethical difference** (25 min) Compare telling a spouse and telling a parent.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion on whether Heidi should have been told.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Sugar-dating sites drew wide press coverage in the 2010s, especially stories of students using them to pay tuition. Beachwood is a real suburb of Cleveland; Bentonville, Arkansas, is where suppliers pitch to Walmart.

- [ ] **Sugar dating** (35 min) Research press coverage of students using sugar-dating sites in the 2010s. Note facts, not sensation.
- [ ] **Beachwood** (20 min) Find facts about Beachwood, Ohio.
- [ ] **Walmart suppliers** (25 min) Read about how suppliers pitch to Walmart in Bentonville.
- [ ] **Student debt** (25 min) Research average US student debt around 2015.
- [ ] **NYU costs** (20 min) Look up NYU's cost of attendance in 2015.
- [ ] **Red Lobster** (15 min) Read a short history of the chain.
- [ ] **Floor-care industry** (15 min) Look up which companies own major vacuum brands.
- [ ] **Online privacy promises** (25 min) Research how sites describe "discretion" in their terms.
- [ ] **Sex work law** (30 min) Read a neutral explainer on how US law treats paid sexual arrangements.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Ibsen's Gregers Werle in The Wild Duck is the classic idealist who demolishes a family with truth and leaves. Conan Doyle's Milverton profits from secrets. The stranger seems to want to be the first and may be the second.

- [ ] **The Wild Duck again** (35 min) Compare Gregers Werle and the stranger in a page.
- [ ] **Milverton again** (30 min) Compare Milverton and the stranger.
- [ ] **The Circle** (30 min) Read about Eggers' transparency cult. How does it echo the stranger's creed?
- [ ] **Bok on secrets** (35 min) Read a short section of Sissela Bok on the ethics of revelation.
- [ ] **Mother-daughter novels** (20 min) List three novels where a mother learns a daughter's secret.
- [ ] **What the Dead Know** (20 min) Read about Lippman's novel of family secrets.
- [ ] **Goffman** (25 min) Revisit "front stage" and "back stage" for Kimberly's double life.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Restaurant scenes** (20 min) Find a famous restaurant scene in a thriller and compare.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The novel suddenly leaps four hundred miles west to Ohio. The geography of the stranger's work is wide; Adam's problem is one pin on a larger map.

- [ ] **Ohio pin** (15 min) Add Beachwood and University Heights to your map.

- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Use the Distance calculator between Cedarfield and Beachwood.
- [ ] **Car-park map** (20 min) Sketch the Red Lobster lot: Heidi's car, the rental two spaces away.
- [ ] **Network map** (25 min) Start a map of the stranger's operations as cases appear.
- [ ] **NYU** (15 min) Add New York City and NYU to your map.
- [ ] **Bentonville** (15 min) Note Bentonville on an inset map.
- [ ] **Suburban Ohio** (20 min) Compare Beachwood with Cedarfield in a short paragraph.
- [ ] **Travel logistics** (20 min) How might the stranger and Ingrid travel between jobs?
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 8.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

The test case changes: an adult daughter, a mother, a secret that is legally ambiguous. Does a parent have a right to know about an adult child's sex life and finances?

- [ ] **Should she know?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale for Heidi.
- [ ] **Court of telling** (20 min) Use the Tell or keep tool for Heidi.
- [ ] **Autonomy** (30 min) Write about Kimberly's autonomy versus her mother's concern.
- [ ] **Paternalism** (25 min) Define paternalism. Is the stranger paternalistic?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the stranger's visit.
- [ ] **Means** (25 min) Does researching people's private lives in detail wrong them even if nothing is revealed?
- [ ] **Liking the victim** (20 min) Does the stranger's affection for Heidi make him more or less culpable?
- [ ] **Never staying** (20 min) Is there a duty to stay after delivering bad news?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about news you were glad, or sorry, to learn about family.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A strand switch right after a cliffhanger is a classic thriller cut: we are denied Corinne's answer and given a parallel case instead. The braid begins.

- [ ] **Braided plot** (20 min) Start a strand chart: Adam, the stranger, Heidi.
- [ ] **Parallel case** (20 min) Write about how a parallel case deepens a mystery.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin the stranger's age, the method, the rental car.
- [ ] **Misdirection** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene that misdirects the reader about who a secret concerns.
- [ ] **Character intro** (20 min) How does Coben introduce Heidi so we care in a few pages?
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate the stranger and Ingrid.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Open the Strand braid tool.
- [ ] **Withholding** (15 min) What does the chapter still withhold about the stranger?
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to your pacing chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A chain restaurant at mid-afternoon: big plates, cocktails with paper umbrellas, a lunch that won't end. Picture it in flat, bright, unforgiving light.

- [ ] **Restaurant painting** (45 min) Paint the lunch table in bright chain-restaurant light.

- [ ] **Car-park watercolour** (35 min) Paint the approach in the car park from above.
- [ ] **Hair gesture** (20 min) Draw Ingrid's hair-pulling gesture in three sketches.
- [ ] **Laugh** (15 min) Describe Heidi's laugh as music: pitch, rhythm, volume.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Choose Ohio colours in the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Heidi walking to her car.
- [ ] **Menu design** (20 min) Design a menu for the lunch with prices.
- [ ] **Portrait of Heidi** (30 min) Paint Heidi in a tiger-print top, kindly.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add an idea from this chapter to your cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

The menu tells the story: shared platters, rich pasta, and Heidi's healthier salmon; the stranger's cocktail; the careful accounting of the bill. Food as a portrait of a friendship group.

- [ ] **Mango mai tai** (35 min) Make the Mango Mai Tai Mocktail and watch a room for twenty minutes, noting what you learn.
- [ ] **Salmon lunch** (45 min) Cook a simple grilled salmon lunch for friends and talk about long lunches.
- [ ] **Bill splitting** (20 min) Discuss how your friends split bills. What does it reveal?
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the sugar-site arrangement terms as a ledger entry (in your own words).
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Kimberly's secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you want to know an adult child's secret?
- [ ] **Making: secrets box** (25 min) Add a second compartment for secrets that aren't the Prices'.
- [ ] **Seafood platter** (45 min) Cook a shared seafood or vegetable platter and talk about sharing food.
- [ ] **Recipe for an approach** (15 min) Write a "recipe" for the stranger's method.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Heidi's smile drops before the stranger has said anything; some part of her already knows. Have you ever read bad news in someone's face before they spoke? Write about the seconds in between, and what you did with them.

- [ ] **Knowing before** (20 min) Write about sensing bad news before it was spoken.
- [ ] **Parenting adult children** (25 min) Write privately about what you would want to know.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate your feelings toward the stranger.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict Heidi's next move.
- [ ] **The hug** (20 min) Write about someone who hugs as if they mean it.
- [ ] **Letter to Kimberly** (25 min) Write a letter from Heidi to Kimberly.
- [ ] **Letter to the stranger** (20 min) Write what you'd say to him in the car park.
- [ ] **Rotten foundations** (20 min) Is there something in your life you'd rather demolish than paint over?
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Stranger's Creed

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Close-read the demolition metaphor.
- [ ] Compare with Ibsen's Gregers.
- [ ] Debate it.
- [ ] Write a verdict on the creed.

Ohio Strand

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Records Room

- [ ] Map Beachwood.
- [ ] Start a strand chart.
- [ ] Research the town.
- [ ] Pin the new characters.

Adult Children

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss over a meal.
- [ ] Write a letter from Heidi.

Long Lunch

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Law Office

- [ ] Make the mocktail.
- [ ] Paint the table.
- [ ] Close-read the bill scene.
- [ ] Discuss friendship.

Sugar and Contracts

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research sugar dating neutrally.
- [ ] Discuss transaction and intimacy.
- [ ] Use the Five lenses.
- [ ] Write a paragraph.

Misdirection Lab

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse the assumption trap.
- [ ] Write your own.
- [ ] Test it on a friend.
- [ ] Reflect on how assumptions form.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Evaluate the stranger's philosophy of demolition as presented in chapter 8. Is the novel endorsing or questioning it?
2. Essay: Why does Coben interrupt the Price story at its turning point with an apparently unrelated case? Discuss structure and theme.
3. Creative: Write Ingrid's account of the lunch-hour wait, in first person, including what she thinks of the stranger.

Further reading

- *The Wild Duck*, Henrik Ibsen (1884). The idealist who demolishes a household with truth.
- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). The professional trader in secrets.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). When is revealing a secret justified?
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). A world in which secrets are treated as sins.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Front-stage and back-stage selves.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A family's secret life uncovered decades later.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). On secret lives and what they mean to the people who keep them.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). How private information online becomes public harm.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). The modern culture of exposure and shaming.

9. The Minefield

What happens

Corinne absorbs the question and stays on her feet. Adam asks her to skip the denials, then goes further: are the boys his? She is appalled, tells him to look at them, to buy the tests if he wants. Facing her across the granite island she chose after a long search, Adam reflects that he married her partly in reaction to his own parents: his father was drawn to his mother's volatile "crackle" and worn down by it, so Adam chose a woman he believed was steady and controlled, as if people were that simple.

He tells her about the credit-card charge and the website. She wants to know why he was looking at a two-year-old bill. Instead of answering, she starts telling a story. Years ago, with an unusually long lunch break, she used to eat alone at a café in a bookshop and became part of a little community of regulars, among them a heavily pregnant young woman called Suzanne Hope whom everyone fussed over. Months later Corinne saw Suzanne in a coffee shop in another town, still eight months pregnant, holding court about vitamins. Confronted, Suzanne admitted she lived in Nyack and faked pregnancy for the attention: people held doors, asked how she was, smiled at her. It was, Corinne says, like a drug, and she seemed to find it more pitiable than sick.

Adam presses: does Corinne crave attention like that? She says she needs to think. They are in a minefield, she says; move too fast and everything blows up. He says she put them there. She asks how he found out; when he says a stranger at the Legion told him, she is visibly shaken. It isn't what he thinks, she insists; there is more to it. Ryan calls down for help with his maths homework, and her smile snaps back into place. She begs for time until tomorrow, because the stakes are so high.

Scene by scene

1. Corinne takes the blow; Adam asks her to skip denials and asks if the boys are his.
2. She is outraged; tells him to buy the tests.
3. Adam's parents: the volatile mother, the worn-down father, and why he chose Corinne.
4. He explains the Visa charge; she asks why he was looking.
5. Corinne's story: the bookshop café, the regulars, and Suzanne Hope.
6. Suzanne seen months later, still "eight months" pregnant; her confession about attention.
7. Adam asks if Corinne is like Suzanne; she refuses to say more tonight.
8. The minefield image; who put them there.
9. She asks how he found out and is shaken by "a stranger".
10. Ryan interrupts; she begs for one more day.

Who's here

Corinne Price	Cornered, articulate, stalling with a story; frightened by the word "stranger".
Adam Price	Angry, sarcastic, trying to stay a lawyer.
Suzanne Hope	A woman Corinne met at a café who faked pregnancies for attention (in Corinne's account).
Adam's parents	His father drawn to, then exhausted by, his mother's volatility.
Ryan	Interrupts with maths homework.

Thirty questions

1. How does Corinne react to the question?
2. What does Adam ask about the boys, and what does Corinne say?
3. Why did Adam marry someone he thought was "steady"?
4. Who is Suzanne Hope, and where did Corinne meet her?
5. Why did Suzanne fake pregnancies, according to Corinne?
6. What does Corinne want to know before she will say more?
7. **Why does Corinne tell a long story instead of answering? Is it evasion, explanation, or both?** [book club]
8. Adam's sarcasm returns. What is it protecting?
9. **Was asking about the boys' paternity fair, cruel, or understandable?** [book club]
10. What do the café regulars tell us about Corinne's loneliness or needs?
11. Corinne seems sympathetic to Suzanne. Why might that be?
12. **Is faking pregnancy for attention "harmless", as Corinne suggests? Who is harmed?** [book club]
13. The minefield image: who is in it and who laid the mines?
14. Why does the word "stranger" frighten her more than the accusation?
15. "It isn't what you think." What could the "more" be? List possibilities.
16. How does Ryan's interruption work dramatically?
17. Corinne's smile returns instantly for Ryan. What does that show?
18. Adam's reflection on his parents: is it insight or excuse?
19. **People are not "that simple". What does Adam now realise about choosing a partner by type?** [book club]
20. **Which of them behaves better in this scene?** [book club]
21. Notice the granite island. Why does Corinne pick at it?
22. What does Corinne's lunchtime "bliss" reveal about her life?
23. Why do some people crave being noticed by strangers?
24. How does the chapter keep us uncertain about Corinne?
25. Compare Suzanne's motive with what you suspect Corinne's was.
26. **Does Corinne's request for time seem genuine or manipulative?** [book club]
27. How does the chapter use dialogue rhythm to show a fight?
28. Is Adam right to block her path? What does that gesture mean?
29. What would you have asked Corinne at this point?
30. Predict what tomorrow brings.

Close reading

1. Choosing against your parents

Find it: Chapter 9, early: Adam's memory of his parents and why he chose Corinne.

1. Find the description of his mother's volatility and his father's attraction to it.
2. Note the word the father used for her quality (paraphrase it).
3. Find Adam's "reaction" theory of life.
4. Find the qualifying clause that undermines his choice.

How does this flashback reframe the marriage as a decision made against a fear?

2. A story as a defence

Find it: Chapter 9, middle: Corinne's story of the café regulars and Suzanne Hope.

1. Outline the story's stages.
2. Note each time Adam interrupts.
3. Find Corinne's description of how pregnancy makes a person feel.
4. Notice where she stops.

Why does Corinne tell Suzanne's story, and what does she reveal about herself without meaning to?

3. Freezing the scene

Find it: Chapter 9, close: the minefield image and the interruption from upstairs.

1. Paraphrase the minefield image.
2. Note Adam's retort.
3. Find Corinne's reaction to "a stranger".
4. Read the final plea.

How does the chapter end with more questions than it began with?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The scene is a duel conducted largely through a story-within-a-story. Corinne narrates Suzanne's tale in a calm, reasonable voice while Adam's sarcasm keeps cutting in. Track who controls the conversation, line by line.

- ☐ **Who controls the scene?** (30 min) Annotate the scene, marking each line as an attack, deflection, story, or plea. Count each. Who controls the conversation?
- ☐ **Story within story** (30 min) Retell Suzanne's story in 150 words as Suzanne might tell it. What changes?
- ☐ **Sarcasm as armour** (25 min) Collect Adam's sarcastic lines. Rewrite them sincerely. What would happen to the scene?
- ☐ **The image** (20 min) Analyse the minefield image. Is it fresh or familiar? Why does it work here?
- ☐ **Gesture** (20 min) Find the gestures: picking at the granite, pouring wine, blocking a path, hands on shoulders. Write about each.
- ☐ **Flashback placement** (20 min) Why is the parents' flashback inserted after the paternity question?
- ☐ **Interruption** (35 min) Write a scene in which a child interrupts a marital fight. Keep the child innocent.
- ☐ **Dialogue punctuation** (15 min) Notice short lines and questions. Write about rhythm in a fight.
- ☐ **Last line** (15 min) Rewrite the final plea in three ways and compare.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Attention as a human need, deception as a way to meet it, and the idea that we choose partners as reactions to our parents. Also the novel's refrain: there is more to it than you think.

- ☐ **Attention hunger** (30 min) Discuss attention as a human need and the ways people seek it, including online.

- [ ] **Reaction marriages** (25 min) Discuss the idea that we choose partners in reaction to our parents.
- [ ] **Victimless lies?** (25 min) Debate whether Suzanne's deception harmed anyone.
- [ ] **Third places** (30 min) Read about "third places" (Ray Oldenburg). Discuss Corinne's café community.
- [ ] **Truth on demand** (20 min) Does a spouse have the right to an immediate explanation?
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "attention" and "time" to your themes.
- [ ] **Paternity question** (25 min) Discuss the ethics of asking that question in a fight.
- [ ] **Women's narratives** (20 min) How does Corinne use storytelling as power?
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion on harmless lies.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Faked pregnancy for attention has been documented in medical literature under factitious disorder. Nyack and Ramsey are real; Bergen Pines was a real county facility in Paramus.

- [ ] **Factitious disorder** (30 min) Read a reputable medical explainer on factitious disorder.
- [ ] **Third places** (20 min) Research the term "third place" and its origin.
- [ ] **Nyack** (15 min) Find facts about Nyack and its distance from Bergen County.
- [ ] **Bergen Pines** (20 min) Look up the history of Bergen Pines hospital.
- [ ] **Bookshop cafés** (20 min) Research the rise of cafés in bookshops in the 1990s–2000s.
- [ ] **Cheers** (15 min) Look up the sitcom's premise and cultural impact.
- [ ] **Bipolar disorder** (25 min) Read a reputable explainer on bipolar disorder. Note the novel only hints at Adam's mother's condition.
- [ ] **Teacher schedules** (15 min) Find out how teachers' free periods are scheduled.
- [ ] **Prenatal culture** (30 min) Research the social attention pregnant women receive (studies on helping behaviour).

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Suzanne's performance recalls Goffman's idea of the self as a performance in front of audiences. Corinne's café is a little Cheers, a found community that exists only in one place at one time.

- [ ] **Goffman** (35 min) Read a section of The Presentation of Self on performances. Apply to Suzanne.
- [ ] **Bok on lying** (30 min) Read Bok on "harmless" lies.
- [ ] **Ladder of Years** (25 min) Read about Anne Tyler's novel of a wife who walks away. Compare Corinne's needs.
- [ ] **Cheers and community** (20 min) Watch a short clip of Cheers. Compare the bar with the café.
- [ ] **Marriage fights in fiction** (35 min) Find a famous marital fight scene (e.g. in Revolutionary Road). Compare.
- [ ] **Factitious memoirs** (30 min) Find a nonfiction account of feigned illness. Note the motives.
- [ ] **Rebecca** (25 min) Compare Corinne's self-protection with the second Mrs de Winter's insecurity.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Third places book** (20 min) Read about Oldenburg's The Great Good Place (1989).

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Corinne's story maps a small world: a bookshop café, a coffee shop fifteen minutes away in Ramsey, a home in Nyack thirty minutes off. Suzanne moved lunch spots to avoid being seen; geography as camouflage.

- [ ] **Small world map** (25 min) Map the café, Ramsey and Nyack. Draw Suzanne's circle of avoidance.
- [ ] **Distances** (15 min) Use the Distance calculator for Ramsey and Nyack.
- [ ] **The kitchen** (20 min) Sketch the kitchen as a battlefield: island, cabinet, stairs.
- [ ] **Third places map** (20 min) Map the third places in your own life.
- [ ] **Corinne's commute** (15 min) Imagine Corinne's drive to the café on her long lunch. Map it.
- [ ] **Hudson** (15 min) Add the Hudson River to your map.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 9.
- [ ] **Hiding places** (20 min) Write about how people use distance to keep secrets.
- [ ] **Same town, different worlds** (20 min) Write about places in your town that host different "lives".

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is a lie that harms no one wrong? Suzanne lied to strangers. Corinne, it seems, lied to her husband. The chapter separates the two cases and invites us to judge them differently.

- [ ] **Victimless?** (30 min) Use the Five ethical lenses on Suzanne's deception.
- [ ] **Time to explain** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale on giving Corinne a day.
- [ ] **Cruel questions** (25 min) Is asking a cruel question justified by betrayal?
- [ ] **Attention and dignity** (20 min) Is there anything dignified in Suzanne's need?
- [ ] **Responsibility of storytellers** (20 min) Is Corinne using a story to manipulate?
- [ ] **Physical blocking** (20 min) Is blocking a doorway in an argument a form of coercion?
- [ ] **Shared blame** (25 min) Who put them in the minefield? Write both cases.
- [ ] **Parents and choices** (20 min) Are we responsible for choices made in reaction to our parents?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a time you asked for time to explain.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The chapter delivers a confession that is not a confession, introduces Suzanne (a thread for later), and plants Corinne's fear of "the stranger". It ends on a deferral that keeps the engine running.

- [ ] **Non-confession** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene in which a character avoids confessing by telling someone else's story.
- [ ] **Plant: Suzanne** (15 min) Pin Suzanne Hope. Predict her return.
- [ ] **Plant: fear of the stranger** (15 min) Pin Corinne's reaction to the word "stranger".
- [ ] **Deferral** (15 min) Chart deferrals in the novel so far.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Corinne now.
- [ ] **Reveal management** (20 min) What has been revealed versus implied?
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the Chapter architecture tool.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the return to Adam.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to your chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Picture a café inside a bookshop at midday: corner table, panini, iced tea, regulars who know each other only there. It is the opposite of the kitchen island under pendant lights.

- [ ] **Café painting** (40 min) Paint a corner table in a bookshop café with someone reading alone.
- [ ] **Portrait of Suzanne** (30 min) Draw Suzanne holding court in a coffee shop.
- [ ] **Kitchen at night** (40 min) Paint the kitchen island with two figures on either side.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the minefield moment.
- [ ] **Sitcom title card** (20 min) Design a title card for the café regulars as if they were a sitcom.
- [ ] **Granite** (15 min) Photograph a stone countertop close up as abstract art.
- [ ] **Sound of a fight** (15 min) Describe the sounds of the fight: what is loud, what is quiet.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the minefield image to your cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

The fight happens across a kitchen island Corinne chose with great care. She picks at a fleck on the stone while talking. Kitchens are where families negotiate.

- [ ] **Café panini** (30 min) Make the Café Turkey-and-Swiss Panini and eat it alone with a book.
- [ ] **Homemade iced tea** (20 min) Brew iced tea and talk about small daily pleasures.
- [ ] **Kitchen island** (20 min) Discuss: where are fights held in your home?
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record "what Corinne admitted" and "what she didn't" in two columns.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Suzanne's secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: do you have a "third place"?
- [ ] **Maths homework** (30 min) Help someone with homework and notice the role switch it demands.
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (30 min) Add Corinne's "smile for Ryan" to your two-faced portrait.
- [ ] **Recipe of a deferral** (15 min) Write a recipe for buying time.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Corinne says they are standing in a minefield and that moving too fast could blow everything up. Write about a conversation where you felt that way, and whether you moved or froze.

- [ ] **Minefield** (20 min) Write about a conversation that felt like a minefield.
- [ ] **Being noticed** (20 min) Write about when you most enjoyed being noticed.
- [ ] **Choosing partners** (25 min) Write privately about what you looked for in a partner and why.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust in Corinne.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What is the "more"? Log your guess.
- [ ] **The smile** (20 min) Write about the face you put on for children or colleagues.
- [ ] **Letter to Suzanne** (20 min) Write to Suzanne Hope.
- [ ] **Questions you regret** (20 min) Write about a question you wish you hadn't asked.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Third Places

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research Oldenburg's idea.
- [ ] Map your own third places.
- [ ] Eat a panini alone with a book.
- [ ] Write about Corinne's café.

Story as Defence

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Annotate the fight.
- [ ] Write your own non-confession scene.
- [ ] Debate whether it's manipulation.
- [ ] Pin Suzanne.

Attention Economy

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Records Room

- [ ] Read on factitious disorder.
- [ ] Read Goffman.
- [ ] Discuss attention online.
- [ ] Write a theme claim.

The Minefield

Rooms: Driveway, Diner, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Paint the kitchen standoff.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss who laid the mines.

Parents' Marriages

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Close-read the flashback.
- [ ] Write about your parents' influence.
- [ ] Read a fight scene from Revolutionary Road.
- [ ] Discuss reaction choices.

Suzanne's Map

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Diner

- [ ] Map her lunch spots.
- [ ] Pin her to the board.
- [ ] Draw her holding court.
- [ ] Predict her return.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse Corinne's use of Suzanne Hope's story in chapter 9. Is it an evasion, an explanation, or a confession by proxy?
2. Essay: Discuss how chapter 9 uses Adam's parents' marriage to interpret his own.
3. Creative: Write the scene of Corinne confronting Suzanne in the Ramsey coffee shop, from Suzanne's point of view.

Further reading

- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Selves as performances for audiences: Suzanne's stage.
- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). A philosopher on whether any lie is harmless.
- *Ladder of Years*, Anne Tyler (1995). A wife who steps out of her life to be seen differently.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). The famous fights of a suburban marriage.
- *Rebecca*, Daphne du Maurier (1938). Insecurity, comparison and the fear of being replaced.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). On secrets, attention and the needs they serve.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Patterns of escalation in couples' conflict.
- *The Husband's Secret*, Liane Moriarty (2013). A wife deciding whether to open a secret.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Parents' hidden needs and the children who feel them.

10. Give Me Until Tomorrow

What happens

Upstairs, Corinne simply shuts down. Adam tries anger, pleading, threats, love, shame; she says nothing. At midnight she removes the anniversary studs, puts them on her night table, says goodnight and sleeps. Adam feels the urge to shake the truth out of her and recoils from it. At twelve he watched his father, goaded past endurance by his mother, put his hands around her throat, and what stayed with him was not the danger but how small and pitiful it made his father. Adam will not be that man.

He takes his pillow to the couch, barely sleeps, and creeps back upstairs before dawn so the boys won't notice. Corinne sleeps deeply. He recalls a police theory that the guilty sleep in interrogation rooms and the innocent stay awake, and notes the irony. He asks himself the real question: if it's true, is he still in love with her, and does he want to stay? His gut says yes. All families ignore elephants, he reflects; could he learn to ignore this one?

He oversleeps. Downstairs, Corinne has made him his favourite breakfast, a bacon, egg and cheese bagel (she has suddenly become big on favourites), and the boys are grunting over cereal. Through the window he sees her in the garden on the phone; when he storms out she hangs up and claims it was the school, and won't show him the phone. She asks what his worst case is: would he leave them? He says he can't live with someone he can't trust. Everyone has secrets, she says, even you. She proposes dinner that night at Janice's Bistro, seven o'clock, the back table.

Scene by scene

1. Corinne refuses to talk; Adam tries every tactic.
2. She removes the anniversary studs at midnight and sleeps.
3. Adam remembers his father choking his mother after she goaded him; he resolves never to touch a woman in anger.
4. He sleeps on the couch and returns before dawn.
5. The theory that the guilty sleep; Adam awake, Corinne asleep.
6. Does he still love her? Yes. Could they live with the elephant?
7. Morning: his favourite bagel, the boys' cereal grunts.
8. Corinne on the phone in the garden; she hangs up, claims it was the school, refuses to show him.
9. Worst case; trust; "even you"; dinner at Janice's at seven.

Who's here

Adam Price	Exhausted, tempted to force the truth, refusing to be his father.
Corinne Price	Silent at night, tactical in the morning: favourites, a secret call, a counter-accusation, a dinner date.
Thomas & Ryan	Pre-school grunts and shrugs.
Adam's parents	A memory of violence that shaped him.

Thirty questions

1. What tactics does Adam try in the bedroom?
2. What does Corinne do at midnight?

3. What memory stops Adam from using force?
4. Where does Adam sleep, and why does he go back upstairs?
5. What does Corinne make for breakfast?
6. Who does Corinne say was on the phone?
7. **Why does Adam's memory of his father focus on pity rather than danger?** [book club]
8. What does the chapter suggest about how violence passes, or doesn't, between generations?
9. **Is Corinne's silence cruel, strategic, or self-protective?** [book club]
10. What does the studs ritual mean tonight?
11. The guilty-sleep theory: why include a theory Adam doesn't believe?
12. **Adam's gut says he still loves her. Should feelings decide this?** [book club]
13. **Adam reflects that every family learns to live around certain unmentioned problems. True? Name some.** [book club]
14. Why might Corinne make his favourite breakfast?
15. Is the phone call suspicious? List innocent and guilty explanations.
16. Corinne asks what his worst case is. Why turn the question back?
17. Corinne suggests Adam has secrets of his own. What might she mean?
18. Why choose a restaurant for the conversation?
19. How does the chapter balance Adam's anger with his restraint?
20. Is it significant that Corinne says "leave us" rather than "leave me"?
21. How does the chapter portray the boys' obliviousness?
22. What does Adam's sneaking upstairs show about protecting children from parental conflict?
23. **Is Adam right that he can't live with someone he can't trust?** [book club]
24. How does the narration handle the passage of the night?
25. Which moment is the emotional centre of the chapter?
26. How does this chapter deepen Adam as a character?
27. Does Corinne seem to have a plan? What evidence?
28. **Is forgiving a lie the same as ignoring it?** [book club]
29. How does the breakfast scene echo earlier family scenes?
30. Predict what will happen at Janice's.

Close reading

1. The pitiful father

Find it: Chapter 10, opening: Adam's memory of his father's violence.

1. Find the trigger thought that brings the memory.
2. Note how his mother's role is described.
3. Find what bothered twelve-year-old Adam most.
4. Find his resolution and its reason.

How does this memory both explain Adam's restraint and complicate our view of conflict in marriages?

2. Insomnia and verdicts

Find it: Chapter 10, middle: the night on the couch and the sleeping-guilt theory.

1. Locate the theory and Adam's opinion of it.
2. Note the irony he points out.
3. Find the question he asks himself about love.
4. Find the elephant image.

What does Adam decide during the night, and how firmly?

3. Counter-moves

Find it: Chapter 10, close: the garden phone call and the dinner proposal.

1. List Corinne's moves in order: breakfast, phone, refusal, counter-question, accusation, invitation.
2. Note Adam's responses.
3. Find where he nearly loses control.
4. Read the final details of the plan.

How does Corinne take control of the timeline here, and why might she need to?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter of interior struggle framed by two domestic tableaux, bed at night and kitchen in the morning. Note the paragraph that starts with Adam's urge and slides into childhood memory: Coben uses memory as a brake on action.

- ☐ **Memory as brake** (35 min) Find how the father memory interrupts Adam's urge. Write a scene where a memory stops a character from acting.
- ☐ **Silence on the page** (20 min) How does Coben write a character who says nothing? Analyse the techniques.
- ☐ **Two tableaux** (20 min) Compare the night scene and the morning scene in a table: light, sound, who speaks.
- ☐ **Interior question** (30 min) Rewrite Adam's self-questioning as a dialogue between two parts of him.
- ☐ **Favourites** (15 min) Note the narrator's aside about Corinne and "favourites". How does an aside shape judgement?
- ☐ **Pace of night** (15 min) How is time conveyed overnight? Find the markers.
- ☐ **Accusation reversal** (20 min) Analyse "even you". Write a reversal line for a different argument.
- ☐ **Morning comedy** (15 min) Find the comic notes in the morning scene. Do they belong?
- ☐ **Final plan** (15 min) Why end on concrete logistics (time, place, table)?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Violence and restraint across generations; whether love survives deception; the family habit of ignoring elephants; and the counter-claim that everyone has secrets. The moral centre of the book is shifting.

- ☐ **Violence and restraint** (25 min) Discuss Adam's resolution never to lay hands on a woman and its reasons.
- ☐ **Love and trust** (30 min) Debate whether love can survive without trust.
- ☐ **Family elephants** (20 min) List common "elephants" families ignore. Discuss why.

- [ ] **Secrets as universal** (25 min) Discuss Corinne's claim that everyone has secrets. Is that a defence?
- [ ] **Children and conflict** (25 min) Discuss shielding children from parental conflict.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "restraint" to your themes.
- [ ] **Pity and power** (20 min) Discuss how violence can make the violent look weak.
- [ ] **Food as language** (20 min) Discuss cooking as apology.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion around "Is forgiving the same as ignoring?"

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

The idea that guilty suspects sleep while innocent ones stay awake circulates in police culture and popular media; it is not a validated method. Domestic violence research shows complex intergenerational patterns: many who witness it, like Adam, become determined never to repeat it.

- [ ] **Interrogation myths** (30 min) Research how police interview methods have changed and which "signs" are myths.
- [ ] **Intergenerational violence** (30 min) Read a reputable summary on children who witness domestic violence.
- [ ] **Idioms** (15 min) Look up the origin of "elephant in the room".
- [ ] **Restaurants and confrontations** (20 min) Research why people choose public places for hard conversations.
- [ ] **Sleep and stress** (20 min) Read about stress and sleep from a reliable health source.
- [ ] **Phone privacy in marriages** (25 min) Find surveys on partners checking each other's phones.
- [ ] **Breakfast culture** (15 min) Look up the bacon, egg and cheese as a New Jersey and New York staple.
- [ ] **Help lines** (15 min) Find the US domestic violence hotline and note what it offers (for knowledge, not crisis).
- [ ] **Marriage research** (30 min) Find one study on how couples handle betrayal.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Marital silence as a weapon appears in fiction from Ibsen's A Doll's House to Revolutionary Road. Corinne's "even you" anticipates a reversal common to marriage novels: the accuser also has something to hide.

- [ ] **A Doll's House** (40 min) Read the final scene of Ibsen's play. Compare Nora's exit with Corinne's silence.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (35 min) Read a fight between the Wheelers. Compare.
- [ ] **Gottman** (25 min) Read on "stonewalling" in Gottman's research.
- [ ] **Sons and fathers** (25 min) Find a novel where a son vows not to repeat a father's violence.
- [ ] **Bok on secrets** (30 min) Read Bok on whether everyone is entitled to secrets.
- [ ] **Short story** (30 min) Read Cheever's "The Swimmer" and think about denial.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Perel** (30 min) Read Perel on trust after betrayal.
- [ ] **Poetry** (20 min) Find a public-domain poem about a sleepless night.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The house becomes a map of avoidance: bedroom, couch, stairs crept before dawn, garden for a private call. Domestic space divides along lines of secrecy.

- [ ] **House of avoidance** (20 min) Map where each person is during the night and morning.
- [ ] **Janice's** (15 min) Place Janice's Bistro on your town map.

- [ ] **Garden** (15 min) Add the garden and kitchen window to your house plan.
- [ ] **Bedroom** (15 min) Note the layout of bed and night table.
- [ ] **Walking routes** (15 min) Where do people in your house go to make private calls?
- [ ] **Restaurant geography** (20 min) Why the back table? Sketch a restaurant floor and mark the private spots.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 10.
- [ ] **School** (15 min) Mark Corinne's school and the drive time from home.
- [ ] **Couch** (15 min) Write about the couch as the place of marital exile.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

The ethical question is no longer what Corinne did but what Adam will do: force, wait, leave or forgive. Restraint becomes a moral achievement, and trust becomes the issue.

- [ ] **Love vs trust** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale on staying after deception.
- [ ] **Force** (35 min) Is there ever a right to force a confession? Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Silence** (25 min) Is Corinne's silence a right or a wrong?
- [ ] **Reciprocal secrets** (25 min) If Adam has secrets too, does that change the moral picture?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Corinne's request for time.
- [ ] **Children** (15 min) Is sneaking back upstairs a lie to the boys?
- [ ] **Pity** (20 min) Write about pity as a moral emotion.
- [ ] **Ignoring** (20 min) Is choosing to ignore a wrong ever wise?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a time you held back from force.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The phone call is the chapter's plant. Corinne's "even you" is a second plant. The dinner sets a deadline, which every thriller needs.

- [ ] **Deadline** (15 min) Write about why thrillers set deadlines. Find this one.
- [ ] **Plant: phone call** (15 min) Pin the garden call and list possible callers.
- [ ] **Plant: "even you"** (15 min) Pin it and predict.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Corinne again.
- [ ] **Scene: restraint** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene where a character holds back violence.
- [ ] **Quiet chapter** (20 min) How does a chapter without action raise tension?
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool for this chapter.
- [ ] **Prediction board** (15 min) Pin your prediction for Janice's.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Two images: earrings on a night table under a lamp, and a woman in a garden on a phone seen through a kitchen window. Both are pictures of something set aside or hidden.

- [ ] **Earrings on a table** (30 min) Paint or draw the studs on a night table under lamplight.
- [ ] **Through the window** (40 min) Paint a woman on a phone in a garden seen through a kitchen window.

- [ ] **Couch at dawn** (20 min) Draw the couch with a pillow at first light.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the sleepless night.
- [ ] **Restaurant sign** (20 min) Design a sign for Janice's Bistro.
- [ ] **Elephant** (25 min) Draw an elephant in a suburban living room, played for comedy or dread.
- [ ] **Sound of sleep** (15 min) Describe a sleeping person's breathing from an insomniac's side.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the studs image.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Corinne cooks Adam's favourite on the morning after. Food as apology, bribe, or diplomacy? Ryan reads a cereal box as if it were scripture: the ordinary carrying on.

- [ ] **The bagel** (25 min) Make the Bacon, Egg and Cheese bagel from the Recipe cards. Discuss food as apology.
- [ ] **Breakfast silence** (20 min) Eat breakfast with someone without speaking for ten minutes; then talk about it.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Corinne's moves this morning as entries.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the garden phone call.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what does your family never talk about?
- [ ] **Making: secrets box** (30 min) Decorate your secrets box lid.
- [ ] **Cereal boxes** (15 min) Read a cereal box like scripture and parody it.
- [ ] **Favourites list** (15 min) Write each family member's favourite breakfast.
- [ ] **Reservation** (15 min) Book a table at a local restaurant for your book club's chapter-12 meeting.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam asks himself, honestly, whether he still loves her. Write about a time you had to ask yourself a question you were afraid of answering, and what your first answer was.

- [ ] **Restraint** (20 min) Write privately about a time you held back.
- [ ] **Parents' fights** (25 min) Write about what you learned from your parents' arguments.
- [ ] **Love question** (20 min) Write the honest answer to Adam's question as if for yourself.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Log a prediction for dinner.
- [ ] **Insomnia** (20 min) Write about a sleepless night.
- [ ] **Letter to young Adam** (20 min) Write to twelve-year-old Adam.
- [ ] **Elephants** (20 min) Name an elephant in your life.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Restraint and Its Roots

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the father memory.
- [ ] Research intergenerational patterns.
- [ ] Discuss restraint as a virtue.
- [ ] Write privately.

The Breakfast Strategy

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board

- [ ] Cook the bagel.
- [ ] Map Corinne's morning moves.
- [ ] Debate food as apology.
- [ ] Pin the phone call.

Love Without Trust?

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Read Perel on betrayal.
- [ ] Hold a debate.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Night House

Rooms: Diner, Turnpike, Driveway

- [ ] Map the night positions.
- [ ] Paint the studs on the table.
- [ ] Write about insomnia.
- [ ] Choose a song.

Even You

Rooms: Incident Board, Room 233, Law Office

- [ ] Close-read the reversal.
- [ ] List Adam's possible secrets.
- [ ] Write a reversal scene.
- [ ] Revisit at chapter 35.

Doll's House Evening

Rooms: Library Stacks, Price Kitchen, Diner

- [ ] Read Ibsen's final scene aloud.
- [ ] Serve breakfast-for-dinner.
- [ ] Compare Nora and Corinne.
- [ ] Design a poster for the evening.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 10 use Adam's childhood memory to define his character and the moral boundaries of the novel?
2. Essay: Analyse Corinne's strategy in the morning scene. What does the chapter suggest about power and timing in marriage?
3. Creative: Write the garden phone call from the other end of the line, without revealing who the caller is.

Further reading

- *A Doll's House*, Henrik Ibsen (1879). A wife, a secret, and a marriage reckoning.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Silence and explosion in a suburban marriage.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Stonewalling and repair in couples.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Trust, betrayal and whether marriages survive them.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Whether everyone is entitled to secrets.
- *The Swimmer*, John Cheever (1964). A suburban man in denial, mile by mile.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Families who avoid what everyone knows.
- *Six Years*, Harlan Coben (2013). Coben on love, absence and unanswered questions.
- *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman (1985). How unreliable folk "tells" of guilt really are.

11. Hummel Figurines

What happens

Adam visits his client in Kasselton. Mr Rinsky's kitchen is a museum of a long marriage: his wife Eunice's porcelain Hummel figurines (which he finds creepy and says should star in a horror film), a Las Vegas magnet, a Miami flamingo snow globe, Wizard of Oz collector plates, an owl clock with moving eyes, and a wall of fading police plaques from a long career that Eunice insisted on hanging. Rinsky is a retired senior police officer with a cop's habit of reading faces.

He tells Adam about the mayor's visit. Rick Gusherowski, whom Rinsky arrested twice as a teenager (once for drunk driving, let off with a call to his father, as was common thirty years ago), came in a suit with a flag pin to press the developer's generous offer, lecture him about progress, jobs and crime, dangle a place in new senior housing, and finally lean in to suggest he think of Eunice. If he doesn't take this deal, the next will be worse, and they can force him out. Adam confirms that they can.

Rinsky explains why he won't move. They bought the house in 1970 on his GI Bill and raised three sons there. Eunice's mind sometimes slips; in unfamiliar places she gets frightened and shakes, but at home, among her figurines and the rusty fridge, she is calm again. Adam, unsympathetic to neither progress nor the old couple, says he can help. Rinsky reads his face and sees a dangerous idea forming. Adam says he can end this fast, if Rinsky has the stomach for it. The old cop asks whether he looks afraid of a fight.

Scene by scene

1. The Rinsky kitchen: Hummels, magnets, snow globe, Oz plates, owl clock, police plaques.
2. Rinsky's career and his cop's eye.
3. The mayor's visit: a man Rinsky once arrested, now pushing a developer's offer.
4. The pitch: progress, jobs, crime, senior housing, and "think about Eunice".
5. Adam confirms the town can take the house.
6. Why it matters: bought in 1970 on the GI Bill; Eunice's fragile mind is calm only at home.
7. Adam has a plan; Rinsky reads it on his face.
8. Does Rinsky have the stomach for a fight? He does.

Who's here

Mike Rinsky	Retired senior police officer, sardonic, devoted to his wife.
Eunice Rinsky	His wife (offstage here), whose memory is failing; she loves the figurines.
Rick Gusherowski	Mayor of Kasselton; once arrested by Rinsky as a teenager.
Adam Price	Calm, professional, cooking up a plan.

Thirty questions

1. What objects fill the Rinskys' kitchen?
2. What was Rinsky's career?
3. How does Rinsky know the mayor?
4. What arguments does the mayor use?
5. When and how did the Rinskys buy the house?
6. Why is moving especially hard for Eunice?
7. Why does Coben catalogue the kitchen objects so carefully?
8. **Rinsky finds the figurines creepy but keeps them. What does that say about love?** [book club]

9. How does Rinsky's treatment of the mayor's teenage arrest reveal changing social attitudes?
10. **Is the mayor's case for redevelopment entirely wrong? What's fair in it?** [book club]
11. What does the flag pin represent to Rinsky?
12. Why does Adam hesitate to sit in Eunice's chair?
13. How is this chapter a relief from the Price story, and how is it connected?
14. What does "home" mean to the Rinskys?
15. How does the mayor use Eunice's condition against them?
16. Adam is "not unsympathetic" to the town's goals. Why include that nuance?
17. What does Rinsky read in Adam's face?
18. **Compare the Rinskys' marriage with the Prices'.** [book club]
19. What does "the stomach for it" suggest about Adam's plan?
20. **Is it significant that Rinsky was a cop? Predict how it might matter.** [book club]
21. How does the narrative present old age?
22. **Do houses hold memory? Discuss.** [book club]
23. How does this subplot echo the novel's theme of the suburban dream?
24. Why is the wall of plaques important?
25. Is the mayor corrupt, or just a politician?
26. **What is a home worth beyond its market value?** [book club]
27. How does Coben make Rinsky likeable in a few pages?
28. What would you do in Rinsky's place?
29. Which object in the kitchen would you keep?
30. Predict Adam's "nuclear option".

Close reading

1. A marriage in a kitchen

Find it: Chapter 11, opening: the inventory of the Rinsky kitchen.

1. List every object in order.
2. Sort them into his, hers and theirs.
3. Find Rinsky's joke about the figurines.
4. Find the line about who insisted on the plaques.

How does an inventory of objects tell the story of a fifty-year marriage?

2. Reported persuasion

Find it: Chapter 11, middle: Rinsky's account of the mayor's visit.

1. List the mayor's arguments in order.
2. Note Rinsky's silent responses.
3. Find the moment of greatest offence.
4. Notice Rinsky's comments on patriotism.

How does reported speech let Rinsky, and Coben, judge the mayor?

3. Why stay

Find it: Chapter 11, close: Eunice at home, and Adam's plan.

1. Find the account of buying the house.
2. Find the description of Eunice in strange places versus at home.
3. Note Rinsky's cop's reading of Adam.
4. Read the final exchange.

How does the chapter turn a property dispute into a story about love?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The chapter opens with a list and ends with a challenge. Coben lets Rinsky speak at length in a gruff, comic register, and Adam mostly listens: a change from the Price scenes where Adam is the one under pressure.

- ☐ **Inventory as character** (30 min) Write a 200-word inventory of an elderly relative's kitchen that tells their life.
- ☐ **Gruff voice** (25 min) Imitate Rinsky's voice in a short monologue about something modern he dislikes.
- ☐ **Reported speech** (35 min) Rewrite the mayor's visit as a direct scene. Which version is more effective?
- ☐ **Listening hero** (15 min) Note how little Adam says. Write about listening as characterisation.
- ☐ **Humour and grief** (15 min) Find where humour softens Eunice's condition.
- ☐ **Final exchange** (15 min) Analyse the last two lines as a call-and-response.
- ☐ **Object list craft** (20 min) Compare this inventory with chapter 4's bedroom inventory.
- ☐ **Sentence variety** (15 min) Pick one paragraph and chart its sentence lengths.
- ☐ **Point of view** (25 min) Rewrite one paragraph from Eunice's viewpoint.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Home versus progress; memory and place; patriotism as symbol versus service; the town's needs versus one couple's. The Rinsky subplot is a mirror of the main plot's question: what are you willing to destroy for the greater good?

- ☐ **Home and identity** (25 min) Write about why a house can be part of a person's self.
- ☐ **Progress** (30 min) Debate whether redevelopment is progress.
- ☐ **Symbolic patriotism** (20 min) Discuss Rinsky's critique of flag pins.
- ☐ **Dementia and place** (25 min) Discuss how familiar environments help people with memory loss.
- ☐ **Mirror subplot** (25 min) Write about how the Rinsky subplot mirrors the Price plot.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "home" to your theme list.
- ☐ **Old age** (20 min) Discuss how the novel treats elderly characters.
- ☐ **Power and history** (20 min) Discuss how personal history colours public decisions (the mayor's arrests).
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of home versus progress.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

The GI Bill (1944) helped millions of veterans buy homes after the war. Eminent domain for redevelopment was upheld by the Supreme Court in Kelo v. New London (2005), sparking reforms. Hummel figurines have been made in Germany since 1935.

- [ ] **GI Bill** (35 min) Research the GI Bill's housing benefits and who was excluded from them.
- [ ] **Kelo aftermath** (30 min) Find which states changed their laws after Kelo.
- [ ] **Hummels** (20 min) Look up the history of Hummel figurines.
- [ ] **Drunk-driving history** (30 min) Research how attitudes to drunk driving changed from the 1980s (e.g. Mothers Against Drunk Driving, founded 1980).
- [ ] **Gentrification** (25 min) Read a balanced explainer on gentrification.
- [ ] **Senior housing** (20 min) Research types of US senior housing.
- [ ] **Memory loss and home** (25 min) Find advice from a reputable dementia charity on keeping people in familiar places.
- [ ] **Police careers** (15 min) Look up how police ranks work in New Jersey towns.
- [ ] **Wizard of Oz** (15 min) Find out about collector plates as a mid-century craze.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Jeff Benedict's Little Pink House tells the true story of Susette Kelo, who fought the taking of her home. Matthew Desmond's Evicted explores what losing a home does to people.

- [ ] **Little Pink House** (40 min) Read the opening of Benedict's book.
- [ ] **Evicted** (40 min) Read an excerpt of Desmond's Evicted.
- [ ] **Old couples in fiction** (25 min) Find a novel centred on an elderly couple's home.
- [ ] **The Wizard of Oz** (20 min) Reflect on the famous closing idea of the 1939 film, that home is the one place you need, as a cultural belief.
- [ ] **Ibsen's Enemy** (30 min) Read about An Enemy of the People: a town against one stubborn man.
- [ ] **Kitsch** (25 min) Read a short essay on kitsch and sentiment.
- [ ] **Poems about houses** (20 min) Find a public-domain poem about an old house.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Coben's cops** (20 min) Note other retired-cop characters in crime fiction.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Kasselton is a neighbouring, less fashionable town, its old downtown "gone to seed". The redevelopment would remake its map: condos, chain stores, restaurants. The Rinsky house stands in the way.

- [ ] **Kasselton map** (25 min) Map Kasselton: downtown, the Rinsky house, the planned development.
- [ ] **Redevelopment plan** (30 min) Draw the developer's imagined new streets around the house.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Note the distance between Kasselton and Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Senior village** (15 min) Place the senior housing "in the heights".
- [ ] **Neighbourhood memory** (25 min) Map your childhood neighbourhood and what has changed.
- [ ] **Kitchen plan** (15 min) Sketch the Rinsky kitchen with five chairs.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 11.
- [ ] **Then and now** (25 min) Find old and new photographs of a gentrified street.

- [ ] **Walk** (40 min) Walk an older neighbourhood and note signs of change.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Utilitarian logic says the many benefit from redevelopment; rights-based ethics says a home cannot be taken for private gain. The mayor's appeal to Eunice is a manipulation of care ethics.

- [ ] **Many vs few** (20 min) Use the Eminent domain casebook tool.
- [ ] **Dilemma scale** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale on the Rinsky house.
- [ ] **Manipulation** (25 min) Is the mayor's appeal to Eunice manipulation? Write 200 words.
- [ ] **Rights** (30 min) Write about property rights and their limits.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the redevelopment.
- [ ] **Teen arrest** (20 min) Was letting the teenage mayor off a kindness or a failure?
- [ ] **Patriotism** (20 min) What makes someone a patriot?
- [ ] **Lawyers' tactics** (20 min) What tactics would be fair in this fight?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a place you would refuse to leave.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A subplot chapter that plants a resource: a retired cop who can read people and has skills. Writers often seed helpers early in subplots so they can be used in the main plot.

- [ ] **Seeding a helper** (20 min) Write about how this chapter seeds Rinsky as a future resource.
- [ ] **Subplot rhythm** (15 min) Chart how often the Rinsky subplot appears so far.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin the mayor's history and Adam's plan.
- [ ] **Scene: an old man's kitchen** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene in an old person's kitchen with a hidden plan.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the new strand in the braid tool.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate the mayor.
- [ ] **Comic relief** (15 min) Is this chapter comic relief or serious subplot?
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the final line's energy.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Kitsch as love: Hummels, flamingo snow globes, Oz plates, an owl clock. Collectibles are a folk art of marriage. Imagine painting this kitchen as a still life.

- [ ] **Kitsch still life** (40 min) Paint or photograph a collection of kitsch objects as a loving still life.
- [ ] **Horror Hummel** (30 min) Draw a Hummel figurine as a horror poster, as Rinsky imagines.
- [ ] **Owl clock** (20 min) Design an owl clock with moving eyes.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool for a 1970s kitchen.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song the Rinskys danced to.
- [ ] **Snow globe** (45 min) Make a simple snow globe (jar, glycerin, glitter, figurine).
- [ ] **Plaques wall** (20 min) Design a wall of plaques for an imagined career.
- [ ] **Kitchen colour** (15 min) Describe the colours of wood panelling and vinyl.

- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a domestic object to your cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

An old kitchen with wood panelling, a sticky vinyl tablecloth and five chairs for a family long grown. It calms Eunice. Kitchens hold the shape of the families who used them.

- [ ] **Old-fashioned recipe** (60 min) Cook a 1970s family dish (meatloaf, pot roast) and talk about kitchens of memory.
- [ ] **Vinyl tablecloth** (15 min) Eat at a table with a wipe-clean cloth and discuss what we keep and why.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the developer's offers.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the mayor's past.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what's the oldest object in your kitchen?
- [ ] **Making: memory box** (45 min) Make a small memory box of objects from an older relative.
- [ ] **Five chairs** (15 min) Set a table for a family that has grown up and left. Discuss.
- [ ] **Recipe of a home** (15 min) Write a recipe for "home".
- [ ] **Tea for Eunice** (15 min) Make tea as if for someone with memory loss: familiar cup, familiar way.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

What would it mean to lose the house you have lived in for fifty years? Write about a place that calms you because nothing in it has changed, and what would happen if it went.

- [ ] **A calming place** (20 min) Write about a place that calms you.
- [ ] **Losing a home** (25 min) Write about moving out of a home you loved.
- [ ] **Old age** (20 min) Write about how you hope to age.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate feelings.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict Adam's plan.
- [ ] **Kitsch you love** (20 min) Write about something you keep that others find ugly.
- [ ] **Letter to Eunice** (20 min) Write a gentle letter to Eunice.
- [ ] **A fight worth having** (20 min) What would you fight for?
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Rinsky Case File

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Turnpike

- [ ] Research Kelo and the GI Bill.
- [ ] Map Kasselton.
- [ ] Use the casebook tool.
- [ ] Open a file to update.

Kitchens of Memory

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Cook a 1970s dish.
- [ ] Paint a kitsch still life.
- [ ] Write about a calming place.
- [ ] Make a memory box.

Home versus Progress

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks

- [ ] Read Little Pink House.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Apply ethical lenses.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Ageing and Place

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Read dementia charity advice.
- [ ] Discuss Eunice.
- [ ] Write privately about ageing.
- [ ] Plan a visit to an older relative.

Seeding a Helper

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Library Stacks

- [ ] Analyse Rinsky as a resource.
- [ ] Find retired cops in fiction.
- [ ] Write a seeding scene.
- [ ] Pin Rinsky.

Patriotism Panel

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research the GI Bill.
- [ ] Discuss symbols and service.
- [ ] Hold a panel over tea.
- [ ] Write a reflection.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does the Rinsky subplot reflect and comment on the main story of the Prices?
2. Essay: Analyse the role of objects in chapter 11. How do Coben's inventories create character?
3. Creative: Write the mayor's visit from Eunice's point of view as she watches from the doorway.

Further reading

- *Little Pink House*, Jeff Benedict (2009). The real eminent-domain fight behind Kelo v. New London.
- *Evicted*, Matthew Desmond (2016). What losing a home does to people and families.
- *An Enemy of the People*, Henrik Ibsen (1882). One stubborn man against his whole town.
- *Crabgrass Frontier*, Kenneth T. Jackson (1985). How American suburbs and home ownership were built.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A house paid off at last, and what it means.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Utilitarian and rights-based thinking applied to real cases.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Community bonds and civic life.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Ageing parents and the family home.
- *Independence Day*, Richard Ford (1995). A New Jersey estate agent on what homes mean to people.

12. The Back Table

What happens

Adam gets home at six; Corinne's car isn't there, which he puts down to her wisely avoiding a scene before dinner. The house is a teenage obstacle course of backpacks and sweatshirts. He knocks on Ryan's door and opens it in the same motion, his compromise between privacy and parenthood. He orders a half-pepperoni, half-buffalo-chicken pizza and mozzarella sticks, the boys negotiate like diplomats, and he notes that feeding teenage boys is like filling a bath with a teaspoon.

Unusually, he showers, shaves, puts on aftershave Corinne likes and the blue shirt she once said suited his eyes. Leaving the bedroom with its too many cushions, he wonders melodramatically whether they will ever sleep there together again. The boys tease him about his cologne. At Janice's Bistro, a bring-your-own restaurant where he and Corinne are regulars, Janice's son seats him at the back table and Janice sends out for a good bottle of wine since he forgot to bring one.

Corinne doesn't come. Seven fifteen; a text unanswered. Seven thirty; Janice asks if everything is all right, and Adam says Corinne must be stuck in a parent conference. At 7:45 his phone buzzes. Corinne writes that they may need some time away from each other, that he should look after the children and not try to reach her, and that things will turn out fine. A second message follows, asking him for a few days.

Scene by scene

1. Home at six; Corinne isn't there; the house is strewn with the boys' things.
2. Adam's knock-and-open compromise at Ryan's door.
3. Pizza ordered, half and half, with mozzarella sticks; the bedroom with too many cushions.
4. Shower, shave, aftershave, blue shirt: Adam dresses for his wife.
5. Paper plates, slice negotiations, teasing about cologne.
6. Janice's Bistro: the back table, a borrowed bottle of wine.
7. Corinne is late, then later; Adam covers for her with Janice.
8. 7:45: Corinne's texts asking for time apart.

Who's here

Adam Price	Nervous, hopeful, dressed up for a reckoning that doesn't come.
Ryan & Thomas	Pizza diplomats with strong views on toppings.
Janice	Owner of the bistro, warm and attentive.
David	Janice's son and maître d'.
Corinne Price	Absent; present only as two texts.

Thirty questions

1. Why isn't Corinne home at six?
2. How does Adam handle knocking on Ryan's door?
3. What does Adam order for the boys?
4. How does Adam prepare for dinner?
5. Where is dinner, and what does Janice do?
6. What do Corinne's texts say?
7. **Why does Adam dress up? What does it reveal about his hopes?** [book club]

8. What does the knock-and-open compromise say about parenting teenagers?
9. How does the pizza negotiation mirror larger negotiations in the book?
10. Why do the boys tease him? What do they sense?
11. How does the chapter build suspense through time stamps?
12. **Adam lies to Janice. Is this kindness, pride, or habit?** [book club]
13. **Read the texts' wording closely. Is anything odd about them?** [book club]
14. **What does Corinne's instruction about the children ask of Adam?** [book club]
15. Why "don't try to contact me"? What could she be avoiding?
16. **Does Corinne's absence feel like escape, punishment, or something else?** [book club]
17. How does the domestic comedy in the first half affect the ending?
18. The bedroom with too many cushions: why notice that now?
19. What does this chapter suggest about how families function on autopilot?
20. How does the back table work as a stage for a confession that doesn't happen?
21. What do Janice and her son represent in Adam's life?
22. **Is asking for time apart a reasonable response to the confrontation?** [book club]
23. What would you do at 7:46?
24. How would the boys react if they knew?
25. Why might Corinne send two texts rather than one?
26. Compare this restaurant scene with the Red Lobster scene in chapter 8.
27. How does Coben use the phone as a character?
28. What is the effect of the texts being presented in capitals?
29. What does Adam lose in this chapter?
30. Predict where Corinne is.

Close reading

1. Dressing for hope

Find it: Chapter 12, early: Adam getting ready and looking at the bedroom.

1. List each step of his preparation.
2. Note his self-consciousness about each.
3. Find the bedroom description and his fear.
4. Find the word he uses to dismiss his own fear.

How does the chapter reveal Adam's hope without him admitting it?

2. Comedy of the ordinary

Find it: Chapter 12, middle: the pizza scene with the boys.

1. Note the pizza order and the negotiation.
2. Find the comparisons (bath and teaspoon, locusts, horses).
3. Note the boys' teasing.
4. Find Adam's parting instructions.

Why does Coben give the boys a funny, warm scene just before their mother vanishes?

3. The clock and the message

Find it: Chapter 12, close: the wait at Janice's and the texts.

1. List each time stamp.
2. Note Adam's cover story.
3. Read the two texts and note their tone.
4. Consider what is missing from them.

How does the ending turn a waiting scene into a disappearance?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The chapter is structured by the clock: six, seven, seven fifteen, seven thirty, seven forty-five. Domestic comedy in long paragraphs gives way to short timed sentences, then to two texts in capitals. Watch how form tightens as hope drains away.

- ☐ **The clock as structure** (20 min) Chart every time reference. Write about the clock as a structural device.
- ☐ **Comic similes** (15 min) Collect the similes in the pizza scene and rate them.
- ☐ **Texts as text** (25 min) Analyse the texts' wording and punctuation. Write what each phrase might mean.
- ☐ **Shift in form** (15 min) Find where paragraphs shorten. Why?
- ☐ **Self-mockery** (15 min) Find Adam's self-mockery. What does it protect?
- ☐ **Scene from the waiter** (30 min) Rewrite the restaurant wait from David's viewpoint.
- ☐ **Domestic dialogue** (30 min) Write a comic family dinner negotiation of your own.
- ☐ **The cushions** (15 min) Write about why a small observation can carry dread.
- ☐ **Ending in capitals** (15 min) Experiment: rewrite the texts in lower case. Effect?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Hope and humiliation in marriage; the rituals of family life running on autopilot; the meaning of "space" in a relationship; and the first hint that a message can be read for what it doesn't say.

- ☐ **Space in relationships** (25 min) Discuss when asking for space is healthy and when it is avoidance.
- ☐ **Autopilot families** (20 min) Discuss routines as both stability and blindness.
- ☐ **Dignity** (20 min) Discuss Adam's lie to Janice as protection of dignity.
- ☐ **Parenting alone** (20 min) What does Corinne's instruction to look after the children assume about Adam as a parent? Write 200 words drawing on chapters 1–12.
- ☐ **Hope** (20 min) Write about hope as risk.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "disappearance" to your themes.
- ☐ **Technology and intimacy** (25 min) Is ending a conversation by text a modern cruelty?
- ☐ **Gender expectations** (20 min) Discuss assumptions about who cares for children.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of whether to respect the request.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Bring-your-own restaurants are common in New Jersey because liquor licences are limited by town population and can cost a fortune. The chapter's texts reflect 2015 smartphone etiquette, when a text could end a conversation.

- [ ] **NJ liquor licences** (25 min) Research why BYO restaurants are common in New Jersey.
- [ ] **Pizza culture** (15 min) Look up New Jersey's pizza traditions.
- [ ] **Missing adults** (30 min) Research how US police handle reports of missing adults who left voluntarily.
- [ ] **Texting norms** (20 min) Find research on breaking up or leaving by text.
- [ ] **The Day of the Locust** (15 min) Look up West's novel and its ending.
- [ ] **Veal Milanese** (15 min) Find the origin of cotoletta alla milanese.
- [ ] **Teen nutrition** (15 min) Look up teenage calorie needs. Is the bath-and-teaspoon joke accurate?
- [ ] **Restaurant families** (20 min) Read about family-run restaurants as community hubs.
- [ ] **Hot yoga** (15 min) Look up when hot yoga studios spread in US suburbs.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The spouse who doesn't arrive for dinner is a classic opening of disappearance stories, from Hawthorne's "Wakefield" (a husband who simply stays away) to Anne Tyler's Ladder of Years (a wife who walks off a beach).

- [ ] **Wakefield** (30 min) Read Hawthorne's "Wakefield". Compare a husband who stays away with Corinne.
- [ ] **Ladder of Years** (35 min) Read the opening of Anne Tyler's novel.
- [ ] **Gone Girl** (25 min) Compare Amy's disappearance setup.
- [ ] **Missing You** (20 min) Read about Coben's Missing You.
- [ ] **Disappearance tales** (20 min) List three novels that begin with a spouse vanishing.
- [ ] **Restaurant scenes** (20 min) Find a famous scene of someone stood up.
- [ ] **The Day of the Locust** (30 min) Read the first chapter.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Epistolary** (25 min) Read a short story told in messages or letters.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Home to a town-centre bistro, past a hot-yoga studio, parking across the street. The geography is tiny and familiar, which makes her absence louder: she could be anywhere, but she isn't here.

- [ ] **Town centre** (20 min) Add Janice's, the pizzeria, the wine shop and the yoga studio to your map.
- [ ] **Restaurant plan** (15 min) Sketch the bistro with the back table.
- [ ] **Where could she be?** (20 min) List possible locations within an evening's drive.
- [ ] **House at six** (15 min) Map the debris trail of backpacks and sweatshirts.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) How far is the bistro from home?
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 12.
- [ ] **Back tables** (15 min) Map the "private" tables in a restaurant you know.
- [ ] **Delivery routes** (15 min) Map the pizza delivery route.
- [ ] **Suburban nights** (30 min) Walk your town centre at seven and note who eats alone.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Should Adam honour a request for space, or treat it as a possible sign of danger? Respecting autonomy and acting on concern pull in opposite directions.

- [ ] **Space or search?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Lies to friends** (20 min) Is Adam's cover story to Janice wrong?
- [ ] **Autonomy** (35 min) Write 300 words on respecting a spouse's autonomy.
- [ ] **Duty to children** (25 min) What duties does Corinne's absence break?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Corinne's texts.
- [ ] **Text ethics** (20 min) Is it wrong to end a conversation by text?
- [ ] **Hope and dignity** (15 min) Is hoping a moral act?
- [ ] **Promises** (15 min) "It will be okay": can one promise that?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about being stood up.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A countdown scene with a payoff that is itself a new mystery. The texts are a clue disguised as an answer. Readers who reread later will see what Adam misses.

- [ ] **Countdown** (40 min) Write a 300-word countdown scene ending on a message.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin the texts word for word in your own paraphrase.
- [ ] **Close reading clues** (15 min) Copy the texts' wording into your notebook in your own paraphrase and list three ways each phrase could be read. Keep the list for later.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Corinne.
- [ ] **Reversal** (15 min) How does the expected confession become a disappearance?
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate this ending.
- [ ] **Comic setup** (15 min) Why put comedy before the payoff?
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A table for two set with a borrowed bottle and two poured glasses, one untouched. That's the chapter's image. Paint the empty chair.

- [ ] **Empty chair** (40 min) Paint a table for two with one empty chair and two glasses of wine.
- [ ] **Blue shirt** (25 min) Draw Adam in the blue shirt, waiting.
- [ ] **Pizza box art** (20 min) Design a pizza box for the local pizzeria.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for 7:45.
- [ ] **Restaurant sign** (35 min) Paint Janice's Bistro at night.
- [ ] **Phone screen** (20 min) Design the phone screen with the texts as an art piece.
- [ ] **Sound of a restaurant** (15 min) Describe a quiet early-evening restaurant.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the empty chair.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Pizza politics at home; veal Milanese planned at the bistro. Two meals, one that happens and one that doesn't. Restaurants feed regulars as much with attention as with food.

- [ ] **Half-and-half pizza** (45 min) Make the Half-and-Half Pizza Night recipe with friends and negotiate toppings.
- [ ] **Ice-cream sandwiches** (40 min) Make the Cookie Ice-Cream Sandwiches.
- [ ] **Veal Milanese** (45 min) Cook the Milanese recipe for someone who will turn up.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the evening's timeline.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add "where is Corinne?"
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what is your family's pizza treaty?
- [ ] **BYO night** (45 min) Hold a BYO book club and discuss New Jersey's quirks.
- [ ] **Paper plates** (15 min) Discuss: paper plates or real plates, and who loads the dishwasher?
- [ ] **Making: password card** (15 min) Discuss whether you'd share passwords with family after this chapter.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam dressed in the blue shirt she liked and sat at a table waiting. Write about a time you prepared carefully for someone who didn't come, and what you did with the evening.

- [ ] **Stood up** (20 min) Write about waiting for someone who didn't come.
- [ ] **Dressing for someone** (20 min) Write about dressing to please someone.
- [ ] **Covering** (20 min) Write about a time you covered for someone.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread and trust.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Where is Corinne? Log it.
- [ ] **The text** (20 min) Write the reply Adam might send and the one he should.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (20 min) Write a letter from the back table.
- [ ] **Space** (20 min) Write about a time you needed space.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Missing Dinner

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Cook veal Milanese.
- [ ] Paint the empty chair.
- [ ] Write about being stood up.
- [ ] Discuss the texts at table.

Reading the Texts

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Close-read the texts.
- [ ] Pin them.
- [ ] Debate respecting the request.
- [ ] Revisit when you finish the book.

Disappearance Stories

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Records Room

- [ ] Read "Wakefield".
- [ ] Read the opening of Ladder of Years.
- [ ] Research voluntary missing adults.
- [ ] Write a comparison.

Pizza Diplomacy

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Law Office

- [ ] Make half-and-half pizza.
- [ ] Analyse the negotiation.
- [ ] Discuss family treaties.
- [ ] Write a comic scene.

Town Centre Map

Rooms: Turnpike, Diner, Records Room

- [ ] Add the bistro and shops.
- [ ] Paint the bistro.
- [ ] Research BYO laws.
- [ ] Annotate the map.

Countdown Lab

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Chart the clock.
- [ ] Write a countdown scene.
- [ ] Rate tension.
- [ ] Reflect on waiting.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse how chapter 12 builds suspense through time, domestic comedy and the final texts.
2. Essay: Read Corinne's texts closely. What do they say, what do they not say, and how does Adam interpret them?
3. Creative: Write where Corinne is at 7:45 and what she is doing, without explaining why.

Further reading

- *Wakefield*, Nathaniel Hawthorne (1835). A spouse who simply stays away.
- *Ladder of Years*, Anne Tyler (1995). A wife who walks out of her life one afternoon.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). A missing wife and a husband under suspicion.
- *Missing You*, Harlan Coben (2014). Coben on love, online messages and absence.
- *Gone for Good*, Harlan Coben (2002). Coben on a disappearance that hides a family secret.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Distance, secrecy and what partners owe each other.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Withdrawal and pursuit in couples.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). A marriage that breaks over dinner.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband haunted by a wife's disappearance.

13. Room 233

What happens

Adam bombards Corinne with texts, nice, angry, calm, desperate; nothing comes back. Janice insists he take two veal Milaneses home. At the door Ryan asks where his mother is and frets about his missing home uniform. Adam notices that Ryan, like Corinne, agonises over small things, while Corinne is calm, even clutch, in real crises. He snaps at the boy, then covers with a story about a teachers' conference running over. At three in the morning he checks Ryan's phone too. Nothing. Would Corinne abandon her sons?

At dawn a thought strikes him: whatever she does to him, Corinne never misses school. In four years she has taken one day off, the day after the "miscarriage" (a Thursday), which he insisted she take after she went to the doctor on her own so as not to worry him. He marvelled then at how quickly she bounced back. Now he wonders how naive one man can be. He drives to the 1970s high school, grey with faded aqua trim, talks his way through the buzzer and signs in illegibly to wait outside her homeroom, 233. A young substitute comes out.

Kristin Hoy grabs him with a grip like a steel trap and pulls him into an empty chemistry lab. Where is Corinne? Adam admits he doesn't know. Kristin got a text too. Reluctantly she reveals that Corinne has been acting strangely for a month, distracted, missing classes and workouts, and once asked Kristin to say she'd been with her if anyone asked. The day before, Corinne asked Kristin to cover her lunchtime study hall, ran to her car, and never came back. The text to Kristin arrived around two that afternoon.

Scene by scene

1. Unanswered texts; Janice sends dinner home.
2. Ryan's missing uniform; Adam snaps, then lies about a conference.
3. A 3 a.m. check of Ryan's phone: no reply from Corinne there either.
4. Realisation: Corinne never misses school; only once, after the "miscarriage".
5. Memory of that day and Adam's naivety.
6. The high school: security buzzer, sign-in, visitor pass.
7. Homeroom 233: a substitute.
8. Kristin pulls him into a chemistry lab: she got a text too.
9. Corinne had been acting oddly for a month and asked Kristin for an alibi.
10. Yesterday she left at lunchtime and never came back.

Who's here

Adam Price	Sleepless, guilty about snapping, driven to act.
Ryan Price	Anxious about a uniform, like his mother over small things.
Kristin Hoy	Strong, loyal to Corinne, reluctantly forthcoming.
A substitute teacher	Under thirty, in Corinne's room.

Thirty questions

1. How does Adam try to reach Corinne?
2. What does Ryan need, and how does Adam react?
3. What does Adam realise about Corinne and school?

4. When did Corinne last miss school, and why?
5. Who is in Corinne's classroom?
6. What does Kristin tell Adam?
7. **Why does Adam snap at Ryan? Is he to blame?** [book club]
8. Ryan worries about small things; Corinne is "clutch" in crises. What does this tell us about her?
9. Why check Ryan's phone at 3 a.m.?
10. How does the memory of the miscarriage day read differently now?
11. **Adam berates himself for naivety. Is he naive or trusting? Is there a difference?** [book club]
12. What does the security process at school show about modern schools?
13. Why does Adam sign in illegibly?
14. What does the narrator's comparison of the school to an old sci-fi set convey?
15. Why might Kristin pull him into a chemistry lab?
16. Kristin assumes the couple has been fighting a lot. Why might she think so?
17. **What does Corinne's request for an alibi suggest?** [book club]
18. **Was Kristin right to tell Adam? Was she right to hold back?** [book club]
19. How does the timeline change: did Corinne leave before or after their confrontation?
20. **Why does this matter: odd behaviour for a month before the stranger came?** [book club]
21. How does the chapter use the word "missing" without the police?
22. Adam can understand Corinne being angry with him. Why is abandoning the boys worse?
23. How does the chapter treat Kristin's body? Compare with earlier chapters.
24. What does Adam do well as an investigator here?
25. What emotions does Adam cycle through?
26. How are teachers presented in this novel?
27. What is the effect of ending on "she never came back"?
28. What would you do next if you were Adam?
29. Write a timeline of Corinne's last known movements.
30. **Predict what Corinne was doing during her odd month.** [book club]

Close reading

1. Rereading the past

Find it: Chapter 13, middle: the memory of the day after the miscarriage.

1. Find what Corinne said she did when the cramps started.
2. Note her reason for not calling Adam.
3. Find Adam's insistence she stay home.
4. Find his reaction now.

How does the novel teach us to reread earlier events as Adam does?

2. Infiltration

Find it: Chapter 13, the school entrance and the wait outside 233.

1. List the security barriers.
2. Note each of Adam's small deceptions.
3. Describe the corridor rush.
4. Find the moment the substitute appears.

What does the school scene say about Adam's willingness to bend rules?

3. Pulling it out of her

Find it: Chapter 13, close: Kristin's revelations in the chemistry room.

1. Note each of Adam's questions.
2. Note each of Kristin's hesitations.
3. Find the alibi request.
4. Read the final exchange.

How does the scene balance loyalty and disclosure, and who wins?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter of action after a chapter of waiting. Coben uses the school's physical barriers as a series of mini-obstacles, then a cross-examination in a chemistry lab, where Adam, the lawyer, extracts a witness's story question by question.

- ☐ **Obstacle course** (35 min) List each barrier at the school and how Adam passes it. Write a scene with a similar obstacle sequence.
- ☐ **Cross-examination** (25 min) Annotate the chemistry-room conversation as a lawyer: open questions, leading questions, silences.
- ☐ **Memory revision** (30 min) Rewrite the miscarriage memory twice: as Adam saw it then, as he sees it now.
- ☐ **Similes** (15 min) Collect the chapter's similes (heart disease, Cheez Whiz, mullet). Which work?
- ☐ **Snapping** (15 min) Analyse the moment Adam snaps at Ryan. How is regret shown?
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare the speed of this chapter with chapter 12.
- ☐ **Dialogue tags** (15 min) Note how Kristin's hesitations are written.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the final line's rhythm.
- ☐ **Free indirect worry** (15 min) Find where narration becomes Adam's panic.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Responsibility to children, loyalty between friends, and the past made strange by new knowledge. The chapter also shows how ordinary life (uniforms, homework) continues around a crisis.

- ☐ **Loyalty** (25 min) Discuss loyalty between friends versus duties to spouses.
- ☐ **Reinterpreting** (25 min) Discuss how new knowledge rewrites memory.
- ☐ **Children in crisis** (25 min) Discuss how adults should talk to children when a parent goes missing.
- ☐ **Alibis** (20 min) What does asking for an alibi imply? Discuss.
- ☐ **Teachers' duty** (20 min) Discuss Corinne's professional responsibility.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "loyalty" to your themes.
- ☐ **Naivety** (20 min) Is trust a form of naivety?
- ☐ **Small and big worries** (20 min) Discuss personality differences in handling crises.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Kristin's choice.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Following school shootings such as Columbine (1999) and Sandy Hook (2012), US schools adopted locked doors, buzzers, cameras and sign-in procedures, which Adam has to negotiate.

- [ ] **School security** (30 min) Research post-Columbine security measures in US schools.
- [ ] **Teacher absence** (15 min) Find typical teacher absence rates.
- [ ] **Substitutes** (15 min) Look up how schools arrange substitutes at short notice.
- [ ] **1970s school design** (20 min) Research 1970s school architecture.
- [ ] **Logan's Run** (15 min) Look up the film and its look.
- [ ] **Missing persons** (25 min) Research when police treat a voluntary absence as a missing-person case.
- [ ] **Miscarriage and work** (20 min) Find guidance on bereavement leave after pregnancy loss.
- [ ] **Teen phones** (20 min) Find research on parents checking children's phones.
- [ ] **Visitor logs** (15 min) Look up how visitor management systems work.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Rereading the past in light of a revelation is the engine of detective fiction from Oedipus onward. Tana French's In the Woods shows a detective whose own past keeps changing meaning.

- [ ] **In the Woods** (35 min) Read the opening of Tana French's novel.
- [ ] **Oedipus** (20 min) Reread a summary: how does the past change meaning?
- [ ] **Friends' secrets** (25 min) Find a novel where a friend keeps another's secret from a spouse.
- [ ] **School novels** (20 min) Find a novel set largely in a school.
- [ ] **Big Little Lies** (25 min) Compare women's friendship and covering in Moriarty.
- [ ] **Teacher heroes** (20 min) List fictional teachers with double lives.
- [ ] **Rebecca** (25 min) Compare reinterpreting a dead or absent wife's past.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems of absence** (20 min) Find a public-domain poem about someone absent.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The high school, a 1970s building on a parking lot with no spaces; room 233 down additions and corridors. Corinne's last known location is this lot at lunchtime.

- [ ] **School map** (25 min) Sketch the school: lot, front door, office, corridors, room 233, chemistry lab.
- [ ] **Lunchtime route** (20 min) Map possible routes Corinne could have taken from the school at lunchtime.
- [ ] **Timeline map** (20 min) Combine a timeline with your map.
- [ ] **Parkway** (15 min) Note the nearest major highway to the school.
- [ ] **Kristin's house** (15 min) Add it to your map.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 13.
- [ ] **Parking** (15 min) Write about illegal parking as a small rebellion.
- [ ] **Corridors** (15 min) Describe a school corridor between periods.
- [ ] **Hidden rooms** (15 min) Map the empty rooms of a school where conversations happen.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Kristin's dilemma is loyalty versus helping. Adam's is honesty with his son versus protecting him. The ethics of covering for people keep multiplying.

- [ ] **Kristin's choice** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Lying to children** (20 min) Is Adam's conference story right?
- [ ] **Checking phones** (20 min) Is checking Ryan's phone justified?
- [ ] **Alibi ethics** (25 min) Is giving a friend an alibi ever right?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Kristin.
- [ ] **Abandonment** (20 min) Weigh Corinne's duty to her sons.
- [ ] **Breaking rules** (15 min) Is Adam's sign-in deception wrong?
- [ ] **Anger at children** (20 min) Discuss parental anger and apology.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about covering for a friend.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A new timeline emerges: odd behaviour for a month, departure at lunchtime, a text at 2 p.m. Detective stories run on timelines; start one now.

- [ ] **Timeline** (25 min) Build a timeline of Corinne's last 36 hours.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin the alibi request and the lunchtime departure.
- [ ] **Witness scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene in which a reluctant witness reveals a key fact.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Kristin and Corinne.
- [ ] **Reversal** (15 min) How does the realisation about school drive action?
- [ ] **Plant and payoff** (15 min) Log the miscarriage memory as a plant.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A chemistry lab with beakers, high taps and the obligatory periodic table: the setting for a secret conversation. Classrooms empty between periods have their own eerie stillness.

- [ ] **Chemistry lab** (40 min) Paint an empty chemistry lab with two figures.
- [ ] **1970s school** (30 min) Draw the school with grey walls and aqua trim.
- [ ] **Visitor pass** (15 min) Design a school visitor pass.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the corridor rush.
- [ ] **Periodic poem** (20 min) Write a short poem using element names.
- [ ] **Substitute** (15 min) Draw the substitute teacher.
- [ ] **Sound of a bell** (15 min) Describe a school bell and corridor noise.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add room 233 to your cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Janice's pity Milanese sits uneaten. Ryan's missing uniform is the domestic emergency. The household is short of the person who runs it.

- [ ] **Leftover Milanese** (25 min) Repurpose leftover Milanese into sandwiches; talk about leftovers of an evening.
- [ ] **Uniform hunt** (15 min) Discuss the hunt for lost kit in your home.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Corinne's timeline.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the alibi request.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: have you ever covered for a friend?
- [ ] **Lunch break** (20 min) Make a teacher's packed lunch and talk about workplace escapes.
- [ ] **Making: notebook** (20 min) Add a timeline page to your ledger notebook.
- [ ] **Breakfast alone** (20 min) Make breakfast for children when a parent is away; discuss routines.
- [ ] **Recipe of a crisis** (15 min) Write a recipe for "keeping it together".

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam snaps at his son and regrets it at once. Write about a time you took your fear out on someone smaller than the problem, and what you did afterwards.

- [ ] **Snapping** (20 min) Write about snapping at someone you love.
- [ ] **3 a.m.** (20 min) Write about 3 a.m. worries.
- [ ] **Naivety** (25 min) Write about a time you trusted and were wrong.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Where did Corinne go at lunchtime?
- [ ] **Letter to Ryan** (20 min) Write an apology to Ryan.
- [ ] **Friend's secret** (20 min) Write about keeping a friend's secret.
- [ ] **Schools** (15 min) Write a memory of your school corridors.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Corinne's Timeline

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Build the timeline.
- [ ] Map her possible routes.
- [ ] Annotate with sources (who told Adam what).
- [ ] Update each chapter.

Loyalty Lab

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss alibis.
- [ ] Write about covering for a friend.
- [ ] Write a verdict on Kristin.

School Investigation

Rooms: Turnpike, Diner, Records Room

- [ ] Map the school.
- [ ] Research security.
- [ ] Paint the chemistry lab.
- [ ] Write the infiltration scene from the guard's side.

Rereading the Past

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the miscarriage memory.
- [ ] Read the opening of In the Woods.
- [ ] Write a "then and now" memory.
- [ ] Discuss memory and trust.

Children in Crisis

Rooms: Room 233, Price Kitchen, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss how to talk to children.
- [ ] Cook a normal breakfast.
- [ ] Debate the conference lie.
- [ ] Write a guide.

Suspicion Board

Rooms: Incident Board, Room 233, Diner

- [ ] Use the Suspicion meter.
- [ ] Rate Kristin and Corinne.
- [ ] Draw a suspect wall.
- [ ] Discuss.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse how chapter 13 reinterprets the "miscarriage" through Adam's new knowledge. What does the novel suggest about memory and trust?
2. Essay: Discuss Kristin Hoy's role as witness in chapter 13 and the ethics of loyalty she embodies.
3. Creative: Write Corinne's lunchtime departure from the school car park from Kristin's window.

Further reading

- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). A detective whose understanding of the past keeps shifting.
- *Oedipus the King*, Sophocles (c. 429 BCE). A man whose past changes meaning with each revelation.
- *Big Little Lies*, Liane Moriarty (2014). Women covering for each other.
- *Rebecca*, Daphne du Maurier (1938). An absent wife reinterpreted through others' accounts.
- *Gone for Good*, Harlan Coben (2002). A family disappearance and a reinterpreted past.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). The ethics of confidences between friends.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Searching for a missing person in a tight community.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband who reinterprets the day his wife vanished.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Parenting styles and children's anxieties.

14. A Visitor for Heidi

What happens

The stranger has left Heidi a link and her daughter's login. She signs in as Kimberly and finds everything confirmed. He has also asked for money: ten thousand dollars within three days, or Kimberly's "hobby" goes public. Heidi cries, washes her face and decides first that Marty must not know. He overreacts, and Heidi remembers what happened years ago when a well-meaning busybody told them about a teenage Kimberly at a party: Marty exploded, the father-daughter bond never recovered, and Kimberly chose a college far away. Heidi doesn't want to know this, and does; she can't un-know it now.

She calls Kimberly. The conversation passes through denial, innocent explanations and angry accusations of privacy invasion before Kimberly opens up: money is tight in New York; a classmate said the men only want company. They talk for two hours. Kimberly promises to break it off, asks her mother not to come yet, and begs her not to tell Dad. That evening Marty grills burgers and the secret sits at the table in Kimberly's empty chair.

In the morning a man knocks: Detective John Kuntz of the NYPD's cyber crime unit, gap-toothed, comb-over, tired eyes. He reassures her Kimberly is safe, then says they know about the online prostitution but only want help catching the syndicate behind the couple who approached her. Heidi asks for a lawyer, then for the restaurant's name to be left alone, and starts to notice things that don't fit: how did he know so fast? Who told him? She tells him to leave. He says he can't, shoots her in the knee, covers her mouth, and threatens her daughter. Then he asks again which restaurant it was.

Scene by scene

1. Heidi logs in as Kimberly and confirms the truth; the stranger demands $10,000 in three days.
2. She cries, composes herself, and decides not to tell Marty.
3. Memory: a neighbour's "helpful" call about teenage Kimberly, Marty's overreaction, the damage.
4. The parental paradox: not wanting to know, and needing to.
5. Two hours on the phone: denial, defence, defiance, then honesty. "Don't tell Dad."
6. Burgers with Marty; the secret in Kimberly's chair.
7. Morning: "Detective Kuntz" of the NYPD cyber crime unit.
8. His questions and claims; Heidi's growing suspicion about how he knew.
9. She asks him to leave; he shoots her in the knee and threatens her daughter.

Who's here

Heidi Dann	Shocked, steady, protective, perceptive to the end of the chapter.
Kimberly Dann	At NYU; ashamed, defensive, then candid.
Marty Dann	Kind, volatile when it comes to his daughter; kept in the dark.
John Kuntz	Claims to be an NYPD cyber crime detective; middle-aged, tired, sinister.
The stranger	Absent, but his demand for money changes how we see him.

Thirty questions

1. What does the stranger demand from Heidi?
2. Why does Heidi decide not to tell Marty?

3. What happened when Kimberly was in high school?
4. What stages does Kimberly go through on the phone?
5. Who comes to Heidi's door, and what does he claim?
6. What makes Heidi suspicious?
7. **The stranger asks for money. How does that change your view of him?** [book club]
8. Heidi's secret from Marty mirrors other secrets in the book. How?
9. **Was the busybody neighbour right to tell, years ago?** [book club]
10. **The "parental paradox": wanting and not wanting to know. Do you recognise it?** [book club]
11. How does Heidi handle the call with Kimberly? What does it show about her as a mother?
12. **Kimberly asks her mother not to tell her father. Is that fair to ask?** [book club]
13. The secret "sits" in Kimberly's chair. Discuss the image.
14. How does Kuntz manipulate Heidi before the violence?
15. What does his description (comb-over, gap teeth) do to our impression?
16. How does Heidi's intelligence show in this scene?
17. Why does Kuntz want the restaurant's name?
18. **Is the violence shocking within the novel's tone? Why might Coben choose this moment?** [book club]
19. Who might Kuntz really work for? Speculate from the evidence.
20. How does this chapter raise the stakes of the stranger's operation?
21. **What does the chapter suggest about the dangers of revelation?** [book club]
22. How do the two halves of the chapter (mother and daughter; mother and gunman) mirror each other?
23. Why does Kuntz say he has kids too?
24. What would you have done at the door?
25. How does Heidi's point of view differ from Adam's?
26. The stranger told Heidi; now someone else knows. How?
27. What does the chapter show about secrets travelling?
28. How is Marty characterised in absentia?
29. What is the effect of ending on a question?
30. Predict what Kuntz will do next.

Close reading

1. Telling, then and now

Find it: Chapter 14, opening: Heidi's decisions after logging in, and the memory of the busybody's call.

1. Find Heidi's first decision.
2. Summarise the earlier incident.
3. List its consequences for the family.
4. Find the "paradox" sentence and paraphrase it.

How does the earlier "helpful" disclosure comment on the stranger's?

2. Stages of confession

Find it: Chapter 14, middle: the phone call with Kimberly.

1. List the stages Kimberly passes through.
2. Note Heidi's steadiness.
3. Find Kimberly's explanation of how she started.
4. Find the final request.

Why does the novel spell out the predictable stages of confession, and how do they compare with Corinne's?

3. Reading a threat

Find it: Chapter 14, close: Kuntz at the door through to the shot.

1. Note Kuntz's reassurances.
2. Find the moment Heidi's "tingling" begins (paraphrase).
3. Trace her logic about the timing.
4. Note how quickly the violence comes.

How does Coben build the scene so that Heidi, and the reader, realise the danger together?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The first chapter from a victim's point of view. Heidi's voice is practical and wry even in grief. The chapter moves from long reflective paragraphs to clipped dialogue to sudden violence in a few lines; note how the prose refuses to linger on the gunshot.

- ☐ **Victim's voice** (30 min) Compare Heidi's narrative voice with Adam's. Write 150 words in her voice about something ordinary.
- ☐ **Stages** (20 min) Map Kimberly's stages as a graph of emotional intensity.
- ☐ **Restraint in violence** (20 min) Analyse how few words the shooting takes. Why?
- ☐ **Menace in description** (15 min) List Kuntz's physical details. Which create menace?
- ☐ **Logic on the page** (20 min) Trace Heidi's reasoning about timing line by line.
- ☐ **Image of the chair** (15 min) Write a paragraph about the secret in the empty chair.
- ☐ **Dialogue as trap** (20 min) Show how Kuntz's questions trap Heidi.
- ☐ **Rewrite** (30 min) Rewrite the door scene from Kuntz's point of view (no violence detail).
- ☐ **Ending on a question** (15 min) Why end with Kuntz repeating his question?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

The ethics of telling cuts both ways here: an old disclosure damaged a family; a new one leads to violence. The novel's optimism about truth darkens. Also, secrets within secrets: Heidi keeps one from Marty while learning one from Kimberly.

- ☐ **Telling and harm** (25 min) Discuss how disclosure caused harm then and now.

- [ ] **Secrets within families** (25 min) Discuss Heidi keeping Kimberly's secret from Marty.
- [ ] **Money and silence** (25 min) Discuss blackmail as a business model.
- [ ] **Student finance** (25 min) Discuss pressures that push students toward risky income.
- [ ] **Violence** (20 min) Discuss how violence changes a novel's moral world.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "consequences" to your themes.
- [ ] **Mothers and daughters** (20 min) Discuss the phone call as a portrait of a relationship.
- [ ] **Father-daughter rifts** (20 min) Discuss Marty and Kimberly.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of "was the busybody right?"

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Students using sugar-dating sites to pay tuition made headlines around 2014–15. Impersonating police is a serious crime; real investigators would not arrive alone from another state overnight without coordination, which is one thing Heidi notices.

- [ ] **Impersonating police** (20 min) Research the crime of impersonating a police officer.
- [ ] **Student debt 2015** (25 min) Research student debt and living costs in New York around 2015.
- [ ] **Cybercrime units** (20 min) Look up when big-city police forces created cyber units.
- [ ] **Blackmail law** (25 min) Research the legal definition of extortion.
- [ ] **Sugar dating press** (25 min) Find a balanced article on students and sugar dating.
- [ ] **Victim support** (15 min) Look up what victim-support services do (for knowledge).
- [ ] **NYU costs** (15 min) Find NYU's cost of attendance around 2015.
- [ ] **Teen party culture** (20 min) Find research on parents learning about teenage parties.
- [ ] **Burgers** (15 min) Look up the American backyard grill as a cultural ritual.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The menacing man who presents as an official recalls the false policemen of noir. Kuntz enters a tradition including the soft-spoken killers of Patricia Highsmith and Dennis Lehane.

- [ ] **Lehane** (25 min) Read about the menacing figures in Gone, Baby, Gone.
- [ ] **Highsmith** (25 min) Read about Ripley's calm menace.
- [ ] **Mothers and secrets** (25 min) Find a novel where a mother keeps a child's secret from a father.
- [ ] **Milverton** (20 min) Revisit: does the stranger now look like Milverton?
- [ ] **False police** (25 min) Find a classic crime story with a false policeman.
- [ ] **Ronson** (30 min) Read Ronson on exposure online.
- [ ] **Bok** (25 min) Read Bok on blackmail.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Little Fires** (25 min) Compare a mother's investigation of a daughter.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The Dann house in Beachwood; Kimberly in New York; Kuntz claims to have flown in that morning. The novel's map now has a second hub, and danger travels between them.

- [ ] **Beachwood house** (15 min) Sketch the Dann house: door, living room, chair.

- [ ] **Travel time** (20 min) How long would it take to fly from New York to Cleveland and reach Beachwood by morning?
- [ ] **Strand map** (20 min) Draw lines between Beachwood, New York and Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Kimberly's New York** (15 min) Add NYU and Greenwich Village to your map.
- [ ] **Red Lobster** (15 min) Mark it relative to the house.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 14.
- [ ] **Suburban vulnerability** (20 min) Write about how houses can feel unsafe.
- [ ] **Neighbours** (15 min) Map the busybody neighbour's house.
- [ ] **Danger map** (15 min) Mark where danger has appeared so far.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Was Heidi right not to tell Marty? Was the stranger right to tell Heidi? Did he consider who else might learn? The chapter adds a new moral variable: unforeseen consequences.

- [ ] **Tell Marty?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Blackmail** (30 min) Is the stranger's demand morally different from telling for free?
- [ ] **Busybody** (30 min) Use the Five lenses on the neighbour's call years ago.
- [ ] **Consequences** (25 min) Is the stranger responsible for Kuntz's violence?
- [ ] **Daughter's request** (20 min) Should Heidi honour "don't tell Dad"?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update your verdict on the stranger in the Tell or keep tool.
- [ ] **Lying to police** (15 min) Was Heidi right to ask for a lawyer?
- [ ] **Protection** (20 min) Heidi protects Kimberly to the end. Discuss.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write privately about a family secret kept from one parent.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A new antagonist enters, fully menacing, with motives hidden. The strand braid gains a dark thread. The chapter ends on a question we know Heidi will answer.

- [ ] **New antagonist** (20 min) Write about how Kuntz is introduced and what is withheld.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin the $10,000 demand and Kuntz's question.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Add the Kuntz strand.
- [ ] **Threat scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene in which a polite visitor becomes a threat.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Kuntz and the stranger.
- [ ] **Plant and payoff** (15 min) Log "who told Kuntz?" as a plant.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A suburban living room on a bright morning: couch, chair, rug, a stranger with a golf pencil. Violence in a bright domestic room is one of the most unsettling images in suspense art.

- [ ] **Bright room, dark act** (40 min) Paint a bright suburban living room with an ominous figure.

- [ ] **Kuntz portrait** (25 min) Draw Kuntz from the description, without caricature.
- [ ] **Empty chair** (25 min) Paint Kimberly's empty chair at the dinner table.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the phone call.
- [ ] **Badge** (20 min) Design a fake badge and note what makes it look real.
- [ ] **Morning light** (15 min) Describe Ohio morning light.
- [ ] **Sound of a knock** (15 min) Write about how a knock can sound wrong.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the door to your cover brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Burgers on the grill, drinks poured, two people talking about their days while a third chair holds a secret. The family dinner as a performance of normality, once more.

- [ ] **Backyard burgers** (45 min) Grill burgers and discuss performances of normality.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the $10,000 demand.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Heidi's secret from Marty.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you tell your partner about your child's secret?
- [ ] **Empty place** (15 min) Set an empty place at dinner and discuss absence.
- [ ] **Comfort** (15 min) Make tea for someone after a hard phone call.
- [ ] **Making: secrets box** (20 min) Add a "dangerous secrets" compartment.
- [ ] **Student budget** (25 min) Make a student's weekly budget for New York and discuss.
- [ ] **Recipe of a phone call** (15 min) Write the recipe for a hard conversation.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Heidi says she didn't want to know, and did. Write about a truth you wished you hadn't learned and also couldn't have lived without knowing.

- [ ] **Not wanting to know** (20 min) Write about a truth you wish you hadn't learned.
- [ ] **Protecting a child** (25 min) Write privately about protecting a child from a parent's reaction.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Will Heidi tell him?
- [ ] **Letter to Kimberly** (20 min) Write from Heidi.
- [ ] **Letter to Marty** (20 min) Write what Heidi might have told him.
- [ ] **Fear** (20 min) Write about a moment you sensed danger.
- [ ] **Busybodies** (20 min) Write about someone who "helpfully" told you something.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Telling, Then and Now

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the busybody memory.
- [ ] Compare with the stranger.
- [ ] Apply the Five lenses.
- [ ] Write privately.

The Kuntz File

Rooms: Incident Board, Records Room, Turnpike

- [ ] Pin Kuntz.
- [ ] Research police impersonation.
- [ ] Map his travel.
- [ ] Predict his employer.

Mothers and Daughters

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Close-read the phone call.
- [ ] Read a mother-daughter novel excerpt.
- [ ] Discuss at table.
- [ ] Write a letter from Heidi.

Blackmail as Business

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research extortion law.
- [ ] Discuss the stranger's demand.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Bright Room, Dark Act

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Incident Board

- [ ] Paint the room.
- [ ] Analyse restraint in violence.
- [ ] Write a threat scene.
- [ ] Discuss what to show and not show.

Normality as Performance

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Grill burgers.
- [ ] Discuss the empty chair.
- [ ] Write about performing normal.
- [ ] Compare with the Prices' dinner.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 14 complicate the novel's view of truth-telling? Consider the old disclosure, the stranger's demand and the consequences.
2. Essay: Analyse Heidi Dann as a point-of-view character. How does Coben make her vivid and sympathetic so quickly?
3. Creative: Write Kimberly's side of the two-hour phone call, beginning after she hangs up.

Further reading

- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). Holmes' blackmailer, who sells silence.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). A crime story full of people who are not what they say.
- *The Talented Mr. Ripley*, Patricia Highsmith (1955). A charming, ruthless impostor.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). The real damage of public exposure online.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). On secrecy, revelation and blackmail.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). A mother investigating another family's secrets.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). Family secrets and false identities.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). What children hide from parents and why.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). How an online record can follow a young person.

15. Toll Records

What happens

At his desk Adam asks the obvious question: if Corinne ran, where would she go? He can't imagine her confiding in anyone but him, so she's probably alone in a hotel, and that costs money. He handles the family finances and knows every password. Her cards show a charge almost every day (supermarket, coffee, the lacrosse shop, lunch spots, sushi takeaway, the gym, online clothes) and then nothing, yesterday and today. Her last cash withdrawal was two hundred dollars, two weeks ago. Did she plan this? Was she surprised by the confrontation or resigned to it? He realises he knows nothing for sure, and his mind swings to darker possibilities: the texts could have come from someone else.

Something about the texts bothers him, though he can't say what. He thinks about going to the police, but the local chief, Len Gilman, has a son in Ryan's homeroom, and the town would talk; Corinne fought hard to make this town hers again. Andy Gribbel, in sunglasses after a late gig, recounts the band's set: a slow seventies ballad, then a big duet he sang both parts of himself. He also passes on a request: Kasselton's mayor wants to meet after a town-hall event.

Adam has another idea: E-ZPass. If she drove on toll roads, her transponder will have logged it. He needs the account details from bills at home. Driving home, he takes a call from Thomas asking where Mom is. In his driveway he finds Tripp Evans, who has been texting Corinne without reply. She missed a lacrosse board meeting; Tripp wants to "fill her in" on some business but cites board confidentiality. Both men look rattled, and both say so. Tripp leaves, asking Adam to have her call.

Scene by scene

1. Where would Corinne go? Probably a hotel, alone.
2. Adam checks every account: daily charges until two days ago, then nothing.
3. Last ATM withdrawal: $200, two weeks earlier. Did she plan this?
4. Darker thoughts: what if the texts didn't come from her?
5. The police dilemma: the local chief, gossip, Corinne's hard-won place in town.
6. Gribbel's gig report; the mayor wants a meeting.
7. The E-ZPass idea; the account number is at home.
8. Thomas calls: where's Mom?
9. Tripp Evans waiting in the drive: Corinne missed a board meeting; "board confidentiality".
10. Each man tells the other he looks rattled.

Who's here

Adam Price	Methodical, frightened, doing the research.
Andy Gribbel	Hungover, cheerful, a one-man duet.
Thomas Price	Starting to ask harder questions.
Tripp Evans	Awkward in a suit, evasive about lacrosse business.
Len Gilman	The police chief Adam doesn't want to call.

Thirty questions

1. Where does Adam think Corinne would go?
2. What do the card records show?
3. When was her last cash withdrawal, and how much?
4. Why doesn't Adam go to the police?
5. What is the E-ZPass idea?
6. Why has Tripp come to the house?
7. **Adam handles all the finances and knows every password. What does this division of labour say about the marriage?** [book club]
8. What does a person's spending reveal? List what Corinne's charges say about her.
9. **Did Corinne plan this? Weigh the evidence.** [book club]
10. Why does Adam start to wonder whether Corinne sent the texts at all? Is that reasonable or paranoid?
11. **What is "off" about the texts? Make a list of possibilities.** [book club]
12. How do gossip and reputation shape Adam's choices?
13. Corinne fought to make this town hers again. Why does that matter to Adam's decisions?
14. Why does Coben include Gribbel's comic gig report here?
15. **Is singing both parts of a duet a metaphor for anything in the novel?** [book club]
16. What does Thomas's phone call add?
17. How is Tripp described physically, and what does the suit suggest?
18. Why might Tripp be rattled?
19. **"Board confidentiality" about a children's sports league: plausible or suspicious?** [book club]
20. How does the chapter use money as a trail?
21. What does Adam do well as an investigator in this chapter?
22. How is technology both a help and a threat in this chapter?
23. What would you search first if someone you loved vanished?
24. How does the E-ZPass idea reflect a surveilled world? What other trails might exist?
25. Why end the chapter on Tripp leaving?
26. Compare Tripp in his suit with Tripp at the Legion bar.
27. Adam senses something wrong in the texts but can't name it. What does that make you go back and check?
28. **Is it ethical for Adam to search Corinne's accounts now?** [book club]
29. How does the narrative keep the Rinsky subplot alive?
30. Predict what the lacrosse business is.

Close reading

1. A life in transactions

Find it: Chapter 15, opening: Adam's review of Corinne's card charges and withdrawals.

1. List the regular charges.
2. Note what has stopped and when.
3. Find the cash-withdrawal detail.
4. Find the questions Adam asks about planning.

How does a list of purchases become both a portrait and a clue?

2. Reasons not to call

Find it: Chapter 15, middle: Adam weighing the police and rereading the texts.

1. List his reasons against going to the police.
2. Note his thoughts about gossip and Corinne's town.
3. Find where he rereads the texts.
4. Note his inability to name what's wrong.

What do Adam's reasons for not calling the police tell us about the town and about him?

3. Two rattled men

Find it: Chapter 15, close: Tripp in the driveway.

1. Note Tripp's reasons for coming.
2. Find the description of him in a suit.
3. Find the exchange about looking rattled.
4. Note what Tripp refuses to say.

What tension enters with Tripp, and how does the dialogue signal it?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A procedural chapter: research, inference, ideas, interruption. The comic Gribbel scene sits in the middle as a hinge. The closing driveway exchange uses mirrored dialogue (each man saying "I'll be honest") to show a shift in their relationship.

- ☐ **Procedural rhythm** (35 min) Outline the chapter as a series of investigative steps. Write a procedural scene of your own.
- ☐ **Mirrored dialogue** (20 min) Analyse the "I'll be honest" exchange. Write a mirrored exchange of your own.
- ☐ **The list** (15 min) Write about how a list of purchases characterises Corinne.
- ☐ **Gribbel's voice** (20 min) Write a new gig report in Gribbel's voice.
- ☐ **Darker thoughts** (15 min) Find where Adam's thoughts spiral and the line that halts them.
- ☐ **Suits** (15 min) Analyse the description of men in suits. Whose view is it?
- ☐ **Radio** (15 min) Analyse the radio-flipping passage as an image of the search.
- ☐ **Interruption** (15 min) Count the interruptions in the chapter.
- ☐ **Summary** (15 min) Write a 50-word summary for a book club newsletter.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Surveillance as care and as threat; reputation and gossip; the division of financial knowledge in marriage. The chapter also introduces institutional secrecy (board confidentiality) into the private story.

- ☐ **Financial knowledge** (25 min) Discuss who manages money in partnerships and why it matters.
- ☐ **Gossip** (25 min) Discuss gossip as social control in small towns.
- ☐ **Reputation vs safety** (25 min) Debate calling the police.
- ☐ **Institutional secrets** (20 min) Discuss confidentiality in volunteer organisations.

- [ ] **Surveillance as care** (20 min) Discuss when tracking is caring.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "trails" to your themes.
- [ ] **Planning** (20 min) What would it mean if Corinne planned this?
- [ ] **Masculinity** (15 min) Discuss men "looking rattled" and admitting it.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of the police decision.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

E-ZPass launched in the 1990s and spread across the north-east; toll records have been used in court cases. Online banking let spouses see each other's spending instantly. These are the trails the novel's characters leave.

- [ ] **E-ZPass history** (25 min) Research when E-ZPass began and how toll data is stored.
- [ ] **Toll data in court** (30 min) Find a case where toll records were used as evidence.
- [ ] **Financial abuse** (25 min) Read a reputable explainer on financial control in relationships (to contrast with this marriage).
- [ ] **ATM limits** (15 min) Look up typical daily ATM limits.
- [ ] **Volunteer boards** (30 min) Research governance of youth sports nonprofits (treasurer's duties).
- [ ] **Missing adults policy** (20 min) Research when police take a missing adult report.
- [ ] **Kansas and Meat Loaf** (15 min) Look up the songs' histories.
- [ ] **Bank alerts** (15 min) Research when banks introduced spending alerts.
- [ ] **Garden State Parkway** (15 min) Look up its history.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Following the money is a staple from Chandler to modern procedurals. Gribbel's one-man duets echo the theme of people playing both parts of a relationship.

- [ ] **Following the money** (25 min) Find a classic detective story that turns on financial records.
- [ ] **Chandler** (30 min) Read Chandler's essay "The Simple Art of Murder".
- [ ] **Zuboff** (30 min) Read an excerpt on data trails.
- [ ] **Duet songs** (15 min) List duets that tell a story of a relationship.
- [ ] **Gossip in fiction** (25 min) Find a novel where gossip drives the plot.
- [ ] **Big Little Lies** (20 min) Revisit the gossip theme.
- [ ] **Solove** (25 min) Read on gossip and the internet.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Accounting novels** (20 min) Find a thriller about embezzlement.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Toll plazas on the Garden State Parkway near the school would have logged Corinne's car if she drove south or north. The map of where she went is now a map of where she paid.

- [ ] **Toll map** (20 min) Mark toll plazas near the school on your map.
- [ ] **Spending map** (20 min) Map Corinne's regular shops.
- [ ] **Distance** (20 min) How far could she have got by the time of her text?
- [ ] **Office to home** (15 min) Map Adam's commute via I-80.

- [ ] **Tripp's Durango** (15 min) Mark the driveway encounter.
- [ ] **Hotels** (20 min) List hotels near major highways out of Bergen County.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 15.
- [ ] **Data map** (25 min) Draw a map of all the data trails a person leaves in a day.
- [ ] **Kasselton** (15 min) Mark the town hall at PineCliff.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is checking a spouse's finances surveillance or concern? Is gossip a reason not to call the police? The chapter weighs privacy, safety and reputation.

- [ ] **Police dilemma** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Financial privacy** (20 min) Is searching joint accounts a violation?
- [ ] **Confidentiality** (30 min) Use the Five lenses on Tripp's confidentiality.
- [ ] **Gossip ethics** (20 min) Is spreading news about a neighbour ever right?
- [ ] **Reputation** (20 min) How much should reputation weigh?
- [ ] **Planning and guilt** (20 min) If Corinne planned to leave, is she more culpable?
- [ ] **Children's right to know** (20 min) Should Adam tell Thomas the truth?
- [ ] **Trust in institutions** (20 min) Why doesn't Adam trust the local police?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about protecting someone's reputation.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

New threads: the texts feel wrong; the cash trail stops; the lacrosse board is hiding something. The chapter adds Tripp as a figure of unease.

- [ ] **Money trail** (15 min) Pin the spending stop and the $200.
- [ ] **The texts** (15 min) Pin Adam's unease about the texts, and list three things that could be wrong with them.
- [ ] **Tripp** (15 min) Pin Tripp's visit and his secrecy.
- [ ] **Procedural scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene of someone searching records.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Tripp.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Update Corinne's timeline.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note three strands touched here.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Gribbel's band opens with a slow ballad about everything blowing away, then segues into a car-park duet. Think about setlists as storytelling.

- [ ] **Setlist** (20 min) Write a setlist for Gribbel's band and explain its arc.
- [ ] **One-man duet** (20 min) Perform a duet alone for friends; discuss what it does.
- [ ] **Receipt art** (30 min) Make art from a receipt of a week.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.

- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick the "nonexistent perfect song".
- [ ] **Driveway** (35 min) Paint two men in suits in a driveway at dusk.
- [ ] **Toll plaza** (35 min) Paint a toll plaza at night.
- [ ] **Radio dial** (20 min) Draw an old radio dial with stations as moods.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a data-trail idea.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Corinne's card statement is a menu of her week: supermarket, coffee, sushi takeaway, lunch out. You could draw her life as a receipt.

- [ ] **Sushi night** (40 min) Make or buy sushi and talk about habits that reveal us.
- [ ] **Receipt diary** (20 min) Keep a week's food receipts; what do they say?
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Corinne's charges and the stop.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Tripp's board secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who manages money in your home?
- [ ] **Burgers from frozen** (30 min) Cook frozen burgers and talk about convenience food in crisis.
- [ ] **Making: licence-plate notebook** (30 min) Start the licence-plate notebook project.
- [ ] **Budget** (25 min) Draw up a household budget.
- [ ] **Recipe of a trail** (15 min) Write a recipe for disappearing without trace.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam drives home flipping radio stations looking for the right song and never finds it. Write about searching for something that keeps being almost right.

- [ ] **Radio search** (15 min) Write about searching for the right song.
- [ ] **Where would I go?** (20 min) Write privately: if you ran, where would you go?
- [ ] **Reputation** (20 min) Write about caring what the town thinks.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What is the lacrosse business?
- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (20 min) Write what Adam might say truthfully.
- [ ] **Rattled** (20 min) Write about seeing someone strong look rattled.
- [ ] **Passwords** (15 min) Write about the passwords you share.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Data Trail

Rooms: Records Room, Turnpike, Incident Board

- [ ] Research E-ZPass and bank alerts.
- [ ] Map a day of data.
- [ ] Pin Corinne's trail.
- [ ] Update the timeline.

The Lacrosse Board

Rooms: Incident Board, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin Tripp's secrecy.
- [ ] Research board governance.
- [ ] Debate confidentiality.
- [ ] Predict.

Gossip Town

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss gossip.
- [ ] Read on reputation.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Setlist Night

Rooms: Diner, Price Kitchen, Law Office

- [ ] Listen to the songs.
- [ ] Write a setlist.
- [ ] Make sushi.
- [ ] Write a gig report.

Receipts

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Keep receipts.
- [ ] Close-read the charges.
- [ ] Write a character from receipts.
- [ ] Reflect.

Where Would You Go?

Rooms: Driveway, Turnpike, Room 233

- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Map hotels.
- [ ] Discuss running away.
- [ ] Compare with Corinne.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 15 use financial and electronic trails to explore privacy and intimacy in marriage?
2. Essay: Analyse the encounter between Adam and Tripp at the end of chapter 15. How does dialogue create tension?
3. Creative: Write a day in Corinne's life as told only through her card statement, with one line per charge.

Further reading

- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). How our everyday data becomes a trail others can read.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Gossip, reputation and the internet.
- *The Simple Art of Murder*, Raymond Chandler (1944). Chandler on what crime fiction is for.
- *Big Little Lies*, Liane Moriarty (2014). Gossip as social power in a wealthy town.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Searching for a missing person.
- *The (Honest) Truth About Dishonesty*, Dan Ariely (2012). How honest people rationalise small dishonesty with money.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Civic associations and their volunteers.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Coben on rumour and reputation in a suburban town.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband following electronic traces.

16. Call Me Gush

What happens

Mayor Rick Gusherowski looks exactly as Adam expected: soft, ruddy, practised smile. Three of Kasselton's last four mayors were indicted, and Gusherowski served in two of those administrations. The town hall meeting he's ending is at PineCliff Luxury Village, a new retirement community whose median resident looks to be in their eighties. He greets Adam with a game-show grin and a politician's handshake and insists on being called "Gush".

He gives Adam a tour. Asked what makes the place "state-of-the-art", Gush can only offer flat-screen televisions and internet access. The deluxe unit looks, Adam says, like an airport chain hotel. Gush's pitch moves through nostalgia (memories hold us back), community (progress, jobs, a new centre, an end to blight) and finally Eunice, who would be happier here.

Adam refuses on principle: in America it isn't the state's job to rule on what will make a citizen happy. Gush offers fifty thousand dollars more. Adam answers in a movie villain's voice with a joke figure and then a straight no. Gush reminds him a judge has already approved the taking and the Rinskys' previous lawyer lost the appeal. Adam suggests the developers simply build around the house. Gush, his smile gone, says that can't happen, and that after the way they've behaved he'll throw them out with pleasure. Adam says he figured as much and leaves.

Scene by scene

1. Gush's appearance and Kasselton's record of indicted mayors.
2. The town hall at PineCliff Luxury Village.
3. "Call me Gush."
4. The tour: "state-of-the-art" means flat screens and Wi-Fi.
5. The deluxe unit, compared to a chain hotel.
6. The pitch: memories, progress, community, Eunice.
7. Adam: it isn't the state's job to rule on a citizen's happiness.
8. Fifty thousand more; Adam's villain joke; no.
9. Gush: the law is on his side; he'll throw them out with pleasure.
10. Adam: "build around the house"; he leaves.

Who's here

Rick "Gush" Gusherowski	Mayor of Kasselton: a showman with a sharp edge.
Adam Price	Dry, principled, enjoying himself a little.
The PineCliff residents	An elderly audience for a town hall meeting.

Thirty questions

1. What is Kasselton's record with mayors?
2. Where is the town hall meeting held?
3. What makes PineCliff "state-of-the-art", according to Gush?
4. What is Gush's offer?
5. What legal facts favour the town?
6. What does Adam suggest as a compromise?

7. **Is it fair for Adam to judge Gush on his looks and his town's history?** [book club]
8. How does Coben make Gush a comic villain?
9. **What is Adam's principle about government and happiness? Do you agree?** [book club]
10. **Gush says memories can hold us back. Is he entirely wrong?** [book club]
11. Why does Adam enjoy needling Gush?
12. What changes when Gush stops smiling?
13. Does the "build around the house" suggestion seem realistic?
14. **How does this subplot mirror the main plot's theme of who decides what's good for you?** [book club]
15. **The stranger also decides what's good for people. Compare him with Gush.** [book club]
16. Why set the meeting in a retirement community?
17. What does the chain-hotel comparison imply about the unit?
18. Is Adam a good advocate here? What tactics does he use?
19. How does Gush's handshake technique work?
20. What does "with pleasure" reveal?
21. Does the chapter present the developers fairly?
22. How does humour serve the argument?
23. What would you say to Gush?
24. What does Adam's "I figured" ending suggest about his plan?
25. Is there any sympathy for Gush in the chapter?
26. How do game-show comparisons frame politics?
27. What does the chapter say about New Jersey?
28. **Is property more than money? Discuss.** [book club]
29. How has the Rinsky case changed since chapter 11?
30. Predict the next move in the Rinsky fight.

Close reading

1. Prejudice or perception?

Find it: Chapter 16, opening: Adam's first impression of Gush and the town's history.

1. List the details of Gush's appearance.
2. Note the facts about Kasselton's mayors.
3. Find the narrator's rule about smoke and fire (paraphrase).
4. Note Adam's claim not to judge on looks.

Does the opening judge Gush fairly? How does the narration handle its own prejudice?

2. Deflating a salesman

Find it: Chapter 16, middle: the tour and the "state-of-the-art" exchange.

1. Trace Adam's questions about "state-of-the-art".
2. Note Gush's answers.
3. Find the hotel comparison.
4. Note how Gush recovers.

How does Socratic questioning expose a sales pitch?

3. The smile drops

Find it: Chapter 16, close: the offer, the refusal and the threat.

1. Find Adam's principle about government.
2. Note the offer and the joke.
3. Find the legal reminders.
4. Read the final threat and Adam's answer.

What does the final exchange reveal about each man?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Comic set piece in the form of a tour. Adam plays the straight man with questions; Gush fills silence with clichés. Watch how many TV comparisons the narration uses: politics as game show.

- ☐ **Straight man** (30 min) Analyse Adam as the straight man. Write a comic dialogue where one character keeps asking "what does that mean?"
- ☐ **TV comparisons** (15 min) List every TV reference. What do they do?
- ☐ **Pitch parody** (20 min) Write a sales pitch for a deliberately ordinary product.
- ☐ **Smile tracking** (15 min) Track Gush's smile through the chapter.
- ☐ **Principle in a line** (20 min) Rewrite Adam's principle in five different registers.
- ☐ **Villain voice** (15 min) Write about why Adam's joke works.
- ☐ **Opening prejudice** (20 min) Rewrite the opening without prejudgement.
- ☐ **Dialogue pace** (15 min) Compare pace here with the Tripp driveway scene.
- ☐ **Last line** (15 min) Analyse "I figured".

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Paternalism is the theme: officials deciding what makes people happy. It echoes the stranger, who decides what people need to know. Who gets to decide what's good for you?

- ☐ **Paternalism** (25 min) Discuss paternalism with examples from the novel.
- ☐ **Who decides?** (30 min) Debate: who should decide what's good for you?
- ☐ **Corruption** (20 min) Discuss how corruption is portrayed comically.
- ☐ **Elderly as audience** (20 min) Discuss the setting at a retirement community.
- ☐ **Progress** (20 min) Revisit the progress debate.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "paternalism" to your themes.
- ☐ **Stranger and Gush** (25 min) Compare two characters who decide for others.
- ☐ **Memory** (20 min) Is nostalgia a trap?
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of the happiness principle.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

New Jersey has a long history of municipal corruption prosecutions by the US Attorney's office. Eminent-domain takings for redevelopment were upheld in Kelo (2005), which is why the town has the law on its side.

- [ ] **NJ corruption** (30 min) Research a notable New Jersey municipal corruption case.
- [ ] **Retirement communities** (20 min) Research the growth of "luxury" senior living.
- [ ] **Appeals** (20 min) Look up how eminent-domain appeals work.
- [ ] **Mill** (25 min) Read about Mill's harm principle.
- [ ] **Guy Smiley** (15 min) Look up the Muppet and what his comparison says about Gush.
- [ ] **Game shows** (15 min) Research The Price Is Right's history.
- [ ] **Developers** (25 min) Research how developers partner with towns.
- [ ] **Compensation** (25 min) Look up how "just compensation" is calculated.
- [ ] **Town halls** (15 min) Research the US town-hall meeting tradition.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Ibsen's An Enemy of the People pits one man against civic leaders who put the town's economy first. Sandel's Justice explains utilitarian reasoning and its critics.

- [ ] **On Liberty** (35 min) Read Mill's chapter on individuality.
- [ ] **Enemy of the People** (35 min) Read Act 4 of Ibsen's play (the public meeting).
- [ ] **Little Pink House** (30 min) Read the chapter on the city's offers.
- [ ] **Satire of politicians** (20 min) Find a comic portrait of a politician in fiction.
- [ ] **Sandel** (35 min) Read Sandel's chapter on utilitarianism.
- [ ] **Evicted** (25 min) Compare forced moves.
- [ ] **Corruption novels** (20 min) List three novels about local corruption.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Senior fiction** (20 min) Find a novel set in a retirement home.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

PineCliff sits "in the heights", above the old downtown the developer wants to clear. The map of a town is also a map of who gets moved where.

- [ ] **Heights and downtown** (20 min) Map PineCliff and the old downtown.
- [ ] **Development map** (30 min) Draw the developer's plan with the house in the middle.
- [ ] **Build around** (30 min) Redesign the plan to build around the house.
- [ ] **Retirement geography** (20 min) Map senior housing in your area.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 16.
- [ ] **Corridors** (15 min) Describe a corridor in a new building.
- [ ] **Chain spaces** (20 min) Write about generic spaces (hotels, airports).
- [ ] **Town hall** (15 min) Map where your own town holds meetings.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Kasselton on your status ladder.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Adam's line about happiness is a liberal principle (in the philosophical sense): individuals, not governments, judge their own good. John Stuart Mill made the classic case in On Liberty (1859).

- [ ] **Happiness principle** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Mill** (25 min) Apply Mill's harm principle to the case.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the taking.
- [ ] **Offers** (20 min) Is refusing more money irrational or principled?
- [ ] **Spite** (15 min) Is "with pleasure" a moral failing in an official?
- [ ] **Lawyers' humour** (15 min) Is mocking an opponent professional?
- [ ] **Compromise** (20 min) Is building around the house a fair compromise?
- [ ] **Paternalism** (25 min) Compare Gush and the stranger ethically.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about someone deciding what was good for you.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A subplot chapter that sharpens an antagonist and raises stakes (the law is against them). It also keeps the "nuclear option" hidden, a suspense device for a lighter strand.

- [ ] **Raising stakes** (15 min) Write how this chapter raises the subplot stakes.
- [ ] **Hidden plan** (15 min) Write about the suspense of a hidden plan.
- [ ] **Antagonist** (35 min) Write a short scene with a smiling antagonist.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (15 min) Pin Gush's threat.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Gush.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the Rinsky strand.
- [ ] **Comic subplot** (15 min) Discuss comic subplots in thrillers.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Game shows, Muppets, The Price Is Right: the visual culture of American TV supplies the chapter's comedy. Picture Gush as a host revealing a prize door.

- [ ] **Game-show poster** (25 min) Design a game-show poster for "Name That Bribe".
- [ ] **Gush portrait** (20 min) Draw Gush with his grin.
- [ ] **Generic room** (30 min) Paint a generic hotel room as a still life.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a game-show theme for Gush.
- [ ] **Flag pin** (15 min) Design a lapel pin for an honest politician.
- [ ] **Model reveal** (20 min) Draw the door opening with a flourish.
- [ ] **Sound of a tour** (15 min) Describe the sounds of a new building.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a civic image.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A Tic Tac on the mayor's breath as he leans in to threaten: the minty freshness of corruption. Small sensory details make villains real.

- [ ] **Retirement-home menu** (25 min) Design a week's menu for PineCliff residents.
- [ ] **Breath mints** (15 min) Discuss small social props (mints, handshakes).
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the offer.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Gush's vindictiveness.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you take the money?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (35 min) Make a two-faced portrait of Gush.
- [ ] **Community supper** (60 min) Host a supper for an older neighbour.
- [ ] **Recipe of a pitch** (15 min) Write a recipe for a sales pitch.
- [ ] **Comfort** (30 min) Cook something Eunice might find comforting.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam leaves knowing a fight is coming and not minding. Write about a time you were glad an opponent showed their true face, because it made your choice easier.

- [ ] **True colours** (20 min) Write about when someone showed their true face.
- [ ] **Happiness** (20 min) Write about who decides your happiness.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate feelings.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Predict Adam's next move.
- [ ] **Letter to Gush** (20 min) Write to the mayor.
- [ ] **Nostalgia** (20 min) Write about a memory that holds you back.
- [ ] **Home** (20 min) Write about your idea of home in old age.
- [ ] **Principle** (20 min) Write about a principle you hold even when it costs.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Who Decides?

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Read Mill on liberty.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Compare Gush and the stranger.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Build Around It

Rooms: Turnpike, Diner, Records Room

- [ ] Research developer plans.
- [ ] Redesign the plan.
- [ ] Paint it.
- [ ] Present it.

Corruption Comedy

Rooms: Law Office, Records Room, Diner

- [ ] Research NJ corruption.
- [ ] Analyse the comedy.
- [ ] Design a poster.
- [ ] Write a scene.

Rinsky File Update

Rooms: Records Room, Incident Board, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Add the offer and threat.
- [ ] Pin Gush.
- [ ] Use the casebook tool.
- [ ] Predict.

Ageing Well

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Design a menu.
- [ ] Write about home in old age.
- [ ] Discuss senior housing.
- [ ] Visit an older neighbour.

Straight-Man Lab

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Diner

- [ ] Analyse the tour.
- [ ] Write a straight-man scene.
- [ ] Perform it.
- [ ] Discuss timing.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 16 use comedy to explore paternalism and power? Compare Gush with the stranger.
2. Essay: Evaluate Adam's claim that government should not decide what makes a person happy, with reference to the Rinsky case.

3. Creative: Write Gush's phone call to the developer after Adam leaves.

Further reading

- *On Liberty*, John Stuart Mill (1859). The classic case that individuals should decide their own good.
- *An Enemy of the People*, Henrik Ibsen (1882). A town's leaders against one stubborn citizen.
- *Little Pink House*, Jeff Benedict (2009). A real family's fight against eminent domain.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Utilitarian reasoning and its critics.
- *Evicted*, Matthew Desmond (2016). The human cost of forced moves.
- *Crabgrass Frontier*, Kenneth T. Jackson (1985). How suburbs and towns were built and rebuilt.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Civic life and its decline.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). Salesmanship and the pitch.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Ageing and the question of where the old should live.

17. Four Days Before the Wedding

What happens

The stranger dreads this visit. Michaela Siegel, twenty-six, a third-year internal-medicine resident at a New York hospital, is saying tipsy goodbyes to friends in a hotel lobby at two in the morning, four days before her wedding. She moved her residency from another prestigious hospital after a scandal: a sex tape of her appeared on a revenge-porn site, and everyone (colleagues, patients, teachers, parents) saw it. She blamed her ex-boyfriend, David Thornton, after a bad fight. He denied it.

The stranger tells her David was telling the truth. The site promises its uploaders anonymity, but someone behind every anonymous site sees every keystroke. The upload came from the IP address of her fiancé, Marcus, who was David's close friend and roommate and seized his chance. The stranger, who once glimpsed the video only long enough to confirm it, offers proof in an envelope. Michaela refuses to look. He is chosen for these visits because he has an honest face; his colleagues Eduardo and Merton would make people run.

Michaela turns the conversation on him. Did he imagine she'd run back to David and that he'd be the hero of their love story? She had a crush on Marcus even while she was with David; maybe Marcus's guilt is why he's so good to her. Her choice now is between blowing up her life and living a lie. She is in love, she says, and love makes people capable of almost anything. She asks if he will tell anyone else; he won't. As the elevator doors close she tells him he hasn't revealed a secret at all. He has created a new one.

Scene by scene

1. The stranger dreads this one: Michaela Siegel, resident doctor, four days before her wedding.
2. Background: a revenge video, a hospital move, the ex she blamed.
3. He approaches her at the elevators after two failed attempts.
4. The question about David Thornton; her face shuts.
5. The truth: the IP address belongs to her fiancé, Marcus.
6. Anonymity is a lie: someone behind every site watches.
7. Why him: his honest face; Eduardo and Merton named.
8. Michaela refuses the proof and turns on him.
9. She loved Marcus first; she chooses to stay, saying love excuses a great deal.
10. Her parting verdict: he created a secret instead of revealing one.

Who's here

The stranger	Uncomfortable, idealistic, hoping to "restore balance".
Michaela Siegel	Twenty-six, a sharp, wounded doctor-in-training.
Marcus	Her fiancé, who posted the video (offstage).
David Thornton	Her ex, wrongly blamed (offstage).
Eduardo & Merton	The stranger's colleagues, named for the first time.

Thirty questions

1. Who is Michaela Siegel?
2. What happened to her at her previous hospital?
3. Whom did she blame, and who was really responsible?

4. How does the stranger know?
5. Why is the stranger chosen for these visits?
6. What does Michaela decide?
7. **Is anything online truly anonymous? Discuss the stranger's claim.** [book club]
8. Why does the stranger dread this visit more than others?
9. **He admits glimpsing the video. Is that itself a violation?** [book club]
10. What did the stranger hope would happen? Is that hope naive?
11. Michaela calls him "Mr Secret Revealer". What is she mocking?
12. She says she had a crush on Marcus anyway. Does that change Marcus's act?
13. **Is she choosing love or denial?** [book club]
14. **Michaela says his revelation has only made a new secret. Is she right?** [book club]
15. How does this case complicate the stranger's creed of demolition?
16. **What does the stranger owe David Thornton, the wrongly blamed ex?** [book club]
17. Who has been wronged here, and by whom?
18. How does the setting (lobby, 2 a.m., elevators) shape the scene?
19. Why does Coben name Eduardo and Merton now?
20. Compare Michaela with Heidi as recipients of the stranger's news.
21. Compare Michaela's choice with what Adam might choose.
22. The stranger feels a flush remembering the video. What does that suggest about him?
23. Why doesn't Michaela look at the proof?
24. Is the stranger's promise to tell no one meaningful?
25. What does the chapter say about forgiveness?
26. **Does this chapter make you more or less sympathetic to the stranger?** [book club]
27. How might Marcus's guilt shape their marriage?
28. Michaela claims love makes people capable of almost anything. What might that foreshadow?
29. Would you tell David Thornton?
30. Predict whether this thread returns.

Close reading

1. The myth of the anonymous site

Find it: Chapter 17, middle: the explanation of the IP address and anonymity.

1. Paraphrase the stranger's claim about anonymous sites.
2. Note the moment Michaela guesses the name.
3. Find the description of the bystanders in the lobby.
4. Note the envelope.

How does the scene dramatise the gap between promised anonymity and human access?

2. An honest face

Find it: Chapter 17, the passage on why the stranger is chosen for these approaches.

1. Find his explanation of his "honest face".
2. Note the colleagues mentioned and why they wouldn't work.
3. Find Michaela's reply about David's face.
4. Consider the irony.

Why does the novel stress that honesty can be a look, and what does Michaela's answer teach the stranger?

3. Turning the tables

Find it: Chapter 17, close: Michaela's choice and her final line at the elevator.

1. Trace her shift from shock to anger to resignation.
2. Find her account of loving Marcus first.
3. Note the choice she names.
4. Paraphrase her last line.

How does Michaela's last line challenge the whole premise of the stranger's work?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Another stranger chapter, and the most morally complicated. Notice how Michaela takes control of the dialogue from the middle on, and how the stranger, so fluent with Heidi, falls nearly silent. The final line inverts the novel's premise.

- ☐ **Who controls the scene** (20 min) Mark where control shifts from the stranger to Michaela.
- ☐ **Final line** (20 min) Write about the final line as a thesis statement for the novel.
- ☐ **Free indirect discomfort** (15 min) Find the stranger's physical discomfort and analyse it.
- ☐ **Bystanders** (15 min) Analyse the sentence about people present and absent at once.
- ☐ **Exposition** (15 min) How is Michaela's backstory delivered?
- ☐ **Dialogue turn** (35 min) Write a scene where a messenger is turned on by the recipient.
- ☐ **Euphemism** (15 min) Note how the stranger avoids naming the video.
- ☐ **Ironies** (20 min) List the ironies in the chapter.
- ☐ **Rewrite** (35 min) Rewrite the scene from Michaela's point of view.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Anonymity, consent, forgiveness and the limits of truth-telling. Michaela's choice to live with the truth privately complicates the idea that secrets must be destroyed. A revealed secret can become a new secret.

- ☐ **Anonymity** (25 min) Discuss the stranger's claim that nothing online is anonymous.
- ☐ **Forgiveness** (25 min) Is Michaela forgiving Marcus? Discuss.
- ☐ **New secrets** (25 min) Discuss how revealing one secret creates another.
- ☐ **Consent** (25 min) Discuss consent and image-based abuse.
- ☐ **Wrongly blamed** (20 min) Discuss David's position.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "new secrets" to your themes.
- ☐ **Love and wrong** (20 min) Discuss what people do "in the name of love".
- ☐ **Messengers** (20 min) Discuss the ethics of being the messenger.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Michaela's choice.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

New Jersey was the first state to criminalise non-consensual sharing of intimate images (2004); most states followed from 2013. IP addresses identify connections, not people, which is why investigators still need corroboration.

- [ ] **Revenge-porn laws** (30 min) Research the spread of US laws against image-based abuse.
- [ ] **IP addresses** (25 min) Read a clear explainer on IP addresses and what they can and can't show.
- [ ] **Medical residency** (20 min) Research residency structure and transfers.
- [ ] **Platform liability** (30 min) Research Section 230 and platform responsibility (neutral source).
- [ ] **Victim support** (15 min) Look up organisations supporting victims of image-based abuse.
- [ ] **Hotel culture** (15 min) Research the history of New York hotel lobbies.
- [ ] **Weddings** (15 min) Look up statistics on called-off weddings.
- [ ] **Digital forensics** (25 min) Research how investigators attribute uploads.
- [ ] **Citron** (15 min) Look up Danielle Citron's work.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Danielle Keats Citron's Hate Crimes in Cyberspace (2014) documents revenge porn's harms. Michaela's choice to marry the man who wronged her has echoes in many marriage plots where knowledge is absorbed rather than acted on.

- [ ] **Citron** (35 min) Read an excerpt of Hate Crimes in Cyberspace.
- [ ] **Ronson** (35 min) Read Ronson on online humiliation.
- [ ] **Marriage plots** (25 min) Find a novel where a bride learns a groom's secret before the wedding.
- [ ] **Wild Duck** (25 min) Compare Gregers' hope for redemption with the stranger's.
- [ ] **Bok** (25 min) Read Bok on whether revealing can harm.
- [ ] **The Circle** (20 min) Revisit transparency.
- [ ] **Perel** (25 min) Read Perel on forgiveness.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems of choice** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about choosing between two paths.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A hotel lobby in New York at 2 a.m.: concierge, elevators, a party breaking up. Transitional spaces suit transitional moments.

- [ ] **New York map** (15 min) Add the hotel and hospitals to your map.
- [ ] **Network map** (15 min) Add Michaela to the stranger's case map.
- [ ] **Lobby plan** (15 min) Sketch the lobby with elevators and concierge.
- [ ] **Hospital geography** (15 min) Map the three institutions named.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 17.
- [ ] **Night city** (20 min) Write 150 words on Manhattan at 2 a.m.
- [ ] **Wedding venue** (15 min) Imagine where the wedding will be.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) How far is New York from Cedarfield?
- [ ] **Transitional spaces** (20 min) Write about lobbies and stations as places of change.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Autonomy versus truth: if Michaela freely chooses to stay, does the stranger's visit have any value? And what of David, the innocent party, who remains wronged?

- [ ] **Respect the choice?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Court** (20 min) Rule on Michaela's case in the Tell or keep tool.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Marcus's act and to the stranger's visit.
- [ ] **Autonomy** (25 min) Write about autonomous choices that look self-harming.
- [ ] **Third parties** (20 min) What is owed to David?
- [ ] **Viewing** (15 min) Was glimpsing the video wrong?
- [ ] **Love as excuse** (20 min) Can love excuse wrongdoing?
- [ ] **Ring of Gyges** (15 min) Use the Ring of Gyges tool on Marcus.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a truth you chose to live with.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A self-contained episode that tests the antagonist's philosophy and names two new characters. It also seeds a line about love and wrongdoing that may echo later.

- [ ] **Episode structure** (15 min) Write about this chapter as a self-contained episode.
- [ ] **Names** (15 min) Pin Eduardo and Merton.
- [ ] **Philosophy test** (15 min) Write how this case tests the stranger.
- [ ] **Turn scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene that ends with a reversal line.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Marcus and the stranger.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Add this to the victims strand.
- [ ] **Echoes** (15 min) Pin Michaela's claim about love as a possible echo, and note any later character who acts on the same belief.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Hotel lobbies at night: polished floors, a concierge, elevator lights counting floors. Photographers have long used lobbies as stages for strangers.

- [ ] **Lobby painting** (40 min) Paint a hotel lobby at 2 a.m.
- [ ] **Elevator doors** (25 min) Draw elevator doors closing on a face.
- [ ] **Envelope** (15 min) Draw the unopened envelope.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the closing doors.
- [ ] **Wedding invitation** (25 min) Design an invitation with a hidden crack.
- [ ] **Portrait** (25 min) Draw Michaela with dignity.
- [ ] **Sound of a lobby** (15 min) Describe lobby sounds at night.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add an elevator image.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A pre-wedding night out: drinks, hugs, the slur in a voice. Celebrations are where secrets are most painful to receive, because everyone around you expects joy and you have to perform it anyway.

- [ ] **Pre-wedding toast** (25 min) Write a toast for Michaela that tells no lies and no secrets.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the case.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Marcus's secret and Michaela's new one.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you go through with the wedding?
- [ ] **Wedding cake** (15 min) Discuss wedding cakes as symbols of public happiness.
- [ ] **Making: secrets box** (15 min) Add a "chosen silence" slip.
- [ ] **Celebration food** (45 min) Cook a celebration dish and talk about bad news at celebrations.
- [ ] **Recipe of a choice** (15 min) Write a recipe for living with a truth.
- [ ] **Hangover cure** (20 min) Make a gentle morning-after breakfast.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Michaela chooses to keep living a life she now knows is built on a lie. Write about whether you could do the same, and what it would cost you each morning.

- [ ] **Living with it** (20 min) Write about living with a truth you can't share.
- [ ] **Messengers** (20 min) Write about being blamed for news.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate sympathy for the stranger.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Will this case return?
- [ ] **Letter to David** (20 min) Write to the wrongly blamed ex.
- [ ] **Letter to Michaela** (20 min) Write to Michaela.
- [ ] **Love** (20 min) Write about something done "for love".
- [ ] **Privacy** (20 min) Write about your online privacy.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Anonymity Audit

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research IP addresses.
- [ ] Discuss anonymity.
- [ ] Use the Ring of Gyges tool.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Michaela's Choice

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss at table.
- [ ] Write a toast.

The Stranger Tested

Rooms: Incident Board, Library Stacks, Law Office

- [ ] Close-read the final line.
- [ ] Compare with Ibsen.
- [ ] Write a reversal scene.
- [ ] Update the case map.

Image-Based Abuse

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Research the laws.
- [ ] Read Citron.
- [ ] Discuss consent.
- [ ] Find support resources.

Lobby at Night

Rooms: Diner, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Paint the lobby.
- [ ] Map New York.
- [ ] Analyse the bystanders.
- [ ] Write a lobby scene.

New Secrets

Rooms: Room 233, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] List secrets created by revelations so far.
- [ ] Pin them.
- [ ] Write a theme claim.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Michaela Siegel tells the stranger that he has created a secret rather than revealed one. Assess how this chapter challenges his philosophy.
2. Essay: Discuss the novel's treatment of online anonymity in chapters 8–17.
3. Creative: Write the wedding day four days later, from Marcus's point of view, without revealing whether he knows she knows.

Further reading

- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). A legal scholar on revenge porn and online abuse.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Public shaming in the internet age.

- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). When revelation helps and when it harms.
- *The Wild Duck*, Henrik Ibsen (1884). An idealist who thinks truth will heal a marriage.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Forgiveness and betrayal in relationships.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Reputation and privacy online.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). A world where transparency is mandatory.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Who sees what we do online.
- *Missing You*, Harlan Coben (2014). Coben on online life and hidden intentions.

18. Face Against the Glass

What happens

At the town line Adam texts Corinne that he and the boys are worried. Then he thinks about how he came to live in Cedarfield at all. It is, on paper, the prize: handsome houses, a pretty centre, sports fields, a duck pond, a national magazine ranking, the state's top socioeconomic category for school districts. People grow up here, leave for college, come back and raise children who will do the same. Corinne lived here until she was ten, when her father died in a car crash at thirty-seven with almost no insurance. Her mother sold the house and moved with her two daughters, Corinne and the older Rose, into a modest apartment complex in Hackensack. The friendships faded as Corinne could no longer afford the activities. Rose rebelled; Corinne studied, kept her head down, and vowed to return. For twenty years she pressed her face to the glass. The house she and Adam bought looks suspiciously like her childhood home. When you marry, Adam thinks, you marry your spouse's dreams.

He finds Kristin Hoy at her gym, a temple of grunts and mirrors, coaching five women in bikinis and high heels for a fitness competition: posture, smiles, diet, water, a list of glues and tanners for the trip. Kristin drops the taskmaster role the moment she sees him in the mirror. Corinne was going to be her travel partner at Nationals, her first show as a professional. Adam asks about the pregnancy two years ago, and Kristin nearly topples off her heels. She claims not to remember how Corinne told her; then offers a theory that Corinne recovered too well from the miscarriage and bottled up her grief.

Adam notices her phrasing: she thought that "at first". Pressed, Kristin turns on him: none of them knows what happens behind the manicured lawns; for all she knows, Adam is abusive. Tears come, and Adam wonders for the first time about her own husband, Hank, and the long sleeves she sometimes wears. Every house is its own island. When he tells her he doesn't think Corinne was ever pregnant, Kristin, with her back to him, denies knowing anything and tells him to leave.

Scene by scene

1. Adam texts Corinne at the town line.
2. Cedarfield on paper: rankings, facilities, the cycle of leaving and returning.
3. Corinne's childhood: her father's death at 37, the move to Hackensack, lost friendships.
4. Rose rebels; Corinne vows to return; their house resembles her childhood home.
5. Marrying a spouse's dreams.
6. The gym: Kristin coaching fitness competitors.
7. Kristin drops the coach persona; Corinne was her travel partner.
8. Adam asks about the pregnancy; Kristin wobbles, evades, theorises.
9. Kristin turns on Adam: what happens behind the lawns? Could he be abusive?
10. Adam wonders about her husband; Kristin denies knowing anything and sends him away.

Who's here

Adam Price	Reflective, then probing.
Corinne (as a child)	Fatherless at ten, exiled to Hackensack, determined to return.
Rose	Corinne's older sister, who rebelled.
Kristin Hoy	Coach, competitor, loyal friend; frightened and defensive.

Hank Hoy	Kristin's husband (offstage), the subject of Adam's sudden suspicion.
The gym desk man	A sneering bodybuilder who asks if Corinne is all right.

Thirty questions

1. What happened to Corinne's father?
2. Where did Corinne move after his death?
3. How did Corinne and Rose respond differently?
4. What does Kristin do at the gym?
5. What theory does Kristin offer about Corinne's grief?
6. How does Kristin turn on Adam?
7. **Corinne's face pressed to the glass for twenty years: what does that image capture?** [book club]
8. **Does Corinne's backstory make you more sympathetic to her deception?** [book club]
9. What does the novel think of Cedarfield's rankings and "shampoo-rinse-repeat" life (Adam's phrase, paraphrased)?
10. **When you marry, do you marry your spouse's dreams? Discuss.** [book club]
11. Why does the house look like Corinne's childhood home?
12. How does the gym scene characterise Kristin beyond the earlier male gaze?
13. **Adam notices how quickly Kristin switches from coach to friend. How does that idea of switching roles apply to everyone in the book?** [book club]
14. Why does Kristin almost topple when Adam says "pregnancy"?
15. Is Kristin lying? Find the tells.
16. Why does Kristin suggest Adam might be abusive?
17. **Adam suddenly wonders about Hank. Is that fair or a leap?** [book club]
18. **Adam comes to see every house as an island with its own secrets. Discuss.** [book club]
19. How does class shape Corinne's character?
20. What do Corinne's lost childhood friendships say about money and belonging?
21. How does the narrator describe the gym? What is the tone?
22. What does the competition prep reveal about bodies and performance?
23. Why does Adam feel awkward talking to Kristin in a bikini?
24. How is Rose different from Corinne, and why mention her?
25. How does Adam's reflection change his understanding of the marriage?
26. Is Kristin protecting Corinne or herself?
27. What does Kristin's final denial really mean?
28. How does the chapter use mirrors?
29. Would you have pushed harder than Adam?
30. Predict what Kristin knows.

Close reading

1. A town as a prize

Find it: Chapter 18, opening: Adam's reflection on Cedarfield and Corinne's childhood.

1. List the credentials Cedarfield boasts.
2. Trace Corinne's family story from the father's death to Hackensack.
3. Contrast Rose and Corinne.
4. Find the image of the face pressed to glass (paraphrase).

How does Corinne's history recast her fake pregnancy as part of a lifelong campaign?

2. Roles we slip into

Find it: Chapter 18, middle: Kristin coaching the competitors.

1. Note Kristin's instructions to the women.
2. Find the list of travel supplies.
3. Find the moment she sees Adam.
4. Find Adam's reflection on roles.

What does the gym scene suggest about performance and identity?

3. Behind the facades

Find it: Chapter 18, close: Kristin's defensiveness and the island image.

1. Find her phrase "at first" and Adam's pounce on it.
2. Note her accusation.
3. Find Adam's thoughts about Hank and the sleeves.
4. Read the ending.

How does the scene suggest that every house in Cedarfield hides something?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Two contrasting halves: a long essayistic reflection on a town and a woman's past, then a physical, comic, then tense scene in a gym. Note how the narration uses a single repeated sight, Kristin in absurd heels, first for comedy and then to show her unsteadiness.

- ☐ **Essay in a novel** (25 min) Analyse the opening reflection as a mini-essay: thesis, evidence, turn.
- ☐ **Backstory compression** (20 min) Summarise Corinne's childhood in 50 words. What did Coben include that you cut?
- ☐ **Comic to tense** (15 min) Mark where the gym scene turns.
- ☐ **The slip** (35 min) Write a scene in which a witness gives herself away with one word.
- ☐ **Lists** (15 min) Analyse Kristin's supply list as comedy and characterisation.
- ☐ **Mirrors** (15 min) Trace the mirrors in the scene.
- ☐ **The island image** (15 min) Write about the "island" image's strength.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite the gym scene from one of the competitors.
- ☐ **Narrative judgement** (20 min) Find the narrator's judgements on Cedarfield; are they Adam's?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Class and return: the suburban dream as something Corinne lost and won back. The idea that we marry each other's dreams. And the suspicion that every manicured house hides its own violence or secret.

- ☐ **Return** (25 min) Discuss the desire to return to a lost place.
- ☐ **Class and childhood** (25 min) Discuss how money shaped Corinne's friendships.
- ☐ **Marrying dreams** (25 min) Debate: do we marry our partner's dreams?

- [ ] **Facades** (20 min) Discuss "behind the facades".
- [ ] **Performance** (20 min) Discuss roles and performance (gym, school, home).
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "return" and "class" to your themes.
- [ ] **Siblings** (20 min) Discuss Rose and Corinne's different responses.
- [ ] **Suspicion** (20 min) Discuss how suspicion spreads.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Corinne's backstory.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

New Jersey's District Factor Groups ranked school districts by socioeconomic status from A to J; they were real and widely discussed. Money magazine has published "Best Places to Live" lists since the 1980s. Hackensack is the county seat, a working city beside wealthy suburbs.

- [ ] **DFGs** (25 min) Research New Jersey's District Factor Groups.
- [ ] **Best places** (20 min) Find how "best places to live" rankings are calculated.
- [ ] **Hackensack** (20 min) Research Hackensack's history and demographics.
- [ ] **Life insurance** (20 min) Research how families fare after a breadwinner dies uninsured.
- [ ] **Fitness competitions** (20 min) Research WBFF judging criteria.
- [ ] **Water cutting** (20 min) Read a reliable health source on extreme dehydration before shows.
- [ ] **Domestic abuse signs** (20 min) Read a reputable list of signs of domestic abuse.
- [ ] **Garden apartments** (15 min) Look up "garden apartment" complexes in New Jersey.
- [ ] **Suburban return** (20 min) Find research on adults returning to hometowns.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Gatsby is the archetype of a person pressing their face to the glass of wealth; Corinne's version is quieter. Annette Lareau's Unequal Childhoods explains why money determines children's activities and friendships.

- [ ] **The Great Gatsby** (30 min) Read the passage of Gatsby's longing for Daisy's world (public domain in the US since 2021).
- [ ] **Lareau** (30 min) Read about "concerted cultivation" in Unequal Childhoods.
- [ ] **Crabgrass Frontier** (30 min) Read on suburban aspiration.
- [ ] **Dare Me** (20 min) Compare bodies and competition.
- [ ] **Goffman** (20 min) Revisit roles.
- [ ] **American Pastoral** (25 min) Compare Swede Levov's dream.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (25 min) Compare April Wheeler's yearning.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Sister novels** (20 min) Find a novel about two sisters who respond differently to loss.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Ten miles between Cedarfield and Hackensack, and a social chasm. Draw them on your map and the gulf between them. Then the gym, Hard-core, with its mirrors.

- [ ] **Ten miles** (20 min) Map Cedarfield and Hackensack and draw the "chasm".
- [ ] **Childhood house** (25 min) Draw Corinne's childhood house and the Prices' house side by side.

- [ ] **Gym** (15 min) Add Hard-core Gym to your map.
- [ ] **Town facilities** (20 min) Map the town centre, duck pond, fields and library.
- [ ] **Status ladder** (15 min) Use the Status ladder tool.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 18.
- [ ] **Your own return** (20 min) Map a place you left and returned to.
- [ ] **Kristin's house** (15 min) Mark it and imagine its interior.
- [ ] **Garden apartment** (15 min) Sketch a garden apartment complex.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Kristin's dilemma: protect her friend or help a husband who might be dangerous. Her suspicion of Adam is itself responsible: she doesn't know him. Adam's suspicion of Hank mirrors it.

- [ ] **Kristin's loyalty** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Suspicion as duty** (20 min) Was Kristin right to suspect Adam?
- [ ] **Adam's suspicion** (20 min) Was Adam right to wonder about Hank?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Kristin's silence.
- [ ] **Bodies** (20 min) Is extreme bodily discipline a virtue?
- [ ] **Class and blame** (25 min) Does Corinne's past mitigate her lie?
- [ ] **Dreams** (20 min) Is it wrong to make your partner's dream yours?
- [ ] **Facades** (20 min) Is keeping up appearances a moral failing?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about loyalty to a friend under pressure.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A major backstory reveal (Corinne's childhood) and a witness who lies badly. The "at first" slip is a classic interrogation catch. Kristin moves up the suspicion meter.

- [ ] **Backstory reveal** (15 min) Write about how the backstory changes the stakes.
- [ ] **Witness slip** (15 min) Pin "at first".
- [ ] **Hank** (15 min) Pin Hank and the sleeves (mark as unsure).
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Kristin.
- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin the resemblance between the Prices' house and Corinne's childhood home, and note what it might mean.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene in a gym where a secret slips.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the Adam strand.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A gym of mirrors, posing practice, bikinis and stilettos: a theatre of bodies. Think about the photography of fitness competitions: oiled skin, held poses, strained smiles.

- [ ] **Face at the glass** (40 min) Paint a child's face pressed to a lit window from outside.
- [ ] **Gym mirrors** (35 min) Paint a room of mirrors with one woman in heels.

- [ ] **Two houses** (35 min) Paint the two similar houses.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a gym song and a song for young Corinne.
- [ ] **Posing study** (20 min) Draw three fitness poses as gesture sketches.
- [ ] **Ranking poster** (20 min) Design a satirical "Best Places" poster.
- [ ] **Sound of a gym** (15 min) Describe the gym's sounds.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the face at the glass.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Diet as discipline: ninety per cent protein, carb-loading, cutting water to nothing on competition day. Control of the body echoes Corinne's control of her life.

- [ ] **Competition diet** (20 min) Plan (don't follow) a day of a competitor's diet and discuss discipline.
- [ ] **Comfort for Corinne** (45 min) Cook a dish from a working-class New Jersey kitchen of the 1980s.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Corinne's family losses.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Kristin's evasion.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: is there a place you want to return to?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (30 min) Draw Kristin as coach and as frightened friend.
- [ ] **Protein snacks** (30 min) Make high-protein snacks and talk about body culture.
- [ ] **Sister supper** (45 min) Cook for a sibling and talk about different paths.
- [ ] **Recipe of a return** (15 min) Write a recipe for coming home.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Corinne spent twenty years trying to get back to the town that let her go. Write about a place you lost and wanted back, and whether getting it back would be enough.

- [ ] **Lost place** (20 min) Write about a place you lost.
- [ ] **Dreams inherited** (20 min) Write about whose dreams you live.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust in Kristin.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What does Kristin know?
- [ ] **Letter to young Corinne** (20 min) Write to Corinne at ten.
- [ ] **Behind your facade** (20 min) Write privately about what your house hides.
- [ ] **Roles** (20 min) Write about the roles you switch between.
- [ ] **Siblings** (20 min) Write about a sibling's different path.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Corinne's Return

Rooms: Room 233, Turnpike, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read the backstory.
- [ ] Map the ten-mile chasm.
- [ ] Write about a lost place.
- [ ] Write a theme claim on return.

Class Lens

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Research DFGs and Hackensack.
- [ ] Read Lareau.
- [ ] Discuss class in the novel.
- [ ] Use the Status ladder.

Behind the Lawns

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss Kristin's suspicion.
- [ ] Pin Hank as unsure.
- [ ] Use the Five lenses.
- [ ] Reflect privately.

Bodies on Stage

Rooms: Diner, Records Room, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research WBFF.
- [ ] Paint the mirrors.
- [ ] Plan a competitor's diet.
- [ ] Discuss performance.

The Witness

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Close-read the "at first" catch.
- [ ] Write a slip scene.
- [ ] Rate Kristin.
- [ ] Debate her loyalty.

Two Houses

Rooms: Diner, Turnpike, Room 233

- [ ] Draw both houses.
- [ ] Discuss repetition and return.
- [ ] Write about it.
- [ ] Share.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse how Corinne's childhood, as told in chapter 18, reframes her actions and the novel's portrayal of the suburban dream.
2. Essay: Discuss Kristin Hoy's suspicion of Adam and Adam's of Hank. What does the novel suggest about what we can know of other households?
3. Creative: Write ten-year-old Corinne's last visit to an old friend's house in Cedarfield after the move.

Further reading

- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). How money shapes children's activities and friendships.
- *Crabgrass Frontier*, Kenneth T. Jackson (1985). The history and psychology of suburban aspiration.
- *American Pastoral*, Philip Roth (1997). A man's faith in the American dream.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). A woman suffocating inside a suburban ideal.
- *Dare Me*, Megan Abbott (2012). Discipline, bodies and loyalty.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). The roles we perform in different settings.
- *The Virgin Suicides*, Jeffrey Eugenides (1993). A suburb's view of a family it can't see inside.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). Class, aspiration and a perfect suburban family.
- *Shelter*, Harlan Coben (2011). Coben on New Jersey towns and hidden lives.

19. The Uniform

What happens

Ryan is waiting at the back door. Where is Mom? Adam says she's travelling for a teachers' thing. Ryan, panicking, needs his uniform: without it his coach will make him run laps and sit out a game. He has checked the drawer, the laundry basket, the washer and the dryer; Adam keeps asking anyway. Ryan shouts that his father never finds anything, that they need Mom, that she isn't answering his texts.

Adam explodes. Does Ryan think his parents exist only to serve him? They are human beings too, with lives, sadness and worries of their own. Ryan's eyes fill and he runs upstairs and slams his door. Thomas stands at the top of the stairs staring at his father in disbelief. Adam admits he lost his temper. Thomas asks again where Mom is. Another teachers' thing, in Atlantic City, Adam says. No, says Thomas. He knows where she is, and it's nowhere near Atlantic City.

The scene is only a page or two long, but it marks a turn. For the first time Adam loses control in front of his children, and for the first time one of them knows something he doesn't. The boys have been shielded with stories about conferences; now the shield cracks from both sides, Ryan in tears and Thomas holding a key to his mother's whereabouts.

Scene by scene

1. Ryan meets Adam at the door with the same questions.
2. The uniform crisis and the coach's punishment.
3. Ryan's panic escalates into blame.
4. Adam's outburst: parents are human beings too.
5. Ryan in tears, door slammed.
6. Thomas witnesses it.
7. Adam's lie about another conference.
8. Thomas: I know where she is, and it's not Atlantic City.

Who's here

Ryan Price	Sixth-grader, rule-following, overwhelmed.
Adam Price	Exhausted and lying, then exploding.
Thomas Price	Watching, and knowing more than his father.
Coach Jauss	Ryan's coach, who punishes missing uniforms (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. Why is Ryan panicking?
2. What will happen without his uniform?
3. What does Ryan say about his father?
4. What does Adam shout?
5. Who witnesses the outburst?
6. What does Thomas reveal?
7. **Is Adam's outburst justified, understandable, or wrong?** [book club]
8. **Is there truth in what he says, even if the timing is wrong?** [book club]
9. Why does Ryan blame his father for not finding things?
10. What does the uniform represent for Ryan?

11. Why does Adam keep asking if Ryan checked places he already said he checked?
12. How does the chapter show the household falling apart without Corinne?
13. Why does Thomas stare in disbelief?
14. Thomas's reveal: how could he know?
15. Why does Adam lie again about a conference?
16. **Is it fair to lie to children to protect them?** [book club]
17. How do the brothers differ in this crisis?
18. What is the effect of such a short chapter?
19. What does the slammed door mean?
20. **Compare this outburst with Adam's restraint with Corinne.** [book club]
21. Why might children assume parents exist to serve them?
22. How does the chapter end, and why there?
23. **What should Adam say to Ryan now?** [book club]
24. How do teenagers see through parental lies?
25. What does the chapter say about Corinne's role in the house?
26. Is Coach Jauss's rule reasonable?
27. How does fear show itself as anger in parents?
28. **What would your parents have said?** [book club]
29. What does Thomas risk by telling?
30. Predict how Thomas knows.

Close reading

1. Escalation

Find it: Chapter 19, the uniform exchange at the back door.

1. Map the rising volume of Ryan's lines.
2. Note Adam's repeated questions.
3. Find the moment Ryan blames him.
4. Mark Adam's breaking point.

How does the dialogue build to the outburst?

2. Parents are people

Find it: Chapter 19, Adam's outburst.

1. Paraphrase Adam's speech.
2. Note its rhetorical questions.
3. Note the effect on Ryan.
4. Find the apology that comes too late.

What truth does Adam tell, and why is it wrong to tell it now?

3. The son who knows

Find it: Chapter 19, close: Thomas on the stairs.

1. Find Thomas's silence before speaking.
2. Note Adam's lie.
3. Read Thomas's two-sentence reply.
4. Note what is withheld.

How does the chapter shift power from father to son in a few lines?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

One of the shortest chapters: a single escalating exchange, an explosion, and a hook. Notice how the exclamation marks pile up, then the quiet of Thomas's two lines.

- [ ] **Exclamation marks** (15 min) Count the exclamation marks. Write about punctuation as volume.
- [ ] **Short chapter** (15 min) Write about why this chapter is so short.
- [ ] **Rewrite calmly** (25 min) Rewrite Adam's outburst as a calm talk. Which version is truer to him?
- [ ] **Two lines** (15 min) Analyse Thomas's final two lines.
- [ ] **Repetition** (15 min) Find repeated questions and their effect.
- [ ] **Escalation scene** (35 min) Write a 250-word escalation between a parent and child.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Ryan's point of view.
- [ ] **Silence** (15 min) Find where silence does work.
- [ ] **Hook** (15 min) Compare this hook with previous ones.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Parents as human beings; children's entitlement; the toll a missing parent takes on a household; and the protective lie that teenagers see through.

- [ ] **Parents as people** (25 min) Discuss when children should learn their parents are people.
- [ ] **Entitlement** (20 min) Discuss children's expectations of parents.
- [ ] **Invisible labour** (25 min) Discuss who does the laundry and why it matters.
- [ ] **Protective lies** (25 min) Debate lying to children in a crisis.
- [ ] **Repair** (20 min) Discuss repairing after losing your temper.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "repair" to your themes.
- [ ] **Siblings** (20 min) Discuss how siblings respond differently.
- [ ] **Teen knowledge** (20 min) Discuss what teenagers know that parents don't think they know.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Adam's outburst.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Many youth sports teams penalise missing kit to teach responsibility. Research on parental conflict suggests children are less harmed by arguments than by unrepaired ones: what Adam does next matters.

- [ ] **Parental conflict research** (25 min) Find a reputable summary of how parental conflict affects children.
- [ ] **Household labour** (25 min) Find statistics on how US couples divide household tasks.
- [ ] **Team rules** (15 min) Find a youth team's code on uniforms.
- [ ] **Children and divorce** (25 min) Read guidance on talking to children about separations.
- [ ] **Teen tech** (20 min) Research teenagers' tech skills vs parents'.
- [ ] **Anger** (20 min) Read about parental anger management.
- [ ] **Lacrosse kit** (15 min) Look up a youth lacrosse uniform kit list.
- [ ] **Sibling studies** (20 min) Find research on birth order (with caution).

- [ ] **Apologies** (15 min) Research how to apologise to a child.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Children seeing through parental lies is a staple of coming-of-age fiction, from Jeffrey Eugenides to Celeste Ng. Thomas will soon make an argument about Santa Claus to the same effect.

- [ ] **Coming-of-age** (25 min) Find a novel where a child sees through parents' lies.
- [ ] **Everything I Never Told You** (25 min) Compare parental pressure.
- [ ] **The Virgin Suicides** (25 min) Compare parents and children as mysteries to each other.
- [ ] **Gopnik** (25 min) Read Gopnik on parenting.
- [ ] **The Corrections** (20 min) Compare family explosions.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a father and son.
- [ ] **Plays** (25 min) Read a father-son scene from Death of a Salesman.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Hold Tight** (20 min) Compare parents and teens in Coben.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Back door, staircase, slammed bedroom: domestic geography as emotional terrain. The house's vertical layout puts the boys above and the father below.

- [ ] **Vertical house** (20 min) Draw the house in cross-section: who's on which floor.
- [ ] **Laundry route** (15 min) Map the laundry's journey through a house.
- [ ] **Atlantic City again** (15 min) Note the lie on your timeline.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 19.
- [ ] **Where is she?** (15 min) List possible locations again.
- [ ] **Coach's field** (15 min) Add Ryan's practice field.
- [ ] **Back door** (15 min) Write about back doors as family entrances.
- [ ] **Stairs** (15 min) Write about staircases in family dramas.
- [ ] **Bedroom doors** (15 min) Map which doors close in the house.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Adam's words are true and his timing is cruel. The ethics of honesty with children depends on age, need and manner, not just truth.

- [ ] **Outburst** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Honesty with children** (35 min) Write 300 words on honesty with children.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam's lie.
- [ ] **Repair duty** (20 min) Do parents have a duty to apologise?
- [ ] **Entitlement** (15 min) Is Ryan wrong to expect help?
- [ ] **Thomas's choice** (20 min) Is Thomas right to tell?
- [ ] **Anger** (20 min) Is anger ever good parenting?
- [ ] **Labour** (20 min) Is unequal household labour a moral issue?

- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about an outburst you regret.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A cliffhanger chapter that hands investigative power to a teenager. Note how Coben plants Thomas's knowledge without explaining it, for the next chapter to pay off.

- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin Thomas's knowledge.
- [ ] **Hook** (30 min) Write a 200-word chapter ending on a child's revelation.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate your trust in Adam as narrator here.
- [ ] **Power shift** (15 min) Write about the shift of investigative power.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the Adam strand.
- [ ] **Short chapters** (15 min) Compare short chapters so far.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A boy at the top of a staircase looking down at his father in the hall: one of the oldest compositions in family drama, from Victorian illustration to film. The higher figure holds the power. Draw it, and decide where the light comes from.

- [ ] **Staircase** (35 min) Paint a boy at the top of the stairs.
- [ ] **Slammed door** (15 min) Draw a door with motion lines.
- [ ] **Uniform** (15 min) Draw the missing uniform as a ghost.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the slammed door.
- [ ] **Comic strip** (30 min) Make a four-panel strip of the scene.
- [ ] **Faces** (25 min) Sketch three faces: Ryan, Adam, Thomas.
- [ ] **Sound of a house** (15 min) Describe the silence after a slammed door.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the staircase.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No dinner yet; the house without its organiser is short on clean uniforms and patience. Laundry is the invisible labour that holds a family together.

- [ ] **Laundry night** (30 min) Do a family laundry together and talk about who does what.
- [ ] **Peace offering** (40 min) Cook a child's favourite as an apology.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the lie.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Thomas's knowledge.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: when did you learn your parents were human?
- [ ] **Making: password card** (15 min) Discuss what children should know.
- [ ] **Kit list** (15 min) Make a kit checklist for a sports bag.
- [ ] **Recipe for repair** (15 min) Write a recipe for making up.

- [ ] **Cocoa** (15 min) Make cocoa for a sulking child; discuss rituals of comfort.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam tells his son that parents are human beings with their own sadness, then hates himself for it. Write about a time a parent let you see they were human, or you let a child see it.

- [ ] **Parents as people** (20 min) Write about when you learned this.
- [ ] **Outburst** (20 min) Write privately about losing your temper with a child.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate sympathy for Adam.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) How does Thomas know?
- [ ] **Letter to Ryan** (20 min) Write Adam's apology.
- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (15 min) Write thanks to Thomas.
- [ ] **Invisible work** (20 min) Write about invisible work you do.
- [ ] **Lies to children** (20 min) Write about a lie told to you as a child.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Parents Are People

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Close-read the outburst.
- [ ] Discuss honesty with children.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.

Repair Kit

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Research apologies to children.
- [ ] Cook a peace offering.
- [ ] Write Adam's apology.
- [ ] Discuss repair.

Invisible Labour

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research household labour.
- [ ] Do laundry together.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write a reflection.

The Son Who Knows

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Library Stacks

- [ ] Pin Thomas's knowledge.
- [ ] Write a revelation scene.
- [ ] Find teen-knowledge novels.
- [ ] Predict.

Staircase Drama

Rooms: Diner, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Draw the house in section.
- [ ] Paint the staircase.
- [ ] Analyse the escalation.
- [ ] Write the scene from Ryan.

Family Rules

Rooms: Room 233, Price Kitchen, Records Room

- [ ] Collect your family's rules.
- [ ] Compare with the Prices'.
- [ ] Discuss consequences.
- [ ] Draft new ones.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse Adam's outburst at Ryan in chapter 19. What does it reveal about Adam, and about how the novel views parenting under pressure?
2. Essay: How does chapter 19 shift investigative power to Thomas, and why might Coben do this?
3. Creative: Write Ryan's diary entry that night.

Further reading

- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). What children need from parents, and what parents get wrong.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Children and the pressures parents place on them.
- *The Virgin Suicides*, Jeffrey Eugenides (1993). Parents and children as mysteries to each other.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A father's failures seen by his sons.
- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Coben on parents, teens and secrets.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Family routines and children's expectations.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Family conflict across generations.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Repair after conflict.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). Teenagers who know more than parents think.

20. LoveMyFamily

What happens

Adam sits Thomas down in the kitchen. Looking at his elder son, he sees himself in the boy's gestures and has no doubt Thomas is his; he admits, privately, that the stranger has dragged into the light a misgiving every man keeps in a dark corner, and wonders whether that explains his outburst at Ryan. Thomas, snapping a green lacrosse wristband against his skin, says Mom will be angry: he promised never to do this. He asks whether Adam was telling the truth about the conference. Adam says no; they had a fight. Thomas reasons that perhaps Mom wouldn't want him to say where she is. Adam agrees that's possible, but says Corinne would never put the boys in that position.

Thomas explains. Years ago Corinne installed an upgraded phone-locator app on all their phones. The deal was that she would use it only in emergencies, never to spy, and Thomas would never use it at all. He hands Adam the map: three dots in the same house, blue, red, and green. The green dot is Adam. For three or four years Corinne could have seen exactly where her husband was. Adam, proud of keeping his phone free of apps, absorbs this.

Thomas zooms out. An orange dot sits, no longer blinking, in Pittsburgh, more than six hours' drive away. A few hours earlier it was moving; then the battery ran down to four per cent and died. The last location is a strip mall on South Braddock Avenue: a supermarket, a dollar store, a sports-shoe shop, a video-game shop. Corinne knows no one in Pittsburgh, as far as Adam knows. Maybe she stopped for supplies; maybe she met the stranger. The app is on Adam's phone too, hidden on the last screen. The password is LoveMyFamily.

Scene by scene

1. Adam and Thomas in the kitchen; Adam's certainty about Thomas, and the secret misgiving all men keep.
2. Thomas snaps his wristband; he broke a promise to his mother.
3. Adam admits the conference was a lie: they had a fight.
4. The phone-locator app and Corinne's rule: emergencies only; Thomas must never use it.
5. Three dots at home, one of them Adam: she could track him for years.
6. Zooming out: the orange dot in Pittsburgh.
7. The battery died at four per cent; the dot stopped.
8. A strip mall on South Braddock Avenue.
9. The app is on Adam's phone too. Password: LoveMyFamily.

Who's here

Thomas Price	Tech-savvy, conflicted, honest with his father.
Adam Price	Learning how much he was watched.
Corinne Price	Present as an orange dot and a set of rules.

Thirty questions

1. What does Thomas reveal about the app?
2. What was the deal between Thomas and Corinne?
3. Which dot is Adam?
4. Where is Corinne's last location?

5. Why did the dot stop blinking?
6. What is the password?
7. **Adam admits a secret misgiving all men keep. What is it, and why voice it now?** [book club]
8. Why does Thomas snap the wristband?
9. Is Thomas right that Mom might not want Adam to know?
10. **Adam tells Thomas the truth about the fight. Was that right?** [book club]
11. **Corinne could see Adam's location for years. How should he feel?** [book club]
12. Is the emergencies-only rule meaningful if only Corinne enforced it?
13. What does Adam's pride in having no apps reveal about him?
14. Why Pittsburgh? Brainstorm explanations.
15. Could she have been meeting the stranger?
16. **What does the password say about Corinne? Is it ironic now?** [book club]
17. How does technology both reveal and conceal in this chapter?
18. Thomas explains tech to his father. What does the role reversal show?
19. How is surveillance framed as love here?
20. **Compare this tracking with Adam reading Thomas's messages years ago.** [book club]
21. What do the shops in the strip mall suggest?
22. Why does the narrative include the battery percentage?
23. What should Adam do next?
24. How does the chapter treat Thomas's guilt?
25. **Is it better to know where people are?** [book club]
26. What does the four per cent detail add?
27. How might Corinne have used this app before?
28. Does this change your view of Corinne?
29. What would your family's password be?
30. Predict when the dot will reappear.

Close reading

1. The dark corner

Find it: Chapter 20, opening: Adam watching Thomas and thinking about paternity.

1. Find where Adam sees himself in Thomas.
2. Find the reflection on a secret misgiving.
3. Note how the stranger is blamed.
4. Find Adam's question about his outburst.

Why does the novel make Adam admit this universal doubt here?

2. Watched without knowing

Find it: Chapter 20, middle: the dots on the map.

1. Note the colours of the dots.
2. Find Adam's realisation that one is him.
3. Find how long the app has existed.
4. Find his pride in his app-free phone.

How does the scene turn Adam from investigator into the investigated?

3. A dot on a map

Find it: Chapter 20, close: zooming to Pittsburgh.

1. Follow the zoom-out.
2. Note the battery detail.
3. Read the strip mall description.
4. Read the password.

How does the chapter make a dot on a screen feel like a person?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A dialogue chapter that builds slowly through Thomas's guilt to the technical reveal. The prose mirrors the app: zooming in on a face, zooming out to a state, then in again on a strip mall. The password closes the chapter like a punchline that hurts.

- ☐ **Zoom structure** (20 min) Map the chapter's "zooms" from close to wide and back.
- ☐ **Guilt dialogue** (15 min) Analyse how Thomas's guilt is written.
- ☐ **Punchline ending** (15 min) Write about the password as an ending.
- ☐ **Tech exposition** (20 min) How does Coben explain the app without boring us?
- ☐ **Role reversal** (30 min) Write a scene where a child teaches a parent.
- ☐ **Free indirect doubt** (15 min) Find the paternity reflection and paraphrase it.
- ☐ **Detail selection** (15 min) Why list the strip mall shops?
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare pace with chapter 19.
- ☐ **Rewrite** (30 min) Rewrite the reveal from Thomas's point of view.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Surveillance as care; the asymmetry of who watches whom in a family; trust between parent and teenager; and the irony of loving words used as a lock.

- ☐ **Surveillance and love** (25 min) Discuss surveillance as care or control.
- ☐ **Consent** (25 min) Discuss consent in family tracking.
- ☐ **Promises to children** (20 min) Discuss Thomas's broken promise.
- ☐ **Asymmetry** (20 min) Who watches whom in your family?
- ☐ **Irony** (15 min) Discuss the password as irony.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "watching" to your themes.
- ☐ **Paternal doubt** (25 min) Discuss the misgiving Adam admits.
- ☐ **Honesty with teenagers** (20 min) Discuss Adam's admission of the fight.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of family tracking.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Location sharing spread rapidly in the 2010s. Apple's Find My iPhone (2010) and family-sharing features let relatives see each other's phones. Battery-dependent tracking stops when a phone dies, which the plot uses.

- [ ] **Location sharing** (25 min) Research the history of family location apps.
- [ ] **Teen tracking surveys** (20 min) Find surveys on parents tracking teens.
- [ ] **Pittsburgh** (20 min) Research Pittsburgh and South Braddock Avenue area.
- [ ] **Battery and GPS** (20 min) Read how location services work and when they stop.
- [ ] **Wristbands** (15 min) Look up the history of charity wristbands.
- [ ] **Smartphones 2015** (15 min) Find smartphone ownership rates in 2015.
- [ ] **Privacy law** (25 min) Research spousal tracking and law (neutral source).
- [ ] **Drive time** (15 min) Calculate the drive from Bergen County to Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Passwords** (15 min) Research password advice and common passwords.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Surveillance by those who love us is a theme of Coben's Hold Tight and of Dave Eggers's The Circle. Orwell made watching political; this novel makes it domestic.

- [ ] **Hold Tight** (35 min) Read the opening of Coben's Hold Tight.
- [ ] **The Circle** (25 min) Compare transparency culture.
- [ ] **Nineteen Eighty-Four** (30 min) Compare watching at the state and family level.
- [ ] **Zuboff** (30 min) Read on location data.
- [ ] **Bentham** (20 min) Read about the panopticon.
- [ ] **Family tech essays** (20 min) Find an essay on family tracking.
- [ ] **Solove** (25 min) Read on privacy within families.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about watching over someone.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Six hours west on the interstates: Pittsburgh, South Braddock Avenue, a strip mall. The map jumps from Bergen County to western Pennsylvania. Measure it.

- [ ] **Pittsburgh pin** (15 min) Add Pittsburgh to your map.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Use the Distance calculator for Cedarfield to Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Route** (20 min) Trace the interstate route from New Jersey to Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Strip mall** (20 min) Sketch a strip mall from the description.
- [ ] **Dots map** (15 min) Draw a map with family dots.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 20.
- [ ] **Where next?** (20 min) From Pittsburgh, where could she be heading?
- [ ] **Dead zone** (15 min) Write about places where phones die.
- [ ] **Six hours** (20 min) Write about a six-hour drive alone.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Corinne watched without telling. Thomas watched against a promise. Adam reads both as betrayals and is grateful for both. Surveillance ethics depend on consent and purpose.

- [ ] **Love or control?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Corinne's app.
- [ ] **Broken promise** (20 min) Was Thomas right to break his promise?
- [ ] **Telling teenagers** (20 min) Was Adam right to admit the fight?
- [ ] **Watching spouses** (25 min) Is tracking a spouse ever acceptable?
- [ ] **Ring of Gyges** (15 min) Does being watched make people better?
- [ ] **Doubt** (20 min) Is paternal doubt a moral failing?
- [ ] **Rules** (15 min) Who should make family tech rules?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about being tracked.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A major clue: the last known location. It also plants a suspicion that will be explained later. A dead battery is a classic way to freeze a trail.

- [ ] **Last location** (15 min) Pin Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Dead battery** (15 min) Write about dead batteries as plot devices.
- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin the years of tracking.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene where a map on a phone reveals a location.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Corinne.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Update Corinne's timeline with Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the Adam strand.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Three coloured dots in a house, one orange dot hundreds of miles away. The map on a phone screen is a new kind of family portrait.

- [ ] **Dot map** (30 min) Paint a map with coloured dots as a family portrait.
- [ ] **Strip mall** (35 min) Paint a strip mall at dusk.
- [ ] **Wristband** (15 min) Design a wristband for your family.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the zoom-out.
- [ ] **Screen art** (20 min) Design a phone screen showing the orange dot.
- [ ] **Two faces** (25 min) Sketch father and son across the table.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe the sound of a phone's silence.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the orange dot.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

The kitchen table becomes an interrogation room where a son confesses to his father, snapping a rubber wristband against his skin. Kitchens are where families hold their hardest conversations, sitting where they eat every day.

- [ ] **Kitchen confession** (25 min) Hold a conversation over the kitchen table without phones.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the app and the last location.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Corinne's tracking.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: do you share locations? Why?
- [ ] **Making: password card** (20 min) Finish your password card; discuss what passwords say.
- [ ] **Pittsburgh food** (45 min) Cook a Pittsburgh dish (pierogies) and discuss the city.
- [ ] **Phone-free dinner** (30 min) Hold a phone-free dinner.
- [ ] **Recipe of trust** (15 min) Write a recipe for trust in a family.
- [ ] **Comfort** (20 min) Make something comforting for a guilty teenager.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam learns his wife could see where he was for years. Write about how you would feel learning someone had always known where you were, and whether it would feel like love.

- [ ] **Being watched** (20 min) Write about being watched without knowing.
- [ ] **Promises** (20 min) Write about a promise you broke for a good reason.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust in Corinne.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Why Pittsburgh? Log it.
- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (15 min) Write Adam's thanks.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (20 min) Write about the app.
- [ ] **Doubt** (20 min) Write privately about a doubt you keep in a dark corner.
- [ ] **Password** (15 min) Write what your password would be and why.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Family Tech Charter

Rooms: Room 233, Price Kitchen, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss tracking.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Hold a phone-free dinner.
- [ ] Draft a charter.

The Orange Dot

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Diner

- [ ] Map Pittsburgh.
- [ ] Pin the clue.
- [ ] Paint the dot map.
- [ ] Predict.

Watched Without Knowing

Rooms: Law Office, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Close-read the dots.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Read on the panopticon.
- [ ] Discuss.

Promises to Children

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss Thomas's promise.
- [ ] Apply the lenses.
- [ ] Write a letter.
- [ ] Reflect.

Pittsburgh Night

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Records Room, Turnpike

- [ ] Research Pittsburgh.
- [ ] Cook pierogies.
- [ ] Trace the route.
- [ ] Discuss.

Role Reversal

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Room 233

- [ ] Analyse the scene.
- [ ] Write a child-teaches-parent scene.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Perform.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 20 explore surveillance within families? Consider Corinne's app, Thomas's promise and Adam's earlier reading of messages.
2. Essay: Analyse the role reversal between Thomas and Adam in chapter 20.
3. Creative: Write the evening Corinne installed the app, years ago, and set the password.

Further reading

- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Coben on parents, technology and surveillance.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). A world where everything is visible.
- *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, George Orwell (1949). The classic novel of being watched.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). How location data is gathered and used.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Privacy inside families and communities.
- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). Trust and freedom in parenting.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Family pressure and the things not said.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband following electronic traces of a wife.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Parents, teenagers and what technology reveals.

21. Big Bob on Fire

What happens

For the first time we are inside Bob Baime's head, at a pickup basketball game for town fathers in a church gym, and he is on fire: hitting jumpers, crashing the boards, even shoving past a former college star and NBA draft pick with a bad knee. His late father, the high school's old-school athletic director for thirty years, mocked him throughout childhood with girls' names and slurs, and Bob believes the hard love made him. He has climbed from the teachers-and-tradesmen side of town to a mansard-roofed manor in the country-club district, his-and-hers Mercedes, membership of the golf club his father only ever visited as a guest.

But he lost his job, his wife Melanie (once the cheerleading captain) has turned from worship to nagging, the bank is moving to foreclose and the repo man is circling the cars. Today, though, he aced an interview arranged by Jimmy Hoch's father, the headhunter. There was no quid pro quo, he tells himself, just the mutual back-scratching sport teaches. All three of those B-team boys were towel boys anyway. His son Pete is losing his scholarship chances as Thomas Price takes his position.

The call comes from the big investment bank: it's a no. Smiling into the phone like an idiot so he'll sound confident, Bob feels darkness seep into his chest. A thought surfaces about draft night: Adam had been hit with crushing news at the Legion bar just minutes before he started arguing, and yet he bounced back fast enough to pick a fight. Maybe, like Bob on the court, Adam needed an outlet. And how would Adam react to everything about his wife, beyond the deception he has already learned? Bob jogs back onto the court. He'll find out soon enough.

Scene by scene

1. Bob's point of view: pickup basketball at a church gym; he's unstoppable.
2. He bullies a former star with a bad knee.
3. His father: the high school's tough athletic director who mocked him as a boy.
4. Bob's climb: the country-club house, the cars, the golf club.
5. The fall: job loss, a nagging wife, foreclosure, repossession threats.
6. Today's interview via the headhunter; his self-justifications about the draft.
7. Pete losing ground to Thomas Price.
8. The rejection call from the bank.
9. Bob reveals he knew Adam had just been given crushing news on draft night.
10. He hints there is more to Corinne's story than Adam knows, and that Adam will find out.

Who's here

Bob Baime	Proud, wounded, bullying, desperate; more complicated than his nickname.
Robert Baime Sr.	Bob's late father, the school's athletic director, cruel and admired.
Melanie Baime	Bob's wife, a former cheerleading captain, now anxious about money.
Pete Baime	Bob's son, losing his place to Thomas.
Jerry Katz	The caller from the bank with bad news.
The former star	A one-time college All-American whose pro career ended with a knee injury.

Thirty questions

1. Where is Bob, and how is he playing?
2. Who was Bob's father, and how did he treat Bob?
3. What signs of status has Bob achieved?
4. What is going wrong in Bob's life?
5. What news does the phone call bring?
6. What does Bob realise about draft night?
7. **Does this chapter make you pity Bob? Should it?** [book club]
8. **How did Bob's father shape him? Is "hard love" love?** [book club]
9. Bob calls the draft favour "back-scratching". Is that self-deception?
10. Why does Bob think the B-team boys didn't matter?
11. What does the bullying of the former star show?
12. **How does the novel present masculinity through Bob?** [book club]
13. What does Melanie's change from worship to nagging reveal about the marriage?
14. **Compare Bob's fall with Adam's fears for his own dream.** [book club]
15. Bob smiles on the phone to sound confident. What does that say about performance?
16. How did Bob know about Adam's news?
17. What more might there be to Corinne's story, according to Bob?
18. Why give Bob a point-of-view chapter now?
19. **Is Bob a villain, a victim, or both?** [book club]
20. How does class mobility work in Cedarfield, according to this chapter?
21. What does the golf club symbolise?
22. Why does the chapter end with Bob returning to the game?
23. How does this change your reading of chapter 2?
24. Bob blames others. Find three examples.
25. What is the effect of the homophobic slurs remembered from his father?
26. How is sport his refuge?
27. What does Pete's situation add?
28. **Does Bob's knowledge make him dangerous?** [book club]
29. What would you say to Bob after the call?
30. Predict what Bob will do with what he knows.

Close reading

1. Inside the bully

Find it: Chapter 21, opening: Bob on the court and the memory of his father.

1. Note the boastful voice of the opening.
2. Find the memory of his father's insults (paraphrase, don't copy the slurs).
3. Find Bob's verdict on that upbringing.
4. Note his wish his father could see him now.

How does the chapter make us understand Bob without excusing him?

2. Status and collapse

Find it: Chapter 21, middle: Bob's account of his rise and fall.

1. List his status symbols.
2. List his troubles.
3. Find his justification about the draft.
4. Note his view of the B-team boys.

What does Bob's self-justification reveal about how people defend their own corruption?

3. The turn

Find it: Chapter 21, close: the phone call and Bob's realisation about Adam.

1. Find Bob's fake smile.
2. Note the darkness in his chest.
3. Find his question about draft night.
4. Read the final thought about what Adam doesn't know.

How does the chapter convert Bob's humiliation into a threat?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A new point of view with its own voice: boastful, sporty, crude, self-pitying. The narration adopts Bob's idiom (on fire, the man, the zone) then lets the phone call puncture it. The final paragraph turns a comic figure sinister.

- ☐ **Voice study** (25 min) Collect Bob's idioms. Write a paragraph about something you love in his voice.
- ☐ **Puncture** (15 min) Find where the phone call deflates the voice.
- ☐ **Comic to sinister** (15 min) Trace the chapter's tonal arc.
- ☐ **Free indirect self-pity** (15 min) Find self-pity in the prose.
- ☐ **Rewrite** (30 min) Rewrite the court scene from the former star's point of view.
- ☐ **Status list** (15 min) Analyse the list of status symbols.
- ☐ **Final line** (15 min) Analyse the last line's threat.
- ☐ **Inside the antagonist** (20 min) Write about how POV changes sympathy.
- ☐ **Reported speech** (20 min) Rewrite the rejection call as direct dialogue.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Masculinity, fathers and sons, status and its collapse, and self-justification. Bob's chapter mirrors Adam's fear: the dream can be repossessed. It also reveals that others know more about Corinne than Adam does.

- ☐ **Masculinity** (25 min) Discuss masculinity in Bob's chapter.
- ☐ **Fathers** (25 min) Discuss how fathers shape sons in the novel so far.
- ☐ **Status** (25 min) Discuss status anxiety in suburbs.
- ☐ **Self-justification** (20 min) Discuss how we justify favours.
- ☐ **Sympathy** (25 min) Debate whether Bob deserves sympathy.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "status" to your themes.
- ☐ **Hidden knowledge** (20 min) Discuss who else knows Corinne's secret.
- ☐ **Repossession** (20 min) Discuss the fragility of the dream.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Bob.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

After the 2008 financial crisis many US professionals faced long unemployment and foreclosure; suburban status anxieties of the period are well documented. The interview is with a major investment bank.

- [ ] **Foreclosure crisis** (25 min) Research US foreclosures after 2008.
- [ ] **Long-term unemployment** (25 min) Find statistics on long-term unemployment among professionals.
- [ ] **Athletic directors** (15 min) Research the role of a high-school athletic director.
- [ ] **Country clubs** (25 min) Research the history of US country clubs and exclusion.
- [ ] **Pickup culture** (15 min) Research pickup basketball culture.
- [ ] **Headhunters** (15 min) Research executive search firms.
- [ ] **Repossession** (15 min) Look up how car repossession works.
- [ ] **Slurs** (25 min) Research the history of homophobic language in sport.
- [ ] **Mansard roofs** (15 min) Look up mansard architecture.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Arthur Miller's Willy Loman in Death of a Salesman is the great American portrait of a man who confuses being liked with being worthy, and of a son crushed by a father's expectations.

- [ ] **Death of a Salesman** (35 min) Read the scene where Biff confronts Willy.
- [ ] **Masculinity studies** (25 min) Read a short essay on masculinity and sport.
- [ ] **Pastoral** (25 min) Compare Swede Levov's status.
- [ ] **Sports novels** (20 min) Find a novel about a father living through sport.
- [ ] **The Corrections** (25 min) Compare fathers and failure.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare Frank Wheeler's pride.
- [ ] **Status anxiety** (20 min) Read about Alain de Botton's Status Anxiety (2004).
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Bullies in fiction** (15 min) List three adult bullies in fiction.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Cedarfield has sides: the country-club section with manors, the side where teachers and tradesmen live. Bob crossed the town's internal border and fears being sent back.

- [ ] **Sides of town** (20 min) Map Cedarfield's sides: country club, teachers and tradesmen.
- [ ] **Church gym** (15 min) Add the church gym.
- [ ] **Bob's house** (15 min) Add Bob's manor.
- [ ] **Golf club** (15 min) Add the golf club.
- [ ] **Status ladder** (15 min) Place Bob on your status ladder.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 21.
- [ ] **Commute** (15 min) Map Bob's commute to the city interview.
- [ ] **Crossing borders** (20 min) Write about crossing a town's internal border.
- [ ] **Foreclosure map** (15 min) Imagine foreclosure signs on your map.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Does Bob's upbringing excuse him? The chapter invites compassion without exoneration. Ethics of character: Bob has been formed by cruelty and passes it on.

- [ ] **Upbringing** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Favours** (20 min) Was the B-team pick corrupt? Revisit with new information.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Bob's secret knowledge.
- [ ] **Bullying adults** (15 min) Discuss Bob's treatment of the former star.
- [ ] **Pride** (20 min) Is pride a vice here?
- [ ] **Compassion** (20 min) Write about compassion for unpleasant people.
- [ ] **Knowledge** (20 min) Is knowing someone's secret a responsibility?
- [ ] **Family pressure** (15 min) Discuss Melanie's nagging fairly.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a time pride came before a fall.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A minor antagonist gains a point of view and a secret, and the reader learns something Adam doesn't: others knew of the stranger's visit. A classic way to widen the conspiracy.

- [ ] **New POV** (15 min) Write about adding a POV for a minor antagonist.
- [ ] **Clue** (15 min) Pin Bob's knowledge of the stranger's visit to Adam.
- [ ] **Clue** (15 min) Pin Bob's hint that there is more to Corinne's story.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Bob.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene from a bully's viewpoint.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Add the lacrosse strand.
- [ ] **Plant and payoff** (15 min) Log Bob's knowledge.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A church gym at night, sneakers squeaking, grown men playing as if it matters. Basketball as a stage for male status, painted under fluorescent light.

- [ ] **Church gym** (35 min) Paint a church gym at night.
- [ ] **On fire** (20 min) Draw a comic sports-page panel of Big Bob.
- [ ] **Status still life** (20 min) Arrange status objects (car keys, club card) and photograph.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick Bob's walk-on song.
- [ ] **Father portrait** (20 min) Draw Robert Baime Sr. as a stern photograph.
- [ ] **Sound of a gym** (15 min) Describe squeaks and grunts.
- [ ] **Fake smile** (20 min) Draw a face smiling while falling apart.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a sports image.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food here; the chapter's appetite is for status. Bob imagines celebrating with Melanie in her pink outfit: rewards imagined, never delivered.

- [ ] **Post-game food** (40 min) Cook a post-game meal and talk about sport as refuge.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Bob's debts.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Bob's knowledge.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what did your father teach you about winning?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (30 min) Draw Big Bob and the frightened man.
- [ ] **Budget crisis** (25 min) Make a crisis budget for the Baimes.
- [ ] **Celebration that wasn't** (15 min) Discuss cancelled celebrations.
- [ ] **Recipe of a fall** (15 min) Write a recipe for a fall from status.
- [ ] **Team dinner** (20 min) Plan a team dinner for fathers and sons.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Bob smiles into the phone while his hopes collapse, so he will still sound confident. Write about a time you kept smiling through bad news, and what it cost.

- [ ] **Smiling through** (20 min) Write about smiling through bad news.
- [ ] **Fathers** (25 min) Write privately about your father's voice in your head.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate sympathy for Bob.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Bob do?
- [ ] **Letter to Bob** (20 min) Write to Bob after the call.
- [ ] **Letter to Pete** (15 min) Write to Pete.
- [ ] **Status** (20 min) Write about something you own to prove something.
- [ ] **Refuge** (15 min) Write about your refuge activity.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Inside Big Bob

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Analyse Bob's voice.
- [ ] Discuss sympathy.
- [ ] Use the Five lenses.
- [ ] Write from his POV.

Fathers and Sons

Rooms: Library Stacks, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Read Death of a Salesman.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss fathers in the novel.
- [ ] Write a theme claim.

Status Map

Rooms: Turnpike, Records Room, Diner

- [ ] Map the sides of town.
- [ ] Research foreclosure.
- [ ] Paint a status still life.
- [ ] Use the Status ladder.

Who Knows?

Rooms: Incident Board, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin Bob's knowledge.
- [ ] List who knows what.
- [ ] Debate responsibility.
- [ ] Predict.

Crisis Budget

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Records Room, Driveway

- [ ] Research costs.
- [ ] Make a budget.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Reflect.

Church Gym Night

Rooms: Diner, Price Kitchen, Law Office

- [ ] Paint the gym.
- [ ] Cook post-game food.
- [ ] Read the opening aloud.
- [ ] Discuss sport as refuge.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does Bob Baime's point-of-view chapter complicate our view of him? Discuss sympathy, masculinity and status.
2. Essay: Compare Bob's and Adam's relationships to "the dream" and its fragility.
3. Creative: Write Melanie Baime's account of the same evening at home, waiting for the call.

Further reading

- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A father, a son, and the American measure of success.
- *American Pastoral*, Philip Roth (1997). A golden boy's faith in the dream.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Male pride in the suburbs.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Fathers, failure and judgement.
- *Game On*, Tom Farrey (2008). Fathers living through children's sport.

- *Playing to Win: Raising Children in a Competitive Culture*, Hilary Levey Friedman (2013). Status and children's competition.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Class and parental investment.
- *The Sportswriter*, Richard Ford (1986). A former athlete in a New Jersey suburb.
- *Deal Breaker*, Harlan Coben (1995). Coben on sport, money and pride.

22. The Press Conference

What happens

At two in the morning Adam remembers Suzanne Hope from Nyack, the woman who led Corinne to the website. Expecting a false name, he searches anyway and finds a listing at once: age bracket, phone, address. He saves it with a screenshot trick Ryan taught him.

Next day he springs his "nuclear option": a press conference in the Rinskys' cramped living room, smelling of pine cleaner and cat. A handful of reporters from New Jersey papers and a local TV crew squeeze among the Hummels. Adam tells the story: a Vietnam veteran who came home in 1970, married his high-school sweetheart, bought this house with GI Bill money, rose from patrolman to chief, volunteered, paid off the mortgage, and now has a sick wife who finds comfort only here. The government wants to bulldoze it for chain stores. Rinsky plays his part, hunched and bewildered, holding Eunice's photograph. Adam notes, without guilt, what he left out: the generous offers. Lawyers take sides; the media want the best story, not the truest one. When Gush calls, Adam bluffs that national morning TV is interested and threatens to reveal the mayor's grudge against the cop who once arrested him. Build around the house, he says again.

Afterwards Adam finds Rinsky in a breakfast nook full of computers, printers and a corkboard of clippings. The old cop works cold cases with amateur sleuths online, including an unidentified young woman found dead in Wisconsin in 1984. Adam asks how to check whether Suzanne Hope is home without warning her. Rinsky dials from his old black phone with caller ID blocked, poses as a chimney-cleaning company, and gets hung up on. She's home.

Scene by scene

1. 2 a.m.: Adam finds Suzanne Hope's listing and saves it.
2. The Rinsky press conference: reporters among the figurines.
3. Adam's narrative: veteran, sweetheart, GI Bill, police career, paid-off home, sick wife.
4. Rinsky's performance with Eunice's photograph.
5. Adam's reflection: attorneys take sides; the media want the best story.
6. Gush calls; Adam bluffs about national TV and threatens to expose the mayor's grudge.
7. Rinsky's tech nook and cold-case hobby.
8. Rinsky's pretext call to Suzanne Hope: she's home.

Who's here

Adam Price	Advocate at full power, and an investigator at night.
Mike Rinsky	Veteran, retired chief, natural performer, amateur cold-case sleuth.
Eunice Rinsky	Present in a photograph and as the centre of the story.
Andy Gribbel	Who gathered the press.
Mayor Gush	On the phone, angry.
Reporters	From state papers and a local TV channel.

Thirty questions

1. How does Adam find Suzanne Hope?
2. What is the "nuclear option"?

3. What story does Adam tell the press?
4. What did he leave out?
5. How does Adam pressure Gush?
6. What is Rinsky's hobby?
7. **Is Adam's press strategy ethical? Is it different from what the stranger does?** [book club]
8. **Adam believes the media prefer a compelling story to an accurate one. Do you agree?** [book club]
9. **Rinsky performs frailty. Is that a lie?** [book club]
10. Why include Rinsky's cold-case hobby?
11. How does the press conference mirror the novel's themes of performance?
12. **Is threatening to expose the mayor's past blackmail?** [book club]
13. How does Adam compare with Gush as a performer?
14. What does the screenshot trick show about parents and children?
15. How does Rinsky's pretext call work?
16. **Is the pretext call a lie? Is it justified?** [book club]
17. What does the Jane Doe case add to the novel's themes?
18. How does Adam feel about his own manipulation?
19. Why place this triumph in the middle of Adam's personal crisis?
20. What does the room (Pine-Sol, cat, plastic-covered sofa) say about the couple?
21. How might Rinsky help Adam later?
22. Compare the press conference with the stranger's approaches.
23. What does "attorneys take sides" mean for justice?
24. **Would you have left out the offers?** [book club]
25. How is technology used for good here?
26. What do the reporters represent?
27. How does Gribbel help?
28. Why is Rinsky so willing?
29. What does "she's home" set up?
30. Predict the meeting with Suzanne.

Close reading

1. The best story

Find it: Chapter 22, middle: Adam's speech to the reporters.

1. List the biographical beats Adam uses.
2. Find the moment he pauses for effect.
3. Note Rinsky's staging.
4. Find Adam's admission of what he omitted.

How does Adam build a persuasive narrative, and what does the chapter think of it?

2. The bluff

Find it: Chapter 22, the phone call with Gush.

1. Find the bluff about national TV.
2. Note Gush's counter.
3. Find the threat about the arrest.
4. Note the parting advice.

Is Adam's tactic here different in kind from blackmail?

3. The old cop's skills

Find it: Chapter 22, close: Rinsky's nook and the pretext call.

1. Describe the tech nook.
2. Summarise the cold case.
3. Note the old phone and caller ID.
4. Read the call and its result.

How does the chapter turn Rinsky into an ally for the main plot?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A set-piece speech, delivered with rhetorical questions and a pause for water, then deconstructed by the narration's honesty about what was left out. The style mirrors its subject: storytelling as advocacy.

- ☐ **Speech analysis** (25 min) Annotate Adam's speech for rhetorical devices.
- ☐ **Omission** (25 min) Rewrite the speech including the offers. Is it weaker?
- ☐ **Staging** (15 min) Analyse the stage directions for Rinsky.
- ☐ **Bluff dialogue** (30 min) Write a bluffing phone call.
- ☐ **Honest narration** (15 min) Find where narration admits Adam's bias.
- ☐ **Tableau** (15 min) Describe the living room as a stage set.
- ☐ **Pace** (15 min) Compare the press scene and the nook scene.
- ☐ **Pretext call** (20 min) Write a pretext call of your own (harmless).
- ☐ **Last line** (15 min) Analyse "she's home" as an ending.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Truth and advocacy; media and narrative; performance as persuasion; and the ethics of pressure. The press conference rhymes with the stranger's work: both choose which truths to reveal.

- ☐ **Truth and advocacy** (25 min) Discuss how lawyers handle truth.
- ☐ **Media** (25 min) Discuss the best story versus the truest.
- ☐ **Performance** (20 min) Discuss performance in public life.
- ☐ **Pressure** (25 min) Is threatening exposure blackmail?
- ☐ **Cold cases** (20 min) Discuss amateur investigators.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "narrative" to your themes.
- ☐ **Comparison** (25 min) Compare Adam's press tactics with the stranger's.
- ☐ **Old age** (15 min) Discuss Rinsky's vitality.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of advocacy ethics.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Crowdsourced cold-case work became prominent in the 2000s–2010s; volunteers have helped identify unidentified remains. Pretext calls are an old investigative tool, legally grey in some contexts.

- [ ] **NJ media** (20 min) Research New Jersey's main newspapers and their history.
- [ ] **Cold-case groups** (25 min) Research online groups that identify unidentified remains.
- [ ] **Pretexting law** (20 min) Research legal limits on pretext calls.
- [ ] **Vietnam veterans** (25 min) Research veterans' return in 1970.
- [ ] **Caller ID** (15 min) Look up the history of caller ID and blocking.
- [ ] **Screenshots** (15 min) Look up when phone screenshots became common.
- [ ] **Press conferences** (20 min) Research legal advocacy through media.
- [ ] **Hummels** (15 min) Revisit Hummel history for the tableau.
- [ ] **Local TV news** (15 min) Research regional cable news in New Jersey.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Ibsen's An Enemy of the People shows a public meeting where truth loses to interest. Janet Malcolm's writing on journalism (The Journalist and the Murderer, 1990) famously questions the ethics of storytelling about others.

- [ ] **Enemy of the People** (30 min) Read the public meeting scene.
- [ ] **Janet Malcolm** (30 min) Read the opening of The Journalist and the Murderer (1990).
- [ ] **Little Pink House** (25 min) Read on media in the Kelo fight.
- [ ] **Cold-case fiction** (20 min) Find a novel about an amateur cold-case investigator.
- [ ] **Rhetoric** (20 min) Read about Aristotle's modes of persuasion.
- [ ] **Ronson** (25 min) Read on media narratives.
- [ ] **The Big Sleep** (20 min) Note how Marlowe uses pretexts.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about an old soldier.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The Rinskys' living room becomes a press room; Nyack, across the state line, is half an hour away. A pretext call bridges the distance.

- [ ] **Nyack** (15 min) Pin Suzanne's address area.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Calculate Kasselton to Nyack.
- [ ] **Living room** (20 min) Sketch the press conference.
- [ ] **Media map** (15 min) Map the newspapers' home towns.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 22.
- [ ] **Madison, Wisconsin** (15 min) Note the Jane Doe case location.
- [ ] **Command centre** (15 min) Sketch Rinsky's nook.
- [ ] **Strand map** (15 min) Draw how the Rinsky strand connects to the Adam strand.
- [ ] **Town reaction** (20 min) Imagine Kasselton reading the news.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Lawyers advocate; journalists select; investigators deceive with pretexts. Each role has its own ethics of truth. Where are the lines?

- [ ] **Advocacy** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the omission.
- [ ] **Pretext** (20 min) Is the pretext call justified?
- [ ] **Threats** (20 min) Is Adam's threat to Gush ethical?
- [ ] **Performance** (15 min) Is Rinsky's act deceptive?
- [ ] **Media duty** (20 min) What do journalists owe the public?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Compare Adam's act with the stranger's in the court tool.
- [ ] **Cold cases** (15 min) Is amateur sleuthing good?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a time you told a one-sided story.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The subplot pays off (Adam's plan revealed) and becomes useful to the main plot (Rinsky as ally). Suzanne is located: a thread from chapter 9 picked up.

- [ ] **Payoff** (15 min) Write about the subplot payoff.
- [ ] **Ally** (15 min) Pin Rinsky as an ally.
- [ ] **Thread** (15 min) Pin Suzanne located.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word press conference scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Gush.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note both strands.
- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin the Jane Doe hobby.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A living room full of reporters among Hummels and a cuckoo clock: a comic tableau. The photograph of Eunice held up for cameras is the image the news will use.

- [ ] **Tableau** (40 min) Paint the press conference among the figurines.
- [ ] **Photograph** (25 min) Design the newspaper front page.
- [ ] **Old phone** (15 min) Draw a black rotary phone.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Rinsky's act.
- [ ] **TV still** (15 min) Design a local-news lower third.
- [ ] **Corkboard** (25 min) Make a corkboard collage.
- [ ] **Sound of a room** (15 min) Describe a crowded small room.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a press image.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Rinsky's breakfast nook has become a command centre with computers on a Formica desk. Kitchens are often where family archives and new hobbies live.

- [ ] **Press coffee** (20 min) Make coffee for a crowd and discuss hospitality as strategy.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record what was omitted.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the mayor's past.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: is spin ever honest?
- [ ] **Breakfast nook** (20 min) Set up a breakfast-nook "command centre" for your book club.
- [ ] **Making: licence-plate notebook** (30 min) Use it for a cold-case style observation.
- [ ] **Veteran's supper** (45 min) Cook a 1970s veteran's supper and discuss.
- [ ] **Recipe of a story** (15 min) Write a recipe for a news story.
- [ ] **Cat-friendly snack** (15 min) Discuss pets in old houses.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam shades the truth for a client without guilt, while hunting for the truth about his wife. Write about a time you told a one-sided story for a good cause, and how it sat with you.

- [ ] **One-sided** (20 min) Write about telling one side.
- [ ] **Performance** (20 min) Write about performing for an audience.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate feelings.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Suzanne say?
- [ ] **Letter to Eunice** (15 min) Write to Eunice about the press.
- [ ] **Letter to Gush** (15 min) Write a reply to Gush.
- [ ] **Cold cases** (20 min) Write about an unsolved mystery in your life.
- [ ] **Advocacy** (20 min) Write about advocating for someone.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Best Story vs Truest

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Annotate the speech.
- [ ] Rewrite with omissions.
- [ ] Discuss media.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Rinsky's Nook

Rooms: Records Room, Incident Board, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Research cold-case groups.
- [ ] Pin Rinsky as ally.
- [ ] Set up a book-club command centre.
- [ ] Discuss amateur sleuths.

Press Day

Rooms: Diner, Records Room, Law Office

- [ ] Design a front page.
- [ ] Paint the tableau.
- [ ] Research NJ media.
- [ ] Write the news segment.

Pressure and Blackmail

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Incident Board

- [ ] Compare Adam and the stranger.
- [ ] Use the court tool.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Pin.

Finding Suzanne

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Map Nyack.
- [ ] Pin the thread.
- [ ] Predict.
- [ ] Write a letter.

Veterans and Homes

Rooms: Records Room, Price Kitchen, Library Stacks

- [ ] Research the GI Bill and Vietnam return.
- [ ] Cook a 1970s supper.
- [ ] Read an old soldier poem.
- [ ] Discuss.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse Adam's press conference in chapter 22. How does the novel use it to explore the relationship between truth and storytelling?
2. Essay: Compare Adam's pressure on the mayor with the stranger's methods. Is one more defensible?
3. Creative: Write the local TV news segment about the Rinskys as it might air.

Further reading

- *An Enemy of the People*, Henrik Ibsen (1882). A public meeting where truth loses to interest.
- *Little Pink House*, Jeff Benedict (2009). Media and the real Kelo fight.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Narrative and exposure in the media.
- *The Big Sleep*, Raymond Chandler (1939). A detective who uses pretexts freely.
- *The Simple Art of Murder*, Raymond Chandler (1944). Chandler on the detective as moral agent.

- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Lying in public life and professional roles.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Ends, means and advocacy.
- *Evicted*, Matthew Desmond (2016). Real stories of homes lost.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). A detective drawn to an old unsolved case.

23. Apartment 9B

What happens

The drive takes exactly twenty minutes. Suzanne Hope lives in one of those monotonous brick garden-apartment complexes that house young couples saving for a first home and divorced parents who can't afford more. Adam knocks on 9B with no plan. She won't open the door; he talks to it. When he says his wife is missing, it opens a crack, the chain still on. A postman eyes him suspiciously.

Suzanne last saw Corinne two or three years ago, at the coffee shop where she was caught out. Adam half-trusts a pop-psychology rule about eyes moving up and to the right when someone remembers rather than invents, and decides she isn't lying. Yes, Corinne asked a lot of questions: where to buy the belly, how to get the sonograms. Suzanne says they felt like kindred spirits; Corinne didn't judge her. Adam notices she wears no ring. Suzanne was married to Harold, who had a low sperm count; she was never pregnant at all. The stillborn story she told Corinne was a lie to win sympathy.

She wanted children badly. Her sister, who swore she'd never have any, has three and glowed with the attention pregnancy brought. Suzanne tried faking it once as a joke, and people held doors, offered parking spaces, asked how she was. It was a high, she says, a dopamine hit. She stopped a few months back, after Harold discovered it and discarded her; she's in therapy and owns her illness. Harold never loved her, maybe. Then she says she's glad she didn't pay the money; maybe the man who told Harold did her a favour. Adam goes cold. What man? Suzanne opens the door fully, stricken. He told you too.

Scene by scene

1. Twenty minutes to Nyack; a sad brick garden-apartment complex.
2. Talking to a closed door; the chain; a suspicious postman.
3. Suzanne last saw Corinne two or three years ago at the coffee shop.
4. Adam's eye-movement rule of thumb, with caveats.
5. Corinne asked about bellies and sonograms; "kindred spirits".
6. No ring: Suzanne was married to Harold, who had a low sperm count.
7. She was never pregnant; the stillborn story was a lie.
8. Her sister's glow and the high of attention; rock bottom a few months back, after Harold discovered it.
9. Therapy, ownership, a toxic marriage.
10. She didn't pay the money; a man told Harold. "He told you too."

Who's here

Suzanne Hope	Lonely, candid, in therapy, frightened at the door.
Harold	Her ex-husband, infertile, who discarded her (offstage).
Sarah	Suzanne's sister, mother of three (offstage).
Adam Price	Patient, careful, then chilled.
A postman	Suspicious of a man at a woman's door.

Thirty questions

1. Where does Suzanne live?
2. How does she first respond to Adam?

3. When did she last see Corinne?
4. What did Corinne ask her?
5. Was Suzanne ever pregnant?
6. Why did she fake pregnancy?
7. What does Adam learn at the very end?
8. Adam half-trusts the eye-movement rule. Should he?
9. **Why does Suzanne call Corinne a kindred spirit? What does that imply about Corinne?** [book club]
10. How does Suzanne's honesty now compare with her past lies?
11. **Suzanne's husband had a low sperm count, like Adam. What does this parallel suggest?** [book club]
12. **Is Suzanne's compulsion an illness, a choice, or both?** [book club]
13. How does the novel treat Suzanne? With mockery, pity or respect?
14. What role does her sister's experience play?
15. How does the chain on the door work as an image?
16. Why does the postman matter?
17. **What changes for Adam when Suzanne realises he has been visited too?** [book club]
18. **Is the man who exposed Suzanne a villain or an agent of truth?** [book club]
19. How does Suzanne's marriage mirror the Prices'?
20. Suzanne says she owns her illness. What does that mean?
21. How does Adam earn her trust?
22. What does Suzanne lose by talking?
23. How does therapy language appear in the chapter, and how does Adam react?
24. Would you have opened the door?
25. **What does "kindred spirits" say about loneliness?** [book club]
26. How does the setting contrast with Cedarfield?
27. How is attention like a drug, according to Suzanne?
28. Is Adam kind to Suzanne?
29. What will Adam ask next?
30. Predict how this changes his view of Corinne's situation.

Close reading

1. A conversation through a chain

Find it: Chapter 23, opening: talking through the door.

1. Note each of Suzanne's defensive replies.
2. Find what makes her open the door a crack.
3. Note the postman.
4. Find Adam's eye-movement reasoning and its caveats.

How does the physical barrier shape the conversation?

2. The story beneath the lie

Find it: Chapter 23, middle: Suzanne's confession about Harold and her sister.

1. Find the clue that leads to Harold.
2. Summarise the fertility story.
3. Note her sister's experience.
4. Find her description of the high.

How does Suzanne's history complicate the harsh judgement Adam passed on her in chapter 9?

3. The chill

Find it: Chapter 23, close: Suzanne's remark about not paying, and the reveal that follows.

1. Find her remark about not paying.
2. Find Adam's physical reaction.
3. Note his question.
4. Read her final line.

How does a throwaway remark become the chapter's turning point?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A conversation conducted through a door chain, slowly loosening. Notice how Suzanne's voice moves from defensive snaps to therapy-speak to an unguarded remark that changes everything. The final line reverses who knows what.

- ☐ **Door dialogue** (30 min) Write a scene conducted through a door.
- ☐ **Voice shifts** (20 min) Trace Suzanne's voice through the scene.
- ☐ **Therapy language** (15 min) Find therapy terms; analyse their effect.
- ☐ **Eye rule** (15 min) Analyse how Adam's caveats shape our trust.
- ☐ **Reversal line** (15 min) Write about the final line.
- ☐ **Sherlock** (15 min) Analyse the sarcasm about deduction.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Suzanne's side of the door.
- ☐ **Detail** (15 min) Analyse the description of the complex.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 22.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Loneliness, the craving for attention, infertility and male shame, and therapy as a way of owning one's story. The chapter also discovers a pattern: the stranger blackmails.

- ☐ **Loneliness** (25 min) Discuss loneliness and attention.
- ☐ **Male infertility** (25 min) Discuss male shame in the novel.
- ☐ **Owning illness** (20 min) Discuss therapy and accountability.
- ☐ **Exposure as gift** (25 min) Debate the dilemma.
- ☐ **Kindred spirits** (20 min) Discuss what Suzanne saw in Corinne.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "attention" again with new evidence.
- ☐ **Pattern** (20 min) Discuss the stranger's blackmail pattern.
- ☐ **Judgement** (20 min) Revisit Adam's earlier judgement of Suzanne.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Suzanne.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Eye-movement "tells" of lying come from neuro-linguistic programming and are not supported by research. Male infertility is common, contributing to a substantial share of couples' infertility.

- [ ] **Lie detection myths** (20 min) Research the evidence on eye-movement cues.
- [ ] **Male infertility** (20 min) Read a reputable explainer on male factor infertility.
- [ ] **Garden apartments** (15 min) Research the history of garden apartment complexes.
- [ ] **Nyack** (15 min) Research Nyack.
- [ ] **Factitious pregnancy** (20 min) Find a documented case in reputable press.
- [ ] **Therapy** (20 min) Research cognitive-behavioural therapy for compulsions.
- [ ] **Dopamine** (20 min) Read a reliable explainer on dopamine and reward.
- [ ] **Postal workers** (15 min) Research mail carriers as community watchers.
- [ ] **Blackmail statistics** (20 min) Research sextortion and blackmail trends.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Suzanne's attention-seeking echoes Goffman on self-presentation; her pain echoes literature of childlessness. The blackmail reveal links back to Conan Doyle's Milverton.

- [ ] **Goffman** (25 min) Apply Goffman to Suzanne.
- [ ] **Childlessness literature** (25 min) Find a memoir or novel about longing for children.
- [ ] **Milverton** (20 min) Revisit the blackmailer.
- [ ] **Ekman** (25 min) Read on lie detection.
- [ ] **Perel** (25 min) Read on secrets and shame in couples.
- [ ] **Ladder of Years** (20 min) Compare Delia's need to be seen.
- [ ] **Rebecca** (20 min) Compare jealousy of attention.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about longing.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Nyack, across the New York state line on the Hudson; a complex of identical brick buildings. Twenty minutes and a world away from Cedarfield.

- [ ] **Nyack pin** (15 min) Add Suzanne's complex.
- [ ] **Twenty minutes** (15 min) Map the drive.
- [ ] **Complex plan** (20 min) Sketch the garden-apartment complex.
- [ ] **State line** (15 min) Write about crossing a state line.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 23.
- [ ] **Coffee shops** (15 min) Map Suzanne's lunch spots.
- [ ] **Contrast** (20 min) Compare Nyack and Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Sister** (15 min) Imagine Sarah's town.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Suzanne to the stranger's case map.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Suzanne's exposure ended her marriage and her compulsion. Does a good outcome redeem a cruel act? And was Corinne's exposure the same kind of act?

- [ ] **Exposure** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Court** (20 min) Rule on Suzanne's case.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the stranger's blackmail.
- [ ] **Illness and blame** (20 min) Is Suzanne responsible?
- [ ] **Harold** (20 min) Was Harold cruel or wounded?
- [ ] **Lies to strangers** (20 min) Who did Suzanne harm?
- [ ] **Kindness** (15 min) Was Adam kind?
- [ ] **Good outcomes** (20 min) Do outcomes justify acts?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about wanting attention.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A thread from chapter 9 pays off with a twist: the stranger blackmails. Adam now has a pattern. The final line is a reversal: Suzanne realises Adam is a victim too.

- [ ] **Pattern** (15 min) Pin blackmail as the method.
- [ ] **Thread** (15 min) Pin the chapter 9 thread paid off.
- [ ] **Reversal** (35 min) Write a scene ending on "you too".
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate the stranger.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Add victims strand.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add Suzanne's exposure four months ago.
- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin Harold's infertility parallel.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A woman's face in the gap of a chained door: a classic thriller image. Paint the sliver of light and the hand on the frame.

- [ ] **Chained door** (35 min) Paint a face in a chained door.
- [ ] **Brick complex** (30 min) Paint the monotonous complex.
- [ ] **Glow** (30 min) Paint a pregnant woman glowing with attention.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Suzanne.
- [ ] **Bracelets** (15 min) Draw her bracelets.
- [ ] **Postman** (15 min) Draw the suspicious postman.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a chain sliding.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the door chain.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Suzanne's life in this chapter has no table, no meal, no guest: only a door kept on its chain. Hospitality begins when the chain comes off. Notice what she does as soon as she lets Adam in.

- [ ] **Tea for a stranger** (20 min) Make tea for an unexpected visitor; discuss hospitality and fear.

- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Suzanne's blackmail.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Suzanne's secrets.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: when have you craved attention?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (30 min) Draw Suzanne glowing and Suzanne alone.
- [ ] **Sister supper** (45 min) Cook for a sibling.
- [ ] **Comfort** (15 min) Discuss foods of loneliness.
- [ ] **Recipe of attention** (15 min) Write a recipe for being noticed.
- [ ] **Baby shower** (15 min) Discuss baby showers as attention rituals.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Suzanne says she wanted to be noticed so badly she invented a pregnancy. Write about a time you wanted to be seen, and what you did, or didn't do, to make it happen.

- [ ] **Being seen** (20 min) Write about wanting to be seen.
- [ ] **Longing** (20 min) Write privately about something you longed for.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate feelings.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Did Corinne pay?
- [ ] **Letter to Suzanne** (20 min) Write kindly.
- [ ] **Letter to Harold** (15 min) Write to Harold.
- [ ] **Doors** (15 min) Write about a door you wouldn't open.
- [ ] **Therapy** (20 min) Write about owning a problem.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Suzanne's Story

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Close-read her confession.
- [ ] Discuss attention.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Write her story in her voice.

The Pattern

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Records Room

- [ ] Pin blackmail.
- [ ] Research blackmail law.
- [ ] Use the court tool.
- [ ] Predict.

Eyes and Lies

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Law Office

- [ ] Research lie-detection myths.
- [ ] Read Ekman.
- [ ] Analyse Adam's caveats.
- [ ] Discuss.

Parallel Marriages

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks

- [ ] Compare the Hopes and the Prices.
- [ ] Discuss male infertility.
- [ ] Apply ethics.
- [ ] Write.

The Chained Door

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Turnpike

- [ ] Paint the door.
- [ ] Write a door scene.
- [ ] Map Nyack.
- [ ] Discuss barriers.

Exposure as Gift?

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss at table.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Verdict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 23 complicate the novel's portrayal of Suzanne Hope, and what does she reveal about attention and loneliness?
2. Essay: Discuss the parallels between the Hopes' marriage and the Prices'.
3. Creative: Write the moment Harold found out, from Harold's side.

Further reading

- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Self-presentation and audiences.
- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). The blackmailer pattern.
- *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman (1985). What really signals a lie.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Shame, secrecy and marriage.
- *Ladder of Years*, Anne Tyler (1995). A woman wanting to be seen differently.

- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Lies told to strangers and their costs.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Longing and what it does to families.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Exposure and its aftermath.
- *Missing You*, Harlan Coben (2014). Coben on loneliness and online deception.

24. The Picnic Table

What happens

Inside, Suzanne's apartment has white walls and white furniture and still feels dark and grimy, its art too bland for a budget motel. She wears a stack of jangling bracelets; her eyes blink as if expecting a blow. She offers wine. Adam, remembering that alcohol loosens tongues, accepts a glass he finds undrinkable and drinks anyway.

Suzanne works part-time at a department store till. One day on her lunch break a young man in a baseball cap was waiting at the picnic tables behind the store: thin, white, a bit of a geek, with a smile that made her relax. He asked if her husband knew she had faked pregnancies, called himself something like a stranger who reveals truth, and said he had proof. He wanted five thousand dollars, once. If she paid and stopped the deception, he would vanish; if she kept faking, he'd tell her husband. Asked how she could trust him not to come back for more, he smiled and said his people don't operate that way. Oddly, she believed him.

She didn't pay. What had she done wrong, she reasoned? She'd lied to strangers, not to Harold. Maybe she wanted him to find out; maybe he'd see a cry for help. The man sent Harold a link to everything she'd ordered from the fake-pregnancy site. Harold exploded; it fed every insecurity about his manhood and infertility. Suzanne tells Adam she's surprised Corinne made the same choice and didn't pay. She'd have expected Corinne to pay: Corinne loved him, and had so much to lose.

Scene by scene

1. Suzanne's white, dark apartment; bracelets; wary eyes.
2. Wine as an interrogation tool; Adam drinks something awful.
3. Her job and the picnic tables behind the store.
4. The young man in the cap: thin, nerdy, kind smile.
5. The demand: $5,000, once, and stop faking; or Harold finds out.
6. Trust: he insists his group doesn't come back for more, and she strangely believes him.
7. She refuses; she lied to strangers, not to Harold.
8. Maybe she wanted to be caught; a cry for help.
9. Harold gets the link and explodes; manhood and infertility.
10. Suzanne's surprise that Corinne didn't pay: she had so much to lose.

Who's here

Suzanne Hope	Candid, rueful, still a little in thrall to the stranger.
The stranger	Described by a victim for the first time: young, thin, gentle, a smile that disarms.
Harold Hope	Who learned the truth by link and turned on her.
Adam Price	Calculating, sympathetic, increasingly uneasy.

Thirty questions

1. Describe Suzanne's apartment.
2. Why does Adam accept the wine?
3. Where did the stranger approach Suzanne?
4. How does Suzanne describe him?
5. What were his terms?
6. What happened when she refused?

7. Why does Suzanne say she believed him?
8. **Is the condition to stop lying a moral fig leaf or a genuine principle?** [book club]
9. **Suzanne says she lied to strangers, not to her husband. Is that a real distinction?** [book club]
10. Did Suzanne want to be caught? What evidence?
11. How does the stranger's smile function in all his approaches?
12. What does Harold's reaction reveal about infertility and masculinity?
13. **Why does Suzanne expect Corinne to have paid?** [book club]
14. What does "she had so much to lose" make Adam realise?
15. How does Adam use the wine strategically? Is that fair?
16. How does the stranger's "we" change our understanding?
17. **Compare the stranger's approach to Suzanne with his approach to Adam.** [book club]
18. Is a one-time fee more ethical than ongoing blackmail?
19. How does the white-but-dark apartment reflect Suzanne?
20. Do you trust Suzanne's account?
21. Why is the picnic-table setting effective for the stranger?
22. What new questions does this raise about Corinne?
23. Is Harold a victim?
24. How does the chapter handle Suzanne's self-awareness?
25. **What would you have done in Suzanne's place?** [book club]
26. How does Coben make the stranger more human here?
27. What is Adam drinking to?
28. Why might Corinne not have paid?
29. **Is truth that arrives as a weapon still truth?** [book club]
30. Predict Adam's next theory.

Close reading

1. A room as a person

Find it: Chapter 24, opening: the apartment and Suzanne's appearance.

1. Note the contradictions in the description (white yet dark, clean yet grimy).
2. Find the detail of her eyes.
3. Find the bracelets.
4. Note Adam's decision about wine.

How does the description of the room prepare us for Suzanne's story?

2. The stranger seen by a victim

Find it: Chapter 24, middle: the encounter at the picnic tables.

1. List Suzanne's description of the man.
2. Paraphrase his terms.
3. Find his answer about trust.
4. Note her reaction to his smile.

How does seeing the stranger through Suzanne's eyes change him?

3. So much to lose

Find it: Chapter 24, close: Harold's reaction and Suzanne's surprise about Corinne.

1. Find how Harold learned.
2. Note Suzanne's analysis of his reaction.
3. Find her surprise about Corinne.
4. Note her reasons.

Why does the chapter end on Corinne's refusal to pay, and why should that bother Adam?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Reported narrative inside dialogue: Suzanne tells the stranger's approach in her own words, so we see him secondhand. Adam's silent strategies (accepting wine, letting her talk) are the chapter's quiet craft.

- ☐ **Secondhand portrait** (20 min) Analyse the stranger as described by Suzanne.
- ☐ **Interrogation tactics** (15 min) List Adam's quiet tactics.
- ☐ **Room description** (25 min) Write a room that is clean but sad.
- ☐ **Reported dialogue** (35 min) Rewrite the picnic-table scene as direct dramatisation.
- ☐ **Final line** (15 min) Analyse the ending's implication.
- ☐ **Bracelets** (15 min) Write about a single detail that characterises.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 23.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Write the stranger's version of the picnic table.
- ☐ **Irony** (15 min) Find ironies in Suzanne's account.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Blackmail with a moral condition; lies to strangers versus lies to intimates; wanting to be caught; masculinity and infertility. The novel complicates the stranger again.

- ☐ **Condition** (25 min) Debate the moral condition on blackmail.
- ☐ **Intimate vs public lies** (25 min) Discuss the distinction.
- ☐ **Wanting to be caught** (20 min) Discuss self-sabotage.
- ☐ **Masculinity** (20 min) Discuss Harold's reaction.
- ☐ **Trusting a blackmailer** (20 min) Why did she believe him?
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "coerced honesty".
- ☐ **Loss** (20 min) Discuss "so much to lose".
- ☐ **Method** (20 min) Discuss the stranger's method as a system.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Extortion is a crime whatever the demand's condition. Research on self-sabotage suggests some secret-keepers do unconsciously seek discovery.

- [ ] **Extortion law** (20 min) Research extortion definitions.
- [ ] **Self-sabotage** (20 min) Read on the psychology of wanting to be caught.
- [ ] **Retail work** (15 min) Research part-time retail work and breaks.
- [ ] **Infertility and masculinity** (25 min) Find research on men's experience of infertility.
- [ ] **In vino veritas** (15 min) Research alcohol and disclosure.
- [ ] **Online purchase records** (20 min) Research how purchase histories are stored.
- [ ] **Blackmail history** (25 min) Research the history of blackmail as a crime.
- [ ] **Department stores** (15 min) Look up Kohl's history.
- [ ] **Cry for help** (15 min) Research the phrase's use in psychology.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Conan Doyle's Milverton and the stranger differ: Milverton profits only. Hawthorne's Minister's Black Veil explores a man who wants his secret seen.

- [ ] **Milverton** (25 min) Compare Milverton and the stranger.
- [ ] **Black Veil** (30 min) Read Hawthorne's story.
- [ ] **Bok** (25 min) Read Bok on blackmail.
- [ ] **Gone Girl** (20 min) Compare coerced revelation.
- [ ] **Perel** (25 min) Read on wanting to be caught in affairs.
- [ ] **Crime and Punishment** (30 min) Compare Raskolnikov's urge to confess.
- [ ] **Tell-Tale Heart** (20 min) Read Poe's story of a secret that wants out.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about confession.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Behind a department store: picnic tables, a loading area, the edge of a car park. The stranger's settings are always transitional and public.

- [ ] **Store map** (15 min) Sketch the back of a department store.
- [ ] **Settings** (20 min) Map all the stranger's approach settings so far.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Update the case map.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 24.
- [ ] **Lunch break** (15 min) Map a worker's lunch-break world.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Nyack to Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Public places** (20 min) Write about public places for private news.
- [ ] **Suzanne's town** (15 min) Map Suzanne's routine.
- [ ] **Harold** (15 min) Imagine where Harold lives now.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is coercion toward honesty still coercion? The stranger's condition looks principled, but the money muddies it. Kantian ethics forbids using people as means; consequentialists may disagree.

- [ ] **Condition** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the blackmail.
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update Suzanne's case.
- [ ] **Wine** (15 min) Is plying a witness with drink fair?
- [ ] **Intimate lies** (35 min) Write 300 words on Suzanne's distinction.
- [ ] **Harold** (20 min) Discuss Harold's response ethically.
- [ ] **Trust** (20 min) Can a blackmailer be trustworthy?
- [ ] **Paying** (20 min) Would paying have been wrong?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a secret you half wanted found.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The method is now explicit and a new suspicion emerges: if Corinne didn't pay, why? Note the stranger's "we". The chapter ends with an anomaly to pin.

- [ ] **Method card** (15 min) Write the stranger's method as a card.
- [ ] **Anomaly** (15 min) Pin "Corinne didn't pay?"
- [ ] **"We"** (15 min) Pin the group.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene of a blackmail approach.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate the stranger.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Plant and payoff** (15 min) Log the payment question.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A white room that feels dark, art too generic for a motel, bracelets jangling: interior design as psychology. Paint a room that looks clean and feels sad.

- [ ] **Sad room** (35 min) Paint a white, sad room.
- [ ] **Picnic tables** (30 min) Paint picnic tables behind a store.
- [ ] **Smile** (20 min) Draw a disarming smile under a cap.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the picnic table.
- [ ] **Bracelets** (15 min) Design a bracelet stack.
- [ ] **Bad wine label** (15 min) Design a label for the worst wine.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe jangling bracelets.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the picnic table.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Wine as a tool of interrogation: Adam drinks something that tastes terrible to keep a witness talking. Hospitality and strategy share a glass.

- [ ] **Wine tasting** (30 min) Taste a cheap and a good wine (or juices) and discuss hospitality.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record $5,000.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the stranger's method.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you have paid?
- [ ] **Lunch break** (15 min) Pack a lunch for a store worker.
- [ ] **Making: secrets box** (20 min) Sort secrets into "told for money" and "told for free".
- [ ] **Comfort** (45 min) Cook for a lonely neighbour.
- [ ] **Recipe of trust** (15 min) Write a recipe for trusting a stranger.
- [ ] **Picnic** (45 min) Hold a picnic and discuss public privacy.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Suzanne wonders whether some part of her wanted her husband to find out, hoping he would finally pay attention. Write about a secret you half wanted someone to discover, and what you hoped would happen when they did.

- [ ] **Half-wanted** (20 min) Write about a secret you half wanted found.
- [ ] **Loss** (20 min) Write about having much to lose.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust in Corinne.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Why didn't Corinne pay?
- [ ] **Letter to Suzanne** (15 min) Write to Suzanne.
- [ ] **Letter to the stranger** (20 min) Write to the stranger.
- [ ] **Cry for help** (20 min) Write about a cry for help you heard or made.
- [ ] **Rooms** (15 min) Write about a room that matched your mood.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Method

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Records Room

- [ ] Write the method card.
- [ ] Research extortion.
- [ ] Apply ethics.
- [ ] Update the case map.

Wanting to Be Caught

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Read "The Tell-Tale Heart".
- [ ] Discuss self-sabotage.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Compare with Suzanne.

Coerced Honesty

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Discuss at table.
- [ ] Verdict.

Rooms and Selves

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Paint a sad room.
- [ ] Write a room description.
- [ ] Reflect.
- [ ] Share.

Why Didn't She Pay?

Rooms: Incident Board, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Pin the anomaly.
- [ ] List theories.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Revisit later.

Picnic Interview

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Law Office, Turnpike

- [ ] Hold a picnic.
- [ ] Analyse the picnic-table scene.
- [ ] Map approach settings.
- [ ] Discuss public privacy.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse the stranger's method as described by Suzanne. Does the condition that she stop lying change the moral character of his blackmail?
2. Essay: How does chapter 24 raise a new question about Corinne, and why is it unsettling for Adam?
3. Creative: Write the email Harold received, as he read it.

Further reading

- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). A blackmailer for profit only.
- *The Minister's Black Veil*, Nathaniel Hawthorne (1836). A secret that wants to be seen.
- *The Tell-Tale Heart*, Edgar Allan Poe (1843). A guilty heart that wants to confess.
- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). The urge to confess and be caught.

- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). The ethics of revelation and coercion.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Wanting to be caught in affairs.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). Revelation as a weapon in marriage.
- *The (Honest) Truth About Dishonesty*, Dan Ariely (2012). How people justify dishonesty.
- *Six Years*, Harlan Coben (2013). Coben on secrets and the people who keep them.

25. The Smell Test

What happens

Could it all be that simple, a blackmail scheme gone wrong? The stranger asks for money; you refuse; he tells. On the drive home Adam tests the theory and it fails the smell test. Corinne is a planner, a worrier, the perfect student. If she had been threatened and decided not to pay, she would have been ready for exposure. Instead, when Adam confronted her, she was clearly surprised and could only stall. And running off haphazardly, barely contacting anyone, leaving the boys: that isn't Corinne. Something else is going on.

He replays the stranger at the Legion: calm, concerned, taking no pleasure in it, not a psychopath but not businesslike either. He checks the locator app again; no sign of Corinne's phone. He guesses she was only passing through Pittsburgh and has switched the phone off, perhaps realising the boys could track her. Passing through to where? He has no idea. Should he respect her request, or get help, or call the police?

The question answers itself as he turns into his street. Three men are waiting at the edge of his lawn: his neighbour Cal Gottesman, Tripp Evans, and Bob Baime. For a split second Adam fears the worst about Corinne, then reasons that if Corinne were hurt the news would come from Len Gilman, not from these three. A police car marked with the town's name slides up and Len Gilman steps out. Adam sprints toward them on unsteady legs. We need to talk, Len says.

Scene by scene

1. The blackmail theory, stated plainly.
2. Why it doesn't pass the smell test: Corinne the planner was surprised.
3. Running off haphazardly and leaving the boys isn't like her.
4. Replaying the stranger: calm, concerned, neither psycho nor businesslike.
5. The locator app: still nothing; she was probably passing through Pittsburgh.
6. Respect her request, get help, or go to the police?
7. Three men on the curb: Cal, Tripp and Bob.
8. A police car: Len Gilman.
9. "We need to talk."

Who's here

Adam Price	Reasoning like a lawyer, then running like a husband.
Cal Gottesman	Neighbour, glasses-pusher, board secretary.
Tripp Evans	League president.
Bob Baime	Board vice-president.
Len Gilman	Police chief, arriving in a squad car.

Thirty questions

1. What is the simple theory Adam tests?
2. Why does it fail the smell test?
3. What does Adam conclude about Corinne's surprise?
4. What does he think happened in Pittsburgh?
5. Who is waiting at his house?
6. What does Len say?

7. **Is character evidence reliable? Adam uses Corinne's nature as proof.** [book club]
8. **Adam decides the stranger seemed neither unhinged nor coldly professional. What does that suggest?** [book club]
9. Why would Corinne turn off her phone?
10. **Is Adam right to resist the simplest explanation?** [book club]
11. What does Adam fear when he sees the men?
12. Why does he reason that Len, not the others, would deliver bad news?
13. What could bring these four men together?
14. How does the chapter use the street as a stage?
15. Why is Cal described as a neighbour now?
16. How does the chapter end on an unspecified threat?
17. What does the speed of Adam's run say?
18. Compare Adam's reasoning here with chapter 3's "do the work".
19. How does the narration self-mock ("Captain Obvious")?
20. **Is Adam's indecision about the police reasonable?** [book club]
21. What has changed in Adam's understanding of the stranger?
22. How might the lacrosse board be connected?
23. What would you do if four neighbours were waiting for you?
24. Is the novel playing fair with its clues so far?
25. How does the chapter mix reasoning and fear?
26. **Adam concludes there must be more to it than blackmail. What does that imply about the structure of the mystery?** [book club]
27. **How does Adam know his wife? Does he?** [book club]
28. What is the effect of the squad car?
29. Why such a short chapter?
30. Predict what Len will say.

Close reading

1. Reasoning from character

Find it: Chapter 25, opening: testing the blackmail theory.

1. State the theory in your own words.
2. List Adam's objections.
3. Find his description of Corinne as a student and planner.
4. Find his conclusion.

How strong is an argument from someone's character, and how does the novel use it?

2. Reassessing the messenger

Find it: Chapter 25, middle: replaying the stranger and checking the app.

1. Find how Adam now describes the stranger.
2. Note the two categories he rules out.
3. Find his theory about the phone.
4. Note his unresolved choice.

How has the stranger changed in Adam's mind since chapter 1?

3. A street as a tribunal

Find it: Chapter 25, close: the men on the curb.

1. List the men in order of appearance.
2. Find Adam's flash of fear.
3. Find his reasoning about who brings bad news.
4. Read the last line.

How does the chapter stage a domestic street as a scene of judgement?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A reasoning chapter written in the rhythm of argument: a theory, objections, conclusion, then a jolt of action. The ending uses a classic image of dread, men waiting on a lawn, and a four-word line.

- ☐ **Argument structure** (20 min) Outline Adam's argument as premises and conclusion.
- ☐ **Self-mockery** (15 min) Analyse "Captain Obvious".
- ☐ **Image of dread** (30 min) Write a scene ending with people waiting on a lawn.
- ☐ **Four words** (15 min) Write about the final line.
- ☐ **Fear and logic** (15 min) Trace where fear interrupts logic.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapters 23–24.
- ☐ **Rewrite** (30 min) Rewrite the ending from Len's POV.
- ☐ **Short chapter craft** (15 min) Why short?
- ☐ **Tense** (15 min) Note tense and time shifts.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Knowing a person versus explaining their actions; the limits of simple theories; community as tribunal. The novel signals that its mystery has more layers.

- ☐ **Knowing people** (25 min) Discuss how well we know those close to us.
- ☐ **Simple theories** (20 min) Discuss when simple explanations fail.
- ☐ **Community tribunal** (20 min) Discuss groups judging individuals.
- ☐ **Character evidence** (25 min) Debate its reliability.
- ☐ **Messenger** (20 min) Discuss Adam's new view of the stranger.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "knowing".
- ☐ **Police** (15 min) Discuss police as neighbours.
- ☐ **Fear** (15 min) Discuss anticipatory fear.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Occam's razor is attributed to the fourteenth-century philosopher William of Ockham. Police notifications of bad news are typically made in person, often in pairs, which Adam knows.

- [ ] **Occam** (15 min) Research William of Ockham.
- [ ] **Death notifications** (20 min) Research how police deliver bad news.
- [ ] **Character evidence law** (25 min) Research character evidence in US trials.
- [ ] **Phone tracking** (15 min) Research how switching off affects tracking.
- [ ] **Youth sports boards** (15 min) Research typical board structure.
- [ ] **Neighbours** (15 min) Research neighbourhood watch culture.
- [ ] **Smell test** (15 min) Look up the idiom.
- [ ] **Pittsburgh routes** (15 min) Research routes west from Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Police cars** (15 min) Look up municipal police in NJ.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Detectives from Poirot onward argue from character and psychology. Christie's The Murder of Roger Ackroyd is the great warning about trusting appearances.

- [ ] **Roger Ackroyd** (20 min) Read about Christie's famous twist.
- [ ] **Poirot** (25 min) Read a Poirot passage on psychology.
- [ ] **Crewdson** (20 min) Look at Twilight photographs.
- [ ] **Tell No One** (20 min) Compare a husband's certainty about his wife.
- [ ] **Rebecca** (20 min) Compare knowing a spouse.
- [ ] **Epistemology** (25 min) Read a short piece on knowledge of other minds.
- [ ] **The Lottery** (20 min) Compare community gatherings.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about waiting for news.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Adam drives home from Nyack thinking, and the novel's map shrinks with each turn: the state line, the town, his street, his curb, the length of his own front walk, where a squad car glides to a stop.

- [ ] **Street** (20 min) Sketch the street with the men and the car.
- [ ] **Neighbours** (15 min) Mark Cal's house.
- [ ] **Pittsburgh onward** (20 min) Map routes beyond Pittsburgh.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 25.
- [ ] **Nyack to home** (15 min) Map the drive.
- [ ] **Lawn** (15 min) Write about lawns as stages.
- [ ] **Police station** (15 min) Mark the Cedarfield police station.
- [ ] **Board members' homes** (15 min) Mark them.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place each man on the status ladder.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is it rational to trust what you know of someone over a neat explanation? Epistemology meets love: how do we know the people we live with?

- [ ] **Character vs explanation** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Respect or report** (20 min) Revisit the police decision.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam's choice.
- [ ] **Group power** (15 min) Is a delegation intimidation?
- [ ] **Knowing** (25 min) Write about the ethics of assuming you know someone.
- [ ] **Trust** (20 min) Is trusting Corinne's character loyal or naive?
- [ ] **Stranger** (15 min) Reassess the stranger in the court tool.
- [ ] **Police as friends** (15 min) Discuss conflicts of roles.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about defending someone's character.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The chapter clears one theory and sets up another; the ending introduces a group of possible antagonists at once. A tidy example of misdirection and escalation.

- [ ] **Theory cleared** (15 min) Pin the failed blackmail theory.
- [ ] **Delegation** (15 min) Pin the four men.
- [ ] **Scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word scene of a delegation at a door.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate all four.
- [ ] **Misdirection** (15 min) Write about clearing a theory.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Update.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate the ending.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the lacrosse strand.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Four men in a row on a suburban curb, a police car gliding in: an image straight out of a Gregory Crewdson photograph, everything still and wrong.

- [ ] **Curb tableau** (40 min) Paint four men on a curb at dusk.
- [ ] **Squad car** (20 min) Draw a police car gliding in.
- [ ] **Crewdson style** (30 min) Photograph your street at dusk in a staged way.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the turn into the street.
- [ ] **Sketch** (15 min) Draw Adam running.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a car door in a quiet street.
- [ ] **Storyboard** (20 min) Storyboard the last page.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the curb.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food; the house waits behind the men, its kitchen empty. Their wives and kitchens are elsewhere: this is a delegation of fathers and board members, and kitchens, where the women of Cedarfield make many decisions, are pointedly absent.

- [ ] **Visitors** (15 min) Discuss what you offer unexpected visitors.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record theories.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add "why are they here?"
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: how well do we know each other?
- [ ] **Making: notebook** (20 min) Add a theories page.
- [ ] **Comfort** (40 min) Cook something for a frightened neighbour.
- [ ] **Neighbours supper** (60 min) Invite neighbours and discuss trust.
- [ ] **Recipe of dread** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Coffee** (15 min) Make coffee for four.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam's knees nearly give way when he sees men waiting for him. Write about a time you feared bad news from the sight of people waiting.

- [ ] **Waiting people** (20 min) Write about fearing news.
- [ ] **Knowing someone** (20 min) Write privately about how well you know your partner.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Len say?
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write again.
- [ ] **Character** (20 min) Write about defending someone's character.
- [ ] **Simple answers** (15 min) Write about rejecting a simple answer.
- [ ] **Neighbours** (15 min) Write about your neighbours.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Smell Test

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board

- [ ] Outline Adam's argument.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Pin the cleared theory.
- [ ] Write a verdict.

Dread on the Curb

Rooms: Diner, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Paint the tableau.
- [ ] Map the street.
- [ ] Write a delegation scene.
- [ ] Discuss.

Knowing Each Other

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Hold a neighbours supper.
- [ ] Reflect.

Clue Fairness

Rooms: Incident Board, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Review clues so far.
- [ ] Read about Ackroyd.
- [ ] Debate fair play.
- [ ] Pin.

Four Men

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Turnpike

- [ ] Rate each.
- [ ] Map their homes.
- [ ] Discuss group power.
- [ ] Predict.

Occam's Razor

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Law Office

- [ ] Research Ockham.
- [ ] Apply to the case.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Assess Adam's reasoning in chapter 25. Is an argument from Corinne's character convincing, and how does the novel test it?
2. Essay: How does chapter 25 use setting and image to create dread?
3. Creative: Write the conversation among the four men on the curb before Adam arrived.

Further reading

- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). A classic warning about trusting appearances.
- *Twilight: Photographs by Gregory Crewdson*, Gregory Crewdson (2002). Staged suburban dread in photographs.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband's faith in his wife's character.
- *Rebecca*, Daphne du Maurier (1938). How well can we know a spouse?

- *The Lottery*, Shirley Jackson (1948). A community gathering with a dark purpose.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Public faces and private selves.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). What partners know about each other.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). A detective whose theories keep failing.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Coben on rumour and community judgement.

Chapter 26 of 56 · told through Johanna

26. A Rug from Ravi

What happens

Johanna Griffin, police chief of Beachwood, Ohio, has seen plenty of death: natural causes, overdoses, suicides, terrible car crashes. She has never stood at a murder scene. Murder offends her on another level; it is a person taking on a god's power over life for the worst of reasons. And this victim is Heidi Dann, her friend, lying on the Oriental rug she bought for four hundred dollars from a cheerful man called Ravi who sells them out of a truck outside the Whole Foods. Heidi was shot in the knee and in the forehead.

Her young officer, Norbert Pendergast, tries not to look excited and points out the county will take the case; local departments handle traffic and bike licences, not homicide. Johanna knows that, and resents it. This is her town. She knew Heidi: her dancing, her bridge, her naughty laugh, her taste in nail polish and in television. She goes to the kitchen, where Marty sits shattered, back from a convention in Columbus. She sits in Heidi's chair and asks quick questions before the county arrives.

Nothing seems stolen; Heidi's grandmother's engagement ring is still on her finger. Marty can't think of an enemy; Heidi didn't have one. He asks Johanna to help tell the children. Johanna knows the county detectives will fixate on the husband, and knows, as only a friend can, that he didn't do it. When the county men arrive she hands over without a fight. Heidi deserves the experts. But she has no intention of stopping.

Scene by scene

1. Johanna Griffin, Beachwood police chief, at her first homicide scene.
2. Murder as an obscenity; the victim is her friend Heidi.
3. The rug from Ravi; the wounds.
4. Norbert notes the county will take over.
5. Johanna's knowledge of Heidi's life.
6. Marty in the kitchen, back from Columbus; questions in Heidi's chair.
7. No robbery: the grandmother's ring remains.
8. No enemies; Marty asks her to help tell the kids.
9. The county detectives arrive; Johanna steps aside but won't stop.

Who's here

Johanna Griffin	Police chief of Beachwood: blunt, warm, grieving, determined.
Norbert Pendergast	A rookie officer, eager despite himself.
Marty Dann	Heidi's husband, devastated, with an alibi.
Heidi Dann	The victim, remembered vividly.
Ravi	A rug seller with a ready smile who keeps coming back.
County detectives	The specialists who take over homicides.

Thirty questions

1. Who is Johanna Griffin?
2. Why is this scene different from others she has seen?
3. Who will take the case?
4. Where was Marty?
5. Why does Johanna rule out robbery?

6. What does Marty ask her to do?
7. How does the chapter make Heidi present though she is dead?
8. **Johanna calls murder an obscenity. What distinguishes it from other deaths?** [book club]
9. Why include Ravi and the rug?
10. **Is Johanna's certainty about Marty professional or personal?** [book club]
11. What does the chapter say about jurisdiction and expertise?
12. How does Johanna's voice differ from Adam's?
13. Heidi loved a show about a single woman and a show about a criminal. What does that say about her?
14. Why does the novel introduce a new investigator now?
15. **How do readers know more than Johanna?** [book club]
16. What does sitting in Heidi's chair mean?
17. Is Johanna right to resent the county detectives?
18. How does the chapter treat Norbert's excitement?
19. What is the effect of the kneecap detail on readers who remember chapter 14?
20. **How does grief motivate investigation?** [book club]
21. What will Johanna need to discover?
22. How does this chapter connect Ohio to New Jersey?
23. **Is the dark humour about "county dicks" appropriate in a grief scene?** [book club]
24. **Compare Johanna and Len Gilman as police chiefs.** [book club]
25. How does the chapter characterise Marty in a few lines?
26. What does it mean that Heidi had no enemies?
27. How might the stranger's visit lead to Heidi's death?
28. What is the moral weight of being the one to tell children?
29. Who do you think killed Heidi, from the reader's vantage?
30. Predict Johanna's first lead.

Close reading

1. The obscenity of murder

Find it: Chapter 26, opening: Johanna's reflections on death and murder.

1. List the kinds of death she has seen.
2. Find her description of murder.
3. Note the turn to the personal.
4. Find the image of Heidi on the rug.

How does the chapter build from the general to the personal?

2. A life in details

Find it: Chapter 26, middle: Johanna's knowledge of Heidi.

1. List what Johanna knows about Heidi.
2. Note the repetition of the rug story.
3. Find Norbert's question.
4. Note her resentment of the county.

Why does the chapter insist on trivial details about Heidi's life?

3. Questions before the experts

Find it: Chapter 26, close: Marty in the kitchen and the county's arrival.

1. Note Marty's state.
2. List Johanna's questions.
3. Find the ring detail.
4. Note her final resolve.

How does the chapter set up Johanna as an unofficial detective?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A new point-of-view character with a strong, colloquial, Midwestern voice. The chapter uses repetition (the rug, Ravi, the price) as a grief mechanism: Johanna keeps returning to small details because the large one is unbearable.

- ☐ **New voice** (20 min) Compare Johanna's voice with Adam's and Heidi's.
- ☐ **Repetition as grief** (15 min) Trace the rug detail's repetitions.
- ☐ **Restraint** (15 min) Analyse how the body is described.
- ☐ **Dark humour** (15 min) Analyse the humour about county detectives.
- ☐ **Interview scene** (35 min) Write a short interview of a grieving spouse.
- ☐ **Details** (20 min) Write a paragraph of trivial details that portray a friend.
- ☐ **Point of view** (25 min) Rewrite one paragraph from Norbert's view.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the final resolve.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 25.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Murder, grief, jurisdiction, friendship and the limits of institutions. The novel's secrets now have a body count; the theme shifts from moral to mortal stakes.

- ☐ **Murder** (25 min) Discuss what makes murder distinct.
- ☐ **Grief and work** (20 min) Discuss working through grief.
- ☐ **Jurisdiction** (20 min) Discuss institutional limits.
- ☐ **Friendship** (20 min) Discuss loyalty after death.
- ☐ **Stakes** (20 min) Discuss how the novel's stakes have changed.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "consequences" with new weight.
- ☐ **Women in authority** (20 min) Discuss Johanna as a female chief.
- ☐ **Telling children** (20 min) Discuss breaking bad news to children.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion of Johanna.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

In many US metro areas, small municipal police forces call in county or state investigators for homicides. Beachwood is real; its police chief in the novel is fictional. Heidi's favourite shows are real.

- [ ] **Homicide jurisdiction** (25 min) Research county homicide units in Ohio.
- [ ] **Beachwood** (15 min) Research Beachwood.
- [ ] **Female police chiefs** (20 min) Research women police chiefs in the US.
- [ ] **TV shows** (15 min) Look up the two shows Heidi loved.
- [ ] **Alibis** (20 min) Research how alibis are checked.
- [ ] **Spouse suspicion** (20 min) Research why spouses are first suspects.
- [ ] **Rug trade** (15 min) Research street sales of rugs.
- [ ] **Death notifications** (20 min) Research guidance on telling children.
- [ ] **Crime scenes** (20 min) Research crime-scene procedure.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The friend who investigates outside official channels is a crime-fiction staple, from Agatha Christie's amateurs to Laura Lippman's Tess Monaghan. Johanna is a chief working like an amateur.

- [ ] **Lippman** (20 min) Read about Laura Lippman's detective novels.
- [ ] **Christie** (20 min) Read about Miss Marple as amateur.
- [ ] **Grief literature** (20 min) Find a novel narrated by a grieving friend.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (25 min) Compare grief and investigation.
- [ ] **Tana French** (20 min) Compare personal involvement.
- [ ] **Breaking Bad** (15 min) Read about the show's premise.
- [ ] **Female detectives** (15 min) List three female detectives.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain elegy.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Beachwood again: the Dann house, the Whole Foods, Interstate 271, Columbus three hours away. Johanna knows every inch; the county men don't.

- [ ] **Beachwood map** (20 min) Detail Beachwood: house, Whole Foods, I-271.
- [ ] **Columbus** (15 min) Map Marty's alibi trip.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Beachwood to Columbus.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 26.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Link Heidi's death to the stranger's visit.
- [ ] **Johanna's town** (20 min) Write about policing your hometown.
- [ ] **County seat** (15 min) Find Cuyahoga County's seat.
- [ ] **Neighbours** (15 min) Map Heidi's friends.
- [ ] **Danger map** (15 min) Update.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Partiality again: Johanna's love for Heidi gives her insight and bias. Should friends investigate friends' deaths? Professional ethics say no; loyalty says yes.

- [ ] **Unofficial investigation** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Bias** (20 min) Can love be evidence?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Johanna's choice.
- [ ] **Stranger's responsibility** (25 min) Is the stranger responsible for Heidi's death?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update Heidi's case in the court tool.
- [ ] **Duty to tell** (15 min) Discuss telling the children.
- [ ] **Murder** (20 min) Why is murder uniquely wrong?
- [ ] **Institutions** (20 min) When should you work around institutions?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about grief and duty.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A second investigator enters. The reader knows more than she does (Kuntz, the restaurant), creating dramatic irony. Johanna becomes a parallel to Adam.

- [ ] **Second detective** (15 min) Pin Johanna.
- [ ] **Dramatic irony** (15 min) List what we know that she doesn't.
- [ ] **Clues** (15 min) Pin the kneecap and the ring.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word first-homicide scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Marty.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Add the Heidi strand.
- [ ] **Parallel** (15 min) Compare Johanna and Adam.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

An Oriental rug bought from a truck outside a supermarket: a small comic history now stained. Paint the rug, not the body.

- [ ] **The rug** (35 min) Paint an Oriental rug pattern.
- [ ] **Truck** (20 min) Draw Ravi's rug truck.
- [ ] **Portrait** (20 min) Draw Johanna in her ill-fitting uniform.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Heidi.
- [ ] **Nail polish** (15 min) Design weird nail colours for Heidi.
- [ ] **Kitchen** (30 min) Paint a kitchen with a grieving man.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a crime scene's quiet.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the rug.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Johanna sits in Heidi's own chair at the kitchen table to question Marty, the seat still shaped by her friend. Kitchens recur in this novel as places of interrogation and confession, because they are where families sit facing each other every day.

- [ ] **Casserole** (45 min) Cook a casserole for a grieving family.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Heidi's case.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add "who killed Heidi?"
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: how do we honour friends?
- [ ] **Bridge night** (60 min) Play bridge or cards in Heidi's honour.
- [ ] **Making: memory box** (40 min) Make a memory box for a friend.
- [ ] **Recipe of grief** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea for someone in shock.
- [ ] **Chair** (15 min) Discuss the empty chair.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Johanna keeps thinking about the rug and what Heidi paid for it because the larger fact is unbearable. Write about the small details your mind clung to when you had bad news.

- [ ] **Small details** (20 min) Write about details you clung to.
- [ ] **Friend** (20 min) Write about a friend who made you feel special.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Johanna's first lead?
- [ ] **Letter to Heidi** (20 min) Write to Heidi.
- [ ] **Letter to Johanna** (15 min) Write to Johanna.
- [ ] **Grief** (20 min) Write about grief and work.
- [ ] **Home town** (15 min) Write about your town.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Johanna's File

Rooms: Incident Board, Records Room, Turnpike

- [ ] Pin Johanna and the clues.
- [ ] Research jurisdiction.
- [ ] Map Beachwood.
- [ ] Track her from now on.

In Memory of Heidi

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Play cards.
- [ ] Paint the rug.
- [ ] Write a letter.
- [ ] Make a memory box.

Grief and Duty

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Verdict.

Second Detective

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Incident Board

- [ ] Compare voices.
- [ ] Read about amateur detectives.
- [ ] Write a scene.
- [ ] Pin parallels.

Consequences

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Incident Board, Room 233

- [ ] Trace the chain from the stranger to the murder.
- [ ] Debate responsibility.
- [ ] Use the court tool.
- [ ] Write.

Telling the Children

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Driveway

- [ ] Research guidance.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write the scene.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 26 change the novel's stakes and tone? Discuss Johanna Griffin as a new point of view.
2. Essay: Analyse the role of small details (the rug, the ring, the shows) in characterising Heidi after her death.
3. Creative: Write Johanna telling Kimberly the news.

Further reading

- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Grief and investigation in a close community.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A detective and a family's long secret.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). A detective too close to the case.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Investigators working against the odds.

- *The Big Sleep*, Raymond Chandler (1939). The detective as moral witness.
- *The Simple Art of Murder*, Raymond Chandler (1944). What crime fiction owes the dead.
- *Gone for Good*, Harlan Coben (2002). Coben on murder in an ordinary family.
- *Six Years*, Harlan Coben (2013). Coben on grief and pursuit.
- *The Lottery*, Shirley Jackson (1948). A friendly community and sudden violence.

27. Friends and Neighbors

What happens

Len Gilman asks whether the boys are home. He looks less like a police chief than an ageing biker, with a nicotine-stained handlebar moustache and furry forearms. The five men stand on the curb, absurdly, until Len leads them inside. Jersey the dog offers a muted greeting and slinks off. Len takes Adam's armchair; the other three line up on the couch like the three wise monkeys. Adam stays standing. Two feelings hit him at once: relief, because if Corinne were hurt Len would know where she was; and fear, because whatever this is, it's bad.

Len insists he's here as a friend and neighbour, not as police chief. They are looking for Corinne. She missed a board meeting and hasn't answered texts, emails or calls; Len even went to the school and spoke to the principal. Adam recognises the cop technique of waiting in silence for the subject to fill it. Tripp, as president, finally says it: there are discrepancies in the lacrosse finances. Bob snaps that money is missing. Cal nods.

Len plays Mr Reasonable: if the books are made whole, it stays in the room. No questions. Adam, through his fear, feels disgust: organisations always cover up for the greater good. How much is missing? Confidential. You can't think Corinne would… Right now they just need to talk to her. Where is she? The lawyer in Adam takes over; he has warned too many clients not to talk. He tells them to leave.

Scene by scene

1. Len asks if the boys are home; his biker look.
2. Five men on the curb; inside, Jersey slinks away.
3. Len takes Adam's chair; the three monkeys on the couch.
4. Relief and fear.
5. "Friend and neighbour", not police chief.
6. Corinne missed the board meeting; Len went to the school.
7. The cop's silence technique.
8. Tripp: discrepancies in the finances. Bob: money missing.
9. Make the books whole and it stays in the room.
10. Adam's disgust at cover-ups; lawyer's instinct; "leave".

Who's here

Len Gilman	Police chief playing neighbour.
Tripp Evans	President, reluctant spokesman.
Bob Baime	Vice-president, aggressive.
Cal Gottesman	Secretary, nervous.
Adam Price	Relieved, afraid, then guarded.
Tom Gorman	The school principal (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. Why have the four men come?
2. What roles do they hold on the board?

3. What does Len say about why he is there?
4. What is missing?
5. What deal do they offer?
6. How does Adam respond?
7. **Is Len really there "as a friend"? Can a police chief ever be off duty?** [book club]
8. Why does Len take Adam's chair?
9. Why does Adam feel relief and fear?
10. **Is the offer to keep it quiet generous or corrupt?** [book club]
11. Why does Adam feel disgust?
12. Is Adam right not to tell them where she is (which he doesn't know anyway)?
13. What does the cop technique of silence reveal?
14. How do the three men on the couch behave?
15. **Does Corinne's secret pregnancy make the theft charge more believable?** [book club]
16. How does the chapter link the lacrosse board to Corinne's disappearance?
17. What does "board confidentiality" now mean?
18. **Is Adam acting like a husband or a lawyer?** [book club]
19. How does the dog respond, and why mention it?
20. What does Len's visit to the school show about small towns?
21. How does the chapter treat institutional power?
22. Compare this group visit with the stranger's solo visits.
23. Who seems most hostile, and why?
24. **What would you do in Adam's place?** [book club]
25. How does this change your theory about Corinne?
26. **Is it plausible Corinne stole money?** [book club]
27. What does "it stays in this room" remind you of?
28. How might the missing money relate to the fake pregnancy?
29. How does the chapter use the living room as a stage?
30. Predict how much is missing.

Close reading

1. Taking the room

Find it: Chapter 27, opening: the men entering the house.

1. Note Len's appearance.
2. Note the dog's reaction.
3. Find who sits where.
4. Find Adam's double reaction.

How does the chapter show power through seating and movement?

2. Two hats

Find it: Chapter 27, middle: Len's "friend and neighbour" speech and the silence.

1. Find Len's disclaimer.
2. Find his account of visiting the school.
3. Note his use of silence.
4. Note Adam's recognition of it.

How does Len try to be two things at once, and does it work?

3. The cover-up offer

Find it: Chapter 27, close: the accusation and the offer.

1. Find who speaks the accusation.
2. Note the offer's terms.
3. Find Adam's reflection on organisations.
4. Read his final line.

Why does Adam respond as a lawyer rather than a husband?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A scene of power choreography: who enters first, who sits where, who speaks, who stays silent. The comic image of three men on a couch as the wise monkeys undercuts the menace. Watch the dialogue alternate between Len's smoothness and Bob's snaps.

- ☐ **Choreography** (20 min) Diagram the movements and seating.
- ☐ **Monkeys** (15 min) Analyse the comic image.
- ☐ **Dialogue roles** (15 min) Assign each speaker a role (smooth, snappy, silent).
- ☐ **Silence** (30 min) Write a scene where silence is a tactic.
- ☐ **Relief and fear** (15 min) Analyse the double reaction.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Cal's POV.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse "leave".
- ☐ **Repetition** (15 min) Note repeated "friend and neighbour".
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 25.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Institutions and cover-ups; friendship as a mask for authority; the presumption of guilt. The novel connects the private lie (pregnancy) to a public accusation (theft), testing how one colours the other.

- ☐ **Cover-ups** (25 min) Discuss organisational cover-ups.
- ☐ **Two hats** (20 min) Discuss conflicts of role.
- ☐ **Presumption** (20 min) Discuss presumption of guilt.
- ☐ **Private lie, public charge** (25 min) Does one lie make another believable?
- ☐ **Silence** (20 min) Discuss the right to silence.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "institutions".
- ☐ **Small towns** (20 min) Discuss everyone knowing everyone.
- ☐ **Volunteer power** (15 min) Revisit volunteer boards.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Embezzlement from volunteer youth sports organisations is a real and recurring problem, often by trusted treasurers; many cases end with quiet repayment. The right to silence is protected by the Fifth Amendment.

- [ ] **Youth sports embezzlement** (30 min) Research real cases of treasurers embezzling from youth leagues.
- [ ] **Restorative justice** (20 min) Research restorative justice.
- [ ] **Fifth Amendment** (15 min) Research the right to silence.
- [ ] **Board roles** (20 min) Research nonprofit board officer duties.
- [ ] **Police ethics** (15 min) Research off-duty conduct rules.
- [ ] **Three monkeys** (15 min) Look up the proverb's origins (Japan).
- [ ] **Principals** (15 min) Research principal confidentiality.
- [ ] **Forensic accounting** (20 min) Research how missing funds are traced.
- [ ] **Audits** (15 min) Research audits of small nonprofits.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The genial authority figure who promises it will stay in the room recurs in crime fiction. Tripp's earlier speeches and this scene recall Miller's All My Sons, where community loyalty shades into complicity.

- [ ] **All My Sons** (25 min) Revisit community complicity.
- [ ] **Enemy of the People** (20 min) Revisit town interest.
- [ ] **Embezzlement fiction** (20 min) Find a novel about embezzlement.
- [ ] **Ariely** (25 min) Read on everyday dishonesty.
- [ ] **Bok** (25 min) Read Bok on secrecy in institutions.
- [ ] **The Corrections** (15 min) Compare family and money.
- [ ] **Caught** (20 min) Compare Coben's community accusations.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about suspicion.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The novel's map contracts to a single living room: armchair, couch, front door, a dog's path to the kitchen. Yet the whole town has come inside with these four men: the league, the police, the school and the neighbours, all mapped onto Adam's furniture.

- [ ] **Living room** (20 min) Sketch the room with positions.
- [ ] **Board homes** (15 min) Map the four men's houses.
- [ ] **School** (15 min) Mark Len's visit.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 27.
- [ ] **Lacrosse fields** (15 min) Mark the turf fields the money funded.
- [ ] **Bank** (15 min) Imagine where the league banks.
- [ ] **Neighbourhood** (15 min) Map who can see the Price curb.
- [ ] **Status ladder** (15 min) Rank the four men.
- [ ] **Town hall** (15 min) Mark the police station.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is private resolution of wrongdoing mercy or corruption? Restorative justice values repair; rule-of-law values accountability. The board's offer sits between.

- [ ] **Private resolution** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the offer.
- [ ] **Presumption** (35 min) Write 300 words on presumption of guilt.
- [ ] **Role conflict** (20 min) Is Len's visit improper?
- [ ] **Silence** (20 min) Is Adam right to stay silent?
- [ ] **Loyalty** (20 min) What does Adam owe Corinne here?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Begin a case file on the money.
- [ ] **Institutions** (20 min) When do institutions deserve trust?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about being accused.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A major new plot thread: missing money, with Corinne as suspect. It retroactively explains Tripp's visit. The board members now form a suspect pool.

- [ ] **New thread** (15 min) Pin the missing money.
- [ ] **Suspects** (15 min) Pin the four men and Corinne.
- [ ] **Retroactive** (15 min) Revisit Tripp's earlier visit.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word accusation scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate all four men.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add the board meeting.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the lacrosse strand.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Three men in a row on a couch, one sprawled in the host's armchair, the host himself left standing: a group portrait that is also a diagram of power. Paint it, and decide where the light falls and who is in shadow.

- [ ] **Group portrait** (40 min) Paint the living-room tableau.
- [ ] **Monkeys** (20 min) Draw the three monkeys as the board.
- [ ] **Moustache** (15 min) Draw Len.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the accusation.
- [ ] **Ledger art** (20 min) Design a page of a doctored ledger.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a deliberate silence.
- [ ] **Dog** (15 min) Draw Jersey slinking away.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add a ledger.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Adam offers no drinks, no coffee, no seat. In a town where hospitality is a reflex, withholding it is a statement: this is not a social call, whatever Len claims, and Adam will not pretend it is.

- [ ] **Hospitality withheld** (15 min) Discuss refusing hospitality.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Start a page on the lacrosse money.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the missing money.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you keep it quiet?
- [ ] **Making: ledger** (40 min) Bind a second ledger signature for the league's accounts.
- [ ] **Bake sale** (15 min) Discuss bake sales and volunteer funds.
- [ ] **Budget** (25 min) Draft a youth league budget.
- [ ] **Recipe of a cover-up** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Coffee for five** (15 min) Discuss what you'd serve and why.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam's first feeling is relief: if they're asking where Corinne is, she isn't dead. Write about a time bad news came as a relief because it wasn't the worst news.

- [ ] **Relief** (20 min) Write about relief that it wasn't the worst.
- [ ] **Accused** (20 min) Write about being suspected.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust in Corinne.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Did Corinne take it?
- [ ] **Letter to Len** (15 min) Write to Len.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write about the money.
- [ ] **Silence** (20 min) Write about choosing silence.
- [ ] **Neighbours** (15 min) Write about neighbours as judges.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Lacrosse Money

Rooms: Incident Board, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin the thread.
- [ ] Research youth-league embezzlement.
- [ ] Start a case file.
- [ ] Debate private resolution.

Power in a Room

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Turnpike

- [ ] Diagram the room.
- [ ] Paint it.
- [ ] Write a scene.
- [ ] Discuss.

Cover-ups

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Read All My Sons again.
- [ ] Apply lenses.
- [ ] Write.

Suspect Pool

Rooms: Incident Board, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Rate the men.
- [ ] Discuss motives.
- [ ] Predict.
- [ ] Reflect.

League Budget

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Records Room, Incident Board

- [ ] Draft a budget.
- [ ] Research audits.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Bind the ledger.

Two Hats

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Records Room

- [ ] Research police ethics.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Verdict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Analyse the power dynamics of the living-room scene in chapter 27.
2. Essay: How does the accusation of theft interact with what we already know of Corinne's deception?
3. Creative: Write the board meeting Corinne missed, from Cal's minutes.

Further reading

- *All My Sons*, Arthur Miller (1947). Community, money and complicity.
- *The (Honest) Truth About Dishonesty*, Dan Ariely (2012). How ordinary people rationalise taking a little.
- *An Enemy of the People*, Henrik Ibsen (1882). A town's leaders protecting the town's interest.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Secrecy in institutions.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Accusation and reputation in a suburb.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Families, money and shame.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Justice, fairness and repair.
- *The Lottery*, Shirley Jackson (1948). The community that turns on one of its own.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). The volunteer life of American towns.

28. The Forty-Yard Dash

What happens

Dan Molino, a big ex-linebacker who runs a small furniture-delivery business from Sparta, New Jersey, stands in the bleachers trying not to cry. He always cries at his children's triumphs and hides it behind sunglasses and excuses; his wife Carly, whom he thinks married beneath her, loves him for it. His son Kenny, a 285-pound high-school senior, is about to run the forty-yard dash at a football combine. A time under 5.2 seconds would clinch a full scholarship; big programmes are watching, even Notre Dame.

A small, nerdy man in a too-big baseball cap, plainly not a football person, asks if Dan knows. Kenny runs a personal-best 5.07, and Dan's tears, for once, won't come. The stranger hands him a manila envelope. Kenny gained fifty-five pounds in a year; it wasn't puberty and hard work. It was steroids, bought on the hidden online marketplace Silk Road with bitcoin, the purchases traceable to the family computer's IP address. Every trophy since junior year is tainted.

The stranger asks for ten thousand dollars, once, a bargain, he notes, given college costs. He sketches what exposure would mean: the scouts, the pub where everyone slaps Dan's back, what the town would think of Carly. Kenny jogs over, beaming, looking for his father's approval. The stranger tells Dan to look at the envelope at home, and meanwhile to enjoy this special moment with his son.

Scene by scene

1. Dan Molino in the bleachers: a crier who hides it.
2. His business, his marriage to Carly, his three children.
3. Kenny, 285 pounds, needs under 5.2 in the forty.
4. The stranger appears and asks whether Dan already knows.
5. Kenny runs 5.07; Dan's tears don't come.
6. The envelope: steroids from Silk Road, paid in bitcoin, traceable to the home IP.
7. Ten thousand dollars, once.
8. The threat to Dan's standing, and to Carly.
9. Kenny arrives; the stranger tells Dan to savour the moment.

Who's here

Dan Molino	A soft-hearted big man, proud father, small-business owner.
Kenny Molino	A senior football prospect, devoted son, secret steroid user.
Carly Molino	Dan's wife, née Applegate.
The stranger	Small, nerdy, out of place, smiling.
Eddie Thompson	Carly's wealthy former admirer, whose family owns fast-food franchises (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. Who is Dan Molino?
2. Why does he wear sunglasses?
3. What time does Kenny need, and what does he run?
4. What is in the envelope?
5. How much does the stranger ask for?
6. What does the stranger say about Carly?

7. Why do Dan's tears stop when the stranger appears?
8. **Did Dan know, on some level? The stranger thinks so.** [book club]
9. **Is the stranger cruel to choose this moment?** [book club]
10. How does the novel present Dan's soft-heartedness?
11. What does Dan's insecurity about Carly reveal?
12. **Is a scholarship won with steroids stolen from another boy?** [book club]
13. **Should Dan pay?** [book club]
14. What does the stranger's parting advice to savour the moment suggest about him?
15. How does this case differ from Heidi's and Suzanne's?
16. How does the chapter use sport as a mirror of the lacrosse world?
17. Why is the stranger described as small and out of place?
18. What does the reference to college costs reveal?
19. How does technology betray Kenny?
20. **What would you do as Dan?** [book club]
21. Is the stranger targeting wrongdoing or vulnerability?
22. What does the "pub" detail show about small-town status?
23. How does Kenny's devotion to his father complicate the moral picture?
24. Why might the novel keep showing these other cases?
25. Compare Dan and Bob Baime as sports fathers.
26. Is doping in high-school sport common, and does that matter morally?
27. How is timing used for drama?
28. What does the stranger know that worries you?
29. **Do you think Dan will pay?** [book club]
30. Predict the consequences.

Close reading

1. A soft giant

Find it: Chapter 28, opening: Dan's tears and his marriage.

1. Find Dan's tear habit and his cover stories.
2. Note his view of Carly's choice.
3. Find the background on his business.
4. Note Kenny's character.

How does Coben make us like Dan before the blow?

2. Time slowing

Find it: Chapter 28, middle: the race.

1. Find the stranger's first words.
2. Note Dan's reaction.
3. Read the race description.
4. Find the missing tears.

How does the race scene combine triumph and dread?

3. Blackmail at a celebration

Find it: Chapter 28, close: the envelope and the stranger's parting words.

1. List the drugs and the evidence.
2. Note the demand.
3. Find the threat to Carly.
4. Read the parting words.

Is the stranger's parting advice kindness or cruelty?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

Another victim POV, deftly characterised: Dan's tears, his sunglasses, his sense of having married above himself. The race is written in slow motion with an aside about time slowing during new experiences. The final line pairs tenderness and menace.

- ☐ **Character in habits** (15 min) Analyse Dan's crying habit as characterisation.
- ☐ **Slow motion** (25 min) Write a 150-word slow-motion sports moment.
- ☐ **Juxtaposition** (15 min) Analyse triumph and blackmail side by side.
- ☐ **Stranger's language** (20 min) Compare the stranger's lines here and in chapter 8.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the parting line.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Kenny's view.
- ☐ **Detail** (15 min) Analyse the drug names as realism.
- ☐ **Insecurity** (15 min) Write about Dan's view of Carly.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 27.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Cheating, parental complicity, the cost of college, and blackmail at the moment of triumph. The sports world here mirrors the lacrosse world of Cedarfield: scholarships and status corrupt.

- ☐ **Cheating** (25 min) Discuss cheating in youth sport.
- ☐ **Complicity** (20 min) Did Dan know?
- ☐ **College costs** (20 min) Discuss scholarship pressure.
- ☐ **Timing** (20 min) Discuss cruelty of timing.
- ☐ **Masculine tears** (20 min) Discuss men crying.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "cheating".
- ☐ **Pattern** (20 min) Discuss the stranger's pattern.
- ☐ **Status** (15 min) Discuss local fame.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Silk Road operated from 2011 until the FBI shut it in 2013; drugs were bought with bitcoin. Anabolic steroid use among US high-school athletes has been documented by surveys. Forty-yard dash times are central to football recruiting.

- [ ] **Silk Road** (25 min) Research Silk Road and its shutdown.
- [ ] **Teen steroids** (20 min) Find survey data on teen steroid use.
- [ ] **Recruiting** (20 min) Research football recruiting combines.
- [ ] **Forty-yard dash** (15 min) Look up typical lineman times.
- [ ] **Bitcoin** (15 min) Read a basic explainer.
- [ ] **Sparta NJ** (15 min) Research Sparta.
- [ ] **Scholarships** (20 min) Research athletic scholarships.
- [ ] **Steroid health risks** (20 min) Read a reliable health source.
- [ ] **Delivery businesses** (15 min) Research small delivery firms vs chains.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Doping scandals and the fathers who push sons echo throughout sports fiction and journalism; Nick Bilton's American Kingpin tells the real Silk Road story.

- [ ] **American Kingpin** (35 min) Read an excerpt.
- [ ] **Sports doping writing** (25 min) Find a reputable book or long article on doping.
- [ ] **Friday Night Lights** (20 min) Read about H. G. Bissinger's 1990 book on high-school football.
- [ ] **Fathers and sons** (20 min) Revisit Death of a Salesman.
- [ ] **Milverton** (15 min) Compare blackmail at a celebration.
- [ ] **Game On** (25 min) Read on youth sport pressures.
- [ ] **Ariely** (25 min) Read on cheating.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a runner (Housman's "To an Athlete Dying Young").

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Sparta, a lake town in Sussex County, north-west New Jersey; a combine at a stadium somewhere; the scouts' universities far away. Dan's world is local; Kenny's chance is national.

- [ ] **Sparta** (15 min) Pin Sparta.
- [ ] **Stadium** (15 min) Imagine the combine location.
- [ ] **Colleges** (20 min) Map Alabama, Ohio State, Penn State, Notre Dame.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Dan.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 28.
- [ ] **Delivery routes** (15 min) Map Dan's delivery area.
- [ ] **Lake town** (15 min) Write about lake towns.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Sparta to Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Pub** (15 min) Imagine O'Malley's.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is a scholarship won by doping theft from another child? Should a father report his son? Love and fairness collide. The stranger's fee makes the dilemma worse: silence can be bought.

- [ ] **Report or protect?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Court** (20 min) Rule on Dan's case.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to paying.
- [ ] **Fairness** (35 min) Write 300 words on the scholarship and the boy who lost it.
- [ ] **Timing** (15 min) Is cruel timing a moral wrong?
- [ ] **Complicity** (20 min) Is willful blindness culpable?
- [ ] **Fee** (15 min) Is a modest fee better than a large one?
- [ ] **Ring of Gyges** (15 min) Did anonymity enable Kenny?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about protecting a child from consequences.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A third blackmail case confirms the pattern and shows the stranger working alone, which may matter. The chapter deepens our sense of the operation's reach.

- [ ] **Pattern** (15 min) Pin the third case.
- [ ] **Alone** (15 min) Note the stranger works alone here.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word blackmail-at-a-celebration scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Dan and the stranger.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Add victims strand.
- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin the absence of Ingrid.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A big man weeping behind sunglasses in bleachers: tender and comic. Paint the sunglasses with the race reflected in them.

- [ ] **Sunglasses** (30 min) Paint sunglasses reflecting a race.
- [ ] **Big man** (20 min) Draw Dan in the bleachers.
- [ ] **Envelope** (15 min) Draw the manila envelope.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the dash.
- [ ] **Trophies** (25 min) Paint a shelf of trophies, one cracked.
- [ ] **Stopwatch** (15 min) Design a stopwatch reading 5.07.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a starter's gun.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the envelope.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Kenny gained fifty-five pounds; the official story was eating and lifting. Bodies are fed and built, and the line between nutrition and doping is the secret here.

- [ ] **Training table** (40 min) Cook a high-protein athlete's meal and discuss bodies.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record $10,000.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Kenny's secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you report your child?
- [ ] **Making: two-faced portrait** (30 min) Draw Kenny the hero and Kenny the cheat.
- [ ] **Victory dinner** (20 min) Plan a victory dinner and discuss its new meaning.
- [ ] **Supplements** (20 min) Discuss legal supplements vs drugs.
- [ ] **Recipe of cheating** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Pub snacks** (30 min) Make pub snacks and discuss local fame.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Dan's tears refuse to come at the moment he has dreamed of. Write about a moment you had waited for that was spoiled by something only you knew.

- [ ] **Spoiled moment** (20 min) Write about a spoiled moment.
- [ ] **Tears** (20 min) Write about crying in public.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate sympathy.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Will Dan pay?
- [ ] **Letter to Kenny** (20 min) Write from Dan.
- [ ] **Letter to Dan** (15 min) Write to Dan.
- [ ] **Pride** (15 min) Write about pride in a child.
- [ ] **Cheating** (20 min) Write about a time you cut a corner.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Cheating and Sport

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research teen steroid use.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Stranger's Pattern

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin all cases.
- [ ] Map them.
- [ ] Compare methods.
- [ ] Write a profile.

Silk Road

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Research.
- [ ] Read Bilton.
- [ ] Discuss the dark web.
- [ ] Write a note.

Fathers in the Stands

Rooms: Driveway, Diner, Room 233

- [ ] Compare Dan and Bob.
- [ ] Paint the bleachers.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Victory Dinner

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Lacrosse Field, Law Office

- [ ] Cook.
- [ ] Discuss reporting.
- [ ] Analyse the ending.
- [ ] Write.

Housman's Athlete

Rooms: Library Stacks, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Read the poem.
- [ ] Paint the trophy shelf.
- [ ] Discuss glory.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: Compare the stranger's approach to Dan Molino with his approaches to Heidi and Suzanne. What patterns emerge?
2. Essay: Discuss the ethics of youth sport in the novel, from the lacrosse draft to Kenny's steroids.
3. Creative: Write the conversation between Dan and Kenny that night.

Further reading

- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). The real story of Silk Road and its founder.
- *Game On*, Tom Farrey (2008). The pressures of youth sport.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A father, a son, and the gap between image and truth.
- *The (Honest) Truth About Dishonesty*, Dan Ariely (2012). Why cheating spreads and how we justify it.
- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). Blackmail and its victims.
- *Playing to Win: Raising Children in a Competitive Culture*, Hilary Levey Friedman (2013). Competition and parental investment.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). When to reveal a child's secret.
- *Deal Breaker*, Harlan Coben (1995). Coben's sports-world intrigue.
- *Scorecasting*, Tobias J. Moskowitz & L. Jon Wertheim (2011). The hidden forces in sporting outcomes.

29. Bonner's Notebook

What happens

The American Legion lot is popular with illegal parkers, so the Legion pays John Bonner to guard it. Bonner was captain of the high-school basketball team; then mental illness took hold. He spends nights at a mental-health facility and days muttering about conspiracies involving the mayor and a Civil War general. His old classmate, the Legion's president, gave him the job to keep him from wandering. Bonner takes it seriously, keeping a vast notebook of paranoid musings and exact licence plates. When people park illegally to shop, he lets them, checks where they went, then calls the president, who happens to own a towing company. The narrator shrugs: it is all a hustle.

Adam has decided he can't just wait. Everything went wrong here, so he starts here. Bonner, in a many-buttoned blazer, a tablecloth-check shirt and laceless sneakers, eyes him warily and lectures him on the local buffalo wings. Adam spins a story: some out-of-towners in a grey Honda sideswiped his car on draft night and he needs their plate for the insurance. Bonner remembers the night precisely and flips frantically through his notebook.

Then he grins. He wants two hundred dollars. Because Adam is lying: Bonner was there and would have heard a crash; Adam's car, parked right over there, has no damage; and before Adam claims he drove another car, Bonner has the details of that night in his book. He remembers the couple, the stranger and a cute blonde, because everyone else he'd seen a million times and they didn't belong. He wondered why they came. Now he knows. Adam asks if it's really two hundred. It's a fair price, says Bonner. No cheques. No quarters.

Scene by scene

1. The Legion lot and its guardian, John Bonner.
2. Bonner's history: basketball captain, then mental illness.
3. The parking racket with the towing company.
4. Adam decides to stop waiting and start where it began.
5. Bonner's outfit and his opinions on wings.
6. Adam's lie about a sideswipe and a grey Honda.
7. Bonner flips through his notebook.
8. Bonner catches the lie, point by point.
9. He remembers the stranger and the blonde: they didn't belong.
10. Two hundred dollars. No cheques, no quarters.

Who's here

John Bonner	The lot attendant: mentally ill, obsessive, sharp, funny.
Rex Davies	Legion president and tow-company owner (mentioned).
Adam Price	A poor liar, outplayed.

Thirty questions

1. Who is John Bonner?
2. What is his job, and how did he get it?
3. What is the parking racket?
4. What lie does Adam tell?

5. How does Bonner catch him?
6. What does Bonner remember about the stranger?
7. **How does the chapter treat Bonner's mental illness?** [book club]
8. Why does Adam underestimate Bonner?
9. **The narrator sees rackets everywhere. Is that the book's philosophy?** [book club]
10. Is Bonner's fee fair?
11. What does his notebook represent in a novel about surveillance?
12. Why do the stranger and blonde stand out to Bonner?
13. How does the chapter use comedy?
14. **Compare Bonner's notebook with Corinne's phone app.** [book club]
15. How does the town treat its former star?
16. What does Bonner's old team captaincy add?
17. Is Adam a good liar? What does that say about him?
18. What does "no quarters" reveal about Bonner?
19. How do outsiders get noticed in Cedarfield?
20. **What is the moral of Adam being outplayed?** [book club]
21. How does the Legion president's tow business reflect the town?
22. Is the chapter kind to Bonner?
23. How does Bonner's obsession become useful?
24. What does this chapter reveal about watchers?
25. Why does Adam pay rather than argue?
26. How does the chapter return to the novel's opening place?
27. **What would you have done to get the plate?** [book club]
28. How might Bonner's observations matter later?
29. **What does the chapter say about dignity?** [book club]
30. Predict what the plate leads to.

Close reading

1. A town's outsider

Find it: Chapter 29, opening: Bonner's history and the parking racket.

1. Summarise Bonner's past.
2. Explain the racket.
3. Note the narrator's verdict on it.
4. Describe his notebook.

How does the chapter present Bonner as both pitiable and powerful?

2. Bad lying

Find it: Chapter 29, middle: Adam's cover story.

1. Find Adam's opening line.
2. Note the wings tangent.
3. Paraphrase the sideswipe lie.
4. Note Bonner's reaction.

What does Adam's clumsy lie reveal about him?

3. The watcher wins

Find it: Chapter 29, close: Bonner's demolition of the lie.

1. List Bonner's three points.
2. Find his memory of the strangers.
3. Note the price.
4. Read the final terms.

How does the chapter reverse the power between Adam and Bonner?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A comic duel of wits. Bonner's speech is erratic, funny and suddenly precise; Adam's lies are tidy and wrong. The final terms (no cheques, no quarters) give Bonner the last laugh and the chapter its punchline.

- ☐ **Comic duel** (20 min) Annotate the exchange as a duel of wits.
- ☐ **Voice** (20 min) Write five lines in Bonner's voice.
- ☐ **Lie anatomy** (15 min) Analyse why Adam's lie fails.
- ☐ **Punchline** (15 min) Analyse the final terms.
- ☐ **Character description** (20 min) Write a vivid outfit description.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Bonner's POV.
- ☐ **Narrator verdict** (15 min) Analyse the narrator's cynical verdict on the lot.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 28.
- ☐ **Exposition** (15 min) How is the racket explained?

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Surveillance by the marginal; mental illness and dignity; small-town rackets; underestimating people. The novel's theme of watching takes a human, analogue form.

- ☐ **Dignity** (25 min) Discuss Bonner's dignity.
- ☐ **Mental illness** (25 min) Discuss portrayal of mental illness.
- ☐ **Rackets** (20 min) Discuss small-town rackets.
- ☐ **Watchers** (20 min) Compare watchers in the novel.
- ☐ **Underestimating** (20 min) Discuss assumptions about people.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "watchers".
- ☐ **Former stars** (15 min) Discuss what happens to local heroes.
- ☐ **Community care** (20 min) Discuss Bonner's job as care or exploitation.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Predatory towing is a real municipal issue across the US. Many towns have former local heroes struggling with mental illness; community jobs like Bonner's are sometimes created out of kindness or convenience.

- [ ] **Predatory towing** (20 min) Research towing regulation.
- [ ] **Supportive housing** (20 min) Research supportive housing for mental illness.
- [ ] **Licence plates** (15 min) Research NJ plate formats.
- [ ] **Stonewall Jackson** (15 min) Read a short factual biography.
- [ ] **Chuck Taylors** (15 min) Research the shoe's history.
- [ ] **Buffalo wings** (15 min) Research their origin (Buffalo, NY, 1964).
- [ ] **American Legion posts** (15 min) Research post management.
- [ ] **Plate data** (20 min) Research automated plate readers and privacy.
- [ ] **Mental illness stats** (15 min) Find prevalence of serious mental illness.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Sherlock Holmes's Baker Street Irregulars: unregarded people who see everything. Bonner is Cedarfield's irregular, with a notebook.

- [ ] **Baker Street Irregulars** (20 min) Read about Holmes's street informants.
- [ ] **Outsiders** (20 min) Find a novel with a marginal witness.
- [ ] **The Lottery** (15 min) Compare community roles.
- [ ] **Mental illness fiction** (20 min) Find a novel with a mentally ill witness treated with respect.
- [ ] **Solove** (20 min) Read on records and privacy.
- [ ] **Zuboff** (20 min) Compare analogue and digital watching.
- [ ] **Hammett** (15 min) Read about Sam Spade buying information.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a watchman.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Back to the Legion lot of chapter 1, with its exits and the bulk-buy shop and garden centre that draw illegal parkers. The opening place returns, seen through a different watcher.

- [ ] **Lot map** (20 min) Map the Legion lot and nearby shops.
- [ ] **Racket map** (15 min) Diagram the towing racket.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 29.
- [ ] **Plate trail** (15 min) Imagine where a plate search leads.
- [ ] **Bub's** (15 min) Place the wings restaurant.
- [ ] **Pines** (15 min) Mark the mental-health facility.
- [ ] **Return** (15 min) Note returning to the opening place.
- [ ] **Outsider map** (15 min) Map who belongs in the lot.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Bonner on the ladder.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Underestimating Bonner backfires, morally and practically. Treating people as instruments (as Adam tries) invites being treated as a mark.

- [ ] **Underestimating** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Paying for info** (20 min) Is buying the plate ethical?
- [ ] **Racket** (15 min) Is the towing racket wrong?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Bonner's job.
- [ ] **Lying** (15 min) Was Adam's lie wrong?
- [ ] **Care** (20 min) Does the town care for Bonner?
- [ ] **Records** (20 min) Is Bonner's notebook a privacy violation?
- [ ] **Fairness** (15 min) Is $200 fair?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about underestimating someone.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A classic investigative step: the overlooked witness with records. The chapter delivers a clue (the plate) at a price, and plants Bonner as a source.

- [ ] **Witness** (15 min) Pin Bonner as a witness.
- [ ] **Clue** (15 min) Pin the plate.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word scene of an overlooked witness.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Bonner.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Plant** (15 min) Pin Bonner's notebook as a future source.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A man in a Civil War-style blazer, a checked tablecloth shirt and laceless sneakers, guarding a lot: a vivid portrait. Draw him with dignity.

- [ ] **Portrait** (30 min) Draw Bonner with dignity.
- [ ] **Notebook page** (20 min) Design a page of his notebook.
- [ ] **Lot at noon** (30 min) Paint the Legion lot by day.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick Bonner's theme.
- [ ] **Blazer** (15 min) Design the many-buttoned blazer.
- [ ] **Wings sign** (15 min) Design a sign for the good wings place.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe frantic page-flipping.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the notebook.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Bonner has strong views on buffalo wings and which local place ruins them. Food opinions are a way of being taken seriously.

- [ ] **Buffalo wings** (45 min) Cook buffalo wings and debate the best place.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record $200 for the plate.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Bonner's notebook.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who notices everything in your town?
- [ ] **Making: licence-plate notebook** (45 min) Spend an hour logging cars like Bonner.
- [ ] **Lunch for a guard** (15 min) Make a packed lunch for a lot attendant.
- [ ] **Recipe of a racket** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Cash only** (15 min) Discuss cash and dignity.
- [ ] **Celery and dip** (15 min) Make the classic wing sides.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam assumes Bonner is easy to fool and is caught at once. Write about a time you underestimated someone and they saw straight through you.

- [ ] **Seen through** (20 min) Write about being seen through.
- [ ] **Former glory** (20 min) Write about someone whose life changed.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate feelings.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Where does the plate lead?
- [ ] **Letter to Bonner** (15 min) Write to Bonner.
- [ ] **Watching** (15 min) Write about what you notice.
- [ ] **Lying** (15 min) Write about a bad lie you told.
- [ ] **Dignity** (15 min) Write about treating people with dignity.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Watcher

Rooms: Room 233, Diner, Incident Board

- [ ] Discuss Bonner.
- [ ] Draw him.
- [ ] Pin him as a witness.
- [ ] Write his notebook page.

Rackets

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Turnpike

- [ ] Research towing.
- [ ] Map the racket.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Analogue Surveillance

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Compare the notebook and the app.
- [ ] Log cars for an hour.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.

Dignity

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Discuss mental illness portrayal.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Apply lenses.
- [ ] Discuss.

Wings Night

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Law Office

- [ ] Cook wings.
- [ ] Design a sign.
- [ ] Read the chapter aloud.
- [ ] Discuss comedy.

Back to the Legion

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Law Office

- [ ] Map the lot.
- [ ] Compare chapters 1 and 29.
- [ ] Write about returning.
- [ ] Pin.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 29 portray John Bonner, and what does he contribute to the novel's theme of watching?
2. Essay: Analyse the reversal of power between Adam and Bonner.
3. Creative: Write a page of Bonner's notebook from draft night.

Further reading

- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Watching, recording and who profits.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Records and reputation.
- *The Lottery*, Shirley Jackson (1948). A community and its roles.
- *The Big Sleep*, Raymond Chandler (1939). A detective paying for information.
- *The Purloined Letter*, Edgar Allan Poe (1844). The overlooked in plain sight.

- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). A town's overlooked witnesses.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Community, roles and belonging.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Coben on suburban outsiders.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Stigma and the presentation of self.

30. BARISTA77

What happens

Rinsky, dressed in beige from head to toe, has traced the plate. Eunice, made up for a garden party, greets Adam as "Norman"; Rinsky stops him correcting her, explaining it's validation therapy. The car was a rental hired under the name Lauren Barna, which Rinsky has found is a cover for a real woman, Ingrid Prisby, of Austin, Texas. He offers to run a background check. Then he offers to listen, and Adam, against all his own advice to clients, tells him everything.

Should he go to the police? Rinsky asks what Adam, as a former prosecutor, would think of a husband whose wife ran off after learning of her betrayal: that he did something to her. And if not that, that she stole the lacrosse money to get away from him. The local chief's wife would spread the pregnancy story all over town. Use her text as your answer, Rinsky advises; keep looking, but don't hand the police anything that incriminates her. Gently, Rinsky says the likeliest story is that Corinne took the money. Adam answers that, if so, something drove her to it.

Adam remembers the phone call in the garden the morning she vanished. On Rinsky's computer he logs into their phone account. He knows the password because he and Corinne always use the same word, chosen at random in a coffee shop because it meant nothing to them: BARISTA, sometimes doubled, sometimes with 77 when numbers are required. The second try works. The last call Corinne made was that one, placed at 7:53 that morning and lasting three minutes. Adam stares at the number. He recognises it.

Scene by scene

1. Rinsky in beige; Eunice calls Adam "Norman"; validation therapy.
2. The plate: a rental under "Lauren Barna" = Ingrid Prisby, Austin, Texas.
3. Adam tells Rinsky the whole story.
4. Rinsky on the police: they'd suspect Adam, or Corinne of theft; gossip.
5. Advice: cite her text; don't incriminate her.
6. Rinsky bets on theft; Adam insists any theft must have had a cause.
7. The garden phone call remembered.
8. The shared password system: BARISTA, BARISTABARISTA, BARISTA77.
9. Her last call: 7:53 a.m., three minutes. Adam knows the number.

Who's here

Mike Rinsky	Investigator, confessor, realist.
Eunice Rinsky	Gracious, confused, calling Adam "Norman".
Ingrid Prisby	The blond driver, identified (offstage).
Adam Price	Confiding at last, then finding a lead.

Thirty questions

1. What does Rinsky discover about the car?
2. Who is Ingrid Prisby?
3. What is validation therapy, and why does Rinsky use it?
4. What does Rinsky advise about the police?

5. What is the couple's password system?
6. What does Adam find in the phone records?
7. **Why does Adam tell Rinsky everything, against his own advice?** [book club]
8. **Is validation therapy a kind of lie? Is it kind?** [book club]
9. How does Rinsky's view of the police reflect his career?
10. **Is Rinsky right that Corinne probably took the money?** [book club]
11. **Adam insists Corinne would only have taken the money for a cause. Loyalty or denial?** [book club]
12. **What does the shared password say about the marriage?** [book club]
13. Why choose a word that means nothing?
14. What does it mean that the password protects their joint account and also leads him to her secret?
15. How does the chapter mix tenderness and investigation?
16. What does Eunice's presence add?
17. Is Adam a good investigator now?
18. Why might Corinne have called that number?
19. **Who might it be? Speculate.** [book club]
20. What does an alias suggest about Ingrid?
21. How is the Rinsky friendship developing?
22. How does the chapter treat the ethics of withholding from police?
23. Compare Rinsky and Len Gilman as cops.
24. What does "Norman" suggest about Eunice's past?
25. How does the chapter end, and why so abruptly?
26. What do you think of password reuse?
27. Is protecting a spouse from police ever wrong?
28. How does technology help here?
29. What is Rinsky's view of human nature?
30. Predict whose number it is.

Close reading

1. Kind untruths

Find it: Chapter 30, opening: Eunice calling Adam by another name.

1. Find Eunice's greeting.
2. Find Rinsky's instruction.
3. Paraphrase validation therapy.
4. Consider how this frames the chapter.

How does this small moment comment on the novel's debate about truth?

2. Thinking like a prosecutor

Find it: Chapter 30, middle: Rinsky's advice about the police.

1. Find Rinsky's question to Adam.
2. List the two theories police would form.
3. Note the gossip point.
4. Find his advice about the text.

How does Rinsky use Adam's own expertise against him?

3. A word that meant nothing

Find it: Chapter 30, close: the password and the call log.

1. Find the story of how the password was chosen.
2. List its variants.
3. Find the call time and duration.
4. Read the last line.

Why make the key to the mystery a word chosen for meaning nothing?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A conversation chapter with two turns: Rinsky's cold logic and the password anecdote, a warm, comic glimpse of the marriage that suddenly becomes a key. The chapter ends on a recognition withheld from the reader.

- ☐ **Two turns** (15 min) Map the chapter's two turns.
- ☐ **Anecdote** (15 min) Write about the password anecdote's tone.
- ☐ **Withholding** (30 min) Write a scene ending on an unshared recognition.
- ☐ **Rinsky's logic** (15 min) Analyse his argument.
- ☐ **Eunice** (15 min) Analyse the "Norman" moment.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Rinsky's POV.
- ☐ **Dialogue** (15 min) Analyse Adam's defence of Corinne's motives.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 29.
- ☐ **Description** (15 min) Analyse the beige outfit.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Kind untruths (validation therapy) versus harmful lies; loyalty; the private codes couples share. The password, chosen because it meant nothing, ends up meaning everything.

- ☐ **Kind untruths** (25 min) Discuss validation therapy as truth ethics.
- ☐ **Loyalty** (25 min) Discuss loyalty vs justice.
- ☐ **Couple codes** (20 min) Discuss shared codes.
- ☐ **Confiding** (20 min) Discuss why Adam confides.
- ☐ **Police** (20 min) Discuss police assumptions.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "codes".
- ☐ **Ageing marriages** (15 min) Discuss the Rinskys.
- ☐ **Probability** (15 min) Discuss "odds are".
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Validation therapy, developed by Naomi Feil from the 1960s, is a recognised approach in dementia care. Car-rental aliases imply false ID. Security experts have long warned against reusing one password.

- [ ] **Validation therapy** (20 min) Research Naomi Feil.
- [ ] **Rental ID** (15 min) Research car rental ID rules.
- [ ] **Austin** (15 min) Research Austin's tech scene.
- [ ] **Passwords** (15 min) Research password security advice.
- [ ] **Phone records** (15 min) Research what carriers show online.
- [ ] **Dementia care** (20 min) Research dementia at home.
- [ ] **Aliases** (15 min) Research legal name use.
- [ ] **Prosecutors** (20 min) Research spousal suspicion in investigations.
- [ ] **Coffee shops** (15 min) Research the rise of the barista.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Shared codes between spouses appear in literature from Victorian letters to modern thrillers. Coben's Fool Me Once (2016) also turns on what a spouse's devices reveal.

- [ ] **Fool Me Once** (20 min) Read about Coben's 2016 novel.
- [ ] **Dementia fiction** (20 min) Find a novel about a spouse with dementia.
- [ ] **Codes in fiction** (20 min) Find a story turning on a password.
- [ ] **Perel** (20 min) Read on intimacy and shared language.
- [ ] **Tell No One** (20 min) Compare a code between spouses.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on loyalty and truth.
- [ ] **The Corrections** (20 min) Compare ageing and memory.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about old love.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Back in the Rinskys' tech nook in Kasselton. A rental car links New Jersey to Austin, Texas: the map widens again, from a Bergen County kitchen table to a state capital two thousand miles away, all through one licence plate.

- [ ] **Austin** (15 min) Pin Austin on your map.
- [ ] **Rental** (15 min) Trace a rental from Newark.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 30.
- [ ] **Kasselton** (15 min) Detail the Rinsky house.
- [ ] **Coffee shop** (15 min) Imagine the coffee shop where the password was chosen.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Ingrid.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Draw Ingrid's links.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Austin to Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Garden** (15 min) Imagine Eunice's garden party.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is it right to protect someone from the police before knowing the truth? Loyalty and justice pull apart. Rinsky, an ex-cop, chooses loyalty.

- [ ] **Withholding from police** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Validation** (20 min) Is validation therapy honest?
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Rinsky's advice.
- [ ] **Loyalty** (35 min) Write 300 words on loyalty vs justice.
- [ ] **Probability** (15 min) Is it fair to judge by odds?
- [ ] **Accessing accounts** (20 min) Is logging into her phone account ethical?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the money case.
- [ ] **Confidences** (15 min) Will Rinsky keep Adam's secrets?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about protecting someone from authorities.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Two clues land: Ingrid's identity and the 7:53 call. The chapter ends on a recognition the reader doesn't share, a classic withholding.

- [ ] **Ingrid** (15 min) Pin Ingrid Prisby.
- [ ] **Call** (15 min) Pin the 7:53 call.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word password-reveal scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Corinne on the money.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add the 7:53 call.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Withheld recognition** (15 min) List possible callers.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Eunice in garden-party make-up applied a little too boldly, serving tea; Rinsky all in beige: a picture of an old marriage that still holds.

- [ ] **Old couple** (35 min) Paint the Rinskys at the table.
- [ ] **Beige** (20 min) Make a beige-only still life.
- [ ] **Password art** (20 min) Design a typographic poster of a meaningless word.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Eunice.
- [ ] **Garden party make-up** (15 min) Draw Eunice made up.
- [ ] **Screen** (15 min) Design the call log screen.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a computer login.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the password.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Tea at the kitchen table, served by a woman who believes it is a garden party. Hospitality survives memory: the rituals of welcome outlast names and dates, and Rinsky lets them stand.

- [ ] **Garden-party tea** (40 min) Host a garden-party tea and discuss memory.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Ingrid's alias.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the 7:53 call.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what codes do you share?
- [ ] **Making: password card** (15 min) Revisit your card: is it meaningless enough?
- [ ] **Coffee** (20 min) Make coffee like a barista.
- [ ] **Beige food** (30 min) Cook an all-beige comfort meal (jokingly).
- [ ] **Recipe of loyalty** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Tea for Eunice** (15 min) Make tea gently.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam and Corinne picked a password because it meant nothing, sitting in a coffee shop. Write about a private code you share with someone and what it has come to mean.

- [ ] **Codes** (20 min) Write about a private code.
- [ ] **Confiding** (20 min) Write about confiding when you shouldn't.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate trust.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Whose number?
- [ ] **Letter to Rinsky** (15 min) Write thanks.
- [ ] **Letter to Eunice** (15 min) Write as "Norman".
- [ ] **Odds** (15 min) Write about being judged by odds.
- [ ] **Loyalty** (15 min) Write about defending someone.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Kind Untruths

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research validation therapy.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Use the Five lenses.
- [ ] Write.

The Password

Rooms: Law Office, Driveway, Diner

- [ ] Close-read the anecdote.
- [ ] Write about your codes.
- [ ] Design a poster.
- [ ] Discuss.

Ingrid File

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Records Room

- [ ] Pin Ingrid.
- [ ] Map Austin.
- [ ] Research aliases.
- [ ] Predict.

Loyalty vs Justice

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Read Bok.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Garden-Party Tea

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Host tea.
- [ ] Paint the Rinskys.
- [ ] Write to Eunice.
- [ ] Discuss memory.

The 7:53 Call

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] List callers.
- [ ] Write the call.
- [ ] Predict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 30 explore kind untruths and loyal silences, from validation therapy to Rinsky's advice?
2. Essay: Analyse the significance of the couple's shared password in the novel.
3. Creative: Write the afternoon in the coffee shop when Adam and Corinne chose the password.

Further reading

- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben on what a spouse's devices reveal.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Codes between a husband and wife.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Ageing parents and fading memory.
- *Mating in Captivity*, Esther Perel (2006). Private languages of couples.
- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Kind lies and their ethics.

- *The Big Sleep*, Raymond Chandler (1939). A detective protecting a client.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Loyalty and justice.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Passwords and privacy.
- *Evicted*, Matthew Desmond (2016). Home and the elderly.

31. Room 715

What happens

John Kuntz gets rid of two guns in the Hudson and takes the A train up to 168th Street, to the children's hospital where his son lies ill. He notes the irony of the building's grand donor names. His ten-year-old, Robby, has bone cancer and is in room 715. Kuntz's wife, Barb, keeps vigil; their other children, Kari and Harry, are shuffled between relatives. The family's whole life is the hospital now.

Kuntz was once an NYPD officer. During an arrest of a shoplifting suspect, a Black man, Kuntz used a restraint that killed him, with his partner beside him. The video spread, the department fired him, and he lost his pension and health benefits. His interior monologue is bitter, self-pitying and openly racist: he blames the media, protesters and politicians, never himself. The novel lets us hear this voice without endorsing it, and it is deliberately ugly.

Then a lifeline. Larry Powers, a young Ivy Leaguer, hired Kuntz as head of security for his start-up, an app that connects Christian handymen with people needing home repairs. The company is heading for a public offering with Bank of America in two months. Kuntz's stock options could be worth around seventeen million dollars: treatment for Robby, security for Barb, everything. Someone is threatening to take it away, and Kuntz has decided nothing will.

Scene by scene

1. Kuntz drops two guns into the Hudson.
2. The A train to 168th Street and the children's hospital.
3. Robby, ten, with bone cancer in room 715; Barb's vigil.
4. Kari and Harry farmed out to relatives.
5. Kuntz's firing after a fatal arrest.
6. His bitter, racist self-justification.
7. Lost pension and benefits.
8. Larry Powers and the Christian handyman app.
9. The IPO in two months; options worth about $17 million.
10. Someone threatens it; Kuntz won't allow that.

Who's here

John Kuntz	Ex-NYPD, fired after a fatal arrest; father of a sick child; now a security chief.
Robby Kuntz	Ten, with bone cancer.
Barb Kuntz	His wife, at Robby's side.
Larry Powers	Young founder of a faith-based handyman app.

Thirty questions

1. What does Kuntz do with the guns?
2. Where is Robby, and what is wrong with him?
3. Why was Kuntz fired from the NYPD?
4. How does Kuntz explain his firing to himself?
5. What is Larry Powers' company?
6. What does the IPO mean for Kuntz?
7. **Why does the novel give a killer a sick child?** [book club]

8. **How does the chapter handle Kuntz's racism?** [book club]
9. **Is it right for a novel to voice ugly views from the inside?** [book club]
10. **Compare Kuntz's fatherhood with Adam's.** [book club]
11. How does money drive Kuntz?
12. What irony does Kuntz notice at the hospital?
13. How does the chapter link violence and love?
14. What does the start-up's religious branding suggest?
15. What threat might face the company?
16. How does Kuntz see himself: hero or victim?
17. What has the firing cost his family?
18. How does this chapter recast earlier events?
19. Is Kuntz frightening? Why?
20. **How does the novel treat American healthcare costs?** [book club]
21. What does the A train ride add?
22. Why name the room number in the chapter title?
23. Does sympathy for Robby make you complicit?
24. How does the chapter structure reveal and withhold?
25. What would Kuntz say justice is?
26. How does the chapter treat police culture?
27. What does Kuntz think of Larry?
28. How might Kuntz's path cross Adam's?
29. **Is the novel fair to Kuntz?** [book club]
30. Predict what Kuntz will do to protect the IPO.

Close reading

1. A cold start

Find it: Chapter 31, opening: the river and the train.

1. Note what he throws away.
2. Trace the route.
3. Find the hospital's donor-name irony.
4. Note his tone.

How does the opening make us complicit with a man disposing of weapons?

2. Self-justification

Find it: Chapter 31, middle: the firing.

1. Summarise the incident.
2. List those he blames.
3. Note what he never admits.
4. Consider the narrative distance.

How does the novel show self-justification without endorsing it?

3. Stakes

Find it: Chapter 31, close: Larry and the IPO.

1. Describe the app.
2. Note the timing.
3. Find the figure.
4. Read the final resolve.

How does the chapter turn money into a matter of life and death?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A villain's POV chapter with no shrinking from his ugliness. Coben uses close third person so the reader hears Kuntz's logic from inside, then sets it against the facts the logic avoids. The chapter title is a hospital room: love sits at the centre of menace.

- ☐ **Villain POV** (25 min) Analyse how Coben voices Kuntz.
- ☐ **Narrative distance** (20 min) Find where the narration undercuts Kuntz.
- ☐ **Title** (15 min) Analyse the chapter's title.
- ☐ **Opening image** (15 min) Analyse the river opening.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite one moment from Barb's POV.
- ☐ **Withholding** (15 min) What does the chapter not say?
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 21.
- ☐ **Structure** (15 min) Map reveal and withhold.
- ☐ **Style** (15 min) Note the tonal shifts.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

The monster as father; self-justification; race and policing; money as survival. The novel complicates its themes: Kuntz also protects his family at any cost, a dark mirror of the question the whole book asks.

- ☐ **Monster as father** (25 min) Discuss the father-villain.
- ☐ **Self-justification** (25 min) Discuss how people excuse harm.
- ☐ **Policing** (25 min) Discuss the use-of-force strand with care.
- ☐ **Money and survival** (20 min) Discuss medical costs and motive.
- ☐ **Mirror** (20 min) Compare Kuntz and Adam.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "protection".
- ☐ **Voicing ugliness** (20 min) Discuss voicing racist views in fiction.
- ☐ **Sympathy** (20 min) Discuss complicity in sympathy.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Fatal restraint cases have driven US debate on policing, especially since 2014. Osteosarcoma is the most common childhood bone cancer. US medical costs can bankrupt families; losing employer insurance is catastrophic. IPOs can make early employees rich overnight.

- [ ] **Children's hospital** (15 min) Research NewYork-Presbyterian's children's hospital.
- [ ] **Osteosarcoma** (20 min) Research childhood bone cancer.
- [ ] **Use of force** (25 min) Research US restraint policy reforms.
- [ ] **Pensions** (15 min) Research police pension rules on dismissal.
- [ ] **IPO** (20 min) Research how an IPO works.
- [ ] **Stock options** (15 min) Research employee stock options.
- [ ] **Medical debt** (20 min) Research US medical debt.
- [ ] **A train** (15 min) Research the A line.
- [ ] **Faith-based tech** (15 min) Research faith-branded start-ups.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Patricia Highsmith's Ripley novels let readers inhabit a killer. Dennis Lehane's Mystic River shows love and violence entangled in fathers. Kuntz is a darker, uglier case of the same pull.

- [ ] **Ripley** (20 min) Read about Highsmith's killer-protagonist.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare fathers and violence.
- [ ] **Crime and Punishment** (20 min) Compare self-justification.
- [ ] **Death of a Salesman** (20 min) Compare a man and his worth.
- [ ] **Evicted** (20 min) Read on money and survival.
- [ ] **Sandel** (20 min) Read on markets and medicine.
- [ ] **Gone Baby Gone** (20 min) Compare protecting children.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a sick child.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The Hudson River, the A train, 168th Street and Washington Heights: the novel's map crosses into Manhattan. Kuntz commutes between violence in New Jersey and a hospital bed in upper Manhattan, carrying both.

- [ ] **Hudson** (15 min) Pin where he might drop the guns.
- [ ] **A train** (15 min) Trace the route to 168th.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 31.
- [ ] **Washington Heights** (15 min) Research the neighbourhood.
- [ ] **Commute** (15 min) Map Kuntz's two worlds.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Kuntz as a node.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Kuntz to Larry.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Manhattan to Beachwood.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Kuntz and Larry on the ladder.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Does a dying child change how we judge a violent man? Explanation is not excuse, and the chapter wants us to feel the pull of both. Care ethics meets justice head-on here.

- [ ] **Motive** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Kuntz.
- [ ] **Explanation vs excuse** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Policing** (25 min) Debate accountability.
- [ ] **Healthcare** (20 min) Is it just that money decides care?
- [ ] **Loyalty** (15 min) Is Kuntz loyal or just desperate?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Begin a case file on Kuntz.
- [ ] **Sympathy** (15 min) Rate your sympathy.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about love going too far.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The reader now knows more than Adam: a hired protector with motive, method and a disposed weapon. The chapter turns the mystery into suspense: we wait for the paths to cross.

- [ ] **Kuntz** (15 min) Pin Kuntz.
- [ ] **Guns** (15 min) Pin the disposed guns.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word villain-POV scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Kuntz.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the Kuntz strand.
- [ ] **Suspense** (15 min) Note what the reader now knows.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A hospital corridor at night, a boy in room 715, a man in a chair: paint the scene in cold fluorescent light with one warm lamp by the bed. No glamour.

- [ ] **Room 715** (35 min) Paint the hospital room at night.
- [ ] **River** (30 min) Paint the Hudson at dusk.
- [ ] **Subway** (20 min) Draw an A train carriage.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a bleak theme.
- [ ] **Corridor** (15 min) Draw a fluorescent corridor.
- [ ] **Stock ticker** (15 min) Design an IPO ticker.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a hospital at night.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the room number.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Hospital vending machines, cafeteria trays and sleep-deprived parents. Families of sick children often live on whatever is quickest. Food here is endurance, not comfort.

- [ ] **Hospital food** (15 min) Discuss what families eat during long stays.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record $17 million.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the guns.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: how far for your child?
- [ ] **Making: care package** (30 min) Assemble a care package for a hospital family.
- [ ] **Volunteer** (20 min) Research a children's hospital charity.
- [ ] **Recipe of rage** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Coffee in a cup** (15 min) Make hospital-style coffee and reflect.
- [ ] **Sandwich** (15 min) Make a sandwich for a vigil.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Kuntz would do anything for his son, and the novel makes that frightening. Write privately about where your own love for someone might lead you too far.

- [ ] **Too far** (20 min) Write about love going too far.
- [ ] **Sick child** (20 min) Write about a hospital memory.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate unease.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Kuntz do?
- [ ] **Letter to Robby** (15 min) Write to Robby.
- [ ] **Letter to Barb** (15 min) Write to Barb.
- [ ] **Blame** (15 min) Write about blaming others.
- [ ] **Money** (15 min) Write about money and fear.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Father-Villain

Rooms: Room 233, Law Office, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Analyse POV.
- [ ] Apply lenses.
- [ ] Write.

Room 715

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Paint the room.
- [ ] Write as Barb.
- [ ] Assemble a care package.
- [ ] Reflect.

Money and Medicine

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research costs.
- [ ] Read Sandel.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Kuntz File

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Records Room

- [ ] Pin him.
- [ ] Map his commute.
- [ ] Research IPOs.
- [ ] Predict.

Policing Strand

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research reforms.
- [ ] Discuss carefully.
- [ ] Debate accountability.
- [ ] Write.

Mirror Fathers

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Compare Kuntz and Adam.
- [ ] Read Mystic River.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Discuss.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 31 make John Kuntz both a father and a menace, and why does the novel take this risk?
2. Essay: Analyse how the novel voices Kuntz's self-justification without endorsing it.
3. Creative: Write a night in room 715 from Barb's point of view.

Further reading

- *The Talented Mr. Ripley*, Patricia Highsmith (1955). Living inside a killer's head.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Fathers, love and violence.
- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). The self-justifying mind.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A man measured by money.
- *Evicted*, Matthew Desmond (2016). Money and survival.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). What money should not buy.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Protecting children at any cost.
- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). A tech empire and the cost of protecting it.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben on hired violence.

32. The Swamps of Jersey

What happens

The number was Tripp Evans's. Adam drives to Tripp's office, a dated low-rise near MetLife Stadium in the Meadowlands marshes, with Tripp's room on the ground floor by the loading dock. Tripp's family once owned Evans Sporting Goods; the big chains crushed it and the shop is now a pharmacy. Tripp went to Madison Avenue, then started his own small marketing firm out here in the swamps. In his thin shirt, brown trousers and cheap shoes he looks ordinary, and he offers diner-style coffee.

Tripp admits it: Corinne called him that morning. She asked for more time. Tripp had told her she'd stalled long enough; the board had been looking into the money for a month. He nearly told Adam on draft night, but Corinne begged him not to. She swore she could prove her innocence if given a week. Tripp doesn't believe her any more; he thinks she's off raising the money. Corinne was two years behind him at school, in Becky's year.

Then Tripp explains how embezzlement happens, as he sees it: a slippery slope. You buy a coffee on the club's card; then petrol; then a dinner, a few pizzas; you hire your own kid as a referee; you borrow for a car payment, meaning to repay. Nobody plans to steal. Adam, grim, asks for more time for Corinne. Tripp says he can try.

Scene by scene

1. The number belongs to Tripp Evans.
2. Tripp's office in the Meadowlands, by a loading dock.
3. The Evans Sporting Goods story: chains crushed the family shop.
4. Tripp's ordinary look; diner coffee.
5. Tripp confirms Corinne called asking for more time.
6. The board has investigated for a month; Corinne begged him not to tell Adam.
7. She promised to prove her innocence in a week.
8. Tripp now thinks she's raising the money.
9. Corinne was in Becky's year.
10. Tripp's slippery-slope account of embezzlement.
11. Adam asks for time; Tripp says he'll try.

Who's here

Tripp Evans	Lacrosse board president, marketing man, family-business survivor.
Adam Price	Seeking answers and time.
Becky Evans	Tripp's wife (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. Whose number did Corinne call?
2. Describe Tripp's office and its location.
3. What happened to Evans Sporting Goods?
4. What does Tripp tell Adam about the call?
5. What did Corinne ask Tripp?
6. How does Tripp describe embezzlement?
7. **Why might Corinne not want Adam told?** [book club]

8. **Is Tripp trustworthy here? Why or why not?** [book club]
9. **What does the family-shop backstory add to Tripp?** [book club]
10. How does the chapter use class and setting?
11. **Why is the slippery-slope speech so persuasive?** [book club]
12. Who might Tripp be describing?
13. What does Tripp's ordinariness suggest?
14. What does the Meadowlands setting add?
15. Why does Adam ask for more time?
16. What do we learn about Corinne and Becky?
17. How does the chapter shift suspicion?
18. Is Tripp kind to Adam?
19. What do big chains have to do with this novel?
20. How does the chapter treat failure?
21. What is the significance of the loading dock?
22. **Would you trust a club treasurer after this speech?** [book club]
23. How does the novel treat small-town institutions?
24. Compare Tripp's office with Adam's.
25. How does Adam handle the revelation?
26. What does Tripp believe about human nature?
27. What does the chapter title suggest?
28. What should Adam do next?
29. **Is Corinne innocent?** [book club]
30. Predict what Tripp will do.

Close reading

1. Setting as biography

Find it: Chapter 32, opening: Tripp's office and the family shop.

1. Describe the building.
2. Note the room's location.
3. Summarise the shop's fate.
4. Note Tripp's clothes.

How does setting tell Tripp's story?

2. A confidant revealed

Find it: Chapter 32, middle: Tripp's account of the call.

1. Find what Corinne asked.
2. Note the board's timeline.
3. Note draft night.
4. Note his current belief.

How does the chapter re-frame Corinne's silence?

3. How theft begins

Find it: Chapter 32, close: the slippery-slope speech.

1. List the steps Tripp gives.
2. Note his tone.
3. Note what he claims about intent.
4. Read Adam's request.

What makes Tripp's account of embezzlement so vivid?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A conversation scene in which a confidant fills in the gaps. Tripp's slippery-slope speech is a tour de force of plausibility, built from a list of small, believable steps. Setting and costume (a dated building, cheap shoes) add quiet characterisation throughout.

- ☐ **Speech** (20 min) Annotate the slippery-slope speech.
- ☐ **Setting** (15 min) Analyse setting as characterisation.
- ☐ **Costume** (15 min) Analyse Tripp's clothes.
- ☐ **Confidant** (15 min) Analyse the confidant role.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Tripp's POV.
- ☐ **Dialogue** (30 min) Write a persuasive monologue of your own.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 30.
- ☐ **Title** (15 min) Analyse the title.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the last line.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Class decline and resentment; gradual corruption; the trust that volunteer institutions rest on. The chapter asks how ordinary people slide into wrongdoing, one small permission at a time.

- ☐ **Slippery slope** (25 min) Discuss gradual corruption.
- ☐ **Class decline** (20 min) Discuss the Evans shop.
- ☐ **Volunteer trust** (20 min) Discuss club finances.
- ☐ **Loyalty** (20 min) Discuss Tripp's silence.
- ☐ **Ordinariness** (20 min) Discuss ordinary wrongdoers.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "small steps".
- ☐ **Big business** (20 min) Discuss chains and small towns.
- ☐ **Persuasion** (15 min) Discuss persuasive speech.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Family-owned sporting goods shops were squeezed by chains such as Dick's and Modell's from the 1980s onward. Fraud examiners note that occupational fraud often begins with small amounts and grows. The Meadowlands have been reshaped by stadiums and landfill.

- ☐ **Sporting retail** (20 min) Research the decline of family sports shops.
- ☐ **Occupational fraud** (20 min) Research how fraud begins.
- ☐ **Meadowlands** (15 min) Research the Meadowlands.
- ☐ **MetLife** (15 min) Research the stadium.
- ☐ **Madison Avenue** (15 min) Research the ad industry's history.
- ☐ **Club controls** (20 min) Research nonprofit financial controls.
- ☐ **Marketing firms** (15 min) Research boutique marketing.

- [ ] **Pharmacies** (15 min) Research chain pharmacies replacing shops.
- [ ] **Diner coffee** (15 min) Research diner coffee culture.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Arthur Miller's Death of a Salesman and All My Sons both explore men undone by business and their self-justifications. Tripp's family history belongs to that tradition.

- [ ] **Death of a Salesman** (20 min) Compare business and pride.
- [ ] **All My Sons** (20 min) Compare self-justification.
- [ ] **The Corrections** (20 min) Compare family decline.
- [ ] **Ariely** (20 min) Read on small dishonesty.
- [ ] **Putnam** (20 min) Read on volunteer trust.
- [ ] **Crabgrass** (20 min) Read on suburban economy.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare corporate disappointment.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about trade or loss.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The Meadowlands near MetLife Stadium: marsh, highways and low office blocks. Tripp jokes about working out in the swamps, a half-proud, half-rueful nickname locals use for this landscape and its people.

- [ ] **Meadowlands** (15 min) Pin the office.
- [ ] **Stadium** (15 min) Pin MetLife.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 32.
- [ ] **Old shop** (15 min) Imagine where Evans Sporting Goods stood.
- [ ] **Route** (15 min) Trace Adam's drive.
- [ ] **Landscape** (15 min) Describe the marsh.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Tripp's office.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Tripp on the ladder.
- [ ] **Swamps** (20 min) Research the Meadowlands' ecology.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Was keeping Adam in the dark kind or wrong? Tripp claims loyalty to Corinne. Duty to a friend, duty to the club, duty to a husband: the chapter sets them against each other.

- [ ] **Silence** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Tripp's silence.
- [ ] **Small theft** (15 min) Is a coffee on the club card wrong?
- [ ] **Gradualism** (35 min) Write 300 words on gradual wrongdoing.
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the money case.
- [ ] **Trust** (15 min) Should Adam trust Tripp?
- [ ] **Loyalty** (20 min) Duty to whom?

- [ ] **Rules** (15 min) Should clubs have stricter controls?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a bent rule.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A major clue lands: the 7:53 call was to Tripp. The speech on embezzlement is also worth pinning: a detailed theory of how money disappears, offered by the man who presides over it.

- [ ] **Call** (15 min) Pin the 7:53 call to Tripp.
- [ ] **Speech** (15 min) Pin the slippery-slope theory.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word confidant scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Tripp, Corinne and Bob.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add the board's month of investigation.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Contradictions** (15 min) Note anything odd in Tripp's story.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A dated office by a loading dock, mugs of bad coffee, a man in a thin shirt: paint the Meadowlands at grey midday with the stadium on the horizon.

- [ ] **Meadowlands** (35 min) Paint the marsh office block.
- [ ] **Loading dock** (20 min) Draw the office by the dock.
- [ ] **Old shop sign** (20 min) Design an Evans Sporting Goods sign.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the swamps.
- [ ] **Cheap shoes** (15 min) Draw Tripp's shoes.
- [ ] **Coffee mug** (15 min) Design a dented office mug.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe traffic and marsh birds.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the stadium.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Cheap coffee in a small office. Hospitality and money mix: a club card buys a coffee, and so it begins, says Tripp. Make a cup and think about the first small step.

- [ ] **Bad coffee** (15 min) Make strong, cheap coffee and discuss small steps.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Tripp's steps as a ledger.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the call.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: when does a perk become a theft?
- [ ] **Making: expense audit** (30 min) Audit a month of your own small expenses.
- [ ] **Pizza for a team** (45 min) Make pizza and discuss team budgets.
- [ ] **Recipe of a slide** (15 min) Write a recipe.

- [ ] **Diner breakfast** (30 min) Make a diner breakfast.
- [ ] **Receipts** (15 min) Sort receipts like a treasurer.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Tripp argues that nobody plans to steal: they slide. Write privately about a small rule you once bent, and whether it grew.

- [ ] **Bent rule** (20 min) Write about a bent rule.
- [ ] **Family business** (20 min) Write about a lost family business.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate suspicion.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Tripp do?
- [ ] **Letter to Tripp** (15 min) Write to Tripp.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write about her week.
- [ ] **Ordinary** (15 min) Write about looking ordinary.
- [ ] **Time** (15 min) Write about asking for time.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Slippery Slope

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Annotate the speech.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Apply lenses.
- [ ] Write.

Family Business

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Research retail decline.
- [ ] Read Salesman.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Discuss.

The 7:53 Call

Rooms: Incident Board, Driveway, Law Office

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Write the call.
- [ ] Analyse the confidant.
- [ ] Predict.

Club Audit

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Records Room, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Audit your expenses.
- [ ] Research controls.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Swamps

Rooms: Turnpike, Diner, Records Room

- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Research.
- [ ] Present.

Ordinary Men

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Read Miller.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 32 use setting and backstory to characterise Tripp Evans?
2. Essay: Analyse Tripp's slippery-slope account of embezzlement. What does it reveal?
3. Creative: Write Corinne's 7:53 phone call to Tripp.

Further reading

- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). Business, pride and failure.
- *All My Sons*, Arthur Miller (1947). A businessman's self-justification.
- *The (Honest) Truth About Dishonesty*, Dan Ariely (2012). How small dishonesty grows.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Trust in volunteer institutions.
- *The Corrections*, Jonathan Franzen (2001). Family decline.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Corporate disappointment.
- *Crabgrass Frontier*, Kenneth T. Jackson (1985). The suburban economy.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Coben on suburban reputations.
- *Scorecasting*, Tobias J. Moskowitz & L. Jon Wertheim (2011). Sports and money.

33. Lunch with the Girls

What happens

The county investigators are fixated on Marty, though his alibi in Columbus is solid. Johanna has lunch with her friends Audrey Fine, Katey Brannum and Stephanie Keiles, the old circle, with an empty seat where Heidi should be. Memories rise. Twenty years ago Johanna had what the doctors called a miracle IVF pregnancy, then lost it. Heidi was the friend who came; Johanna remembers her crying in the car afterwards, head on the steering wheel, hair spread out like a fan. Johanna and her husband, Ricky, never had children.

Audrey mentions that, not long before the murder, she saw Heidi talking with a young couple: a blonde woman and a guy in a baseball cap. Heidi looked shaken. Where? In the car park at the Red Lobster. Johanna goes to the restaurant and persuades the manager to give her a copy of the security footage on a DVD (which she must return).

At home, she watches: Heidi meets the pair; her legs seem to buckle as they speak; after they go, Heidi sits in her car with her head on the steering wheel, crying, just as she once did for Johanna. Johanna takes down the plate of the couple's car and asks Norbert to run it.

Scene by scene

1. The county fixates on Marty despite his solid alibi.
2. Lunch with Audrey, Katey and Stephanie.
3. Memory: Johanna's IVF pregnancy and miscarriage.
4. Heidi crying in the car for her, head on the wheel.
5. Johanna and Ricky never had children.
6. Audrey saw Heidi with a young couple: a blonde and a man in a cap.
7. The Red Lobster lot; security footage on DVD.
8. On tape: Heidi's legs buckle; then she weeps at the wheel.
9. Johanna takes the plate; Norbert will run it.

Who's here

Johanna Griffin	Chief, friend, investigator off the books.
Audrey Fine, Katey Brannum, Stephanie Keiles	Johanna's friends.
Heidi Dann	Remembered, and seen on tape.
Ricky Griffin	Johanna's husband (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. Why is the county fixed on Marty?
2. Who are Johanna's lunch friends?
3. What does Johanna remember about her IVF pregnancy?
4. How did Heidi support her?
5. What does Audrey see?
6. What does the footage show?
7. **Why does the image of Heidi crying in a car recur?** [book club]
8. **How does the chapter link private grief and investigation?** [book club]
9. Why do the county police suspect the husband?
10. **What does friendship mean in this chapter?** [book club]

11. How does the chapter mirror Adam's investigation?
12. What do you think the couple told Heidi?
13. **How does the chapter treat childlessness?** [book club]
14. Is Johanna overstepping?
15. What does the lunch reveal about women's friendships?
16. Why must the DVD be returned? Why might this matter?
17. How does surveillance help here?
18. What does Norbert add to Johanna's story?
19. How does the novel depict middle age?
20. What does Heidi's collapse on tape suggest?
21. How do the two strands now connect?
22. **What do you think Heidi's secret might be?** [book club]
23. How does the chapter use the empty seat?
24. **Is grief a motivation for good policing?** [book club]
25. What does Ricky mean to Johanna?
26. How does the chapter manage emotion?
27. What does a ladies' lunch represent?
28. What does the plate lead to?
29. How do memories work in this chapter?
30. Predict what Norbert finds.

Close reading

1. An empty seat

Find it: Chapter 33, the lunch.

1. List the friends.
2. Note who is absent.
3. Note how they talk of Heidi.
4. Find Audrey's detail.

How does the lunch create a portrait of Heidi through her friends?

2. A remembered kindness

Find it: Chapter 33, the IVF memory.

1. Summarise the pregnancy.
2. Note the loss.
3. Describe Heidi in the car.
4. Note Johanna's life after.

Why does the novel give Johanna this memory now?

3. Seeing a friend from outside

Find it: Chapter 33, the footage.

1. Describe the meeting.
2. Note Heidi's body.
3. Note her weeping.
4. Note the plate.

How does the echo of the car memory deepen the scene?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter built on echo: Heidi weeping at the wheel in memory, then on tape. The lunch provides gossip as evidence; the DVD turns grief into procedure. Johanna's strand is now running parallel to Adam's, and the novel lets us feel the gap closing.

- [ ] **Echo** (20 min) Analyse the car image echo.
- [ ] **Gossip as evidence** (15 min) Analyse Audrey's role.
- [ ] **Footage** (30 min) Write a scene described as CCTV.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite the lunch from Audrey's POV.
- [ ] **Memory** (15 min) Analyse the memory's placement.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 26.
- [ ] **Parallel** (20 min) Compare Johanna's and Adam's methods.
- [ ] **Dialogue** (15 min) Analyse the lunch talk.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the plate ending.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Friendship, childlessness, grief and the investigator's motive. The chapter suggests that love is a form of knowledge: Johanna sees what the county cannot because she knew Heidi.

- [ ] **Friendship** (25 min) Discuss friendship as knowledge.
- [ ] **Childlessness** (20 min) Discuss with care.
- [ ] **Grief** (20 min) Discuss grief as motive.
- [ ] **Husbands suspected** (15 min) Discuss suspecting spouses.
- [ ] **Women at midlife** (20 min) Discuss the lunch circle.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "showing up".
- [ ] **Surveillance** (15 min) Discuss CCTV.
- [ ] **Process** (20 min) Discuss off-book investigation.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

IVF success rates in the 1990s were far lower than today. Chain restaurants routinely record car parks. Spouses are often investigated first in homicides, and alibis are checked carefully.

- [ ] **IVF history** (20 min) Research IVF success rates over time.
- [ ] **CCTV** (15 min) Research restaurant CCTV retention.
- [ ] **Alibis** (15 min) Research how alibis are verified.
- [ ] **Red Lobster** (15 min) Research the chain.
- [ ] **Spousal suspicion** (20 min) Research homicide statistics on partners.
- [ ] **Plate lookups** (15 min) Research police plate searches.
- [ ] **Miscarriage** (20 min) Research pregnancy loss support.

- [ ] **Columbus** (15 min) Research Columbus conventions.
- [ ] **Small-town chiefs** (15 min) Research small police departments.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Tana French's In the Woods and Kate Atkinson's Case Histories both mix personal grief with detection. Women's friendships at midlife are central to Liane Moriarty's Big Little Lies.

- [ ] **Case Histories** (20 min) Read about Atkinson.
- [ ] **In the Woods** (20 min) Compare grief and detection.
- [ ] **Big Little Lies** (20 min) Compare women's circles.
- [ ] **Moriarty** (20 min) Read The Husband's Secret summary.
- [ ] **Tell No One** (20 min) Compare old grief.
- [ ] **Gottman** (20 min) Read on friendship and marriage.
- [ ] **Putnam** (20 min) Read on social circles.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a friend.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A Red Lobster car park in suburban Ohio, near Cleveland, one outpost of a chain spread along American highways. The stranger and Ingrid travelled far for their work: Cedarfield in New Jersey, Beachwood in Ohio, and beyond.

- [ ] **Red Lobster** (15 min) Pin the restaurant lot.
- [ ] **Columbus** (15 min) Pin Marty's convention.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 33.
- [ ] **Lunch spot** (15 min) Imagine the lunch place.
- [ ] **Bridge** (15 min) Draw the plate linking strands.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the couple.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Heidi to the stranger.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place the friends on the ladder.
- [ ] **Radius** (15 min) Draw the strangers' range.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is Johanna right to investigate alone? Her friendship gives her insight but also bias. The chapter honours her motive while hinting at the risk to proper process.

- [ ] **Off-book** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Johanna.
- [ ] **Bias** (25 min) Write about love and bias.
- [ ] **Husbands** (15 min) Is suspecting Marty fair?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Begin a Heidi case file.
- [ ] **Footage** (15 min) Is borrowed footage proper evidence?
- [ ] **Friendship** (20 min) What do friends owe the dead?

- [ ] **Process** (15 min) Should Johanna hand over?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about someone who showed up.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The link between the strands is visible now: a blonde and a man in a cap approached Heidi, just as the stranger and his blonde partner approached Adam. The plate is the bridge.

- [ ] **Couple** (15 min) Pin the couple.
- [ ] **Footage** (15 min) Pin the DVD.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word footage scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Marty.
- [ ] **Bridge** (15 min) Connect Heidi and Adam.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note the convergence.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add the Red Lobster meeting.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A woman alone at night, head on a steering wheel, hair fanned out: paint it twice, once from memory (warm, blurred) and once on grainy security footage (cold, pixelated).

- [ ] **Two cars** (40 min) Paint Heidi at the wheel twice.
- [ ] **CCTV still** (20 min) Make a pixelated CCTV-style picture.
- [ ] **Lunch table** (30 min) Paint the lunch with an empty chair.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the friends.
- [ ] **Hair like a fan** (15 min) Draw the image.
- [ ] **DVD** (15 min) Design a DVD label.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a restaurant car park.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the steering wheel.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A ladies' lunch with an empty chair. Set a table for an absent friend and talk about who she was. Food is how friends keep someone present.

- [ ] **Empty chair lunch** (45 min) Host a lunch with a place for an absent friend.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the plate.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the footage.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who showed up for you?
- [ ] **Making: memory card** (15 min) Write a card for an absent friend.
- [ ] **Seafood** (30 min) Cook a simple seafood dish.
- [ ] **Biscuits** (40 min) Bake cheddar biscuits.

- [ ] **Recipe of friendship** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Tea after** (15 min) Make tea and talk.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Johanna remembers who came when she lost her pregnancy. Write privately about someone who showed up for you in your worst moment.

- [ ] **Showed up** (20 min) Write about someone who came.
- [ ] **Loss** (20 min) Write privately about a loss.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate sorrow.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will the plate show?
- [ ] **Letter to Heidi** (15 min) Write as Johanna.
- [ ] **Letter to friends** (15 min) Write to your circle.
- [ ] **Childlessness** (15 min) Write about lives without children.
- [ ] **Grief** (15 min) Write about grief as fuel.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Steering Wheel

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse the echo.
- [ ] Paint both scenes.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Empty Chair

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Host a lunch.
- [ ] Discuss friendship.
- [ ] Write a card.
- [ ] Reflect.

Converging Strands

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Pin the couple.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Compare methods.
- [ ] Predict.

Off the Books

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Records Room, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Research process.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Women Detectives

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Law Office

- [ ] Read about Atkinson and French.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Present.

Showing Up

Rooms: Driveway, Price Kitchen, Room 233

- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Make a memory card.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Act.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 33 use the repeated image of Heidi weeping in her car?
2. Essay: Analyse friendship as a form of knowledge in Johanna's strand.
3. Creative: Write the Red Lobster meeting from Heidi's point of view (keeping the content of the conversation unknown).

Further reading

- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). Grief and detection.
- *Big Little Lies*, Liane Moriarty (2014). Women's circles at midlife.
- *The Husband's Secret*, Liane Moriarty (2013). Friends and hidden truths.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Old grief returning.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Friendship in long relationships.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Social circles and belonging.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A seasoned woman investigator.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Families and loss.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Watching and recording.

34. Mom's a Mom

What happens

At home, the boys are restless. Ryan is at his drum lesson on Goffle Road; a family friend has offered pizza at Café Amici. Thomas has been lifting weights with his friend Justin. Adam and Thomas shoot hoops in the driveway; Thomas is an inch shorter than his dad and the one-on-one runs close, 11–8. Then Thomas says what he's been holding in: he doesn't believe the story about Mom needing time. She is their mother, and mothers don't just go. He admits he's scared. When Adam says it will be okay, Thomas says plainly that it isn't.

Adam can't argue. Later, alone, he goes through Corinne's phone records more carefully. Recently her life has been an open book: school, the boys, friends. He keeps going back, month after month, until he reaches the February two years ago when she placed her first order with Fake-A-Pregnancy.

There, in that month's calls, is another number he recognises. His heart sinks.

Scene by scene

1. Ryan at drums; a pizza offer; Thomas lifting with Justin.
2. Driveway one-on-one: 11–8.
3. Thomas doesn't buy the cover story about Mom.
4. Thomas admits he's scared; rejects Adam's reassurance.
5. Adam reviews Corinne's recent records: an open book.
6. He goes back two years, to the first Fake-A-Pregnancy order.
7. He finds a familiar number; his heart sinks.

Who's here

Thomas Price	Seventeen-ish, honest, frightened.
Ryan Price	Off at drum lessons.
Adam Price	A father out of reassurances.

Thirty questions

1. What are the boys doing at the start?
2. Who wins the one-on-one?
3. What does Thomas say about his mother?
4. How does Adam respond?
5. What does Adam find in the records?
6. Why does Adam go back two years?
7. **Why is the driveway game a good setting for this talk?** [book club]
8. **Is Thomas right to reject reassurance?** [book club]
9. How does the novel portray teenage honesty?
10. What does the close score suggest?
11. **Why does Adam feel he can't lie to Thomas?** [book club]
12. What does an open book recently imply?
13. Whose number might it be?
14. Why does his heart sink?
15. How does the chapter link parenting and investigation?
16. What does Thomas's height suggest?
17. **How does the novel treat masculinity between father and son?** [book club]
18. Compare Thomas and Ryan.
19. Why does the chapter end on a number?

20. How does Adam cope?
21. What does "mothers don't just go" mean?
22. How do the boys experience the crisis?
23. What does the pizza offer show about community?
24. How does the chapter use sport?
25. **Would you tell your children?** [book club]
26. Is Adam a good father here?
27. What does Thomas fear?
28. How does the novel treat fear in boys?
29. What is Adam looking for?
30. **Predict whose number it is.** [book club]

Close reading

1. Talking sideways

Find it: Chapter 34, the driveway game.

1. Note the score.
2. Note when Thomas speaks.
3. Paraphrase his doubt.
4. Note Adam's reply.

Why do hard conversations between fathers and sons happen during games?

2. Refusing comfort

Find it: Chapter 34, Thomas's fear.

1. Find his admission.
2. Find Adam's reassurance.
3. Find Thomas's rejection.
4. Note Adam's silence.

How does Thomas's honesty challenge Adam?

3. Going back

Find it: Chapter 34, close: the records.

1. Note the recent records.
2. Note the decision to go back.
3. Note the month.
4. Read the last line.

How does the chapter build to its final discovery?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A quiet domestic chapter with a sting. The basketball game frames a conversation that can only happen side by side, not face to face. The final discovery mirrors chapter 30: another familiar number, another withheld name, another sinking heart.

☐ **Side by side** (20 min) Analyse the game as setting.

- [ ] **Mirror** (15 min) Compare with chapter 30's ending.
- [ ] **Dialogue** (30 min) Write a father-son talk during a game.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Thomas's POV.
- [ ] **Score** (15 min) Analyse 11–8.
- [ ] **Withholding** (15 min) Analyse the withheld name.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 33.
- [ ] **Description** (15 min) Analyse the domestic details.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the final line.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Teenage honesty versus parental reassurance; fear in boys; the limits of comfort. Thomas refuses the soothing lie, part of the novel's argument about truth and protection.

- [ ] **Teen honesty** (25 min) Discuss Thomas.
- [ ] **Reassurance** (20 min) Discuss comfort and truth.
- [ ] **Boys and fear** (20 min) Discuss fear in boys.
- [ ] **Side by side** (20 min) Discuss how men talk.
- [ ] **Records** (15 min) Discuss digital pasts.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "refused comfort".
- [ ] **Parenting** (20 min) Discuss Adam's choices.
- [ ] **Mothers** (20 min) Discuss mothers leaving.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Many fathers and sons talk best side by side, during activities rather than face to face; psychologists who study male friendship note the same. Carriers keep call logs that account holders can view online for months or years.

- [ ] **Side-by-side talk** (20 min) Research how fathers and sons communicate.
- [ ] **Call logs** (15 min) Research carrier record retention.
- [ ] **Goffle Road** (15 min) Research the area.
- [ ] **Drum lessons** (15 min) Research music lessons and teens.
- [ ] **Teen anxiety** (20 min) Research teens and family crisis.
- [ ] **Weight training** (15 min) Research teen lifting safety.
- [ ] **One-on-one rules** (15 min) Research street basketball rules.
- [ ] **Pizzerias** (15 min) Research NJ pizza culture.
- [ ] **Parental disappearance** (20 min) Research effects on children.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Coben's Missing You and Six Years both turn on old phone and email records. Fathers and teenage sons appear in Richard Ford's Independence Day, where a trip becomes a fraught attempt at honesty.

- [ ] **Missing You** (20 min) Read about Coben's novel.

- [ ] **Six Years** (20 min) Compare old records.
- [ ] **Independence Day** (20 min) Compare father and son.
- [ ] **Gopnik** (20 min) Read on parenting.
- [ ] **Lareau** (20 min) Read on family life.
- [ ] **Little Fires** (20 min) Compare teen honesty.
- [ ] **Hold Tight** (20 min) Compare parents and teen secrets.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a son.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The driveway hoop, Goffle Road drum lessons, a local pizzeria: the boys' small map of Cedarfield, the world Adam is trying to keep intact while his own world comes apart around him.

- [ ] **Boys' map** (15 min) Map the boys' Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Goffle Road** (15 min) Pin the drum lesson.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 34.
- [ ] **Pizzeria** (15 min) Pin the café.
- [ ] **Driveway** (15 min) Draw the driveway court.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the second number.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Mark two years ago.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place the boys.
- [ ] **Home** (15 min) Map the house rooms.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Should Adam tell his sons what he knows? Their right to the truth versus his duty to protect: the novel keeps this dilemma at the centre of family life.

- [ ] **Tell them?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam.
- [ ] **Right to know** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Comfort** (15 min) Is false comfort wrong?
- [ ] **Records** (20 min) Is reading a spouse's records right?
- [ ] **Children** (15 min) What do children deserve?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Corinne file.
- [ ] **Honesty** (15 min) Rate Thomas's honesty.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about refused comfort.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Another familiar number: a second clue set up for revelation. The chapter also establishes how far back Corinne's secrets go: to the month of her first order.

- [ ] **Second number** (15 min) Pin the familiar number.

- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add the first order's month.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word records scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Guess** (15 min) List possible owners.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A driveway hoop at dusk, a father and son mid-game, the house lit behind them: paint it warm, with one dark window. Let the ball be the brightest thing in the picture, caught mid-arc.

- [ ] **Driveway at dusk** (35 min) Paint the game.
- [ ] **Dark window** (25 min) Paint the house with one dark window.
- [ ] **Drum kit** (15 min) Draw Ryan's drums.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Thomas.
- [ ] **Scoreboard** (15 min) Design a chalk scoreboard.
- [ ] **Phone log** (15 min) Design the old log.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a ball on a driveway.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the hoop.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A pizza offer from friends: community care arriving as food. Make a pizza with whoever is home and talk about something hard while your hands are busy.

- [ ] **Pizza and talk** (45 min) Make pizza and talk about something hard.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the second number.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add it.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: when do you want the truth?
- [ ] **Making: game night** (30 min) Play a game and talk sideways.
- [ ] **Protein shake** (15 min) Make Thomas a post-lift shake.
- [ ] **Recipe of fear** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Snacks** (15 min) Make after-practice snacks.
- [ ] **Family dinner** (40 min) Cook a simple family dinner.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Thomas says it isn't okay. Write privately about a time someone refused your reassurance, or you refused someone else's. Then write what honest comfort might have sounded like instead.

- [ ] **Refused comfort** (20 min) Write about it.

- [ ] **Scared** (20 min) Write about being scared as a teen.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate fear.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Whose number?
- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (15 min) Write to Thomas.
- [ ] **Letter from Thomas** (15 min) Write as Thomas to his mother.
- [ ] **Truth** (15 min) Write about telling children truth.
- [ ] **Games** (15 min) Write about a game that held a talk.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Side by Side

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Analyse the game.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Talk while cooking.
- [ ] Reflect.

Tell the Boys?

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Second Number

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Map the timeline.
- [ ] Compare chapter 30.
- [ ] Predict.

Thomas

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Paint the game.
- [ ] Write as Thomas.
- [ ] Read Hold Tight.
- [ ] Discuss.

Fear in Boys

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Driveway

- [ ] Research.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Game Night

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Play.
- [ ] Talk.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Repeat.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 34 dramatise the conflict between reassurance and honesty in parenting?
2. Essay: Analyse how the novel uses sport to frame conversations between fathers and sons.
3. Creative: Write Thomas's private journal entry that night.

Further reading

- *Missing You*, Harlan Coben (2014). Old records and lost loves.
- *Six Years*, Harlan Coben (2013). Digging up the past.
- *Independence Day*, Richard Ford (1995). A father and a teenage son.
- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). What parents owe children.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Family life and childhood.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). Teen honesty and family secrets.
- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Parents, teens and trust.
- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Truth for children.
- *The Sportswriter*, Richard Ford (1986). A father, a son, and sport.

35. Almost Doesn’t Count

What happens

The number belongs to Sally Perryman, a lawyer Adam once worked closely with. He calls; she agrees to meet at the bar of a chain restaurant. She arrives in a white blouse and pencil skirt with a New York Post, and saves the seat beside her with her coat. It is the first time they have spoken in a long while.

Adam asks whether Corinne ever called her. Yes, Sally says: once, two years ago, during the big case they worked on together. Corinne knew Adam had been to Sally’s house; she had found out through a phone-tracking app. Sally told her it was work, that nothing had happened. To Adam she is franker: nothing happened, but it was nearly something.

Adam says that nearly doesn’t count. Sally replies that, to his wife, it probably did. Adam has nothing to add. He leaves.

Scene by scene

1. The familiar number is Sally Perryman’s.
2. They meet at a chain-restaurant bar.
3. Sally: white blouse, pencil skirt, a tabloid, a coat on the stool.
4. Corinne called Sally once, two years ago, during their case.
5. Corinne tracked Adam to Sally’s house via an app.
6. Sally told Corinne it was work; nothing happened.
7. To Adam she admits it was nearly something.
8. Adam: nearly doesn’t count. Sally: to Corinne it did.
9. Adam leaves.

Who’s here

Sally Perryman	A former colleague; the near-affair.
Adam Price	Confronted with his own secret.

Thirty questions

1. Who is Sally Perryman?
2. Where do they meet?
3. When did Corinne call Sally?
4. How did Corinne know Adam had been to Sally’s house?
5. What does Sally admit to Adam?
6. How does the conversation end?
7. **Does almost count? Why or why not?** [book club]
8. **How does this reframe Corinne’s first fake-pregnancy order?** [book club]
9. **Is Adam a hypocrite in his anger at Corinne?** [book club]
10. **What does the tracking app reveal about trust in the marriage?** [book club]
11. Why does the chapter end so abruptly?
12. How is Sally characterised?
13. What does the saved seat suggest?
14. How does the chapter treat Adam’s secret?
15. **Compare Adam’s secret with Corinne’s.** [book club]
16. What does Sally’s frankness show?
17. Was Sally right to tell Corinne it was work?
18. How does this chapter change your view of Adam?
19. Why place this chapter here?

20. How does surveillance cut both ways in this marriage?
21. What does Adam feel when he leaves?
22. How does a near-affair start?
23. Is emotional intimacy at work dangerous?
24. What does the tabloid detail add?
25. How might Corinne have felt that day?
26. What does Sally owe Corinne?
27. Why does Adam not argue?
28. How does the novel treat male self-deception?
29. **Would you forgive a near-affair?** [book club]
30. Predict how Adam reconsiders the marriage.

Close reading

1. First impressions again

Find it: Chapter 35, opening: Sally at the bar.

1. Describe her clothes.
2. Note the newspaper.
3. Note the saved seat.
4. Note the setting.

How does the chapter make Sally both ordinary and charged?

2. The other side

Find it: Chapter 35, middle: Corinne's call.

1. Find when Corinne called.
2. Find how she knew.
3. Find what Sally told her.
4. Note Adam's reaction.

How does the chapter let us see the marriage from Corinne's side?

3. Counting

Find it: Chapter 35, close: the exchange about almost.

1. Find Sally's admission.
2. Find Adam's reply.
3. Find her answer.
4. Note his exit.

Who wins the argument, and why does Adam leave?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A short, sharp chapter that turns the novel's lens on its hero. The final exchange about what counts is the moral pivot: Adam's own secret reframes Corinne's fake pregnancy as a response, not just a deception.

- ☐ **Pivot** (20 min) Analyse the final exchange as a turning point.
- ☐ **Brevity** (15 min) Analyse why the chapter is short.

- [ ] **Description** (15 min) Analyse Sally's description.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Sally's POV.
- [ ] **Dialogue** (30 min) Write an exchange about almost.
- [ ] **Reframing** (15 min) How does this change chapter 1?
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 34.
- [ ] **Exit** (15 min) Analyse Adam's exit.
- [ ] **Subtext** (15 min) Find subtext in the bar talk.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Emotional affairs, mutual surveillance and the asymmetry of judgment. The novel suggests that both spouses held secrets, and both watched each other. The theme of the stranger's revelations turns inward.

- [ ] **Emotional affairs** (25 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Mutual surveillance** (20 min) Discuss the tracking app.
- [ ] **Asymmetry** (25 min) Discuss judging Corinne vs Adam.
- [ ] **Workplace intimacy** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Hypocrisy** (20 min) Discuss Adam's hypocrisy.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "almost".
- [ ] **Motive** (20 min) Discuss Corinne's motive.
- [ ] **Forgiveness** (20 min) Discuss forgiving almost.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Therapists widely recognise emotional affairs as damaging, even without physical contact. Location-sharing apps such as Find My launched in the early 2010s and are widely used within families.

- [ ] **Emotional affairs** (20 min) Research what therapists say.
- [ ] **Location sharing** (15 min) Research Find My and similar apps.
- [ ] **NY Post** (15 min) Research its history.
- [ ] **Workplace relationships** (15 min) Research workplace intimacy policy.
- [ ] **Tracking ethics** (20 min) Research partner tracking.
- [ ] **Law firms** (15 min) Research long trial teams.
- [ ] **Chain bars** (15 min) Research chain restaurant culture.
- [ ] **Infidelity rates** (15 min) Research survey figures.
- [ ] **Repair** (20 min) Research couples repair after betrayal.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Leo Tolstoy's Anna Karenina and Edith Wharton's The Age of Innocence both trace the force of an affair that might or might not be consummated. Perel's State of Affairs (2017) discusses emotional infidelity.

- [ ] **Anna Karenina** (20 min) Read about Tolstoy's novel.
- [ ] **Age of Innocence** (20 min) Compare an unconsummated love.

- [ ] **State of Affairs** (20 min) Read about Perel.
- [ ] **Gottman** (20 min) Read on trust.
- [ ] **Brief Encounter** (15 min) Read about the 1945 film's story.
- [ ] **Little Children** (20 min) Compare suburban affairs.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare marriage and affairs.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about temptation.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A chain-restaurant bar on a highway, neutral ground for an awkward meeting. Somewhere on the map is Sally's house, and once, a blue dot that Corinne watched there.

- [ ] **Bar** (15 min) Pin the restaurant.
- [ ] **Sally's house** (15 min) Imagine it on the map.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 35.
- [ ] **Blue dot** (15 min) Draw the tracking dot.
- [ ] **Neutral ground** (15 min) Note why a chain bar.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Sally.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add two years ago.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Sally.
- [ ] **Routes** (15 min) Map Adam's old route.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Does almost count? Virtue ethics says character is shaped by intentions as well as acts; consequentialism looks at the harm done. Corinne's pain was real either way.

- [ ] **Almost** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the near-affair.
- [ ] **Intention** (35 min) Write 300 words on intent vs act.
- [ ] **Tracking** (20 min) Was Corinne right to track Adam?
- [ ] **Sally** (15 min) Did Sally lie to Corinne?
- [ ] **Hypocrisy** (15 min) Is Adam hypocritical?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Add a counter-file on Adam.
- [ ] **Forgive** (15 min) Would you forgive?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about something almost done.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

A motive lands: Corinne's first fake order came in the month she learned of Sally. The pregnancy was not a whim but a response. Pin the timeline.

- [ ] **Sally** (15 min) Pin Sally.
- [ ] **Motive** (15 min) Pin Corinne's motive for the first order.

- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word confrontation.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Adam as a keeper of secrets.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Link the call and the order.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Reframe** (15 min) Re-read chapter 1 notes.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A woman at a bar with a newspaper and a coat on the next stool, a man arriving: paint it in amber bar light with a cold TV glow.

- [ ] **Bar scene** (35 min) Paint the bar.
- [ ] **Coat on a stool** (20 min) Paint a saved seat.
- [ ] **Blue dot** (15 min) Design a tracking-map image.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for almost.
- [ ] **Pencil skirt** (15 min) Draw Sally.
- [ ] **Tabloid** (15 min) Design a tabloid front page.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a bar at night.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the stool.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A drink at a bar, ordered and unfinished. Food and drink in this novel are often the setting for truths that end the meal early.

- [ ] **Unfinished drink** (15 min) Mix a drink and discuss almost.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record two years ago.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Adam's secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: does almost count?
- [ ] **Making: two-sided ledger** (20 min) Make a ledger of each spouse's secrets.
- [ ] **Bar snacks** (20 min) Make bar snacks.
- [ ] **Recipe of temptation** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Dinner for two** (40 min) Cook a simple dinner for two.
- [ ] **Coffee after** (15 min) Make coffee and talk.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam thought nearly didn't count. Write privately about something you almost did, and whether it counted to someone else.

- [ ] **Almost** (20 min) Write about something almost.
- [ ] **Watched** (20 min) Write about being watched.

- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate guilt.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) How will Adam change?
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Sally** (15 min) Write as Corinne.
- [ ] **Hypocrisy** (15 min) Write about your own double standard.
- [ ] **Work** (15 min) Write about intimacy at work.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Almost

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Verdict.

Reframing the Marriage

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Library Stacks

- [ ] Analyse the pivot.
- [ ] Pin the motive.
- [ ] Read Perel.
- [ ] Re-read chapter 1.

Two Ledgers

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Make the ledger.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Blue Dot

Rooms: Records Room, Turnpike, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research tracking apps.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Sally

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Paint the bar.
- [ ] Write her POV.
- [ ] Write a letter.
- [ ] Discuss.

The Call Two Years Ago

Rooms: Driveway, Incident Board, Law Office

- [ ] Write the call.
- [ ] Pin the timeline.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Predict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 35 reframe Corinne's fake pregnancy, and what does it reveal about Adam?
2. Essay: Analyse the novel's treatment of mutual surveillance in marriage.
3. Creative: Write Corinne's phone call to Sally two years ago.

Further reading

- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Emotional infidelity.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Trust and betrayal.
- *Little Children*, Tom Perrotta (2004). Suburban near-affairs.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Marriage and temptation.
- *The Husband's Secret*, Liane Moriarty (2013). Secrets within a marriage.
- *A Doll's House*, Henrik Ibsen (1879). A marriage seen anew.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). Spouses watching spouses.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Secrets between intimates.
- *The Virgin Suicides*, Jeffrey Eugenides (1993). Middle-aged men and temptation.

36. Eduardo's Garage

What happens

The stranger's team works out of a garage belonging to Eduardo's father, a nod to the start-up legends of Apple, Amazon, Google, Disney, Mattel, Hewlett-Packard and Harley-Davidson, all said to have begun in garages. Four Wi-Fi routers bounce their traffic around the world. Dan Molino has paid. The team: Eduardo, stringy-haired and an old-school hacker who loves the chase; Gabrielle, forty-four, a single mother of two who once worked as a phone-sex operator and then posed as a lonely housewife on a hook-up site to lure subscribers; and Merton, nineteen, tattooed and shaven-headed with bright blue eyes, chains and a switchblade, who volunteers for a televangelist. Ingrid had brought Merton in.

We learn the stranger's name: Chris Taylor. He founded the group, and the rules are his. Chris is disappointed that Dan Molino gets away with it, because when people pay, the group keeps quiet. Something else bothers him: Ingrid missed a planned appearance at a football tryout. Their protocol is strict: travel separately, no real names in the field, no contact between jobs. The irony is not lost on him: a group devoted to exposing secrets lives by anonymity.

Ingrid never returned her rental car in Philadelphia. Chris calls her through Viber, bounced through Bulgaria. A man answers and asks who is calling. Chris hangs up. They have been compromised.

Scene by scene

1. The garage HQ and the start-up garage myths.
2. Four routers bouncing traffic.
3. Dan Molino has paid.
4. Eduardo: hacker, loves the chase.
5. Gabrielle: forty-four, single mother, an ex-phone-sex worker and fake-profile lure.
6. Merton: nineteen, tattoos, switchblade, televangelist volunteer; brought in by Ingrid.
7. The stranger is Chris Taylor, the founder.
8. Chris dislikes it when payers get away with it.
9. Ingrid missed a job; the protocol of anonymity.
10. Ingrid never returned the rental.
11. A Viber call via Bulgaria; a man answers.
12. They've been compromised.

Who's here

Chris Taylor	The stranger, founder of the group.
Eduardo	Hacker and data-hound.
Gabrielle	Former phone-sex worker; online lure; mother of two.
Merton	Young, tattooed, volatile.
Ingrid Prisby	Missing (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. Where does the group work?
2. Name the members and describe each.

3. What is the stranger's name?
4. What is the group's protocol?
5. What has happened to Ingrid?
6. What happens on the Viber call?
7. **Why does the novel invoke garage start-up myths?** [book club]
8. **Is the group a business, a cause or a crime?** [book club]
9. **What irony lies in their anonymity?** [book club]
10. How does Gabrielle's past connect to deception online?
11. What does Merton's volunteering add?
12. Why is Chris unhappy that Dan paid?
13. How does the chapter humanise the group?
14. What does "compromised" mean for them?
15. Who might have answered Ingrid's phone?
16. Compare the group with a tech start-up.
17. What do the routers suggest?
18. How does the chapter treat hackers?
19. Is Eduardo dangerous?
20. Is Merton?
21. **How does the chapter shift your view of the stranger?** [book club]
22. Why name him now?
23. What does Gabrielle's history suggest about the internet?
24. What does the group believe it is doing?
25. **How does the chapter build menace?** [book club]
26. What might link the group to the recent killings?
27. How does protocol fail?
28. Would you trust these people?
29. **What does the garage represent?** [book club]
30. Predict what the group does next.

Close reading

1. Start-up legend

Find it: Chapter 36, opening: the garage and its myths.

1. List the companies.
2. Note the tone.
3. Describe the routers.
4. Note Dan's payment.

How does the chapter frame the group as a start-up?

2. Character sketches

Find it: Chapter 36, middle: the team.

1. Describe Eduardo.
2. Describe Gabrielle.
3. Describe Merton.
4. Note Chris's role.

How do the sketches vary the group's motives?

3. The voice on the line

Find it: Chapter 36, close: the Viber call.

1. Note the routing.
2. Note the voice.
3. Note Chris's reaction.
4. Read the last line.

How does the chapter turn the hunters into the hunted?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

An ensemble chapter introducing the group through quick sketches, framed by the garage myth. The ending reverses the novel's polarity: those who watch are now being watched. Naming the stranger at last shrinks him from menace to man.

- ☐ **Ensemble** (20 min) Analyse the character sketches.
- ☐ **Frame** (15 min) Analyse the garage frame.
- ☐ **Reversal** (15 min) Analyse the ending's reversal.
- ☐ **Naming** (15 min) Why name the stranger now?
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Gabrielle's POV.
- ☐ **Sketches** (30 min) Write three character sketches.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 31.
- ☐ **Irony** (15 min) Find the irony.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the last line.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Anonymity and exposure; the start-up mythology of disruption; the morality of a vigilante business. The group lives the contradiction at the heart of the book: they reveal secrets while guarding their own.

- ☐ **Anonymity** (25 min) Discuss anonymity and exposure.
- ☐ **Start-up myth** (20 min) Discuss disruption culture.
- ☐ **Vigilante business** (25 min) Discuss.
- ☐ **Online deception** (20 min) Discuss Gabrielle's past.
- ☐ **Hackers** (15 min) Discuss portrayals of hackers.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "hunters hunted".
- ☐ **Faith** (15 min) Discuss Merton's volunteering.
- ☐ **Protocol** (15 min) Discuss rules and failure.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

HP, Apple, Amazon and Google all have garage origin stories, some embellished. Routing traffic through several countries complicates tracing. Viber launched in 2010. Phone-sex lines and fake profiles on dating sites have both been well documented.

- [ ] **Garage myths** (20 min) Research HP's garage.
- [ ] **Routing** (20 min) Research VPNs and onion routing.
- [ ] **Viber** (15 min) Research the app.
- [ ] **Dating-site lures** (20 min) Research fake profiles on dating sites.
- [ ] **Phone-sex industry** (15 min) Research its history.
- [ ] **Televangelism** (15 min) Research televangelism.
- [ ] **Silk Road** (20 min) Research how Ross Ulbricht was traced.
- [ ] **Rental cars** (15 min) Research rental tracking.
- [ ] **Hacker culture** (15 min) Research the hacker ethic.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Jon Ronson's So You've Been Publicly Shamed and Dave Eggers's The Circle explore exposure culture. Nick Bilton's American Kingpin tells how the Silk Road's founder was traced despite his anonymity.

- [ ] **Kingpin** (20 min) Read about American Kingpin.
- [ ] **Ronson** (20 min) Read about public shaming.
- [ ] **The Circle** (20 min) Compare exposure culture.
- [ ] **Zuboff** (20 min) Read on data.
- [ ] **Solove** (20 min) Read on privacy.
- [ ] **Fool Me Once** (20 min) Compare tech and secrets.
- [ ] **Orwell** (20 min) Compare surveillance.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about masks.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A suburban garage, with traffic bounced through Bulgaria and back. Philadelphia, where Ingrid's car should have been returned. The group's map is digital, but its people live in ordinary houses.

- [ ] **Garage** (15 min) Imagine the garage's town.
- [ ] **Bulgaria** (15 min) Trace the routing.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 36.
- [ ] **Philadelphia** (15 min) Pin the rental return.
- [ ] **Team map** (15 min) Map where members live.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the group.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Draw the group's links.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place each member.
- [ ] **Digital map** (15 min) Draw a routing diagram.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is the group's rule (pay and we stay silent) ethical? It turns revelation into a price. Chris's discomfort suggests even he doubts it.

- [ ] **Pay or reveal** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the group.
- [ ] **Business** (35 min) Write 300 words: business or crime?
- [ ] **Anonymity** (15 min) Is anonymity hypocritical here?
- [ ] **Recruitment** (15 min) Is recruiting Merton responsible?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Begin a file on the group.
- [ ] **Chris** (15 min) Rate Chris's conscience.
- [ ] **Lures** (15 min) Was Gabrielle's old work wrong?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about online identity.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Big reveal: the stranger's name and crew. Ingrid's silence and the unknown man answering her phone tie this strand to the murder in chapter 21.

- [ ] **Names** (15 min) Pin each member.
- [ ] **Chris** (15 min) Pin the stranger's name.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word compromised scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate each member.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Link to chapter 21.
- [ ] **Voice** (15 min) Who answered the phone?
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A garage lit by monitors, four blinking routers, a whiteboard, a camp chair, a tattooed young man spinning a knife: paint it like a cave of screens.

- [ ] **Cave of screens** (35 min) Paint the garage.
- [ ] **Group portrait** (30 min) Draw the four.
- [ ] **Routers** (15 min) Draw blinking routers.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a hacker theme.
- [ ] **Switchblade** (15 min) Draw Merton's hands.
- [ ] **Logo** (15 min) Design the group's (secret) logo.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a garage of machines.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the garage door.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Energy drinks and takeaway boxes in a garage: start-up food. Make a garage snack board and talk about who you would trust in a team.

- [ ] **Garage snack board** (20 min) Make it and discuss team trust.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Dan's payment.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the group's names.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who would you trust in a crew?
- [ ] **Making: protocol card** (15 min) Write rules for a secret group.
- [ ] **Takeaway** (30 min) Order or cook takeaway-style food.
- [ ] **Recipe of anonymity** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Coffee for coders** (15 min) Brew strong coffee.
- [ ] **Pizza** (45 min) Make garage pizza.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

The group exposes others while hiding themselves. Write privately about whether you want to be known or hidden online. List three things about you that are findable, and one that is not.

- [ ] **Known or hidden** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Team** (20 min) Write about a team that went wrong.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate menace.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What next?
- [ ] **Letter to Chris** (15 min) Write to Chris.
- [ ] **Letter to Ingrid** (15 min) Write as Chris.
- [ ] **Masks** (15 min) Write about masks.
- [ ] **Garage dreams** (15 min) Write about a garage dream.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Garage

Rooms: Diner, Records Room, Law Office

- [ ] Paint it.
- [ ] Research garage myths.
- [ ] Analyse the frame.
- [ ] Present.

The Crew

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin each member.
- [ ] Write sketches.
- [ ] Rate.
- [ ] Debate.

Anonymity

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Read Kingpin.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Business or Crime

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Incident Board

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Court file.
- [ ] Verdict.

Compromised

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Turnpike

- [ ] Link to chapter 21.
- [ ] Analyse the ending.
- [ ] Map routing.
- [ ] Predict.

Crew Night

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Snack board.
- [ ] Discuss trust.
- [ ] Write rules.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 36 use start-up mythology to characterise the stranger's group?
2. Essay: Analyse the irony of anonymity in a group devoted to exposing secrets.
3. Creative: Write the group's first meeting in the garage.

Further reading

- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). Anonymity and how it fails.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Exposure culture.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). A company devoted to transparency.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Data and its uses.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Privacy and secrets.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben on technology and deception.
- *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, George Orwell (1949). Watching and being watched.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online harms.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Masks and presentation.

37. Holiday Party

What happens

Adam remembers Sally. She was a junior partner who sat first chair with him on a long case defending a Greek diner in Harrison that had stood for forty years, threatened by a road widening tied to a hedge-fund tower and local corruption. The case consumed them. They grew very close. They never kissed; they approached lines and never crossed them. Adam came to believe that, in such a closeness, something has to wither and die, and two months after the case Sally left for a firm in Livingston. Corinne's call to Sally explains a great deal, and the picture it paints of Adam is not pleasant.

Rinsky reports on Ingrid: she lives in Austin, graduated from Rice eight years ago, and has worked at two internet start-ups. Her home phone goes to a robotic voicemail; Rinsky also has her mother's number. Adam remembers Corinne once observing that on Facebook everyone looks happy, a greatest-hits album rather than real life. He joked that it was the Prozac version; she went quiet. Ingrid's Facebook shows a single woman with 188 friends who volunteers at soup kitchens, the Red Cross, the USO and Junior Achievement, and appears only in group shots.

Adam reasons the link is work rather than college or Austin. Fake-A-Pregnancy's contact address is in Revere, Massachusetts; it belongs to a conglomerate, Downing Place. Following chains of Facebook friends, he finds a Gabrielle Dunbar with links to Ocean County College, Fair Lawn High and Revere. At 4:48 a.m. he finds a photograph labelled HOLIDAY PARTY, three years old. At the far left, holding a beer, is the stranger.

Scene by scene

1. Memory: Sally as junior partner on the Greek diner case in Harrison.
2. The case: forty years, a road widening, a hedge-fund tower, corruption.
3. Closeness; lines approached, never crossed.
4. Sally leaves for a firm in Livingston.
5. Rinsky: Ingrid, Austin, Rice, two start-ups, a mother's number.
6. Corinne on Facebook as a greatest-hits album; Adam's joke.
7. Ingrid's Facebook: single, 188 friends, volunteering, group shots.
8. Adam reasons: work is the link.
9. Revere, Massachusetts; Downing Place.
10. Friend chains to Gabrielle Dunbar.
11. 4:48 a.m.: HOLIDAY PARTY photo; the stranger at the far left with a beer.

Who's here

Adam Price	Remembering, then investigating all night.
Sally Perryman	Remembered.
Mike Rinsky	Reporting on Ingrid.
Gabrielle Dunbar	Found online.

Thirty questions

1. What was the Greek diner case?
2. How close were Adam and Sally?

3. Why did Sally leave?
4. What does Rinsky learn about Ingrid?
5. What did Corinne say about Facebook?
6. How does Adam trace Gabrielle?
7. **Is the novel's idea that something has to wither true of work intimacy?** [book club]
8. How does the diner case fit Adam's eminent-domain career?
9. **Why does Adam's Prozac joke silence Corinne?** [book club]
10. **What does Facebook as a greatest-hits album suggest?** [book club]
11. What does Ingrid's volunteering suggest about her?
12. Why does Ingrid appear only in group shots?
13. How does Adam reason his way to work as the link?
14. What is Downing Place?
15. **How does social media betray its users here?** [book club]
16. What does the 4:48 a.m. timestamp suggest?
17. How does the photo change things?
18. Is Adam a good investigator now?
19. How does the chapter combine memory and detection?
20. What does the chapter reveal about Adam's self-image?
21. How does the diner case echo Rinsky's?
22. What do Ingrid's charities suggest about the group's self-image?
23. How might Gabrielle be found?
24. What does a holiday-party photo reveal?
25. Why do workplaces leave digital trails?
26. Is it creepy to trace friends lists?
27. **What would you find about yourself this way?** [book club]
28. **How has Adam changed since chapter 1?** [book club]
29. What is the stranger's link to Fake-A-Pregnancy?
30. Predict what Adam does with this.

Close reading

1. Lines approached

Find it: Chapter 37, opening: the Sally memory.

1. Summarise the case.
2. Note the closeness.
3. Paraphrase the wither-and-die idea.
4. Note Sally's departure.

How honest is Adam with himself in this memory?

2. A greatest-hits life

Find it: Chapter 37, middle: Corinne on Facebook.

1. Paraphrase Corinne's observation.
2. Note Adam's joke.
3. Note her silence.
4. Consider what she meant.

What does this memory reveal about Corinne's inner life?

3. Digital detection

Find it: Chapter 37, close: the friend chain and the photo.

1. Trace the steps.
2. Note Downing Place.
3. Note Gabrielle.
4. Note the time and the photo.

How does the chapter make online research suspenseful?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter in two modes: a confessional memory, then an all-night digital hunt. The two connect: Adam learns how secrets live online at the very moment he faces his own. The 4:48 timestamp makes exhaustion part of the drama.

- ☐ **Two modes** (20 min) Analyse memory and hunt.
- ☐ **Timestamp** (15 min) Analyse 4:48 a.m.
- ☐ **Confession** (15 min) Analyse Adam's candour.
- ☐ **Digital suspense** (30 min) Write a suspenseful online search.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite the Sally memory from her POV.
- ☐ **Dialogue** (15 min) Analyse the Facebook memory.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 35.
- ☐ **Structure** (15 min) Map the chain of reasoning.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the photo reveal.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Work intimacy and its costs; the curated self on social media; how networks reveal what individuals hide. Corinne's remark about Facebook comments on the whole novel: lives as greatest hits.

- ☐ **Work intimacy** (25 min) Discuss.
- ☐ **Greatest hits** (25 min) Discuss curated lives.
- ☐ **Networks** (20 min) Discuss how networks reveal.
- ☐ **Self-image** (15 min) Discuss Adam's self-image.
- ☐ **Charity** (15 min) Discuss Ingrid's volunteering.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "curation".
- ☐ **Exhaustion** (15 min) Discuss sleeplessness.
- ☐ **Privacy** (20 min) Discuss friend-list tracing.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Eminent-domain fights, such as Kelo v. City of New London (2005), have pitted small businesses against development. Rice University is in Houston. Friends lists have been used by investigators and journalists to map networks.

- [ ] **Kelo** (20 min) Research Kelo v. City of New London.
- [ ] **Rice** (15 min) Research Rice University.
- [ ] **Revere** (15 min) Research Revere, MA.
- [ ] **OSINT** (20 min) Research open-source intelligence.
- [ ] **Facebook privacy** (15 min) Research friends-list privacy.
- [ ] **Diners** (20 min) Research NJ Greek diners.
- [ ] **USO** (15 min) Research the USO.
- [ ] **Junior Achievement** (15 min) Research JA.
- [ ] **Conglomerates** (15 min) Research shell companies.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Coben's Missing You uses online dating and data trails. Sherry Turkle's research on online identity and Jon Ronson's work on shaming both inform how we read curated lives.

- [ ] **Missing You** (20 min) Compare online traces.
- [ ] **Ronson** (20 min) Read on curated lives.
- [ ] **The Circle** (20 min) Compare transparency.
- [ ] **Solove** (20 min) Read on reputation.
- [ ] **Gottman** (20 min) Read on turning away.
- [ ] **Perel** (20 min) Read on affairs of the heart.
- [ ] **Zuboff** (20 min) Read on data trails.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a party.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Harrison and its diner, Livingston, Austin and Houston, Revere near Boston, Fair Lawn: a map built from friends lists, spreading across the country from one laptop in Cedarfield.

- [ ] **Harrison** (15 min) Pin the diner case.
- [ ] **Livingston** (15 min) Pin Sally's firm.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 37.
- [ ] **Revere** (15 min) Pin Downing Place.
- [ ] **Houston and Austin** (15 min) Pin Ingrid's past.
- [ ] **Fair Lawn** (15 min) Pin Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the photo.
- [ ] **Network** (20 min) Draw the friend chain.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Downing Place.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Was ending the closeness with Sally right? Adam chose his marriage, imperfectly. Virtue ethics asks about character over time; care ethics about the people affected, including Corinne.

- [ ] **Ending it** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam and Sally.
- [ ] **Tracing** (20 min) Is friend-chain tracing ethical?
- [ ] **Curation** (35 min) Write 300 words on online honesty.
- [ ] **Jokes** (15 min) Was Adam's joke unkind?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the stranger file.
- [ ] **Charity** (15 min) Does Ingrid's charity change your view?
- [ ] **Diner** (15 min) Was saving the diner just?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about what you leave out online.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Big breakthroughs: Downing Place, Gabrielle Dunbar, and the stranger in a photo. The investigation turns from the stranger's acts to his workplace and colleagues.

- [ ] **Downing Place** (15 min) Pin it.
- [ ] **Gabrielle** (15 min) Pin her.
- [ ] **Photo** (15 min) Pin the HOLIDAY PARTY photo.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word discovery.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Timeline** (15 min) Add three years ago.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A Greek diner in Harrison with chrome and a neon sign, and an office holiday party captured on a phone: paint one warm memory and one cheap snapshot.

- [ ] **Greek diner** (35 min) Paint the diner in neon.
- [ ] **Party snapshot** (25 min) Draw an office holiday party.
- [ ] **Facebook page** (15 min) Design a greatest-hits profile.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for 4:48 a.m.
- [ ] **Laptop glow** (20 min) Paint a face lit by a screen.
- [ ] **Group shot** (15 min) Draw a group photo with one face circled.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a house at 4:48 a.m.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the photo.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

The Greek diner Adam fought for. Cook a Greek diner classic (souvlaki, a gyro platter, spanakopita) and talk about places worth saving.

- [ ] **Greek diner night** (45 min) Cook a Greek diner classic.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the chain.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the photo.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what do you leave off social media?
- [ ] **Making: real album** (20 min) Make a page of un-curated photos.
- [ ] **Coffee at 4 a.m.** (15 min) Make coffee and stay up a little.
- [ ] **Spanakopita** (60 min) Bake spanakopita.
- [ ] **Recipe of a curated life** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Holiday party snacks** (20 min) Make party snacks.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Corinne said Facebook shows the greatest hits. Write privately about what your own online life leaves out. Then add one ordinary, unflattering moment you would never post.

- [ ] **Greatest hits** (20 min) Write about what you leave out.
- [ ] **Work closeness** (20 min) Write about a work friendship.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What does Adam do next?
- [ ] **Letter to Sally** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write about the joke.
- [ ] **Night** (15 min) Write about an all-nighter.
- [ ] **Findable** (15 min) Write what is findable about you.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Greatest Hits

Rooms: Room 233, Price Kitchen, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss curation.
- [ ] Make an un-curated album page.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Diner Case

Rooms: Records Room, Price Kitchen, Diner

- [ ] Research Kelo.
- [ ] Cook Greek.
- [ ] Paint the diner.
- [ ] Present.

Friend Chains

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin the chain.
- [ ] Map it.
- [ ] Debate ethics.
- [ ] Verdict.

Sally Remembered

Rooms: Law Office, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Analyse the memory.
- [ ] Write as Sally.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.

The Photo

Rooms: Diner, Incident Board, Law Office

- [ ] Draw a party.
- [ ] Pin the photo.
- [ ] Write the reveal.
- [ ] Predict.

All-Nighter

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Make 4 a.m. coffee.
- [ ] Analyse the timestamp.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Sleep.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 37 link Adam's self-knowledge with his digital detection?
2. Essay: Analyse Corinne's observation about Facebook and its relevance to the novel.
3. Creative: Write the office holiday party where the photo was taken.

Further reading

- *Missing You*, Harlan Coben (2014). Online traces and lost loves.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Curated selves and exposure.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). Transparency and identity.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Reputation in the digital age.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Data trails.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Emotional intimacy outside marriage.

- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Turning towards and away.
- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). Identities exposed by networks.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Front-stage selves.

38. Starsky and Hutch

What happens

Johanna has two Havanese dogs, Starsky and Hutch. She grew up with Great Danes and never imagined herself with small fluffy dogs, but here they are. The bedroom rule (no dogs on the bed) has long since collapsed. Ricky snores. Johanna can't sleep; when she does, she dreams of Heidi. So she takes the dogs out for a late walk.

She is afraid of falling in the dark. Her father fell at seventy-four and was never the same; the fear has stayed with her. She uses the flashlight app on her phone to light the pavement. The quiet streets, the small dogs pulling, the beam of light: it is a picture of a careful woman in the middle of her life, carrying grief.

Her phone buzzes. It's Norbert. He has run the plate from the Red Lobster footage. The car was a rental, hired by a woman named Ingrid Prisby. And Norbert has found something else about Ingrid, something very bad.

Scene by scene

1. Starsky and Hutch, two Havanese; Great Danes in childhood.
2. The collapsed bedroom rule; Ricky's snoring.
3. Johanna dreams of Heidi; sleeplessness.
4. A late walk; fear of falling, rooted in her father's fall at seventy-four.
5. The phone's flashlight on the pavement.
6. Norbert calls: the car was rented by Ingrid Prisby.
7. And there's something very bad about Ingrid.

Who's here

Johanna Griffin	Sleepless, careful, grieving.
Starsky and Hutch	Her Havanese dogs.
Ricky Griffin	Snoring husband.
Norbert Pendergast	Brings news.

Thirty questions

1. What are Johanna's dogs called, and why is that funny?
2. What dogs did she grow up with?
3. Why can't Johanna sleep?
4. What is she afraid of on the walk, and why?
5. What does Norbert discover?
6. Why does the chapter end where it does?
7. **Why give Johanna such an ordinary, comic home life?** [book club]
8. **How does the fear of falling characterise her?** [book club]
9. **How do the strands now meet?** [book club]
10. **What does the flashlight image suggest?** [book club]
11. What is the effect of the TV-cop dog names?
12. How does the chapter create tenderness?
13. What does Ricky add?
14. How does grief show in sleep?
15. What might "very bad" mean?
16. **How does the chapter treat middle age?** [book club]
17. Compare Johanna's home with Adam's.
18. What does Johanna's father's fall suggest about ageing?

19. How does the chapter vary pace?
20. Why are small dogs a joke?
21. How does the chapter link the dog walk to investigation?
22. What does Johanna know now that Adam doesn't?
23. How does the phone function here?
24. What is the mood of the chapter?
25. Why does Johanna dream of Heidi?
26. How does the novel portray marriage at this stage?
27. Would Johanna be a good partner for Adam's investigation?
28. What does a careful person do with bad news?
29. **What do you fear in the dark?** [book club]
30. Predict what Norbert has found.

Close reading

1. Comic domesticity

Find it: Chapter 38, opening: the dogs and the bed.

1. Note the dogs' names.
2. Note the Great Danes.
3. Note the bedroom rule.
4. Note Ricky.

How does humour humanise Johanna?

2. Fear in the dark

Find it: Chapter 38, middle: the walk.

1. Note her fear.
2. Find its source.
3. Note the flashlight.
4. Note the streets.

How does a small fear reveal character?

3. Two strands meet

Find it: Chapter 38, close: Norbert's call.

1. Note the timing.
2. Note the name.
3. Note the implication.
4. Read the last line.

How does the chapter use an ordinary moment to deliver a major turn?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A short, intimate chapter: comic dogs, a snoring husband, a fear of falling, then a phone call that joins the two investigations. Ordinary life is the setting for the plot's biggest convergence, and the contrast makes the call land harder.

- [ ] **Contrast** (20 min) Analyse ordinary life vs plot turn.
- [ ] **Comedy** (15 min) Analyse the dog humour.
- [ ] **Convergence** (15 min) Map the strands meeting.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Norbert's POV.
- [ ] **Short scene** (30 min) Write a quiet scene ending on news.
- [ ] **Imagery** (15 min) Analyse the flashlight image.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 37.
- [ ] **Names** (15 min) Analyse Starsky and Hutch as names.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the cliffhanger.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Middle age, fear, grief and the quiet courage of ordinary people. Johanna is the novel's counter-hero: careful, funny, unglamorous, and the one who will keep going when others stop.

- [ ] **Middle age** (20 min) Discuss middle age in the novel.
- [ ] **Fear and courage** (25 min) Discuss Aristotle's mean.
- [ ] **Grief and sleep** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Counter-hero** (20 min) Discuss Johanna as hero.
- [ ] **Pets** (15 min) Discuss pets and grief.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "carefulness".
- [ ] **Marriage** (15 min) Discuss Johanna and Ricky.
- [ ] **Convergence** (15 min) Discuss the plot's design.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Havanese are the national dog of Cuba. Starsky & Hutch aired on ABC from 1975 to 1979. Falls are a leading cause of injury and loss of independence for older adults, which is why many people fear them.

- [ ] **Havanese** (15 min) Research the breed.
- [ ] **Starsky & Hutch** (15 min) Research the show.
- [ ] **Great Danes** (15 min) Research the breed.
- [ ] **Falls** (20 min) Research falls in older adults.
- [ ] **Grief and sleep** (20 min) Research bereavement and insomnia.
- [ ] **Phone torch** (15 min) Research when phones got flashlights.
- [ ] **Plate lookups** (15 min) Research rental records access.
- [ ] **Small departments** (15 min) Research small-town policing.
- [ ] **Dog walking** (15 min) Research dog walking and health.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Kate Atkinson's Jackson Brodie novels and Louise Penny's Armand Gamache mysteries give detectives domestic lives with dogs. Johanna belongs to that tradition of the humane investigator.

- [ ] **Brodie** (20 min) Read about Atkinson's detective.
- [ ] **Gamache** (20 min) Read about Louise Penny.
- [ ] **Aristotle** (20 min) Read on courage.
- [ ] **Case Histories** (20 min) Compare a humane detective.
- [ ] **Tell No One** (15 min) Compare dogs in Coben.
- [ ] **Didion** (20 min) Read about The Year of Magical Thinking.
- [ ] **Gottman** (20 min) Read on long marriage.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about night walks.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Beachwood at night, quiet suburban pavements lit by a phone. Ingrid's name links Beachwood to Cedarfield and Austin. Two towns, one name; the map closes in.

- [ ] **Night streets** (15 min) Map Johanna's walk.
- [ ] **Convergence** (15 min) Draw Ingrid linking towns.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 38.
- [ ] **Beachwood** (15 min) Detail Beachwood at night.
- [ ] **Red Lobster** (15 min) Link the footage to the walk.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Ingrid to the Heidi map.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Connect both strands.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Johanna.
- [ ] **Radius** (15 min) Draw a five-mile radius.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Are fear and courage opposites? Aristotle saw courage as the mean between cowardice and rashness, which includes feeling fear. Johanna fears falling and still walks out into the dark.

- [ ] **Fear and courage** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Johanna's choices.
- [ ] **Off-book** (15 min) Should she report this?
- [ ] **Courage** (35 min) Write 300 words on everyday courage.
- [ ] **Duty** (15 min) Does she owe Heidi?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Heidi file.
- [ ] **Partners** (15 min) Should she contact Adam?
- [ ] **Process** (15 min) Is she breaking rules?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about an inherited fear.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The strands converge: Ingrid Prisby links Heidi and Adam. Norbert's ominous hint changes the stakes from secrets to violence. Pin the link.

- [ ] **Link** (15 min) Pin Ingrid as the link.
- [ ] **Bad news** (15 min) Pin Norbert's hint.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word call scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark convergence.
- [ ] **Stakes** (15 min) Note rising stakes.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A woman walking two tiny dogs on a dark street, her phone torch a small cone of light: paint it with deep blues and one sharp white beam.

- [ ] **Night walk** (35 min) Paint the walk.
- [ ] **Dogs** (20 min) Draw Starsky and Hutch.
- [ ] **Beam** (20 min) Paint a cone of light.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a 1970s cop-show theme.
- [ ] **Great Danes** (15 min) Draw Johanna's childhood dogs.
- [ ] **Bed** (15 min) Draw the collapsed bedroom rule.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe snoring and paws.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the beam.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A late snack for the dogs and maybe for the walker. Dog walking at night is its own ritual. Make a small midnight snack and think about grief and sleep.

- [ ] **Midnight snack** (15 min) Make a small midnight snack.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Ingrid's name.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Norbert's hint.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what do you fear in the dark?
- [ ] **Making: dog treats** (40 min) Bake simple dog treats.
- [ ] **Warm milk** (15 min) Make warm milk for sleeplessness.
- [ ] **Recipe of a sleepless night** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Comfort food** (40 min) Cook comfort food for grief.
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea for Ricky.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Johanna fears falling because her father fell. Write privately about a fear you inherited from someone you love, and whether you still carry it today.

- [ ] **Inherited fear** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Pets** (20 min) Write about a pet who comforted you.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate unease.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What has happened to Ingrid?
- [ ] **Letter to Johanna** (15 min) Write to her.
- [ ] **Letter to Heidi** (15 min) Write as Johanna.
- [ ] **Sleepless** (15 min) Write about a sleepless night.
- [ ] **Courage** (15 min) Write about everyday courage.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Counter-Hero

Rooms: Room 233, Law Office, Library Stacks

- [ ] Discuss Johanna.
- [ ] Analyse the chapter.
- [ ] Read about Brodie.
- [ ] Write.

Night Walk

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Paint the walk.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Make warm milk.
- [ ] Reflect.

Convergence

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Pin Ingrid.
- [ ] Map both towns.
- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Predict.

Fear and Courage

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Read Aristotle.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Dogs

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Records Room

- [ ] Bake treats.
- [ ] Draw the dogs.
- [ ] Research the breed.
- [ ] Share.

Norbert's Call

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Write it.
- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Predict.
- [ ] Discuss.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 38 use ordinary domestic life to deliver a major plot turn?
2. Essay: Analyse Johanna Griffin as the novel's counter-hero.
3. Creative: Write Norbert's side of the phone call.

Further reading

- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A seasoned woman investigator.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). Grief and detection.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben on loyalty and loss.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Long marriage.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Families and grief.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Small-town crime and community.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Community bonds.
- *Shelter*, Harlan Coben (2011). Coben's lighter investigative voice.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). A village and its secrets.

39. Police at the Door

What happens

At six in the morning Gribbel calls; he has been up after a gig at which his band played a seventies story-song about Chicago gangsters. His band has a Facebook fan page with about eighty followers. More usefully, he has found Gabrielle Dunbar: she has moved back to Fair Lawn, and he has her address.

Upstairs Ryan is sobbing. He misses his mum. Adam feels a surge of anger at Corinne for hurting the boys. When Ryan asks where she is, Adam answers truthfully that he doesn't know, and oddly that soothes the boy more than reassurance would. Corinne always called the boys her boys, and joked that Adam was her biggest child. She loved her life. She would not just leave it.

A police car pulls up. Len Gilman steps out with an Essex County officer. Adam's mind goes straight to the worst: Corinne is dead. Len says it isn't about Corinne, as far as he knows, but Adam needs to come to the station.

Scene by scene

1. Six a.m.: Gribbel, post-gig, with Gabrielle's Fair Lawn address.
2. The band's fan page and its eighty-odd followers.
3. Ryan sobbing for his mother.
4. Adam's anger at Corinne for hurting the boys.
5. Adam answers honestly: he doesn't know where she is; it soothes Ryan.
6. Corinne's phrase for the boys, and Adam as her biggest child.
7. She loved her life.
8. A police car: Len and an Essex County officer.
9. Adam fears she is dead; Len says it's not about her, he thinks.
10. Adam must come to the station.

Who's here

Andy Gribbel	Paralegal and amateur rock singer.
Ryan Price	Grieving his absent mother.
Len Gilman	Police chief.
Adam Price	Father, then suspect.

Thirty questions

1. What news does Gribbel bring?
2. What is Ryan upset about?
3. How does Adam respond to Ryan?
4. **Why does honesty soothe Ryan?** [book club]
5. What did Corinne call the boys?
6. Who comes to the door?
7. What does Adam fear?
8. What does Len say?
9. **How does the chapter treat Adam's anger at Corinne?** [book club]
10. **Is Adam's anger fair?** [book club]
11. What does the biggest-child joke reveal?
12. What does Gribbel's gig add?
13. How does the chapter shift from domestic to procedural?
14. Why is an Essex County officer there?

15. What might the police want?
16. **How does the chapter treat children's grief?** [book club]
17. Compare Ryan's and Thomas's responses.
18. What does Corinne's love of her life suggest?
19. How does the chapter build dread?
20. What does the fan page tell us about Gribbel?
21. How does Adam cope with conflicting feelings?
22. What do you think Adam should do at the station?
23. How does the novel use comic relief in dark chapters?
24. Why does Len say "I think"?
25. How has Adam's situation changed?
26. What does "station" signal?
27. Is Adam now a suspect?
28. **How should you tell a child you don't know?** [book club]
29. **What does this chapter say about mothers?** [book club]
30. Predict what awaits Adam.

Close reading

1. Comic relief

Find it: Chapter 39, opening: Gribbel's call.

1. Note the time.
2. Note the gig.
3. Note the fan page.
4. Note the address.

How does comedy make room for the darker scenes that follow?

2. Honest uncertainty

Find it: Chapter 39, middle: Ryan.

1. Describe Ryan's grief.
2. Note Adam's anger.
3. Find his honest reply.
4. Note its effect.

Why does the truth calm Ryan?

3. Dread

Find it: Chapter 39, close: the police car.

1. Note who arrives.
2. Note Adam's assumption.
3. Note Len's hedge.
4. Note the request.

How does the chapter manipulate our fears?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A three-beat chapter: comic, tender, ominous. Gribbel's cheerful call, Ryan's grief and the police at the door make a rising curve of dread. Len's hedge (not about Corinne, he thinks) keeps every possibility open.

- [ ] **Three beats** (15 min) Map the chapter's three beats.
- [ ] **Dread** (15 min) Analyse rising dread.
- [ ] **Comic relief** (15 min) Analyse Gribbel.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Ryan's POV.
- [ ] **Scene** (30 min) Write a child's grief scene.
- [ ] **Hedge** (15 min) Analyse Len's hedge.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 34.
- [ ] **Dialogue** (15 min) Analyse Adam and Ryan.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the summons.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Children's grief, parental anger and the value of honest uncertainty. The novel argues again that truth, even incomplete truth, can comfort more than false reassurance.

- [ ] **Children's grief** (25 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Honest uncertainty** (25 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Anger at a spouse** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Mothers** (20 min) Discuss Corinne as mother.
- [ ] **Escalation** (15 min) Discuss the police turn.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "honest uncertainty".
- [ ] **Comic relief** (15 min) Discuss Gribbel.
- [ ] **Suspects** (15 min) Discuss Adam as suspect.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Child psychologists often recommend age-appropriate honesty with children during family crises. The Night Chicago Died, by Paper Lace, was a 1974 US number one. Essex County includes Newark.

- [ ] **Talking to children** (20 min) Research advice on telling children hard news.
- [ ] **Paper Lace** (15 min) Research the song.
- [ ] **Essex County** (15 min) Research the county.
- [ ] **Fair Lawn** (15 min) Research Fair Lawn.
- [ ] **Police interviews** (20 min) Research voluntary interviews.
- [ ] **Jurisdiction** (15 min) Research NJ county jurisdiction.
- [ ] **Cover bands** (15 min) Research cover-band culture.
- [ ] **Fan pages** (15 min) Research small fan pages.
- [ ] **Missing parents** (20 min) Research children of missing parents.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Coben's Hold Tight and Celeste Ng's Little Fires Everywhere both explore what children are told. Joan Didion's The Year of Magical Thinking shows grief's strange logic.

- [ ] **Hold Tight** (20 min) Compare parents and children.
- [ ] **Little Fires** (20 min) Compare what children are told.
- [ ] **Didion** (20 min) Read about grief.
- [ ] **Gopnik** (20 min) Read on parenting.
- [ ] **Lareau** (20 min) Read on family life.
- [ ] **Never Told** (20 min) Compare families and loss.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on lies to children.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a child crying.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Fair Lawn, where Gabrielle has moved back, and Essex County, whose officer stands at the door. The case is expanding across county lines and jurisdictions, and it is about to take Adam with it.

- [ ] **Fair Lawn** (15 min) Pin Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Station** (15 min) Pin the police station.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 39.
- [ ] **Jurisdiction** (15 min) Map county lines.
- [ ] **Gig** (15 min) Imagine Gribbel's venue.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the police turn.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Essex County.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Len.
- [ ] **Route** (15 min) Map the route to the station.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is honest uncertainty better for children than false comfort? Care ethics favours attunement to the child; the chapter suggests Ryan wanted honesty more than a promise.

- [ ] **Honest uncertainty** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam and Ryan.
- [ ] **Anger** (15 min) Is Adam's anger fair?
- [ ] **Children** (35 min) Write 300 words on truth for children.
- [ ] **Police** (15 min) Should Adam go willingly?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Adam file.
- [ ] **Mothers** (15 min) Is leaving ever right?
- [ ] **Process** (15 min) Len's role: friend or chief?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about honest uncertainty.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Gabrielle located; police escalation. An Essex County officer means something bigger than lacrosse money. Pin the escalation and Len's hedge.

- [ ] **Gabrielle** (15 min) Pin her address.
- [ ] **Escalation** (15 min) Pin the police car.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word summons scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Adam (from police view).
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Guess** (15 min) Why do police want him?
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A boy crying on a bed at dawn, a father in the doorway, a police car glinting outside the window: paint it in grey morning light.

- [ ] **Dawn** (35 min) Paint Ryan's room at dawn.
- [ ] **Police car** (25 min) Paint a police car in a driveway.
- [ ] **Gig poster** (20 min) Design Gribbel's band poster.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a 1970s story-song.
- [ ] **Doorway** (15 min) Draw Adam in the doorway.
- [ ] **Fan page** (15 min) Design a tiny fan page.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a crying child at dawn.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the police car.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Breakfast that never quite happens. Make a simple breakfast for a family in crisis, and notice how cooking can be a form of steadiness for children.

- [ ] **Crisis breakfast** (20 min) Make a simple breakfast for a family in crisis.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record Gabrielle's address.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Adam's anger.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what should children be told?
- [ ] **Making: comfort box** (20 min) Make a comfort box for a child.
- [ ] **Pancakes** (30 min) Make pancakes with a child.
- [ ] **Recipe of honesty** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Cocoa** (15 min) Make cocoa.
- [ ] **Toast** (15 min) Make toast and talk.

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The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam tells Ryan the truth: he doesn't know. Write privately about a time when someone admitted they didn't know, and how it felt to hear honesty instead of comfort.

- [ ] **Honest uncertainty** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Missing a parent** (20 min) Write about missing someone.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What awaits Adam?
- [ ] **Letter to Ryan** (15 min) Write to Ryan.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write as Ryan.
- [ ] **Anger** (15 min) Write about anger at someone loved.
- [ ] **Dawn** (15 min) Write about a bad dawn.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Honest Uncertainty

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Verdict.

Ryan

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Paint his room.
- [ ] Write as Ryan.
- [ ] Make a comfort box.
- [ ] Reflect.

Three Beats

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Diner

- [ ] Map beats.
- [ ] Pin escalation.
- [ ] Paint the car.
- [ ] Discuss.

Gribbel's Band

Rooms: Diner, Records Room, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Design a poster.
- [ ] Research the song.
- [ ] Party snacks.
- [ ] Play it.

The Summons

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Map jurisdiction.
- [ ] Debate going willingly.
- [ ] Predict.

Talking to Children

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Research advice.
- [ ] Read Gopnik.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write guidance.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 39 explore the value of honest uncertainty with children?
2. Essay: Analyse how the chapter moves from comedy to tenderness to dread.
3. Creative: Write Ryan's morning from his point of view.

Further reading

- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Parents and children in crisis.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). What children are told.
- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). What parents owe.
- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Truth for children.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Families and loss.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Family life.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Coben on suspicion falling on a man.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband under suspicion.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). A missing parent.

40. The Study on Park Avenue

What happens

Kuntz wakes in the hospital chair he privately compares to an interrogation cell. A nurse comes and goes. Texts from Larry Powers summon him to the family's Park Avenue apartment, where Larry's wife Laurie, old money in pearls, lets him in. Kuntz despises men who cheat. Larry's study looks like a superhero's lair; Larry is drinking cognac and crying.

The facts emerge. The IPO carries a morals clause covering adultery, because the product is marketed to Christians. Larry had used a sugar-baby website to meet college students, among them Kimberly Dann. After the strangers revealed something to Heidi, Kimberly emailed Larry: her mother had been murdered, apparently in a break-in. Larry is horrified; Kuntz is calm. He considered killing Kimberly too and decided it was too risky: two deaths with two different guns, four hundred miles apart, are not easily connected. The blackmailers must have found Larry through his credit card.

Kuntz lays out the chain he followed: Heidi told him about the couple; he got the Red Lobster video using fake credentials; the plate led to a rental under Lauren Barna; that led to Ingrid; a credit-card trace led to a roadside motel by the Delaware Water Gap. Larry begs: no more bloodshed. Kuntz reminds Larry that it was Larry who hurt his own wife, and that Larry's ignorance is his protection. Larry should keep his hands clean and play the shy CEO. Nothing will stop this IPO.

Scene by scene

1. Kuntz in the hospital chair; a nurse; Larry's texts.
2. Park Avenue; Laurie Powers in pearls.
3. Kuntz despises cheaters.
4. Larry's superhero-style study; cognac and tears.
5. The IPO's morals clause.
6. Larry's sugar-baby site use, including Kimberly Dann.
7. Kimberly's email: her mother was murdered.
8. Kuntz considered killing Kimberly; decided against it.
9. Two guns, four hundred miles apart.
10. The credit card: how the blackmailers found Larry.
11. Kuntz's chain from Heidi to the Water Gap motel.
12. Larry begs for no more bloodshed.
13. Kuntz: you hurt your wife; deniability; nothing will stop the IPO.

Who's here

John Kuntz	Fixer and killer.
Larry Powers	Founder; weeping, complicit.
Laurie Powers	Larry's wife, old money.
Kimberly Dann	Heidi's daughter (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. Where does Kuntz meet Larry?
2. What is the morals clause?
3. What did Larry do?
4. How is Kimberly connected?
5. How did Kuntz trace Ingrid?
6. What does Kuntz decide about Kimberly?
7. **Is Larry guilty of the murders?** [book club]
8. How does Kuntz justify himself?
9. **Why does Kuntz despise cheaters yet kill?** [book club]
10. What does the Batman-style study suggest about Larry?
11. **How does the chapter treat wealth?** [book club]
12. What does deniability protect?
13. How does the chapter change your view of the Heidi strand?
14. What does Heidi's secret turn out to involve?
15. Is Kimberly in danger?
16. How does the credit card betray Larry?
17. **What is the irony of a Christian app founder on a sugar-baby site?** [book club]
18. How does the chapter treat hypocrisy?
19. **Compare Kuntz's logic with the stranger's.** [book club]
20. What does Laurie know?
21. Why does Larry cry?
22. Who is more dangerous, Larry or Kuntz?
23. How does the chapter build horror calmly?
24. Why two guns?
25. How does the chapter treat young women?
26. What would justice for Heidi look like?
27. What does the reader now know that Adam doesn't?
28. How might Kuntz reach Adam?
29. **Is Kuntz a mirror of any other character?** [book club]
30. Predict what Kuntz does next.

Close reading

1. Wealth and contempt

Find it: Chapter 40, the Park Avenue arrival.

1. Describe the apartment.
2. Describe Laurie.
3. Note Kuntz's view of cheaters.
4. Describe the study.

How does the chapter set Kuntz's class resentment against the Powers' wealth?

2. Hypocrisy

Find it: Chapter 40, the confession of the facts.

1. Note the morals clause.
2. Note Larry's behaviour.
3. Note Kimberly.
4. Note the credit card.

How does the chapter expose layers of hypocrisy?

3. Method and menace

Find it: Chapter 40, close: Kuntz's chain and his warning.

1. Trace Kuntz's chain.
2. Note Larry's plea.
3. Note Kuntz's reply about Laurie.
4. Read the final resolve.

How does the chapter make Kuntz's calm the most frightening thing in it?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A villains' conference in a rich man's study. Kuntz's calm laying-out of his chain of reasoning parodies a detective's summing-up; Larry's tears parody remorse. The chapter answers the Heidi mystery while deepening the menace still ahead.

- ☐ **Parody summing-up** (20 min) Compare Kuntz's chain with a detective's.
- ☐ **Two men** (15 min) Contrast Kuntz and Larry.
- ☐ **Setting** (15 min) Analyse the study.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Larry's POV.
- ☐ **Scene** (30 min) Write a villains' conference.
- ☐ **Calm** (15 min) Analyse Kuntz's calm.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 31.
- ☐ **Revelation** (15 min) Map what is revealed.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the last line.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Hypocrisy (a faith-branded founder, a killer who disdains cheaters), deniability, wealth and the exploitation of young women. Larry's ignorance is chosen: he wants the benefits without the knowledge.

- ☐ **Hypocrisy** (25 min) Discuss layers of hypocrisy.
- ☐ **Deniability** (25 min) Discuss willful blindness.
- ☐ **Wealth** (20 min) Discuss wealth and impunity.
- ☐ **Exploitation** (20 min) Discuss sugar-baby sites.
- ☐ **Heidi** (20 min) Discuss what Heidi was protecting.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "deniability".
- ☐ **Morals clauses** (15 min) Discuss morality in contracts.
- ☐ **Class** (15 min) Discuss Kuntz's resentment.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Morals clauses appear in many endorsement and executive contracts. Sugar-baby sites have been criticised as exploitative. The Delaware Water Gap is a national recreation area on the NJ–PA border. Credit-card trails are a common investigative tool.

- [ ] **Morals clauses** (20 min) Research their use.
- [ ] **Sugar-baby sites** (20 min) Research criticism of such sites.
- [ ] **Water Gap** (15 min) Research the Delaware Water Gap.
- [ ] **Credit-card trails** (15 min) Research how investigators use them.
- [ ] **Park Avenue** (15 min) Research its history.
- [ ] **Willful blindness** (20 min) Research the legal doctrine.
- [ ] **IPO due diligence** (15 min) Research pre-IPO scrutiny.
- [ ] **Accessory liability** (20 min) Research accessory after the fact.
- [ ] **Cognac** (15 min) Research cognac.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Tom Wolfe's The Bonfire of the Vanities skewers Park Avenue privilege. Shakespeare's Macbeth explores deniability and blood that won't wash off. Larry wants his hands clean while someone else's are bloody.

- [ ] **Bonfire** (20 min) Read about Wolfe's Bonfire of the Vanities.
- [ ] **Macbeth** (20 min) Compare blood and hands.
- [ ] **Gatsby** (20 min) Compare wealth and violence.
- [ ] **Talented Mr Ripley** (20 min) Compare cool killers.
- [ ] **Kingpin** (20 min) Compare a founder and violence.
- [ ] **Sandel** (20 min) Read on markets and morals.
- [ ] **Kant** (20 min) Read on persons as ends.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about guilt.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

From Washington Heights to Park Avenue: a few miles of Manhattan and a world of difference. Kuntz's chain stretches to a roadside motel by the Delaware Water Gap, some four hundred miles from Heidi's Ohio suburb.

- [ ] **Manhattan** (15 min) Map Washington Heights to Park Avenue.
- [ ] **Water Gap** (15 min) Pin the motel area.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 40.
- [ ] **Chain map** (20 min) Map Kuntz's chain.
- [ ] **400 miles** (15 min) Draw the distance between killings.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Larry.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Kimberly, Larry, Heidi.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place the Powers family.
- [ ] **Class map** (15 min) Map class across Manhattan.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is Larry guilty? Willful blindness and benefiting from crime raise questions about moral and legal complicity. Kantian ethics condemns using people as means, which is all both men do.

- [ ] **Larry's guilt** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Larry.
- [ ] **Willful blindness** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Kimberly** (15 min) Who protects her?
- [ ] **Exploitation** (20 min) Debate sugar-baby sites.
- [ ] **Court** (20 min) Write charges for Kuntz and Larry.
- [ ] **Kuntz** (15 min) Is his sick son relevant to guilt?
- [ ] **Laurie** (15 min) Should she be told?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about chosen ignorance.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Major answers: Kuntz killed Heidi and Ingrid; Larry's link to Kimberly explains Heidi's secret; Kuntz's chain explains how he found Ingrid. Pin the whole chain.

- [ ] **Killer** (15 min) Pin Kuntz as killer.
- [ ] **Larry and Kimberly** (15 min) Pin the link.
- [ ] **Chain** (20 min) Pin Kuntz's chain.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word study scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Larry.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note convergence.
- [ ] **Answers** (15 min) List solved questions.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A wood-panelled study lit like a superhero's lair, a weeping man with cognac, a cold man standing: paint it with gold lamplight and a black window.

- [ ] **Study** (35 min) Paint the study.
- [ ] **Pearls** (20 min) Draw Laurie.
- [ ] **Window** (20 min) Paint Park Avenue at night.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a cold theme.
- [ ] **Cognac glass** (15 min) Draw the glass.
- [ ] **Chain diagram** (15 min) Design Kuntz's chain as art.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a rich silence.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the study.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Cognac in a crystal glass, poured by a man in tears. Luxury as a hiding place: the comforts of wealth make the horror sit more strangely.

- [ ] **Cognac** (15 min) Discuss luxury and guilt over a glass (or tea).
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the IPO's morals clause.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Larry's secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what is willful blindness?
- [ ] **Making: guilt map** (20 min) Map who knew what.
- [ ] **Park Avenue canapés** (30 min) Make small canapés.
- [ ] **Recipe of deniability** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Plain meal** (30 min) Cook a plain meal as contrast.
- [ ] **Coffee** (15 min) Make coffee and discuss.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Larry wants deniability: to benefit without knowing. Write privately about something you chose not to know because the knowing would cost you, and what it cost others.

- [ ] **Chosen ignorance** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Hypocrisy** (20 min) Write about a hypocrisy you've seen.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate horror.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What does Kuntz do next?
- [ ] **Letter to Kimberly** (15 min) Write to Kimberly.
- [ ] **Letter to Laurie** (15 min) Write to Laurie.
- [ ] **Wealth** (15 min) Write about wealth and safety.
- [ ] **Clean hands** (15 min) Write about clean hands.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Deniability

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Chain

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Pin the chain.
- [ ] Map it.
- [ ] Compare with detection.
- [ ] Discuss.

Park Avenue

Rooms: Diner, Library Stacks, Records Room

- [ ] Paint the study.
- [ ] Read Wolfe.
- [ ] Research.
- [ ] Present.

Kimberly

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Debate protection.
- [ ] Write to her.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Reflect.

Hypocrisy

Rooms: Room 233, Records Room, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Research morals clauses.
- [ ] Map who knew.
- [ ] Write.

Charges

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Incident Board, Records Room

- [ ] Draft charges.
- [ ] Research complicity.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Verdict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 40 explore hypocrisy and deniability?
2. Essay: Analyse Kuntz's chain of reasoning as a dark parody of detection.
3. Creative: Write Laurie Powers's view of the night.

Further reading

- *The Talented Mr. Ripley*, Patricia Highsmith (1955). A cool killer.
- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). A founder and violence.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Markets and morals.
- *On a Supposed Right to Lie from Philanthropy*, Immanuel Kant (1797). Persons as ends.
- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). Self-justifying murder.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online exploitation of women.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Data trails that betray.
- *All My Sons*, Arthur Miller (1947). A businessman's guilt.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben on wealth and violence.

41. Interview Room

What happens

Len assures Adam it isn't about the lacrosse money. Adam is driven to the Essex County sheriff's office in Newark in the back of a car with no inside handles. He is kept waiting an hour and has to ask to use the bathroom: the old tactics he once watched from the other side. Then in walks Johanna Griffin, early fifties, in an institutional-green trouser suit, with a shaggy haircut and a rawboned Midwestern manner.

She shows him a photo of Ingrid. Adam fences with semantics: he has never met her, technically. Johanna already knows about the $200 to Bonner and Rinsky's trace. She shows him a photo of Heidi Dann; Adam has never heard of her. Where is his wife? She raises the lacrosse theft. Then she lays down the photos of Ingrid's body, mutilated with a box cutter and shot in the head, and explains Heidi took a bullet to the knee before the fatal one. The chronology: Ingrid flew from Houston to Newark, stayed at an airport Courtyard Marriott, rented a car, visited the Legion Hall with a man, travelled to Beachwood, and was killed twelve to twenty-four hours later in a motel in Columbia, New Jersey, near the Delaware Water Gap.

Len has filled Johanna in on local gossip: marital trouble years ago, messages with Kristin Hoy, the meeting with Sally Perryman last night. Corinne's text, Johanna points out, is convenient; anyone could have sent it, including Adam. Adam, the former prosecutor, knows that words you never say can never be taken back. He stands to leave. On his way out he tells her to find the man in the cap: he is the key.

Scene by scene

1. Len: not about the lacrosse money.
2. A ride to Newark with no inside handles.
3. An hour's wait; a bathroom request: old tactics.
4. Johanna Griffin: green trouser suit, shaggy cut, Midwestern bearing.
5. Ingrid's photo; Adam's semantic dodge.
6. Johanna knows about Bonner and Rinsky.
7. Heidi Dann's photo; Adam doesn't know her.
8. Where's your wife? The lacrosse theft.
9. The murder photos and wounds.
10. Ingrid's chronology to a motel in Columbia, NJ.
11. Len's gossip: Kristin, Sally, old marital trouble.
12. The text is convenient: anyone could have sent it.
13. Adam leaves, saying: find the man; he's the key.

Who's here

Johanna Griffin	Interrogator, sharp and humane.
Adam Price	Suspect, lawyer, guarded.
Len Gilman	Source of gossip (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. Why is Adam taken to Newark?
2. What tactics are used on him?

3. Who is Johanna Griffin?
4. What does Johanna know already?
5. What happened to Ingrid?
6. What is Ingrid's chronology?
7. **Why does Adam fence with semantics?** [book club]
8. **Is Adam right to leave?** [book club]
9. What does the text's convenience imply?
10. **How does Len's gossip hurt Adam?** [book club]
11. **How does the chapter reverse Adam's old role as prosecutor?** [book club]
12. What does Adam's parting line reveal?
13. How does Johanna read Adam?
14. What does the car with no handles symbolise?
15. How does the chapter treat police methods?
16. Why show the murder photos?
17. How does the chapter join the strands for Adam?
18. Is Johanna fair?
19. How does Adam's marital history become evidence?
20. **What does it feel like to be suspected?** [book club]
21. How does the chapter use the Legion Hall again?
22. What should Adam tell the police?
23. Compare Johanna and Len.
24. Why does Adam not know Heidi?
25. What does the violence of Ingrid's murder suggest?
26. How does the chapter build pressure?
27. Is Adam behaving guiltily?
28. What is the effect of the reader knowing more than Johanna?
29. **What would you have done?** [book club]
30. Predict what Johanna does next.

Close reading

1. The other side of the table

Find it: Chapter 41, opening: the ride and the wait.

1. Note the car.
2. Note the wait.
3. Note the bathroom.
4. Note Adam's recognition.

How does the chapter use Adam's expertise to sharpen his discomfort?

2. Shock as technique

Find it: Chapter 41, middle: the photos.

1. Note each photo.
2. Note Adam's answers.
3. Note what Johanna knows.
4. Note the chronology.

How does Johanna use photographs?

3. Words unsaid

Find it: Chapter 41, close: the text and the exit.

1. Find Johanna's point about the text.
2. Paraphrase Adam's principle.
3. Note his exit line.
4. Note her reaction.

Why does Adam leave, and what does he give Johanna as he goes?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

An interrogation scene played as a chess match between professionals. Johanna's photographs are moves; Adam's semantics are defences. The chronology delivers the plot's facts while the gossip lays bare his marriage.

- ☐ **Chess match** (20 min) Analyse moves and defences.
- ☐ **Photos** (15 min) Analyse photos as technique.
- ☐ **Semantics** (15 min) Analyse Adam's dodges.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Johanna's POV.
- ☐ **Interrogation** (35 min) Write a 300-word interrogation.
- ☐ **Chronology** (15 min) Analyse the info dump.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 27.
- ☐ **Exit line** (15 min) Analyse the parting line.
- ☐ **Description** (15 min) Analyse Johanna's description.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Suspicion, rights, gossip and the private life as evidence. The novel shows how quickly a marriage's secrets turn into a case file, and how silence, though a right, looks like guilt.

- ☐ **Suspicion** (20 min) Discuss being suspected.
- ☐ **Rights** (25 min) Discuss the right to silence.
- ☐ **Gossip** (20 min) Discuss gossip as evidence.
- ☐ **Marriage as file** (20 min) Discuss.
- ☐ **Methods** (20 min) Discuss interrogation ethics.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "the file".
- ☐ **Reversal** (15 min) Discuss Adam's reversal.
- ☐ **Women victims** (20 min) Discuss the victims with care.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

US suspects in custody must be read Miranda rights (1966); voluntary interviews differ. Interrogation tactics, including the Reid technique, are widely criticised for producing false confessions. Spouses are often first suspects.

- [ ] **Miranda** (20 min) Research Miranda v. Arizona.
- [ ] **Reid technique** (20 min) Research its criticisms.
- [ ] **False confessions** (20 min) Research false confessions.
- [ ] **Columbia NJ** (15 min) Research the area.
- [ ] **Courtyard** (15 min) Research airport hotels.
- [ ] **Sheriffs** (15 min) Research NJ county sheriffs.
- [ ] **Multi-state cases** (15 min) Research cross-state cooperation.
- [ ] **Box cutters** (15 min) Research forensic wound analysis.
- [ ] **Alibis** (15 min) Research spousal alibis.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Coben's Tell No One also puts a husband in the interrogation room. Columbo episodes reverse the cat-and-mouse; Crime and Punishment's Porfiry Petrovich is fiction's great patient interrogator.

- [ ] **Tell No One** (20 min) Compare the husband in the room.
- [ ] **Porfiry** (20 min) Read about Crime and Punishment's interrogator.
- [ ] **Columbo** (15 min) Research the show's method.
- [ ] **Caught** (20 min) Compare a man under suspicion.
- [ ] **Gone Girl** (20 min) Compare a husband suspected.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare police and suspects.
- [ ] **Ekman** (20 min) Read on reading faces.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about judgment.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Newark, the airport Courtyard, Columbia near the Delaware Water Gap, Houston and Beachwood: Ingrid's last journey on one map, ending at a motel by the river. Draw it with care.

- [ ] **Ingrid's journey** (20 min) Map Houston to Columbia.
- [ ] **Newark** (15 min) Pin the sheriff's office.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 41.
- [ ] **Courtyard** (15 min) Pin the airport hotel.
- [ ] **Columbia** (15 min) Pin the motel.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add both murders.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Ingrid, Heidi, Adam.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Johanna.
- [ ] **Timeline map** (15 min) Annotate times.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Should Adam tell all? His rights and his family on one side; two murdered women on the other. The chapter makes withholding feel both rational and costly.

- [ ] **Withholding** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam's silence.
- [ ] **Rights** (35 min) Write 300 words on silence.
- [ ] **Gossip** (15 min) Was Len wrong to share it?
- [ ] **Methods** (15 min) Are Johanna's methods fair?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Adam file.
- [ ] **Text** (15 min) Who could have sent it?
- [ ] **Leaving** (15 min) Was leaving wise?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about being suspected.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Massive information dump: Ingrid's murder, wounds, chronology, the police theory. Johanna's suspicion of the text is a theory worth pinning: who could have sent it?

- [ ] **Ingrid** (15 min) Pin her murder.
- [ ] **Chronology** (20 min) Pin the timeline.
- [ ] **Text theory** (15 min) Pin the police theory.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word photo scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Adam from Johanna's view.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark the join.
- [ ] **Key** (15 min) Pin the man in the cap as the key.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A windowless interview room, a woman in green, photos face down on a table, a man standing to leave: paint it in flat fluorescent green-grey.

- [ ] **Interview room** (35 min) Paint the room.
- [ ] **Green suit** (20 min) Draw Johanna.
- [ ] **Face-down photos** (20 min) Paint photos on a table.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a tense theme.
- [ ] **No handles** (15 min) Draw the car door.
- [ ] **Map** (15 min) Design Ingrid's journey map.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a station waiting room.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the room.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Police-station coffee, offered as a tactic. Even hospitality can be a technique: a cup given to build rapport, or withheld to unsettle.

- [ ] **Station coffee** (15 min) Make bad coffee and discuss tactics.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the chronology.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Adam's withheld facts.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you talk to the police?
- [ ] **Making: rights card** (15 min) Write a rights card.
- [ ] **Vending snack** (15 min) Discuss vending food.
- [ ] **Recipe of an interrogation** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Comfort dinner** (40 min) Cook dinner after a hard day.
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea and talk.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam's private life became evidence in minutes. Write privately about how it would feel to have your own small secrets read aloud by a stranger in a cold room.

- [ ] **Secrets read aloud** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Suspected** (20 min) Write about being doubted.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate fear.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What next for Johanna?
- [ ] **Letter to Johanna** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Ingrid** (15 min) Write a memorial.
- [ ] **Silence** (15 min) Write about choosing silence.
- [ ] **Gossip** (15 min) Write about being gossiped about.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Interview Room

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse the chess match.
- [ ] Paint the room.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Rights

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Room 233

- [ ] Research Miranda.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

Ingrid's Last Journey

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Map it.
- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Write a memorial.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Text

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Law Office

- [ ] Pin the theory.
- [ ] Debate who sent it.
- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Predict.

Interrogators in Fiction

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Law Office

- [ ] Read about Porfiry.
- [ ] Research Columbo.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.

Gossip

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Debate Len.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 41 dramatise the reversal of Adam from prosecutor to suspect?
2. Essay: Analyse how private life becomes evidence in the interrogation.
3. Creative: Write Johanna's notes after the interview.

Further reading

- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband interrogated.
- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). The patient interrogator.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). A man under suspicion.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). A husband suspected by police and public.
- *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman (1985). Reading faces and lies.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Police and suspects.

- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Gossip and reputation.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Reputation in records.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A woman investigator at work.

42. So Hum

What happens

Adam takes an Uber to Fair Lawn, where Gabrielle Dunbar lives, a once-modest Cape Cod swollen into a McMansion, with an elaborate doorbell; Gribbel will collect him later. Adam tries a pretext about an inheritance case. Gabrielle denies everything and begins to panic. Adam drops the act: his wife is missing, and he will not stop looking. Tell him that.

Alone, Gabrielle tries to calm herself with the mantra So Hum. Her children, Missy and Paul, will soon need dropping at their father's; her ex calls her Gabs and has moved to Chicago with a woman called Tami. She had always known the group was playing with fire. People kill for secrets. She curls up on the floor, thumb at her mouth.

Then she pulls herself together. She uses the VPN as instructed. She concludes that Adam must have killed Ingrid: a man who can't handle the truth. She takes out the Glock that Merton gave her, after teaching her to shoot at a range in Randolph. Then she photographs a card on which she has written two words, HE KNOWS, and emails it.

Scene by scene

1. Uber to Fair Lawn; a McMansion grown from a Cape Cod.
2. An elaborate doorbell.
3. Adam's inheritance pretext; Gabrielle denies and panics.
4. Adam: my wife is missing; tell him I won't stop.
5. Gabrielle's So Hum mantra.
6. Her kids Missy and Paul; her ex in Chicago with Tami.
7. People kill for secrets.
8. Curled on the floor, thumb to mouth.
9. VPN; she decides Adam killed Ingrid.
10. A Glock from Merton; shooting lessons in Randolph.
11. She emails a photo of a card: HE KNOWS.

Who's here

Gabrielle Dunbar	Group member; mother; terrified.
Adam Price	Direct at last.
Missy and Paul	Gabrielle's children (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. How does Adam get to Gabrielle's?
2. What pretext does he use?
3. What does Adam tell her?
4. What is So Hum?
5. Why does Gabrielle think Adam killed Ingrid?
6. What does she send, and to whom?
7. **How does the chapter make Gabrielle sympathetic?** [book club]
8. **Is her conclusion about Adam reasonable?** [book club]
9. What does the McMansion tell us?
10. Why does Adam drop the pretext?

11. **How does fear change people?** [book club]
12. What does the gun mean in her hands?
13. Why did Merton give her a gun?
14. How does the chapter treat the ex-husband?
15. What does the thumb-sucking image suggest?
16. How does the chapter switch POV?
17. Is the group unravelling?
18. What does HE KNOWS mean to the group?
19. What will the group do with that message?
20. How does the chapter build danger for Adam?
21. **What does the chapter say about mothers in danger?** [book club]
22. How do misunderstandings drive the plot here?
23. Was Adam reckless?
24. What does a mantra offer in crisis?
25. **How does the novel treat guns?** [book club]
26. Compare Gabrielle and Suzanne.
27. What does she fear most: Adam, police, or exposure?
28. How does the chapter use children offstage?
29. **Would you have gone to her door?** [book club]
30. Predict what HE KNOWS triggers.

Close reading

1. Swollen houses

Find it: Chapter 42, opening: the house and the door.

1. Describe the house.
2. Note the doorbell.
3. Note the pretext.
4. Note her panic.

How does the setting reflect Gabrielle's life?

2. Fear from inside

Find it: Chapter 42, middle: So Hum.

1. Note the mantra.
2. Note the children and ex.
3. Paraphrase her fear about secrets.
4. Note her posture.

How does the chapter make us feel Gabrielle's terror?

3. Misreading

Find it: Chapter 42, close: the gun and the card.

1. Note the VPN.
2. Note her conclusion.
3. Note the gun's origin.
4. Note the message.

How does a misreading become dangerous?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter that changes POV mid-scene, from Adam at the door to Gabrielle alone. Dramatic irony is intense: we know Adam isn't the killer; Gabrielle doesn't. Two words on a card turn misunderstanding into a threat to Adam's life.

- [ ] **POV switch** (20 min) Analyse the mid-scene switch.
- [ ] **Dramatic irony** (15 min) Analyse what we know that she doesn't.
- [ ] **Two words** (15 min) Analyse the card.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite the door scene from Gabrielle's POV.
- [ ] **Scene** (30 min) Write a misreading scene.
- [ ] **Mantra** (15 min) Analyse So Hum.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 36.
- [ ] **Setting** (15 min) Analyse the McMansion.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the email.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Fear, misreading and the violence that grows from assumption. The group's philosophy of exposure has a cost they never priced: people do kill for secrets, as Gabrielle now realises.

- [ ] **Misreading** (25 min) Discuss fear and assumption.
- [ ] **Cost of exposure** (25 min) Discuss the group's blind spot.
- [ ] **Guns** (20 min) Discuss guns and fear.
- [ ] **Mothers** (15 min) Discuss Gabrielle as a mother.
- [ ] **Mantras** (15 min) Discuss coping.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "misreading".
- [ ] **Suburbs** (15 min) Discuss McMansions.
- [ ] **Danger** (15 min) Discuss danger to Adam.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

So Hum is a Sanskrit mantra used in breath meditation. McMansion is a pejorative coined in the 1980s. VPNs mask location. The Glock 19 is one of the best-selling handguns in the US.

- [ ] **So Hum** (15 min) Research the mantra.
- [ ] **McMansions** (15 min) Research the term.
- [ ] **VPNs** (15 min) Research VPN use.
- [ ] **Glock** (15 min) Research the Glock 19.
- [ ] **Gun ranges** (20 min) Research NJ ranges and permits.
- [ ] **NJ gun law** (20 min) Research NJ handgun permits.
- [ ] **Cape Cod style** (15 min) Research the style.
- [ ] **Fear response** (20 min) Research fear and decision-making.
- [ ] **Custody** (15 min) Research weekend custody.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Shirley Jackson's We Have Always Lived in the Castle and Daphne du Maurier's My Cousin Rachel both turn on misreading a stranger's intent. Fear makes interpretation dangerous.

- [ ] **Castle** (20 min) Read about Shirley Jackson.
- [ ] **My Cousin Rachel** (20 min) Compare misreading.
- [ ] **Rebecca** (20 min) Compare fear in a house.
- [ ] **Kahneman** (20 min) Read on fast thinking under fear.
- [ ] **Ronson** (20 min) Read on exposure.
- [ ] **Big Little Lies** (20 min) Compare suburban mothers.
- [ ] **Fool Me Once** (20 min) Compare guns at home.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about fear.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Fair Lawn, a Bergen County borough; a range in Randolph, Morris County; an ex in Chicago. Gabrielle's small world stretches between motherhood and a secret life.

- [ ] **Fair Lawn** (15 min) Pin the house.
- [ ] **Randolph** (15 min) Pin the range.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 42.
- [ ] **Chicago** (15 min) Pin the ex.
- [ ] **Uber** (15 min) Trace Adam's route.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Gabrielle and Merton.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Message** (15 min) Trace the email.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is Gabrielle's fear reasonable? From her information, yes; from ours, no. The chapter asks how much moral blame attaches to acting on a reasonable but false belief.

- [ ] **Reasonable fear** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Gabrielle.
- [ ] **False belief** (35 min) Write 300 words on blame and false belief.
- [ ] **Adam's visit** (15 min) Was it wise?
- [ ] **Gun** (15 min) Should she have a gun?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the group file.
- [ ] **Message** (15 min) Is HE KNOWS a threat?
- [ ] **Children** (15 min) What about Missy and Paul?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about misjudging.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

HE KNOWS is a turning point: the group now sees Adam as a threat. Pin the message, the gun and the misreading. Danger has moved to Adam.

- [ ] **HE KNOWS** (15 min) Pin the message.
- [ ] **Gun** (15 min) Pin the Glock.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word card scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Danger** (15 min) Pin danger to Adam.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A swollen suburban house, a woman curled on a kitchen floor, a gun on the counter, a card on the table: paint it with harsh overhead light and long shadows.

- [ ] **Kitchen floor** (35 min) Paint the scene.
- [ ] **Swollen house** (25 min) Draw the McMansion.
- [ ] **Card** (15 min) Design the HE KNOWS card.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a fearful theme.
- [ ] **Doorbell** (15 min) Draw the elaborate doorbell.
- [ ] **Mantra** (15 min) Letter So Hum.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a doorbell chime.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the card.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

A kitchen where no one eats: a place of fear, not nourishment. Gabrielle's kitchen shows how terror empties ordinary rooms of their purpose.

- [ ] **Empty kitchen** (15 min) Discuss kitchens emptied by fear.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record HE KNOWS.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the gun.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: when has fear misled you?
- [ ] **Making: calm tea** (15 min) Make a calming tea and breathe.
- [ ] **Breathing** (15 min) Try a simple breathing exercise.
- [ ] **Recipe of panic** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Kid's lunch** (15 min) Make a school lunch.
- [ ] **Simple supper** (40 min) Cook a steadying supper.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Gabrielle misreads Adam completely and acts on it. Write privately about a time fear made you misjudge someone, and what happened when you discovered your mistake.

- [ ] **Misjudged** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Panic** (20 min) Write about a panic.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate fear.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will the group do?
- [ ] **Letter to Gabrielle** (15 min) Write to her.
- [ ] **Letter to her kids** (15 min) Write as Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Mantra** (15 min) Write your own mantra.
- [ ] **Fire** (15 min) Write about playing with fire.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Misreading

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse irony.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Reflect.

HE KNOWS

Rooms: Incident Board, Diner, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Design the card.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Predict.

Gabrielle

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Paint her kitchen.
- [ ] Write to her.
- [ ] Read Jackson.
- [ ] Discuss.

Guns and Fear

Rooms: Records Room, Lacrosse Field, Room 233

- [ ] Research NJ law.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Verdict.

So Hum

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Records Room, Driveway

- [ ] Breathe.
- [ ] Research the mantra.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Fair Lawn

Rooms: Turnpike, Diner, Incident Board

- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Draw the house.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Present.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 42 use dramatic irony to create danger?
2. Essay: Analyse Gabrielle's fear and its consequences.
3. Creative: Write Gabrielle's evening after sending the card.

Further reading

- *Rebecca*, Daphne du Maurier (1938). Fear in a house.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). The costs of exposure.
- *Big Little Lies*, Liane Moriarty (2014). Suburban mothers and secrets.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Guns in suburban homes.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). Exposure and its victims.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online harms.
- *The Lottery*, Shirley Jackson (1948). Fear and community.
- *Shelter*, Harlan Coben (2011). Coben's misread strangers.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). Masks dropped.

Chapter 43 of 56 · told through Adam

43. Behind the Bleachers

What happens

Adam watches Thomas's lacrosse practice from behind the bleachers by the new artificial turf, where no one will notice him. Parents call this living the dream. Adam thinks dreams are fragile things, and that everyone here is about to wake up.

He drives Thomas home to shower; Ryan is at his friend Max's, and his text reply is a two-letter shorthand for no problem. In the car Adam tells the boys, as carefully as he can, that the police are now involved. He tells them this isn't like their mother. The boys absorb it in their different ways.

At home, a woman is sitting on the front step. It's Johanna Griffin. She is out of her jurisdiction, she says; tonight she's just Johanna. Then she tells him: they have found his wife's car.

Scene by scene

1. Adam watches practice unseen from behind the bleachers.
2. The new turf; parents living the dream.
3. Adam's thought: dreams are fragile; waking is coming.
4. Driving Thomas home; Ryan at Max's; a two-letter text.
5. Adam tells the boys the police are involved.
6. This isn't like her.
7. Johanna on the front step, out of jurisdiction.
8. They've found Corinne's car.

Who's here

Adam Price	Watching, then telling.
Thomas Price	At practice.
Ryan Price	At a friend's.
Johanna Griffin	On the step, informal.

Thirty questions

1. Where does Adam watch practice from?
2. What does he think about dreams?
3. What does he tell the boys?
4. How does Ryan reply to his text?
5. Who is on the step?
6. What news does she bring?
7. **Why does Adam watch from hiding?** [book club]
8. **How does the novel use the dream motif here?** [book club]
9. **Is telling the boys right?** [book club]
10. Why does Johanna say she's just Johanna?
11. What does the car's discovery mean?
12. How does the chapter shift tone?
13. What does the turf represent?
14. How do the boys react?
15. What does the abbreviation show about Ryan?
16. How does the chapter compare to chapter 1?
17. What is the significance of the step?
18. Why does Johanna come in person?
19. How does the chapter use cliffhangers?
20. **Is Adam isolated from the community now?** [book club]
21. How do parents talk about youth sport?
22. What is waking up from the dream?

23. How does Adam protect the boys?
24. What do you think the car will reveal?
25. How does the chapter treat waiting?
26. **What would you tell your children?** [book club]
27. What does the bleacher position symbolise?
28. **How does the chapter treat practice as normality?** [book club]
29. What does Johanna risk by coming?
30. Predict where the car was found.

Close reading

1. Watching unseen

Find it: Chapter 43, opening: behind the bleachers.

1. Note where Adam stands.
2. Note the turf.
3. Paraphrase the dream thought.
4. Note his mood.

How does the opening turn Adam into an outsider in his own town?

2. Telling

Find it: Chapter 43, middle: the car ride.

1. Note Ryan's text.
2. Note what Adam says.
3. Note his phrasing.
4. Note the boys' reactions.

How carefully does Adam tell the truth?

3. A visitor

Find it: Chapter 43, close: Johanna on the step.

1. Describe her.
2. Note her disclaimer.
3. Note the news.
4. Read the last line.

Why does the chapter end on the car?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A short chapter built around watching from hiding and a visitor at the door. The dream motif returns in its darkest form: everyone is about to wake. The ending line pivots the plot from waiting to evidence.

- ☐ **Watching unseen** (15 min) Analyse the bleachers position.
- ☐ **Dream motif** (20 min) Trace the dream motif.

- [ ] **Visitor** (15 min) Analyse the visitor at the door.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Thomas's POV.
- [ ] **Scene** (30 min) Write a car-ride conversation.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the last line.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 39.
- [ ] **Tone** (15 min) Map tone shifts.
- [ ] **Text** (15 min) Analyse Ryan's text.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

The fragility of dreams, the duty to tell children, and the outsider within his own community. Adam now sees Cedarfield from behind the bleachers, a literal and figurative position.

- [ ] **Fragile dreams** (25 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Telling children** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Outsider** (20 min) Discuss Adam's position.
- [ ] **Youth sport** (20 min) Discuss parents and sport.
- [ ] **Alliance** (15 min) Discuss Adam and Johanna.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "waking".
- [ ] **Normality** (15 min) Discuss practice as normal life.
- [ ] **Jurisdiction** (15 min) Discuss informal policing.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Artificial turf fields have spread through US high schools. The phrase American Dream was popularised by historian James Truslow Adams in 1931. Text abbreviations are a recognised feature of teen digital writing.

- [ ] **Turf** (15 min) Research artificial turf.
- [ ] **American Dream** (15 min) Research James Truslow Adams.
- [ ] **Texting** (15 min) Research teen texting.
- [ ] **Abandoned cars** (20 min) Research how police find abandoned cars.
- [ ] **Jurisdiction** (15 min) Research out-of-state officers.
- [ ] **Lacrosse practice** (15 min) Research a typical practice.
- [ ] **Bleachers** (15 min) Research school sports facilities.
- [ ] **Telling kids** (20 min) Research talking to teens about police.
- [ ] **Turf costs** (15 min) Research turf field costs.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The Great Gatsby ends with the dream behind us; John Cheever's The Swimmer shows a suburban dream dissolving. Adam's thought about waking belongs to that tradition.

- [ ] **Gatsby** (20 min) Compare the dream.
- [ ] **The Swimmer** (20 min) Compare a dissolving dream.

- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare suburban hopes.
- [ ] **Sportswriter** (20 min) Compare sport and loss.
- [ ] **Friday Night Lights** (20 min) Read about Bissinger's book.
- [ ] **Hold Tight** (20 min) Compare teens and police.
- [ ] **Didion** (20 min) Read on waking.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about dreams.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The new turf field, Max's house, the front step: Cedarfield's small routes. The car's discovery will soon pull the map outward again, to wherever it was found.

- [ ] **Field** (15 min) Pin the turf field.
- [ ] **Max's** (15 min) Pin Ryan's friend.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 43.
- [ ] **Step** (15 min) Mark the front step.
- [ ] **Car** (15 min) Guess where the car was found.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the car.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Johanna to Adam.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Adam outside.
- [ ] **Routes** (15 min) Map the drive home.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Was telling the boys right? A cautious truth respects them but frightens them. The novel keeps weighing these choices, and so should we.

- [ ] **Telling** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to telling the boys.
- [ ] **Dreams** (35 min) Write 300 words on fragile dreams.
- [ ] **Informality** (15 min) Is Johanna's visit proper?
- [ ] **Watching** (15 min) Is hidden watching wrong?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Corinne file.
- [ ] **Protection** (15 min) How should Adam protect the boys?
- [ ] **Trust** (15 min) Should Adam trust Johanna?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about sensing change.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Corinne's car found: a major development. Johanna's informal visit signals an alliance forming outside official channels. Pin both.

- [ ] **Car** (15 min) Pin the car.
- [ ] **Johanna** (15 min) Pin the alliance.

- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word doorstep scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note convergence.
- [ ] **Evidence** (15 min) What could the car show?
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

Bleachers at dusk from behind, boys on bright green turf under floodlights, a man in shadow: paint it with stadium glare and deep shade.

- [ ] **Bleachers** (35 min) Paint from behind the bleachers.
- [ ] **Floodlights** (25 min) Paint turf under floodlights.
- [ ] **Step** (20 min) Paint a woman on a step.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for waking.
- [ ] **Text bubble** (15 min) Design Ryan's text.
- [ ] **Turf** (15 min) Draw new turf.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe practice from afar.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the bleachers.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Post-practice hunger, dinner deferred by a visitor. Boys need feeding whatever happens, and that small duty keeps a household going through a crisis.

- [ ] **Post-practice dinner** (45 min) Cook a hearty dinner for hungry teens.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the car.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the car.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: when did you wake from a dream?
- [ ] **Making: snack bag** (15 min) Pack a practice snack bag.
- [ ] **Coffee for a guest** (15 min) Make coffee for Johanna.
- [ ] **Recipe of waking** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Pasta** (25 min) Make quick pasta.
- [ ] **Sports drink** (15 min) Make a homemade sports drink.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam feels that everyone is about to wake from the dream. Write privately about a time you sensed a comfortable life was about to change, before anyone else did.

- [ ] **Sensing change** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Watching** (20 min) Write about watching a child unseen.

- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Where was the car?
- [ ] **Letter to the boys** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Johanna** (15 min) Write.
- [ ] **Dreams** (15 min) Write about a dream ending.
- [ ] **Outsider** (15 min) Write about feeling outside.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Dream

Rooms: Room 233, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Trace the motif.
- [ ] Read Gatsby.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Discuss.

Behind the Bleachers

Rooms: Diner, Law Office, Turnpike

- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Present.

Telling the Boys

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Car

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Guess the location.
- [ ] Analyse the ending.
- [ ] Predict.

Practice Night

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Cook.
- [ ] Discuss sport.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Johanna Arrives

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board

- [ ] Analyse her entrance.
- [ ] Debate trust.
- [ ] Pin the alliance.
- [ ] Predict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 43 develop the novel's dream motif?
2. Essay: Analyse Adam's position behind the bleachers as an image of his isolation.
3. Creative: Write the car ride from Thomas's point of view.

Further reading

- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A dream that fails a family.
- *The Swimmer*, John Cheever (1964). A suburban dream dissolving.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Suburban hopes.
- *The Sportswriter*, Richard Ford (1986). Sport and loss.
- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Teens and police.
- *Scorecasting*, Tobias J. Moskowitz & L. Jon Wertheim (2011). The economics of youth sport.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Children's schedules and class.
- *Born to Run*, Bruce Springsteen (2016). Running and dreams.
- *Independence Day*, Richard Ford (1995). A father and son in a changing world.

44. Off the Record

What happens

The boys cook pasta and frozen vegetables. Johanna confesses: she isn't a New Jersey cop at all. She's the police chief of Beachwood, Ohio, here on her own money, working through contacts in Bergen and Essex counties. The county back home is furious and has taken her off the case. Heidi was her friend. Corinne's car, she tells Adam, was found at an airport hotel in Newark and has been towed back to his house. Adam says that makes no sense: Corinne went to Pittsburgh, and they always use the airport's own car park. Johanna swears on Heidi's soul she won't use anything against them.

So Adam tells her everything. He believes Corinne faked the pregnancy because he had made her feel insecure. In midlife they had drifted: logistics, schedules, growing apart. He didn't feel like a real man. Sally looked at him the way Corinne once had. He went to Sally's house instead of the office, and didn't tell Corinne. He wanted to kiss her, though he didn't. Johanna jokes that she can't help what she'd want if a certain Australian movie star offered a sponge bath; wanting isn't the crime. But Corinne called Sally, not him. Adam admits the pregnancy brought him back. It worked.

Johanna says it plainly: Corinne manipulated him. He didn't see the light; someone shone a torch in his eyes. Adam says he can't imagine life without her, and remembers a blue-and-yellow rug bought from an antiques shop in Warwick on an apple-picking day in October. Johanna understands: her husband snores like a helicopter, and she'd feel the same. She points out that the stranger told Adam he was doing it for him, and that Heidi never faked a pregnancy. She knows someone who might know what Heidi's secret was.

Scene by scene

1. The boys cook pasta and frozen veg.
2. Johanna's confession: Beachwood, Ohio; her own money; off the case.
3. Corinne's car found at an airport hotel in Newark, towed home.
4. Adam: it makes no sense; Pittsburgh; the airport lot.
5. Johanna swears on Heidi's soul.
6. Adam tells everything, including Sally.
7. Midlife drift; wanting, not kissing.
8. Johanna's movie-star joke: wanting isn't a crime.
9. The pregnancy brought him back.
10. Johanna: she manipulated you; a torch in your eyes.
11. The Warwick rug; the helicopter snoring.
12. The stranger said he did it for Adam; Heidi wasn't faking a pregnancy.
13. Johanna knows someone who might know.

Who's here

Adam Price	Confessing.
Johanna Griffin	Confessor and ally.
Thomas and Ryan	Cooking dinner.

Thirty questions

1. What does Johanna confess?
2. Where was Corinne's car found?
3. Why does that make no sense to Adam?
4. What does Adam confess?
5. How does Johanna respond?
6. What is the Warwick rug memory?
7. **Is Johanna right that Corinne manipulated Adam?** [book club]
8. **Was Adam's near-affair a betrayal?** [book club]
9. How does the boys' cooking frame the scene?
10. Why does Johanna use humour?
11. **What does the torch image mean?** [book club]
12. How do both confessions build trust?
13. What does Johanna risk?
14. Why does Adam think the car location is wrong?
15. What does the stranger's "for him" suggest?
16. What do we learn about Heidi?
17. **How does the chapter treat midlife?** [book club]
18. **Is wanting different from doing?** [book club]
19. How does the chapter treat love that survives?
20. What does the snoring detail say about marriage?
21. How does the chapter create intimacy between strangers?
22. Why does Adam trust Johanna now?
23. Is Adam too hard on himself?
24. How does Johanna's outsider status help?
25. What does the car location suggest about who left it?
26. How does the chapter re-read the whole marriage?
27. **What is the moral centre of this chapter?** [book club]
28. Who might Johanna's source be?
29. How does the chapter shift the plot?
30. Predict what Johanna learns next.

Close reading

1. Trust by exposure

Find it: Chapter 44, opening: Johanna's confession.

1. Note what she admits.
2. Note her oath.
3. Note the car news.
4. Note Adam's objection.

Why does Johanna go first?

2. The marriage, honestly

Find it: Chapter 44, middle: Adam's confession.

1. Summarise the drift.
2. Note Sally.
3. Note Johanna's joke.
4. Note Adam's admission about the pregnancy.

What does Adam finally admit about himself?

3. Love in details

Find it: Chapter 44, close: the rug and the snoring.

1. Note the torch image.
2. Describe the rug memory.
3. Note Johanna's parallel.
4. Note the final lead.

How does the chapter balance judgment with tenderness?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter of paired confessions in which trust is built by exposure. Johanna's jokes keep it humane; the rug and the snoring husband make love concrete. The torch image is the chapter's sharpest metaphor: manipulation as dazzling, not illuminating.

- ☐ **Paired confessions** (20 min) Analyse the structure.
- ☐ **Torch image** (15 min) Analyse the metaphor.
- ☐ **Humour** (15 min) Analyse Johanna's jokes.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Johanna's POV.
- ☐ **Confession scene** (35 min) Write a mutual confession.
- ☐ **Rug** (15 min) Analyse the rug memory.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 41.
- ☐ **Frame** (15 min) Analyse the boys cooking.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the lead.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Midlife drift, desire versus action, manipulation and love. The chapter finally lets Adam say the uncomfortable thing: Corinne's lie worked, and he was part of why she told it.

- ☐ **Midlife** (25 min) Discuss midlife drift.
- ☐ **Wanting vs doing** (25 min) Discuss.
- ☐ **Manipulation** (25 min) Discuss the fake pregnancy.
- ☐ **Trust** (15 min) Discuss trust by exposure.
- ☐ **Objects** (15 min) Discuss objects that hold love.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "torchlight".
- ☐ **Responsibility** (20 min) Discuss Adam's responsibility.
- ☐ **Outsiders** (15 min) Discuss Johanna as outsider.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Out-of-state police have no authority in another state. Warwick, NY, is known for orchards and antiques. Research on the U-shaped happiness curve suggests midlife dips in wellbeing.

- [ ] **Jurisdiction** (15 min) Research out-of-state police limits.
- [ ] **Warwick** (15 min) Research Warwick, NY.
- [ ] **Happiness curve** (20 min) Research the U-curve.
- [ ] **Airport hotels** (15 min) Research airport hotel parking.
- [ ] **Towing** (15 min) Research police towing of found cars.
- [ ] **Apple picking** (15 min) Research Hudson Valley orchards.
- [ ] **Antiques** (15 min) Research antique rugs.
- [ ] **Couples therapy** (20 min) Research midlife couples therapy.
- [ ] **Snoring** (15 min) Research snoring and marriage.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Esther Perel's Mating in Captivity explores desire and domesticity. Anne Tyler's novels, such as The Amateur Marriage, chart marriages drifting apart through logistics.

- [ ] **Mating in Captivity** (20 min) Read about Perel.
- [ ] **Amateur Marriage** (20 min) Read about Anne Tyler.
- [ ] **Gottman** (20 min) Read on turning towards.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare drift.
- [ ] **Dollhouse** (20 min) Compare a marriage reconsidered.
- [ ] **Husband's Secret** (20 min) Compare confession.
- [ ] **Didion** (20 min) Read on marriage and memory.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a long marriage.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

An airport hotel in Newark rather than the airport lot; Pittsburgh; Warwick, NY, and an October orchard; Beachwood, Ohio, behind Johanna. The car's location is a clue on the map.

- [ ] **Airport hotel** (15 min) Pin the hotel.
- [ ] **Airport lot** (15 min) Pin the usual lot.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 44.
- [ ] **Warwick** (15 min) Pin the orchard trip.
- [ ] **Beachwood** (15 min) Pin Johanna's home.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the car location.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Johanna's source.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Johanna.
- [ ] **Discrepancy** (15 min) Map the car discrepancy.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Manipulation or rescue? Kantian ethics condemns deceiving someone to change their behaviour; consequentialism notes it worked. The chapter refuses an easy verdict.

- [ ] **Manipulation** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Corinne's lie.
- [ ] **Desire** (35 min) Write 300 words on wanting vs doing.
- [ ] **Oath** (15 min) Will Johanna keep her oath?
- [ ] **Johanna** (15 min) Is her private investigation right?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Corinne file.
- [ ] **Responsibility** (15 min) How much is Adam to blame?
- [ ] **Forgiveness** (15 min) Should Adam forgive?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about an object of love.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Key clue: the car at an airport hotel, not the usual lot. Someone may have placed it there. Also: Heidi's secret was different, and Johanna has a lead.

- [ ] **Car** (15 min) Pin the car discrepancy.
- [ ] **Heidi** (15 min) Pin that Heidi's secret differs.
- [ ] **Lead** (15 min) Pin Johanna's source.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word confession scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark the alliance.
- [ ] **Theory** (15 min) Who moved the car?
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A kitchen with two boys at the stove, a man and a woman talking low at the table, a blue-and-yellow rug underfoot: paint warmth inside a crisis.

- [ ] **Kitchen table** (35 min) Paint the scene.
- [ ] **Rug** (25 min) Design a blue-and-yellow rug.
- [ ] **Orchard** (30 min) Paint an October orchard.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for midlife.
- [ ] **Torch** (15 min) Paint dazzle.
- [ ] **Boys cooking** (15 min) Draw the boys.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a helicopter snore.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the rug.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Pasta and frozen vegetables made by teenage boys: the kitchen keeps working. Cook the simplest dinner with whoever is around and notice how ordinary care continues.

- [ ] **Boys' pasta** (25 min) Cook pasta and frozen veg with teens.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the car location.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Adam's confession.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: is wanting a betrayal?
- [ ] **Making: memory object** (20 min) Bring an object and tell its story.
- [ ] **Apple crumble** (50 min) Bake an apple crumble.
- [ ] **Recipe of a marriage** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Cider** (15 min) Make hot cider.
- [ ] **Coffee for two** (15 min) Make coffee and talk late.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam remembers buying a rug on an apple-picking day. Write privately about a small object that holds a whole relationship, and why you keep it.

- [ ] **Object** (20 min) Write about an object of love.
- [ ] **Drift** (20 min) Write about drifting from someone.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Who is Johanna's source?
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Johanna** (15 min) Write thanks.
- [ ] **Wanting** (15 min) Write about wanting.
- [ ] **Torchlight** (15 min) Write about being dazzled.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Paired Confessions

Rooms: Law Office, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse structure.
- [ ] Discuss trust.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Rug

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Design the rug.
- [ ] Write about an object.
- [ ] Bake crumble.
- [ ] Share.

Manipulation or Rescue

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Read Perel.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Car

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Records Room

- [ ] Pin the discrepancy.
- [ ] Map it.
- [ ] Research airport hotels.
- [ ] Theorise.

Midlife

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Research the U-curve.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Johanna

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Diner

- [ ] Analyse her role.
- [ ] Debate her methods.
- [ ] Paint her.
- [ ] Present.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 44 use paired confessions to build trust and reinterpret the Price marriage?
2. Essay: Analyse Johanna's torch image and its judgment of Corinne.
3. Creative: Write the apple-picking day when the rug was bought.

Further reading

- *Mating in Captivity*, Esther Perel (2006). Desire and domesticity.
- *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work*, John M. Gottman & Nan Silver (1999). Turning towards in marriage.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Midlife drift.
- *The Husband's Secret*, Liane Moriarty (2013). Confessions in marriage.
- *A Doll's House*, Henrik Ibsen (1879). A marriage reconsidered.
- *The State of Affairs*, Esther Perel (2017). Emotional infidelity.
- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Deception and its justifications.
- *On a Supposed Right to Lie from Philanthropy*, Immanuel Kant (1797). Deception and respect.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A husband's enduring love.

45. He Knows

What happens

Chris Taylor reflects on the Price job. It was different: it was for hire. A top-level investigation firm, a third party, had paid them; no blackmail was involved. Eduardo had pushed the group to take for-hire work: a firm puts out a name, and Eduardo searches the databanks. Corinne's name came up through Fake-A-Pregnancy. But Corinne never got the choice the group usually offers: pay to keep the secret, or have it revealed. Either way, the group profits or the victim finds catharsis. Corinne got neither. Chris knows that wasn't right.

His conviction is that exposure kills a secret outright, and that secrets grow inside people like tumours. His conviction has a source. At sixteen, after a car accident, Chris needed blood, and his father, trying to donate, learned that he was not Chris's biological father; his mother had had a fling before the wedding. Chris felt his whole life was a lie. His father tried to carry on as before, but the lie festered, and Chris has not seen him in three years. Later, working at Downing Place, Chris saw Fake-A-Pregnancy's sales up close and its competitors. From the man who raised him he took a modest motto about mending things person by person.

There were five at the core, Chris included. Eduardo wanted to do everything online; Chris insisted on face-to-face revelations, out of compassion. Now Chris has his own secret. Is keeping it protection, or just rationalising? Gabrielle's message arrives: HE KNOWS. Chris decides that Adam Price has to be stopped.

Scene by scene

1. The Price job was for hire, paid by an investigation firm.
2. Eduardo pushed for for-hire work; databanks; Corinne via Fake-A-Pregnancy.
3. Corinne never got the usual choice: pay or be revealed.
4. Chris knows that wasn't right.
5. His creed: exposure kills a secret; secrets grow like tumours.
6. Backstory: at sixteen, a car accident and a blood test.
7. His father learns he isn't Chris's biological father.
8. The lie festers; three years without contact.
9. Downing Place and Fake-A-Pregnancy.
10. Mending the world person by person: his father's lesson.
11. The core five; face-to-face out of compassion.
12. Chris's own secret: protection or rationalisation?
13. HE KNOWS arrives; Adam must be stopped.

Who's here

Chris Taylor	The stranger, founder, true believer.
Eduardo	Pushed for for-hire work.
Chris's father	The man who raised him (remembered).

Thirty questions

1. What was different about the Price job?
2. Who hired the group?
3. What choice does the group usually give?
4. Why does Chris think Corinne was wronged?

5. What happened to Chris at sixteen?
6. What does Chris decide at the end?
7. **How does Chris's backstory explain his creed?** [book club]
8. **Does exposing a secret always kill it?** [book club]
9. **Was Chris's father wrong to stay silent?** [book club]
10. **Is the group's two-choice model fair?** [book club]
11. **What does Chris's own secret make him?** [book club]
12. Who might have hired the firm?
13. How does the chapter humanise Chris?
14. Is Chris a hypocrite?
15. What does face-to-face compassion mean to him?
16. How does Eduardo differ from Chris?
17. What does stop mean in Chris's mind?
18. How does the chapter connect Chris and Adam as sons and fathers?
19. What does the blood test reveal about truth in families?
20. How does the chapter treat catharsis?
21. Is the group's work a crusade or a business?
22. Why did Chris work at Downing Place?
23. How does the chapter change your view of the opening?
24. What does his father's person-by-person motto mean here?
25. What does the chapter title refer to?
26. How might Chris's father view him now?
27. Is it right to reveal for a fee?
28. How does the chapter set up danger?
29. **Would you want to know your paternity?** [book club]
30. Predict how Chris will try to stop Adam.

Close reading

1. A broken rule

Find it: Chapter 45, opening: the for-hire job.

1. Note who paid.
2. Note Eduardo's role.
3. Note the usual choice.
4. Note Chris's judgment.

How does the chapter reframe the opening scene?

2. Origin story

Find it: Chapter 45, middle: the blood test.

1. Note the accident.
2. Note the discovery.
3. Note the father's response.
4. Note the estrangement.

How does Chris's past shape his beliefs?

3. Rationalisation

Find it: Chapter 45, close: Chris's secret and HE KNOWS.

1. Note his question to himself.
2. Note the message.
3. Note his decision.
4. Consider the irony.

How does the chapter expose the limits of Chris's creed?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A villain-turned-believer POV: Chris's backstory gives the novel's theme its origin myth. The structure moves from reframing the opening, to the wound, to hypocrisy, ending on a dangerous decision made in the name of protection.

- ☐ **Origin myth** (20 min) Analyse the backstory.
- ☐ **Reframing** (20 min) How does this change chapter 1?
- ☐ **Hypocrisy** (15 min) Analyse Chris's self-questioning.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite the blood test from the father's POV.
- ☐ **Scene** (30 min) Write a discovery scene.
- ☐ **Structure** (15 min) Map the chapter.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 36.
- ☐ **Creed** (15 min) Analyse his creed.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the decision.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Secrets as cancer versus secrets as protection; paternity and identity; the hypocrisy of the crusader who keeps his own secrets. The chapter tests the book's central question on its most committed believer.

- ☐ **Cancer or shield** (25 min) Discuss secrets.
- ☐ **Paternity** (25 min) Discuss with care.
- ☐ **Crusader** (20 min) Discuss the crusader's hypocrisy.
- ☐ **For hire** (20 min) Discuss for-hire exposure.
- ☐ **Fathers** (20 min) Discuss Chris's father.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "origins".
- ☐ **Compassion** (15 min) Discuss face-to-face revelation.
- ☐ **Danger** (15 min) Discuss stopping Adam.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Blood-type incompatibility can reveal non-paternity. Studies of misattributed paternity generally find rates lower than the popular myth. Corporate investigators use databases and subcontractors. Catharsis comes from Aristotle's Poetics.

- [ ] **Blood types** (20 min) Research blood types and paternity.
- [ ] **Misattributed paternity** (20 min) Research the statistics.
- [ ] **DNA tests** (20 min) Research consumer DNA tests and surprises.
- [ ] **Investigators** (15 min) Research corporate investigators.
- [ ] **Data brokers** (15 min) Research data brokers.
- [ ] **Catharsis** (15 min) Research Aristotle's Poetics.
- [ ] **Car accidents** (15 min) Research teen car accidents.
- [ ] **Blood donation** (15 min) Research donation rules.
- [ ] **Estrangement** (20 min) Research family estrangement.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Sophocles' Oedipus Rex is literature's great story of discovered parentage. Dani Shapiro's memoir Inheritance (2019) recounts discovering through DNA that her father was not her biological father.

- [ ] **Oedipus** (20 min) Compare discovered parentage.
- [ ] **Inheritance** (20 min) Read about Dani Shapiro's memoir.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on secrets and selfhood.
- [ ] **Ronson** (20 min) Read on exposure.
- [ ] **Kingpin** (20 min) Compare a believer.
- [ ] **The Circle** (20 min) Compare secrets as lies.
- [ ] **Ackroyd** (15 min) Compare a hidden narrator.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a father.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A car accident, a hospital blood bank, Downing Place in Massachusetts, a garage in New Jersey: Chris's map of wounds and causes. Now his route points towards Adam.

- [ ] **Wound map** (15 min) Map Chris's past.
- [ ] **Downing Place** (15 min) Pin it.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 45.
- [ ] **Firm** (15 min) Imagine the firm's office.
- [ ] **Route** (15 min) Map Chris towards Adam.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the hidden client.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Draw the for-hire chain.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Chris.
- [ ] **Hospital** (15 min) Imagine the hospital.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Are secrets always cancers? Chris's experience says yes, but the group's own anonymity and his new secret say otherwise. Bok's Secrets argues that some secrecy is necessary to selfhood.

- [ ] **Cancers** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the for-hire job.
- [ ] **Father** (35 min) Write 300 words on Chris's father.
- [ ] **Choice** (15 min) Is the two-choice model just?
- [ ] **Stopping** (15 min) What is Chris allowed to do?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the group file.
- [ ] **Hypocrisy** (15 min) Rate Chris's hypocrisy.
- [ ] **Client** (15 min) Is the hidden client guilty?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a late family truth.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Huge reveal: the Price job was commissioned. Someone hired an investigation firm to dig into Corinne. Pin the question: who paid, and why?

- [ ] **For hire** (15 min) Pin the commission.
- [ ] **Client** (15 min) Pin the unknown client.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word decision scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate who hired the firm.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Reframe** (15 min) Re-pin chapter 1.
- [ ] **Danger** (15 min) Pin Chris's decision.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A teenage boy in a hospital bed, a man rolling down his sleeve after a blood test and learning the truth: paint it in pale hospital light.

- [ ] **Hospital bed** (35 min) Paint the boy and the father.
- [ ] **Blood bag** (15 min) Draw a blood bag.
- [ ] **Creed poster** (20 min) Design a poster of Chris's creed.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Chris.
- [ ] **Five faces** (20 min) Draw the core five.
- [ ] **Message** (15 min) Design the HE KNOWS email.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a hospital waiting room.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the blood bag.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food in this chapter: a man alone with his thoughts. Absence of food in a Coben chapter often signals isolation and the coldness of a decision taken alone.

- [ ] **Silent kitchen** (15 min) Discuss food's absence in this chapter.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the commission.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Chris's paternity.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: would you want to know?
- [ ] **Making: family tree** (20 min) Draw a family tree with gaps.
- [ ] **Blood-orange salad** (20 min) Make a blood-orange salad.
- [ ] **Recipe of a creed** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Tea alone** (15 min) Make tea and sit with a thought.
- [ ] **Family dish** (45 min) Cook a dish from your family.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Chris learned at sixteen that his father was not his biological father. Write privately about a family truth you learned late, or one you fear learning, and how it changed you.

- [ ] **Late truth** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Father** (20 min) Write about a father figure.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) How will Chris act?
- [ ] **Letter to Chris** (15 min) Write to Chris.
- [ ] **Letter to his father** (15 min) Write as Chris.
- [ ] **Cancers** (15 min) Write about a secret that festered.
- [ ] **Protection** (15 min) Write about a protective secret.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Origin Myth

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse the backstory.
- [ ] Read about Oedipus.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Cancer or Shield

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Library Stacks

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Read Bok.
- [ ] Verdict.

For Hire

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Turnpike

- [ ] Pin the commission.
- [ ] Debate the client.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Predict.

Fathers and Sons

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Diner

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write as Chris.
- [ ] Paint the hospital.
- [ ] Reflect.

Family Trees

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Records Room, Driveway

- [ ] Draw a tree.
- [ ] Research DNA tests.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Crusader

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board

- [ ] Analyse hypocrisy.
- [ ] Rate.
- [ ] Pin his decision.
- [ ] Debate.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does Chris Taylor's backstory illuminate the novel's central debate about secrets?
2. Essay: Analyse the hypocrisy of the crusader who keeps his own secret.
3. Creative: Write a letter from Chris to the man who raised him.

Further reading

- *Oedipus the King*, Sophocles (c. 429 BCE). Discovered parentage.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Secrets and selfhood.
- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Exposure as crusade.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). Secrets as lies.
- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). A true believer's anonymity.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). A narrator's hidden truth.

- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Family secrets.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Privacy and identity.
- *Republic (Book II, the Ring of Gyges)*, Plato (c. 375 BCE). The Ring of Gyges and invisibility.

46. Aunt Johanna

What happens

Johanna visits Kimberly Dann's dorm in Greenwich Village. It is her sixth trip to New York City in her life. Kimberly greets her as Aunt Johanna. Memories crowd in: Kimberly as a small girl scraping her knee at the zoo; Kimberly's prom, when her date Frank Velle dropped her for someone he considered an upgrade. Johanna promised Marty she would bring Kimberly home for the funeral.

The county's working theory is a robbery by drug addicts. But Johanna has seen the phone records: Heidi and Kimberly spoke three times this semester, six minutes, then four, and then for more than two hours on the night before the murder.

Johanna kneels in front of Kimberly and holds her face in her hands. It isn't her fault, she tells her. Whatever it is. But she needs to tell her.

Scene by scene

1. Kimberly's dorm in Greenwich Village; Johanna's sixth NYC trip.
2. Aunt Johanna.
3. Memories: a scraped knee at the zoo; a prom date who traded up.
4. A promise to Marty: bring Kimberly home.
5. The county's theory: robbery by addicts.
6. Phone records: three calls, the last over two hours, the night before.
7. Johanna kneels, holds Kimberly's face: not your fault; tell me.

Who's here

Johanna Griffin	Family friend, investigator.
Kimberly Dann	Heidi's daughter, a college student.
Marty Dann	Heidi's husband (mentioned).

Thirty questions

1. Where does Kimberly live?
2. What does Kimberly call Johanna?
3. What memories does Johanna have of Kimberly?
4. What promise did Johanna make?
5. What is the county's theory?
6. What do the phone records show?
7. **Why does Johanna tell Kimberly it isn't her fault?** [book club]
8. What might Kimberly feel guilty about?
9. How does the chapter use memory?
10. Why include Johanna's few trips to NYC?
11. **What does the honorary-aunt bond allow?** [book club]
12. **Is Johanna manipulating Kimberly or comforting her?** [book club]
13. How does the chapter treat young women in crisis?
14. What does the prom memory add?
15. How does the chapter build to its final gesture?
16. Why does the county's theory fail?
17. What does a two-hour call suggest?
18. How does this chapter connect to chapter 40?
19. What does the reader already know that Johanna doesn't?
20. How does dramatic irony work here?

21. **Is kneeling a gesture of power or tenderness?** [book club]
22. How does the chapter treat Marty?
23. **What would you want from Johanna if you were Kimberly?** [book club]
24. **How does the chapter treat guilt?** [book club]
25. What does Greenwich Village represent?
26. How does the chapter show Johanna's outsider status?
27. Compare this scene with Adam and Ryan.
28. Why is the chapter so short?
29. What will Kimberly say?
30. Predict how this changes Johanna's investigation.

Close reading

1. An outsider in the city

Find it: Chapter 46, opening: the dorm.

1. Note Johanna's trip count.
2. Note the greeting.
3. Note the setting.
4. Note her promise.

How does the chapter make Johanna both stranger and family?

2. Knowing a child

Find it: Chapter 46, middle: the memories.

1. Describe the zoo memory.
2. Describe the prom memory.
3. Note Johanna's feelings.
4. Consider why now.

Why give Johanna these memories here?

3. Tender pressure

Find it: Chapter 46, close: the phone records and the gesture.

1. Note the call durations.
2. Note the county theory.
3. Describe the gesture.
4. Note her words.

How does the chapter combine comfort and interrogation?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A short, tender chapter in which interrogation and comfort become a single gesture. Memories of a child make the adult's pain vivid; the phone records turn grief into evidence. The reader, who knows more, feels the dread of what Kimberly will say.

- [ ] **One gesture** (20 min) Analyse comfort and interrogation.
- [ ] **Memories** (15 min) Analyse the memories' function.
- [ ] **Irony** (15 min) Analyse dramatic irony.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Kimberly's POV.
- [ ] **Scene** (30 min) Write a tender interrogation.
- [ ] **Brevity** (15 min) Analyse the chapter's length.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 38.
- [ ] **Records** (15 min) Analyse the call durations.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the gesture.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Guilt, protective love and the ethics of pressing the grieving for truth. Johanna's honorary-aunt role gives her a power the police lack, and the chapter asks how she should use it.

- [ ] **Guilt** (25 min) Discuss guilt in the young.
- [ ] **Pressing the grieving** (25 min) Discuss ethics.
- [ ] **Honorary family** (20 min) Discuss the aunt bond.
- [ ] **Young women** (20 min) Discuss vulnerability.
- [ ] **County theory** (15 min) Discuss lazy theories.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "absolution".
- [ ] **Memory** (15 min) Discuss childhood memories.
- [ ] **Outsider** (15 min) Discuss Johanna in NYC.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Call-detail records show numbers, times and durations but not content. Greenwich Village, home to NYU, has a long bohemian history. The honorary aunt is a common feature of American family life.

- [ ] **Call records** (20 min) Research CDRs.
- [ ] **Greenwich Village** (15 min) Research the area.
- [ ] **College counselling** (20 min) Research college grief support.
- [ ] **Bereavement leave** (15 min) Research student bereavement policies.
- [ ] **Robbery theory** (15 min) Research how police rule out burglary.
- [ ] **Funerals** (15 min) Research funeral customs in Ohio.
- [ ] **Prom** (15 min) Research prom culture.
- [ ] **Zoos** (15 min) Research the Cleveland Zoo.
- [ ] **Family friends** (15 min) Research fictive kin.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Tana French's The Likeness and Kate Atkinson's Started Early, Took My Dog both show detectives drawing truth from the vulnerable with care. Johanna's gesture belongs to that humane tradition.

- [ ] **The Likeness** (20 min) Read about French's novel.
- [ ] **Started Early** (20 min) Read about Atkinson's novel.
- [ ] **Didion** (20 min) Read on grief.
- [ ] **Little Fires** (20 min) Compare daughters and mothers.
- [ ] **Never Told** (20 min) Compare a family's grief.
- [ ] **Case Histories** (20 min) Compare compassion.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on confession.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a daughter.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Greenwich Village, Manhattan: a long way from Beachwood, Ohio. Johanna's sixth trip to the city underlines her outsider status as the case pulls her across the country to the east coast.

- [ ] **Village** (15 min) Pin the dorm.
- [ ] **Beachwood** (15 min) Draw the journey east.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 46.
- [ ] **Six trips** (15 min) Imagine Johanna's first trip.
- [ ] **Zoo** (15 min) Pin the childhood zoo.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Kimberly.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Kimberly and Larry (from chapter 40).
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Kimberly.
- [ ] **Home** (15 min) Map the journey home for the funeral.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Should Johanna press Kimberly? Care ethics urges patience; justice needs the truth now. The chapter suggests that tenderness and pressure can coexist without one cancelling the other.

- [ ] **Pressing** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Johanna's approach.
- [ ] **Absolution** (35 min) Write 300 words on forgiveness before confession.
- [ ] **County** (15 min) Is the county negligent?
- [ ] **Promise** (15 min) Does Johanna owe Marty more than truth?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Heidi file.
- [ ] **Kimberly** (15 min) Is she to blame for anything?
- [ ] **Privacy** (15 min) Should Kimberly's secret stay private?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about being forgiven first.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Pin the two-hour call the night before the murder. The county's robbery theory cannot survive it. Kimberly is the key to Heidi's secret, and the reader can guess why.

- [ ] **Call** (15 min) Pin the two-hour call.
- [ ] **Theory** (15 min) Pin the county theory as weak.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word dorm scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note convergence.
- [ ] **Irony** (15 min) List what the reader knows.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A cramped dorm room, string lights, a woman kneeling to hold a young woman's face: paint it close-up, warm, with Manhattan at the window.

- [ ] **Dorm** (35 min) Paint the dorm scene.
- [ ] **Zoo memory** (25 min) Paint a child at the zoo.
- [ ] **Prom photo** (20 min) Draw a prom photo with one face cut out.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Kimberly.
- [ ] **Hands** (15 min) Draw hands holding a face.
- [ ] **Phone log** (15 min) Design the call log.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a dorm hallway.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the hands.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Dorm-room snacks no one touches. Grief closes the appetite. Make something small and gentle that you would bring to a grieving young person, and think about what it says.

- [ ] **Gentle food** (20 min) Make a small comfort food for a grieving student.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the call durations.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Kimberly's secret (unknown).
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who is your honorary family?
- [ ] **Making: care parcel** (25 min) Make a parcel for a student away from home.
- [ ] **Soup** (45 min) Make chicken soup.
- [ ] **Recipe of absolution** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Cookies** (40 min) Bake cookies to send.
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Johanna tells Kimberly it isn't her fault before she even knows what it is. Write privately about a time someone forgave you before you confessed, and how that changed your confession.

- [ ] **Forgiven first** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Honorary aunt** (20 min) Write about an honorary relative.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate sorrow.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Kimberly say?
- [ ] **Letter to Kimberly** (15 min) Write as Johanna.
- [ ] **Letter to Heidi** (15 min) Write as Kimberly.
- [ ] **Guilt** (15 min) Write about misplaced guilt.
- [ ] **Promise** (15 min) Write about a promise to a friend.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Tender Pressure

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Room 233

- [ ] Analyse the gesture.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Verdict.

Kimberly

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Paint the dorm.
- [ ] Write as Kimberly.
- [ ] Make a care parcel.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Two-Hour Call

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Turnpike

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Predict.

Honorary Family

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Records Room

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Research fictive kin.
- [ ] Reflect.

Absolution

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Driveway

- [ ] Write 300 words.
- [ ] Read Bok.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Johanna East

Rooms: Turnpike, Law Office, Diner

- [ ] Map her journey.
- [ ] Analyse her outsider status.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Present.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 46 combine tenderness and investigation?
2. Essay: Analyse the ethics of pressing the grieving for truth in Johanna's strand.
3. Creative: Write the two-hour phone call between Heidi and Kimberly (without inventing details beyond what the novel later confirms).

Further reading

- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). Compassionate detection.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A seasoned woman investigator.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). Mothers and daughters.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). A family's grief.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Confession and secrets.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online harms to young women.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben on grief.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Families after murder.
- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). Parents and grown children.

47. The Tail

What happens

Adam watches Gabrielle's house. Her children look about twelve and ten. She loads one suitcase into the car, then another, then a third. Adam has already called the other people in the holiday-party photo; none of them led anywhere. He decides to follow her, drawing on everything he has learned about tailing from television.

She drives Route 208, then I-287. Johanna rings from Cleveland's airport: she has taken Kimberly home and is flying back to Newark. The stranger, she says, has access to other websites too: this is a blackmail ring. She won't tell Adam what Kimberly's secret is.

Gabrielle exits Route 23 onto Lockwood Avenue in Pequannock and stops at a yellow split-level: her ex-husband's house, with a much younger woman. She drops the children; the ex looks surprised at the luggage. Then Gabrielle drives off with her suitcases. Johanna's parting words to Adam: don't do anything stupid.

Scene by scene

1. Adam watches Gabrielle load three suitcases.
2. Her kids, about twelve and ten.
3. The other photo contacts led nowhere.
4. Adam tails her, using TV knowledge.
5. Route 208, I-287.
6. Johanna calls from Cleveland: a blackmail ring; Kimberly's secret withheld.
7. Route 23 to Lockwood Avenue, Pequannock.
8. A yellow split-level; the ex and a younger woman.
9. The kids dropped; the ex surprised by luggage.
10. Gabrielle drives off; Johanna warns Adam off stupidity.

Who's here

Adam Price	Amateur tail.
Gabrielle Dunbar	Fleeing.
Johanna Griffin	On the phone.
Gabrielle's ex	Surprised.

Thirty questions

1. What does Adam watch Gabrielle do?
2. How does Adam learn to tail someone?
3. What does Johanna tell Adam?
4. Where does Gabrielle stop?
5. What does she do with the children?
6. What does Johanna warn?
7. **Why does Johanna keep Kimberly's secret?** [book club]
8. What does the third suitcase signal?
9. **How does the chapter treat Gabrielle as a mother?** [book club]
10. Is Adam's tail realistic?
11. What does the ex's surprise reveal?
12. Why include the younger woman?
13. How does the chapter build suspense on the road?

14. What does "a blackmail ring" change for Adam?
15. **How do TV tropes shape Adam's actions?** [book club]
16. Why does Adam keep going?
17. Is Adam about to do something stupid?
18. How does the road function as setting?
19. **What does it mean to leave your kids and run?** [book club]
20. **Compare Gabrielle and Corinne as mothers who leave.** [book club]
21. How does the chapter use phone calls?
22. What is the effect of Johanna in the air?
23. How does the chapter treat divorce?
24. Why might Gabrielle go somewhere remote?
25. What would you do in Adam's place?
26. **How has Adam changed as an investigator?** [book club]
27. What does the yellow house add?
28. How does the chapter treat surveillance by amateurs?
29. Why does Gabrielle not see Adam?
30. Predict where Gabrielle is heading.

Close reading

1. Reading luggage

Find it: Chapter 47, opening: the suitcases.

1. Count the suitcases.
2. Note the children.
3. Note Adam's failed calls.
4. Note his decision.

How does the chapter make suitcases tell a story?

2. A wider ring

Find it: Chapter 47, middle: Johanna's call.

1. Note where Johanna is.
2. Note the blackmail-ring theory.
3. Note what she withholds.
4. Note Adam's reaction.

Why does Johanna share some things and keep others?

3. A mother leaving

Find it: Chapter 47, close: Pequannock.

1. Describe the house.
2. Note the ex and his partner.
3. Note the luggage.
4. Note Johanna's warning.

How does the chapter make Gabrielle's departure poignant and ominous?

Activities by room

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Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A road chapter: suspense built from routes, mirrors and phone calls. Adam's TV-learned tail is gently comic; Gabrielle's drop-off is quietly sad. Johanna's warning not to do anything stupid foreshadows exactly that.

- [ ] **Road suspense** (20 min) Analyse suspense on the road.
- [ ] **Comic tail** (15 min) Analyse the TV tail.
- [ ] **Foreshadowing** (15 min) Analyse Johanna's warning.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Gabrielle's POV.
- [ ] **Tail scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word tail.
- [ ] **Luggage** (15 min) Analyse the suitcases.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 43.
- [ ] **Phone call** (15 min) Analyse the call.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the warning.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Surveillance by amateurs, mothers who leave, divorce and the ethics of keeping another person's secret. Johanna's discretion about Kimberly is a model of what the stranger's group never does.

- [ ] **Amateur surveillance** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Mothers who leave** (25 min) Discuss Gabrielle and Corinne.
- [ ] **Keeping secrets** (20 min) Discuss Johanna's discretion.
- [ ] **Divorce** (15 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **TV tropes** (15 min) Discuss TV and real life.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "discretion".
- [ ] **Rings** (15 min) Discuss the blackmail ring.
- [ ] **Risk** (15 min) Discuss Adam's risk.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Routes 208, 287 and 23 are real highways across northern New Jersey. Professional surveillance teams use several vehicles to avoid detection. Split-level houses spread across post-war suburbs from the 1950s.

- [ ] **NJ highways** (15 min) Research Routes 208, 287 and 23.
- [ ] **Surveillance** (20 min) Research professional tailing.
- [ ] **Split-levels** (15 min) Research the style.
- [ ] **Pequannock** (15 min) Research the township.
- [ ] **Cleveland airport** (15 min) Research Hopkins.
- [ ] **Custody** (15 min) Research emergency custody.
- [ ] **Blackmail rings** (20 min) Research online extortion rings.
- [ ] **Dashcams** (15 min) Research tailing detection.
- [ ] **Luggage** (15 min) Research what people pack when fleeing.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Dashiell Hammett's The Maltese Falcon and Raymond Chandler's novels feature tailing as a set piece. Adam's amateur version echoes and gently mocks the convention.

- [ ] **Maltese Falcon** (20 min) Read about Hammett's tail scenes.
- [ ] **Chandler** (20 min) Compare tails in Chandler.
- [ ] **Big Sleep** (20 min) Compare a detective on the road.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare leaving.
- [ ] **Big Little Lies** (20 min) Compare mothers.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on keeping others' secrets.
- [ ] **Gone Girl** (20 min) Compare a spouse who runs.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a road.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Fair Lawn to Route 208, I-287 and Route 23, then Lockwood Avenue in Pequannock: trace the tail. The road leads north-west towards the mountains, away from Cedarfield's cul-de-sacs.

- [ ] **The tail** (20 min) Map Fair Lawn to Pequannock.
- [ ] **Route 23** (15 min) Trace Route 23 north-west.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 47.
- [ ] **Cleveland** (15 min) Pin Johanna's airport.
- [ ] **Yellow house** (15 min) Pin Lockwood Avenue.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Gabrielle's route.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Add the ring's websites.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place the ex.
- [ ] **Direction** (15 min) Mark the direction of travel.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is Johanna right to keep Kimberly's secret from Adam? The chapter suggests respect for a secret's owner can be a moral act, the very opposite of the stranger's creed.

- [ ] **Discretion** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Gabrielle's leaving.
- [ ] **Tailing** (15 min) Is tailing her wrong?
- [ ] **Leaving** (35 min) Write 300 words on mothers who run.
- [ ] **Risk** (15 min) Should Adam stop?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the group file.
- [ ] **Johanna** (15 min) Rate her discretion.
- [ ] **Children** (15 min) What do Gabrielle's kids deserve?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about running.

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The Incident Board: Writing craft

The group is a ring across websites; Gabrielle is running; Kimberly's secret is known to Johanna. Pin all three, and the route Gabrielle takes.

- [ ] **Ring** (15 min) Pin the blackmail ring.
- [ ] **Route** (15 min) Pin Gabrielle's route.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word tail scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Gabrielle.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Warning** (15 min) Pin Johanna's warning.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A yellow split-level, a car loaded with suitcases, two children on a lawn, a man in the doorway: paint it in flat afternoon light with one car idling down the street.

- [ ] **Yellow house** (35 min) Paint the drop-off.
- [ ] **Suitcases** (15 min) Draw three suitcases.
- [ ] **Highway** (25 min) Paint I-287.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a driving song.
- [ ] **Mirror** (15 min) Paint a rear-view mirror.
- [ ] **Map** (15 min) Design a route map.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe tyres on a highway.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the suitcases.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Road snacks, a coffee in a cup holder: the food of a long tail. Pack a road snack and think about what you would take if you had to leave in a hurry.

- [ ] **Road snack** (15 min) Pack a road snack.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the route.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Kimberly's secret (withheld).
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what would you pack?
- [ ] **Making: go-bag** (15 min) List a go-bag.
- [ ] **Thermos coffee** (15 min) Make thermos coffee.
- [ ] **Recipe of a getaway** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Diner stop** (20 min) Make a diner sandwich.
- [ ] **Kids' dinner** (30 min) Make a simple kids' dinner.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Gabrielle leaves her children with their father and drives off with three suitcases. Write privately about what you would pack, and whom you would leave behind, if you had to run.

- [ ] **Running** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Leaving children** (20 min) Write about separation.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate suspense.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Where is she going?
- [ ] **Letter to Gabrielle** (15 min) Write to her.
- [ ] **Letter from her kids** (15 min) Write as her child.
- [ ] **Stupid** (15 min) Write about a stupid brave thing.
- [ ] **Discretion** (15 min) Write about keeping a secret for someone.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Tail

Rooms: Turnpike, Law Office, Diner

- [ ] Map the route.
- [ ] Analyse suspense.
- [ ] Paint the highway.
- [ ] Present.

Discretion

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Library Stacks

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Read Bok.
- [ ] Verdict.

Mothers Who Leave

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Compare.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Ring

Rooms: Incident Board, Records Room, Law Office

- [ ] Pin it.
- [ ] Research rings.
- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Predict.

Go-Bag

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Driveway, Diner

- [ ] List a go-bag.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Draw suitcases.
- [ ] Discuss.

Detective Tails

Rooms: Library Stacks, Law Office, Room 233

- [ ] Read about Hammett.
- [ ] Compare.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 47 build suspense through a road journey?
2. Essay: Analyse Johanna's discretion as a counterpoint to the stranger's creed.
3. Creative: Write Gabrielle's goodbye to her children.

Further reading

- *The Big Sleep*, Raymond Chandler (1939). A detective on the road.
- *The Simple Art of Murder*, Raymond Chandler (1944). Chandler on the detective story.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Keeping others' secrets.
- *Big Little Lies*, Liane Moriarty (2014). Mothers under pressure.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). A spouse who runs.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Leaving.
- *Shelter*, Harlan Coben (2011). Coben's amateur investigators.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online extortion.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). A road into the woods.

48. Lake Charmaine

What happens

The tail takes Adam along Skyline Drive in the Ramapo Mountains. He thinks of the region's legends: the Ramapough Lenape people, whose origins are debated, and the derogatory name outsiders once used for them; the ghost stories teenagers told about these roads. Myths have power. Gabrielle drives on via Route 23 and over the Dingmans Ferry Bridge into Pennsylvania. Adam's phone battery is at 10 per cent.

A sign: LAKE CHARMAINE – PRIVATE, at the end of a dirt drive. Adam leaves his car and walks the overgrown path. A buck watches him. The lake is still. Corinne loved lakes; the ocean frightened her. Before the boys, they would rent a cottage on a lake up in the north of Passaic County, with a shared hammock where he watched her read with total concentration and smile at the page.

He sees a log cabin and Gabrielle's car. He wishes he were armed; his uncle Greg once took him shooting. Gabrielle stands in a clearing, staring at him. Adam asks where his wife is. Then a bat strikes the back of his head, and again, on his skull.

Scene by scene

1. Skyline Drive and the Ramapo Mountains.
2. Legends of the Ramapough Lenape; teenage ghost stories; the power of myth.
3. Route 23; the Dingmans Ferry Bridge into Pennsylvania.
4. Phone at 10 per cent.
5. LAKE CHARMAINE – PRIVATE; a dirt drive.
6. An overgrown path; a buck; a still lake.
7. Memory: Corinne loved lakes; the hammock; her reading.
8. A log cabin; Gabrielle's car.
9. Wishing he were armed; Uncle Greg.
10. Gabrielle in the clearing.
11. Where's my wife?
12. A bat to the back of the head, then the skull.

Who's here

Adam Price	Alone, unarmed, remembering.
Gabrielle Dunbar	In the clearing.
Unknown attacker	With a bat.

Thirty questions

1. What legends does Adam think of on Skyline Drive?
2. Where does Gabrielle cross into Pennsylvania?
3. What does the sign say?
4. What memory does the lake bring?
5. What does Adam find?
6. What happens to him?
7. **Why include the legends of Skyline Drive?** [book club]
8. **How does the novel handle the Ramapough history?** [book club]

9. **What does the memory of Corinne reading reveal?** [book club]
10. Why was Corinne afraid of the ocean but loved lakes?
11. What does the buck symbolise?
12. How does the chapter build dread?
13. Why mention the phone battery?
14. **Was Adam foolish?** [book club]
15. What does wishing to be armed say about Adam?
16. How does the chapter use landscape?
17. Why does Gabrielle stand and stare?
18. Who attacked Adam?
19. How does the chapter end?
20. **What does myth have to do with the novel?** [book club]
21. How does nature contrast with violence?
22. What is the significance of crossing state lines?
23. How does this chapter echo earlier memories of Corinne?
24. What does "private" mean here?
25. **How does Adam's love shape his recklessness?** [book club]
26. What does the hammock memory mean?
27. How does the chapter use silence?
28. Is the lake a trap?
29. What will happen next?
30. Predict what the group will do with Adam.

Close reading

1. Myth and road

Find it: Chapter 48, opening: Skyline Drive.

1. Note the legends.
2. Note the debate over origins.
3. Note the ghost stories.
4. Note the idea about myth.

Why does the novel pause on myth at its moment of greatest danger?

2. Love remembered

Find it: Chapter 48, middle: the lake memory.

1. Note Corinne's fear of the ocean.
2. Describe the lake house.
3. Describe her reading.
4. Note Adam's feeling.

How does this memory change our image of Corinne?

3. Ambush

Find it: Chapter 48, close: the clearing.

1. Note the cabin and car.
2. Note Uncle Greg.
3. Note Gabrielle's stare.
4. Note the blows.

How does the chapter stage the ambush?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A journey chapter that slows to memory just before violence. Landscape, legend and love build a hush that the bat shatters. The memory of Corinne reading in a hammock is one of the novel's most tender images, placed for maximum contrast.

- [ ] **Slowing** (20 min) Analyse the slowing before violence.
- [ ] **Hammock** (15 min) Analyse the hammock image.
- [ ] **Landscape** (15 min) Analyse landscape as mood.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Gabrielle's POV.
- [ ] **Ambush scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word ambush.
- [ ] **Myth** (15 min) Analyse the myth passage.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 47.
- [ ] **Contrast** (15 min) Analyse memory vs violence.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the blows.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Myth and its power; love remembered; courage and folly. The chapter asks what drives Adam into the woods alone: love, desperation, or the stories men tell themselves about being heroes.

- [ ] **Myth** (20 min) Discuss myth's power.
- [ ] **Ramapough history** (25 min) Discuss with care and accuracy.
- [ ] **Love remembered** (20 min) Discuss Corinne reading.
- [ ] **Courage or folly** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Masculinity** (15 min) Discuss wishing to be armed.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "the woods".
- [ ] **Nature** (15 min) Discuss nature and violence.
- [ ] **Private** (15 min) Discuss private places.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

The Ramapough Lenape Nation was recognised by New Jersey in 1980 but not federally; a derogatory name was long used against them. The Dingmans Ferry Bridge is one of the last privately owned toll bridges across the Delaware.

- [ ] **Ramapough Lenape** (25 min) Research their history and recognition.
- [ ] **Skyline Drive** (15 min) Research the road and its legends.
- [ ] **Dingmans Ferry Bridge** (15 min) Research the bridge.
- [ ] **Water Gap** (15 min) Research the recreation area.
- [ ] **Private lakes** (15 min) Research private lake communities in the Poconos.
- [ ] **Phone batteries** (15 min) Research tracking with low battery.
- [ ] **Head injuries** (15 min) Research blunt head trauma.

- [ ] **Bucks** (15 min) Research white-tailed deer.
- [ ] **Lake houses** (15 min) Research Passaic County lakes.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Coben's The Woods (2007) is set around a summer camp in the woods. Tana French's In the Woods uses forest and myth as menace. Robert Frost's poems of woods and choices offer a quieter echo.

- [ ] **The Woods** (20 min) Read about Coben's 2007 novel.
- [ ] **In the Woods** (20 min) Compare forest menace.
- [ ] **Frost** (15 min) Read a Frost woods poem (pre-1929).
- [ ] **Deliverance** (20 min) Read about Dickey's 1970 novel.
- [ ] **Thoreau** (20 min) Read from Walden on lakes.
- [ ] **Aristotle** (20 min) Read on courage.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare violence and water.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain lake poem.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Skyline Drive in the Ramapos, Route 23, the Dingmans Ferry Bridge, Pennsylvania, Lake Charmaine: the map leaves the suburbs and enters forest. The private lake is the end of the road.

- [ ] **Skyline Drive** (15 min) Map the drive.
- [ ] **Bridge** (15 min) Pin Dingmans Ferry.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 48.
- [ ] **Lake** (15 min) Pin Lake Charmaine (fictional).
- [ ] **State line** (15 min) Mark the NJ–PA border.
- [ ] **Lake house** (15 min) Pin the old Passaic County rental.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add the hideout.
- [ ] **Elevation** (15 min) Note the climb into the hills.
- [ ] **Isolation** (15 min) Mark how far from help.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Brave or foolish? Aristotle would ask whether Adam's courage is a mean or rashness. He was warned. Love blinds as well as drives.

- [ ] **Brave or foolish** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam's choice.
- [ ] **Courage** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Guns** (15 min) Would a gun have helped?
- [ ] **Myth** (15 min) Is myth harmful?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the group file.
- [ ] **Gabrielle** (15 min) Is she complicit in the attack?

- [ ] **Warning** (15 min) Should Adam have listened?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a memory of love.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

The hideout found: Lake Charmaine, Pennsylvania. Adam is attacked and unconscious. Pin the location and the attack; no one knows where he is except, perhaps, a phone at 10 per cent.

- [ ] **Hideout** (15 min) Pin Lake Charmaine.
- [ ] **Attack** (15 min) Pin the attack.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word aftermath.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate the attacker.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Phone** (15 min) Pin the dying phone.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A still lake at dusk, a log cabin, a buck in the trees, a woman standing in a clearing: paint it in deep greens and violet, with one figure about to fall.

- [ ] **Lake at dusk** (35 min) Paint the lake.
- [ ] **Hammock** (30 min) Paint Corinne reading.
- [ ] **Buck** (20 min) Draw the buck.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for a lake.
- [ ] **Sign** (15 min) Design LAKE CHARMAINE – PRIVATE.
- [ ] **Bridge** (20 min) Draw the Dingmans Ferry Bridge.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a still lake.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the lake.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food in this chapter, only a memory of lazy lake days. Think of a lake-house lunch: simple, slow, eaten in the shade, with someone reading beside you.

- [ ] **Lake lunch** (30 min) Make a slow lake-house lunch.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the hideout.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the lake.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: lake or ocean?
- [ ] **Making: picnic** (20 min) Pack a picnic.
- [ ] **Lemonade** (15 min) Make lemonade.
- [ ] **Recipe of a still lake** (15 min) Write a recipe.

- [ ] **Campfire food** (40 min) Make campfire food (safely).
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea and remember.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam remembers watching Corinne read with total concentration and smile at the page. Write privately about a small, ordinary sight of someone you love that you keep in your memory.

- [ ] **Small sight** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Lake or ocean** (20 min) Write about your fear or love of water.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What happens next?
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter from the woods** (15 min) Write as Adam, unconscious.
- [ ] **Courage** (15 min) Write about rash courage.
- [ ] **Myth** (15 min) Write about a local legend.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Lake

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Paint the lake.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Make a lake lunch.
- [ ] Reflect.

Ramapo Myths

Rooms: Records Room, Room 233, Turnpike

- [ ] Research the Ramapough.
- [ ] Discuss carefully.
- [ ] Map Skyline Drive.
- [ ] Present.

Brave or Foolish

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Read Aristotle.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Hammock

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Discuss.

Into the Woods

Rooms: Library Stacks, Turnpike, Incident Board

- [ ] Read about The Woods.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Predict.

Ambush

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Debate Gabrielle's role.
- [ ] Predict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 48 use landscape, myth and memory before violence?
2. Essay: Analyse the image of Corinne reading in the hammock and its place in the novel.
3. Creative: Write a local legend about Lake Charmaine.

Further reading

- *The Woods*, Harlan Coben (2007). Coben's woods.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). Forest and menace.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Violence and water.
- *Suburbia*, Bill Owens (1973). The lyrical natural world in a crime novel.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). A lake and a lost wife.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Searching in the wild.
- *Born to Run*, Bruce Springsteen (2016). Wild places.
- *The Virgin Suicides*, Jeffrey Eugenides (1993). Men and quests.
- *Dare Me*, Megan Abbott (2012). Rash courage.

49. The Second DVD

What happens

Johanna lands at Newark. She is the kind of rule-follower who really does switch to airplane mode. Kimberly's story took a long time to come out, piece by piece. Johanna now understands that Heidi's body language on the Red Lobster tape showed a woman being assaulted by words.

The sugar-baby website is run by a woman in Massachusetts who won't release anything without a court order. Johanna has told the county everything she knows, and they are on it at last.

Her phone buzzes: Darrow Fontera, the Red Lobster security man, wants his DVD back. In passing he mentions something that stops her cold. Hers was the second copy he made. The first went to a retired NYPD officer, a man named John Kuntz.

Scene by scene

1. Johanna lands at Newark; airplane-mode rule-follower.
2. Kimberly's story, told slowly.
3. Heidi's body language on tape: an assault by words.
4. The sugar-baby site: run from Massachusetts; court order needed.
5. Johanna has told the county everything.
6. Darrow Fontera wants the DVD back.
7. Hers was the second copy; the first went to retired NYPD officer John Kuntz.

Who's here

Johanna Griffin	Rule-follower who broke the rules.
Darrow Fontera	Red Lobster security.
Kimberly Dann	Her story told (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. What does Johanna now understand about the tape?
2. What does the sugar-baby site require?
3. What has Johanna told the county?
4. Who is Darrow Fontera?
5. What does he reveal?
6. **Why is the second DVD so important?** [book club]
7. **How does the chapter reward Johanna's rule-following?** [book club]
8. **What does an assault by words mean?** [book club]
9. Why does the site need a court order?
10. How does surveillance cut both ways here?
11. What does the reader know that Johanna now learns?
12. How does dramatic irony resolve?
13. **Is telling the county a defeat or a victory?** [book club]
14. How did Kuntz get the DVD?
15. What does this reveal about Kuntz's methods?
16. How does the chapter use an incidental detail?
17. What will Johanna do now?
18. How does Johanna's character pay off?
19. Why is a security guard the key?
20. How does Kimberly's story reframe Heidi?
21. **What does the slow telling suggest about shame?** [book club]
22. Is the sugar-baby site complicit?
23. How does the chapter treat bureaucracy?

24. What does airplane mode tell us about Johanna?
25. How do small details solve cases?
26. **Compare Johanna and Adam as investigators.** [book club]
27. What does this chapter set up?
28. What do you feel at the name Kuntz?
29. Is the county now ahead of Johanna?
30. Predict how Johanna uses this.

Close reading

1. Rules

Find it: Chapter 49, opening: landing.

1. Note airplane mode.
2. Note Kimberly's slow story.
3. Note the tape reading.
4. Note her feelings.

How does the chapter define Johanna as a rule-follower who bends rules?

2. Process

Find it: Chapter 49, middle: the website and the county.

1. Note the Massachusetts owner.
2. Note the court order.
3. Note what she told the county.
4. Note her mood.

Why does Johanna finally hand over?

3. The incidental clue

Find it: Chapter 49, close: Darrow's call.

1. Note his request.
2. Note the second-copy detail.
3. Note the name.
4. Read the last line.

How does a throwaway remark become the key?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A short chapter that pays off a minor character: the Red Lobster security guard. The incidental remark is a classic mystery device: the clue arrives sideways. Dramatic irony resolves as Johanna learns the name the reader already knows.

- ☐ **Incidental clue** (20 min) Analyse the sideways clue.
- ☐ **Payoff** (15 min) Track Darrow's earlier mention.

- [ ] **Irony** (15 min) Analyse irony resolving.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Darrow's POV.
- [ ] **Clue scene** (30 min) Write a sideways clue scene.
- [ ] **Brevity** (15 min) Analyse the short chapter.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 46.
- [ ] **Characterisation** (15 min) Analyse airplane mode.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the name.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Process versus private justice; shame and slow confession; words as assault. Johanna's choice to brief the county contrasts with Adam's solo path, which is about to go very wrong.

- [ ] **Process** (25 min) Discuss process vs private justice.
- [ ] **Shame** (20 min) Discuss slow confession.
- [ ] **Words as assault** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Bureaucracy** (15 min) Discuss court orders.
- [ ] **Rules** (15 min) Discuss Johanna's rules.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "the sideways clue".
- [ ] **Women's safety** (20 min) Discuss sugar-baby sites.
- [ ] **Irony** (15 min) Discuss reader knowledge.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Most platforms require a subpoena or court order to release user data. Retired officers may carry retired ID, and misusing it to obtain evidence can be a crime. CCTV copies are often made on request.

- [ ] **Subpoenas** (20 min) Research data subpoenas.
- [ ] **Retired ID** (15 min) Research retired police ID.
- [ ] **CCTV copies** (15 min) Research CCTV release practices.
- [ ] **Airplane mode** (15 min) Research the rule.
- [ ] **Sugar-baby sites** (20 min) Research regulation.
- [ ] **Multi-state cases** (15 min) Research FBI involvement.
- [ ] **Security guards** (15 min) Research retail security.
- [ ] **Massachusetts** (15 min) Research data law.
- [ ] **Evidence chains** (20 min) Research chain of custody.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Agatha Christie loved the incidental clue: a remark that seems nothing. In The Murder of Roger Ackroyd, small details about time solve everything. Darrow Fontera is a Christie-style witness.

- [ ] **Ackroyd** (20 min) Read about Christie's clue.
- [ ] **Christie** (20 min) Find another incidental clue in Christie.

- [ ] **Case Histories** (20 min) Compare clue-finding.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on confession.
- [ ] **Citron** (20 min) Read on online harms.
- [ ] **Big Sleep** (20 min) Compare minor witnesses.
- [ ] **In the Woods** (20 min) Compare police process.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about arriving.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Newark Airport, a security office in Ohio, a website in Massachusetts, and a retired cop in New York: the map of the Heidi case is now drawn, and it points at Kuntz.

- [ ] **Newark** (15 min) Pin the airport.
- [ ] **Ohio** (15 min) Pin the Red Lobster.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 49.
- [ ] **Massachusetts** (15 min) Pin the website owner.
- [ ] **New York** (15 min) Pin Kuntz.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Draw the DVD chain.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Kuntz to Heidi.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Darrow.
- [ ] **Distances** (15 min) Measure the case's spread.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Was handing over right? Process protects suspects and victims alike, but slows things down. Johanna chooses process just as the clue arrives that might have let her act alone.

- [ ] **Handing over** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Johanna's choice.
- [ ] **Process** (35 min) Write 300 words on process.
- [ ] **Site** (15 min) Should the site release data?
- [ ] **Darrow** (15 min) Was giving copies wrong?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Kuntz file.
- [ ] **Kimberly** (15 min) How should her story be protected?
- [ ] **Rules** (15 min) Rate Johanna's rule-following.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about telling slowly.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Key clue: Kuntz had the first DVD. Johanna can now link the Heidi murder to him. Pin the DVD chain: Fontera, Kuntz, Johanna.

- [ ] **DVD chain** (15 min) Pin it.
- [ ] **Kuntz** (15 min) Pin the link.

- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word call scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark the join.
- [ ] **Irony** (15 min) Note what Johanna now knows.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

An airport arrivals hall at night, a woman with a carry-on, her face lit by a phone as she hears a name: paint it in cold blues with one warm screen.

- [ ] **Arrivals** (35 min) Paint the arrivals hall.
- [ ] **Two DVDs** (15 min) Draw two DVDs.
- [ ] **Phone glow** (20 min) Paint a face lit by news.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for landing.
- [ ] **Security office** (15 min) Draw a security office.
- [ ] **Map** (15 min) Design the DVD chain map.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe an airport at night.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the DVDs.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Airline snacks and a long day. Make something you would want on landing late: a sandwich, a soup, a cup of tea, the food of coming home.

- [ ] **Landing food** (20 min) Make a late-arrival meal.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the second DVD.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Kimberly's story.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who gave you time to tell?
- [ ] **Making: travel snack** (15 min) Pack travel snacks.
- [ ] **Soup** (40 min) Make soup.
- [ ] **Recipe of a clue** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea.
- [ ] **Sandwich** (15 min) Make a sandwich.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Kimberly's story came slowly, piece by piece. Write privately about a truth you could only tell slowly, and who gave you the time to tell it.

- [ ] **Telling slowly** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Landing** (20 min) Write about coming home late.

- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What will Johanna do?
- [ ] **Letter to Kimberly** (15 min) Write as Johanna.
- [ ] **Letter to Darrow** (15 min) Write thanks.
- [ ] **Rules** (15 min) Write about a rule you follow.
- [ ] **Shame** (15 min) Write about shame and telling.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Sideways Clue

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Incident Board

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Read about Christie.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Write.

Process

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Records Room

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Research subpoenas.
- [ ] Verdict.

The DVD Chain

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Diner

- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Draw.
- [ ] Present.

Kimberly's Story

Rooms: Driveway, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss shame.
- [ ] Debate protection.
- [ ] Reflect.

Arrivals

Rooms: Diner, Price Kitchen, Driveway

- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Make a meal.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Kuntz Exposed

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Law Office

- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Update the file.
- [ ] Analyse irony.
- [ ] Predict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 49 use an incidental detail to transform the investigation?
2. Essay: Analyse Johanna's choice of process over private action.
3. Creative: Write Darrow Fontera's account of the day Kuntz came for the DVD.

Further reading

- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). The incidental clue.
- *In the Woods*, Tana French (2007). Police process and its limits.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online harms to young women.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Confession and shame.
- *The Big Sleep*, Raymond Chandler (1939). Minor witnesses.
- *What the Dead Know*, Laura Lippman (2007). A seasoned investigator.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Surveillance records.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Data and court orders.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben's sideways clues.

50. Called to the Office

What happens

Adam wakes on a concrete floor, in pain. He hears voices: someone hit him too hard; they have his gun (he had none); he came here to kill them. He sees a pair of Adidas trainers. The stranger's voice asks why he killed Ingrid.

Meanwhile, Thomas is in AP English with Mr Ronkowitz when he's called to Principal Gorman's office. Walking there, he remembers his rant against Santa Claus: parents say they're protecting you when really they're lying, and then they wonder why kids stop trusting them. The family is a delicate ecosystem, and it has been thrown off balance since Mom came back from her conference.

Johanna is in the office. Dad didn't turn up at work and his phone is off. Thomas knows that Dad never switches his phone off. Then he remembers: the family tracking app shows each phone's last location. He looks it up.

Scene by scene

1. Adam wakes on concrete, in pain.
2. Voices: hit too hard; a gun; he came to kill us.
3. Adidas trainers; the stranger asks why he killed Ingrid.
4. Thomas in AP English; called to the principal's office.
5. Thomas's Santa Claus argument: protection as lying.
6. The family as an ecosystem, thrown off since the conference.
7. Johanna there: Dad missing; phone off.
8. Dad never switches his phone off.
9. The tracking app: last location; Thomas looks it up.

Who's here

Adam Price	Captive.
Thomas Price	A son who acts.
Johanna Griffin	Seeking Adam.
Principal Gorman	Host of the meeting.
The stranger	Interrogating Adam.

Thirty questions

1. Where does Adam wake?
2. What does the group accuse him of?
3. Why is Thomas called to the office?
4. What is Thomas's argument about Santa Claus?
5. What does Thomas know about his father's phone?
6. How does Thomas help?
7. **Is Thomas right about protective lies?** [book club]
8. **How does the tracking app's role reverse its earlier meaning?** [book club]
9. Why cut between Adam and Thomas?
10. **What does the ecosystem metaphor mean?** [book club]
11. Why does the group think Adam is dangerous?
12. How does the chapter treat Thomas's maturity?
13. What is the significance of the Adidas trainers?

14. **How does surveillance save here?** [book club]
15. How does the chapter use school as setting?
16. What does Johanna's presence show?
17. How does the chapter treat teenage cynicism?
18. When did the family ecosystem break?
19. Who has been lying to Thomas?
20. How does the chapter link the novel's themes?
21. What would you do in Thomas's place?
22. **Is the Santa Claus lie harmless?** [book club]
23. How does the chapter build double suspense?
24. How does the novel treat technology in families?
25. Is Thomas now the hero?
26. How does Adam feel waking up?
27. What does the group's misreading cost?
28. How does the chapter treat principals and schools?
29. **What do you think of family tracking apps?** [book club]
30. Predict what Thomas finds.

Close reading

1. Waking

Find it: Chapter 50, opening: the concrete floor.

1. Note the pain.
2. Note the voices.
3. Note the trainers.
4. Note the question.

How does the chapter disorient us with Adam?

2. Protection as lying

Find it: Chapter 50, middle: the Santa Claus argument.

1. Paraphrase Thomas's argument.
2. Note the ecosystem metaphor.
3. Note when it broke.
4. Consider the novel's view.

How does Thomas's argument echo the whole novel?

3. Surveillance as rescue

Find it: Chapter 50, close: the app.

1. Note Johanna's news.
2. Note Thomas's certainty.
3. Note the app.
4. Read the last line.

How does the novel let surveillance save a life?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A cross-cut chapter: captive father, resourceful son. Thomas's Santa Claus argument is a teenage version of the stranger's creed, and the tracking app that once spied on Adam now becomes a lifeline. The cut-off ending sustains double suspense.

- [ ] **Cross-cut** (20 min) Analyse the cross-cutting.
- [ ] **Teen creed** (15 min) Compare Thomas and the stranger.
- [ ] **Reversal** (15 min) Analyse the app's reversal.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Johanna's POV.
- [ ] **Split scene** (35 min) Write a cross-cut scene.
- [ ] **Disorientation** (15 min) Analyse the waking.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 48.
- [ ] **Metaphor** (15 min) Analyse the ecosystem.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the cliffhanger.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Protective lies, teenage trust and the ambivalence of surveillance. Thomas speaks for everyone lied to for their own good, and the novel lets him be right and wrong at once.

- [ ] **Protective lies** (25 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Teen trust** (20 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Surveillance** (20 min) Discuss saving vs spying.
- [ ] **Thomas** (15 min) Discuss Thomas as hero.
- [ ] **Santa** (20 min) Discuss the Santa debate.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "lifeline".
- [ ] **Families** (15 min) Discuss family ecosystems.
- [ ] **Schools** (15 min) Discuss schools in crises.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Psychologists disagree on Santa: some fear damage to trust; studies suggest most children take the discovery calmly. Family location apps are now widespread. AP courses offer college-level work in US high schools.

- [ ] **Santa research** (20 min) Research studies on Santa belief.
- [ ] **Location apps** (15 min) Research Life360 and Find My.
- [ ] **AP courses** (15 min) Research AP English.
- [ ] **Missing adults** (15 min) Research missing-adult reports.
- [ ] **Phone off** (15 min) Research last-known location.
- [ ] **School protocol** (15 min) Research school family-emergency protocols.
- [ ] **Head injury** (15 min) Research concussion.
- [ ] **Basements** (15 min) Research Pocono cabins.
- [ ] **Trust** (20 min) Research adolescent trust.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

J. D. Salinger's The Catcher in the Rye gives a teenager's fury at adult phoniness. Thomas shares Holden's sense of betrayal but turns it into action rather than drift.

- [ ] **Catcher** (20 min) Read about Salinger.
- [ ] **Hold Tight** (20 min) Compare teens and tracking.
- [ ] **Little Fires** (20 min) Compare teen honesty.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on lies to children.
- [ ] **Gopnik** (20 min) Read on parenting.
- [ ] **Zuboff** (20 min) Compare surveillance.
- [ ] **Fool Me Once** (20 min) Compare tracking.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a son.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A concrete basement in Pennsylvania and a principal's office in Cedarfield: two points on the map joined by a phone signal. The tracker will draw the line between them.

- [ ] **Two points** (15 min) Map the basement and school.
- [ ] **Tracker** (15 min) Draw the tracker line.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 50.
- [ ] **School** (15 min) Pin the high school.
- [ ] **Basement** (15 min) Pin the lake cabin.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Thomas's role.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Thomas and Johanna.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Thomas.
- [ ] **Distance** (15 min) Measure the distance.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is the Santa lie harmful? Thomas argues that protection is lying; the novel's adults have done exactly that. Yet the same family tracking app that violated privacy now saves Adam.

- [ ] **Santa lie** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to protective lies.
- [ ] **Tracking** (35 min) Write 300 words: spying or saving?
- [ ] **Group** (15 min) Is the group's fear reasonable?
- [ ] **School** (15 min) Should Thomas be involved?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the group file.
- [ ] **Trust** (15 min) Rate Thomas's trust in parents.
- [ ] **Protection** (15 min) When is protection lying?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a protective lie.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Adam captive; the group's misreading; Thomas with the app. Pin the tracker as the key that may find Adam, and the misreading that may kill him.

- [ ] **Captive** (15 min) Pin Adam captive.
- [ ] **Tracker** (15 min) Pin the app.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word rescue setup.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate the group.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note strands.
- [ ] **Misreading** (15 min) Pin the group's error.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (15 min) Use the tool.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A boy in a school office staring at a phone map, a woman beside him, and far away a man on a concrete floor: paint a split panel, bright and dark.

- [ ] **Split panel** (35 min) Paint the split scene.
- [ ] **Trainers** (15 min) Draw Adidas trainers on concrete.
- [ ] **App map** (15 min) Design the tracker map.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for Thomas.
- [ ] **Office** (15 min) Draw the principal's office.
- [ ] **Santa** (15 min) Draw Santa with a question mark.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a school corridor.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the map pin.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food here: a school office and a concrete floor. Hunger and fear sit in the background. Think about how quickly ordinary comforts vanish in an emergency.

- [ ] **Vanished comforts** (15 min) Discuss food's absence.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the last location.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the Santa lie.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: was Santa a good lie?
- [ ] **Making: family tech pact** (20 min) Write a family tech pact.
- [ ] **School lunch** (15 min) Make a school lunch.
- [ ] **Recipe of trust** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Cocoa** (15 min) Make cocoa.
- [ ] **Family dinner** (30 min) Plan a reunion dinner.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Thomas argues that parents call it protection when they lie. Write privately about a lie told to protect you, and whether you think it was right to tell it.

- [ ] **Protective lie** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Santa** (20 min) Write about learning the truth.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate suspense.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What does Thomas find?
- [ ] **Letter to Thomas** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to parents** (15 min) Write as Thomas.
- [ ] **Ecosystem** (15 min) Write about your family's balance.
- [ ] **Trust** (15 min) Write about earning trust back.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Santa Debate

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Records Room

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Research.
- [ ] Verdict.

Lifeline

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Law Office

- [ ] Pin the tracker.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Analyse reversal.
- [ ] Predict.

Thomas

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Write as Thomas.
- [ ] Read Catcher.
- [ ] Discuss.

Family Tech Pact

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Write a pact.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Cross-Cut

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Incident Board

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Paint a split.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Write.

Ecosystem

Rooms: Room 233, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 50 connect Thomas's Santa Claus argument to the novel's themes?
2. Essay: Analyse the reversal of the tracking app from spy to lifeline.
3. Creative: Write Thomas's walk to the principal's office.

Further reading

- *Hold Tight*, Harlan Coben (2008). Teens, parents and tracking.
- *Little Fires Everywhere*, Celeste Ng (2017). Teen honesty.
- *Lying: Moral Choice in Public and Private Life*, Sissela Bok (1978). Lies to children.
- *The Gardener and the Carpenter*, Alison Gopnik (2016). Parenting.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Surveillance.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben on tracking.
- *Unequal Childhoods*, Annette Lareau (2003). Family life.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). Transparency in families.
- *Everything I Never Told You*, Celeste Ng (2014). Family secrets.

51. The Bike Chain

What happens

Adam is chained by a bike chain to a pipe in the cabin's basement. Around him: Chris Taylor in his cap; Gabrielle; Merton, shaved head, tattoos and piercings, holding a gun sideways; Eduardo, long-haired, about thirty, with the beginnings of a beard. Merton kicks Adam with steel-toed boots. Gabrielle protests that she joined for quick, painless cash, not to hold a man prisoner. Adam insists he has killed no one. Where is his wife? He notices the chain is loosening.

Adam accuses them of blackmail, citing Suzanne. Chris answers with his philosophy: the internet makes deception easy, and they are evening the playing field. Nothing online is truly anonymous; human employees can always see. Adam points out that the group's anonymity seems to work fine for them. They've moved his car and pulled his phone battery. Then Adam tells them that Heidi Dann was murdered too. They didn't know. Merton insists Adam is a threat.

Chris then says something that changes everything. They never blackmailed Adam's wife. They never even spoke to her. They were hired, by an investigation firm called CBW. Adam knows that name. His world drops away. He asks them to untie him. Then a gunshot, and Merton's head explodes.

Scene by scene

1. Chained to a pipe with a bike chain.
2. The group: Chris, Gabrielle, Merton (gun held sideways), Eduardo.
3. Merton's steel-toed kicks.
4. Gabrielle: easy money, not kidnapping.
5. Adam: I killed no one; where's my wife?
6. The chain loosens.
7. Adam cites Suzanne; blackmail.
8. Chris's creed: evening the playing field; nothing anonymous; employees can see.
9. Adam: but not from you.
10. The car moved; phone battery out.
11. Adam: Heidi Dann was murdered too; they didn't know.
12. Chris: we never spoke to your wife; we were hired by CBW.
13. Adam knows the name; his world drops.
14. Untie me. A gunshot: Merton is killed.

Who's here

Adam Price	Chained, arguing, stunned.
Chris Taylor	The founder, explaining.
Gabrielle Dunbar	Out of her depth.
Merton	Violent, then killed.
Eduardo	Watching.

Thirty questions

1. How is Adam held?
2. Describe the four captors.
3. What does Gabrielle say about the job?
4. What is Chris's defence of the group?
5. What do they learn from Adam?
6. What does Chris reveal about Corinne?
7. Who is CBW to Adam?
8. What happens at the end?
9. **How does the revelation that they were hired change everything?** [book club]
10. **Is Chris's defence persuasive?** [book club]
11. **How does Adam turn the argument about anonymity?** [book club]
12. What does Heidi's murder mean to the group?
13. How does the chapter build tension?
14. Why is Merton so violent?
15. How do the captors disagree?
16. What does the loosening chain promise?
17. **How does the chapter treat amateurs in over their heads?** [book club]
18. What does the gunshot mean?
19. Who might be shooting?
20. **How does this chapter change your view of chapter 1?** [book club]
21. How do misunderstandings drive violence here?
22. What does the bike chain symbolise?
23. Is Gabrielle innocent?
24. Is Eduardo dangerous?
25. What does Adam's calm suggest?
26. How does Chris's philosophy fail him here?
27. What does hired mean for Corinne's story?
28. What would you have said in Adam's position?
29. **How does the novel use sudden violence?** [book club]
30. Predict who is outside.

Close reading

1. Captors

Find it: Chapter 51, opening: the basement.

1. Describe the chain.
2. Describe each captor.
3. Note Merton's kicks.
4. Note Gabrielle's complaint.

How does the chapter differentiate the captors?

2. Philosophy under pressure

Find it: Chapter 51, middle: the argument.

1. Note Adam's accusation.
2. Paraphrase Chris's defence.
3. Note Adam's retort.
4. Note the Heidi news.

How does Adam win the argument while chained?

3. Double shock

Find it: Chapter 51, close: CBW and the shot.

1. Note what Chris reveals.
2. Note the firm's name.
3. Note Adam's reaction.
4. Note the gunshot.

How does the chapter stack two shocks?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A hostage chapter staged as a debate. Adam, chained, out-argues his captors; the revelation that the job was commissioned flips the mystery; the gunshot flips the scene. Two shocks in quick succession make this one of the novel's most powerful turns.

- ☐ **Debate** (20 min) Analyse the hostage debate.
- ☐ **Double shock** (15 min) Analyse the two shocks.
- ☐ **Captors** (15 min) Analyse differentiation.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Gabrielle's POV.
- ☐ **Hostage scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word hostage debate.
- ☐ **Chain** (15 min) Analyse the chain as motif.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 50.
- ☐ **Reveal** (15 min) Analyse the CBW reveal.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the gunshot.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Vigilantism, anonymity and the limits of good intentions. The group's philosophy meets real violence, and fails. Amateurs who thought exposure was clean find themselves in a basement with a gun.

- ☐ **Vigilantism** (25 min) Discuss.
- ☐ **Anonymity** (20 min) Discuss Adam's retort.
- ☐ **Amateurs** (20 min) Discuss amateurs and violence.
- ☐ **Hired** (20 min) Discuss the meaning of hired.
- ☐ **Misjudgment** (15 min) Discuss the group's error.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "commissioned".
- ☐ **Violence** (15 min) Discuss sudden violence.
- ☐ **Heidi** (15 min) Discuss the group's shock.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Platform employees can often see user data, as Chris says; anonymity online is rarely absolute. Private investigation firms are licensed in most US states. Bike-chain locks are notoriously heavy.

- [ ] **Investigator licensing** (20 min) Research PI licensing.
- [ ] **Data access** (20 min) Research employee data access.
- [ ] **Kidnapping law** (15 min) Research kidnapping charges.
- [ ] **Chain locks** (15 min) Research bike chains.
- [ ] **Steel toes** (15 min) Research work boots.
- [ ] **Phone batteries** (15 min) Research removing batteries.
- [ ] **Cabin basements** (15 min) Research Pocono cabins.
- [ ] **Hostage negotiation** (20 min) Research basics.
- [ ] **Gun handling** (15 min) Research why sideways grips are inaccurate.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Agatha Christie's And Then There Were None picks off a group in an isolated house. Joseph Conrad's The Secret Agent shows idealists out of their depth with violence.

- [ ] **And Then There Were None** (20 min) Compare isolated groups.
- [ ] **Secret Agent** (20 min) Read about Conrad.
- [ ] **Ronson** (20 min) Read on shaming's costs.
- [ ] **Kingpin** (20 min) Compare a crusader's fall.
- [ ] **The Circle** (20 min) Compare transparency.
- [ ] **Deliverance** (20 min) Compare violence in the woods.
- [ ] **Solove** (20 min) Read on anonymity.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about chains.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A cabin basement by a private lake in Pennsylvania, far from help, with Adam's car moved and phone dead. Only Thomas's tracker points here. Somewhere outside, someone else has followed.

- [ ] **Basement** (15 min) Pin the cabin.
- [ ] **Isolation** (15 min) Mark help's distance.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 51.
- [ ] **Car** (15 min) Guess where the car was moved.
- [ ] **Shooter** (15 min) Imagine the shooter's position.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add CBW.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Draw who hired whom.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place CBW.
- [ ] **Tracker** (15 min) Draw Thomas's line here.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Does evening the playing field justify the group? Chris's argument has some force, but the basement shows its costs: the group misjudged Adam, and now people are dying.

- [ ] **Playing field** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the group.
- [ ] **Vigilantes** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Kidnap** (15 min) Is chaining Adam justified by fear?
- [ ] **Hired** (15 min) Who bears blame for Corinne's exposure?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the group file.
- [ ] **Gabrielle** (15 min) Rate her guilt.
- [ ] **Merton** (15 min) Rate his guilt.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a fact that changed everything.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Major reveal: the group was hired by CBW, and Adam recognises it. Pin CBW and the question of who hired them. And pin the shooter outside.

- [ ] **CBW** (15 min) Pin CBW.
- [ ] **Hired** (15 min) Pin the commission.
- [ ] **Shooter** (15 min) Pin the gunshot.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word aftermath.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate who hired CBW.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Note convergence.
- [ ] **Heidi** (15 min) Pin the group's ignorance.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A basement with a single bulb, a man chained to a pipe, four figures in shadow, a gun held sideways: paint it in harsh light and deep black. Then a flash.

- [ ] **Basement** (35 min) Paint the basement.
- [ ] **Chain** (15 min) Draw a bike chain.
- [ ] **Flash** (20 min) Paint a muzzle flash.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a tense theme.
- [ ] **Captors** (20 min) Draw the four.
- [ ] **CBW** (15 min) Design a firm's logo.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a basement.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the chain.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food in a basement prison. The absence underlines how far Adam has fallen from Cedarfield's kitchens and team dinners into the bare cellar of the plot.

- [ ] **Cellar** (15 min) Discuss food's absence.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record CBW.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the commission.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: who hires investigators?
- [ ] **Making: who-knew chart** (20 min) Chart who knew what.
- [ ] **Water** (15 min) Pour water: what Adam needs.
- [ ] **Recipe of a misjudgment** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Rescue meal** (15 min) Plan a rescue meal.
- [ ] **Coffee** (15 min) Make coffee and discuss.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Chris tells Adam that the group was hired, and Adam's world drops away. Write privately about a moment when a single fact rearranged everything you thought you knew.

- [ ] **Changed everything** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Chained** (20 min) Write about feeling trapped.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate shock.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) Who is shooting?
- [ ] **Letter to Chris** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Gabrielle** (15 min) Write.
- [ ] **Hired** (15 min) Write about who might hire CBW.
- [ ] **Violence** (15 min) Write about sudden violence.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Hostage Debate

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Room 233

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.

Hired

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Pin CBW.
- [ ] Map who hired whom.
- [ ] Debate blame.
- [ ] Predict.

Basement

Rooms: Diner, Driveway, Law Office

- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Write the hostage scene.
- [ ] Discuss.

Vigilantes

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Read Conrad.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Captors

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Diner

- [ ] Pin each.
- [ ] Rate guilt.
- [ ] Draw.
- [ ] Discuss.

Double Shock

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 51 reverse the novel's mystery?
2. Essay: Analyse the hostage debate between Adam and Chris.
3. Creative: Write the basement from Eduardo's point of view.

Further reading

- *So You've Been Publicly Shamed*, Jon Ronson (2015). Shaming's costs.
- *American Kingpin*, Nick Bilton (2017). A crusader's fall.
- *The Circle*, Dave Eggers (2013). Transparency's violence.
- *The Future of Reputation*, Daniel J. Solove (2007). Anonymity and data.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). A twist that rearranges everything.
- *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, Danielle Keats Citron (2014). Online harms.
- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Shoshana Zuboff (2019). Who sees the data.
- *Strangers on a Train*, Patricia Highsmith (1950). Strangers and hired harm.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben on violence and truth.

52. Eight Rounds

What happens

Kuntz got the garage address from Ingrid before he killed her; under his knife she gave up every detail and pleaded for the end. He followed Eduardo over the Dingmans Ferry Bridge to the lake. He knows their names now: Merton Sules, Gabrielle Dunbar. He watched someone take a bat to Adam and was surprised, because Ingrid had said the group was non-violent. Chris arrived later. Kuntz waited for hours with his Sig Sauer P239 and its eight nine-millimetre rounds.

Listening, he learns that the group doesn't know who killed Ingrid, and that Adam has connected Heidi to it. That makes them all a danger to the IPO, and so to Robby. He tells himself it is for his son. When Eduardo spots him at the window, Kuntz fires: Merton, then Eduardo.

Meanwhile Johanna, with Thomas, has found Adam's last location: Lake Charmaine, near Dingmans Ferry in Pennsylvania. She calls the Shohola Township police and Sheriff Lowell. They begin going door to door.

Scene by scene

1. Ingrid gave Kuntz everything before she died.
2. Kuntz tails Eduardo over the Dingmans Ferry Bridge.
3. He knows the names: Merton Sules, Gabrielle Dunbar.
4. He watched the bat attack, surprised.
5. Chris arrives; Kuntz waits hours; Sig Sauer P239, eight rounds.
6. He learns they don't know who killed Ingrid; Adam knows about Heidi.
7. His justification: Robby.
8. Eduardo spots him; Kuntz shoots Merton and Eduardo.
9. Johanna and Thomas locate the lake; local police go door to door.

Who's here

John Kuntz	Killer, waiting.
Merton Sules	Shot.
Eduardo	Shot.
Johanna Griffin	Coordinating the search.
Sheriff Lowell	Local law (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. How did Kuntz find the garage?
2. How did he reach the lake?
3. What did he see?
4. Why does he wait?
5. What does he learn by listening?
6. What does he do when spotted?
7. **How does Kuntz justify the killings?** [book club]
8. How does the chapter use cross-cutting?
9. What does the detail of eight rounds add?
10. Why was Kuntz surprised by the bat?
11. **How does the chapter make us dread the count?** [book club]
12. Compare Kuntz's patience with Adam's rashness.
13. How does Johanna find the lake?
14. What role does Thomas play?
15. Is Kuntz a professional?

16. **How does the chapter treat Ingrid's death?** [book club]
17. What does Robby's name do in Kuntz's mind?
18. How does local policing enter the novel?
19. What would you feel as Johanna?
20. How does the chapter create a race against time?
21. **Is there any sympathy left for Kuntz?** [book club]
22. **What does the chapter say about violence and love?** [book club]
23. How does the novel treat guns?
24. Why name the gun so precisely?
25. What do the names Merton Sules and Gabrielle Dunbar add?
26. How does the group's innocence of murder matter?
27. **What does Kuntz fear?** [book club]
28. How does this chapter mirror chapter 21?
29. What will Johanna find?
30. Predict how Adam survives.

Close reading

1. Cruelty recalled

Find it: Chapter 52, opening: Ingrid's last words.

1. Note what Ingrid gave.
2. Note how.
3. Note Kuntz's tone.
4. Consider the narration.

How does the chapter handle Kuntz's cruelty without dwelling on it?

2. Patience as menace

Find it: Chapter 52, middle: waiting.

1. Note the gun.
2. Note the waiting.
3. Note what he overhears.
4. Note his reasoning.

How does patience make Kuntz more frightening?

3. Race

Find it: Chapter 52, close: shots and search.

1. Note who spots him.
2. Note the shots.
3. Cut to Johanna.
4. Note the door-to-door.

How does cross-cutting create a race against time?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A cross-cut chapter: killer's patience, then search party. Precise details (eight rounds, a named pistol) create a countdown. The narration stays cool, letting Kuntz's self-justification condemn him.

- [ ] **Countdown** (20 min) Analyse the rounds as countdown.
- [ ] **Cross-cut** (15 min) Analyse the race.
- [ ] **Cool narration** (15 min) Analyse the tone.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Johanna's POV.
- [ ] **Race scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word race scene.
- [ ] **Precision** (15 min) Analyse named weapons.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 21.
- [ ] **Justification** (15 min) Analyse his logic.
- [ ] **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the door-to-door.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Love as a motive for murder; the banality of a killer's logic; the race between violence and rescue. The novel insists that explaining Kuntz is not excusing him.

- [ ] **Love and murder** (25 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Banality** (20 min) Discuss a killer's logic.
- [ ] **Rescue** (20 min) Discuss Johanna and Thomas.
- [ ] **Rural policing** (15 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Guns** (15 min) Discuss.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "countdown".
- [ ] **Ingrid** (20 min) Discuss her death with care.
- [ ] **Sympathy** (15 min) Discuss remaining sympathy.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

The Sig Sauer P239 was a compact pistol discontinued around 2018. Shohola Township is in Pike County, Pennsylvania. Local police canvass door to door when searching for missing people in rural areas.

- [ ] **P239** (15 min) Research the pistol.
- [ ] **Shohola** (15 min) Research the township.
- [ ] **Pike County** (15 min) Research the county.
- [ ] **Canvassing** (15 min) Research door-to-door searches.
- [ ] **Cross-border** (15 min) Research NJ–PA police cooperation.
- [ ] **Phone location** (15 min) Research last-known-location accuracy.
- [ ] **Hostage response** (15 min) Research rural SWAT.
- [ ] **Murder statistics** (15 min) Research multiple homicides.
- [ ] **Delaware River** (15 min) Research the river.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Truman Capote's In Cold Blood shows killers' logic coolly; Cormac McCarthy's No Country for Old Men gives a patient, terrifying killer. Kuntz belongs to that line, made pitiable and monstrous by his love for a child.

- [ ] **In Cold Blood** (20 min) Read about Capote.
- [ ] **No Country** (20 min) Read about McCarthy's killer.
- [ ] **Crime and Punishment** (20 min) Compare justification.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare fathers and violence.
- [ ] **Gone Baby Gone** (20 min) Compare rescue.
- [ ] **Ripley** (20 min) Compare cool killers.
- [ ] **Sandel** (20 min) Read on love and duty.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a vigil.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Dingmans Ferry Bridge, Lake Charmaine, Shohola Township in Pike County: the climax converges on a rural corner of Pennsylvania where the nearest police are local and few.

- [ ] **Bridge** (15 min) Pin Dingmans Ferry.
- [ ] **Lake** (15 min) Pin the cabin.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 52.
- [ ] **Shohola** (15 min) Pin the police.
- [ ] **Race map** (15 min) Draw the race.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add Kuntz at the lake.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Link Thomas to the search.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Sheriff Lowell.
- [ ] **Terrain** (15 min) Note the woods.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Does love excuse murder? Every ethical lens says no; yet the novel makes us feel Kuntz's logic. That discomfort is the point.

- [ ] **Love excuses?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Kuntz.
- [ ] **Explain vs excuse** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Ingrid** (15 min) What did she deserve?
- [ ] **Group** (15 min) Did the group deserve this?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Kuntz charges.
- [ ] **Thomas** (15 min) Was involving Thomas right?
- [ ] **Police** (15 min) Should Johanna wait for police?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about love as excuse.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Kuntz at the lake; Merton and Eduardo shot; Johanna and local police closing in. Pin the race and the count of rounds. Note too what Kuntz overhears: he now knows the group is innocent of Ingrid.

- [ ] **Kuntz** (15 min) Pin him at the lake.
- [ ] **Count** (15 min) Pin the rounds.
- [ ] **Search** (15 min) Pin the search.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word shooting aftermath.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark convergence.
- [ ] **Victims** (15 min) List victims so far.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A wooded slope above a cabin, a man crouched with a pistol, a lake beyond; then a police cruiser on a dirt road: paint a two-part scene.

- [ ] **Two-part scene** (35 min) Paint the slope and the cruiser.
- [ ] **Pistol** (15 min) Draw a silhouette only.
- [ ] **Cruiser** (20 min) Paint a police car on a dirt road.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a countdown theme.
- [ ] **Trees** (20 min) Paint woods at dusk.
- [ ] **Map** (15 min) Design the search map.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a shot in woods.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the slope.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Hours of waiting with no food: Kuntz's discipline and coldness. Contrast it with the warm, chaotic kitchens of the Price family and Cedarfield.

- [ ] **No food** (15 min) Contrast with Cedarfield kitchens.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the rounds.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add how Kuntz found the group.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: can love excuse?
- [ ] **Making: rescue flask** (15 min) Make a flask of tea for searchers.
- [ ] **Searcher sandwiches** (15 min) Make sandwiches.
- [ ] **Recipe of patience** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Soup** (40 min) Make soup for waiting.
- [ ] **Water** (15 min) Pack water.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Kuntz tells himself he kills for his son. Write privately about how love can become an excuse, and the line you would never cross for anyone, however much you loved them.

- [ ] **Love as excuse** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Line** (20 min) Write about a line you won't cross.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate dread.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) How does Adam survive?
- [ ] **Letter to Robby** (15 min) Write about his father.
- [ ] **Letter to Ingrid** (15 min) Write a memorial.
- [ ] **Waiting** (15 min) Write about waiting for news.
- [ ] **Search** (15 min) Write about searching for someone.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Countdown

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Diner

- [ ] Analyse the rounds.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Write.

Love and Murder

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Search

Rooms: Turnpike, Incident Board, Price Kitchen

- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Make a searchers' flask.
- [ ] Discuss.

Cold Killers

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Law Office

- [ ] Read Capote.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Compare.
- [ ] Write.

Victims

Rooms: Incident Board, Driveway, Room 233

- [ ] List victims.
- [ ] Write memorials.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Reflect.

Rural Policing

Rooms: Records Room, Turnpike, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Research.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Present.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 52 create suspense through cross-cutting and precise detail?
2. Essay: Analyse how the novel presents Kuntz's logic without excusing it.
3. Creative: Write the door-to-door search from Sheriff Lowell's view.

Further reading

- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). The self-justifying killer.
- *The Talented Mr. Ripley*, Patricia Highsmith (1955). A cool killer.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Fathers and violence.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Searches and rescue.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Love and duty.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A father's desperation.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben's violent climaxes.
- *The Woods*, Harlan Coben (2007). Danger in the woods.
- *Strangers on a Train*, Patricia Highsmith (1950). Strangers and murder.

53. The Basement

What happens

Adam has his right hand free. Merton's blood and brains are on his face. Chris dives through the basement window as shots follow him; he may have been hit. Adam scrambles under the stairs. Gabrielle pleads with the gunman, and is executed.

Adam lunges for Merton's gun. Kuntz kicks it away under a chest of drawers and takes aim. Then a foot comes through the window, Chris's, and kicks Kuntz in the head; Kuntz fires twice out of the window. Adam swings the bike chain like a whip, punches, grapples Kuntz in a bear hug. Sirens sound in the distance.

Kuntz drives punches into Adam's kidneys. Adam bites his wrist, wrenches away the Sig Sauer, and smashes the butt into Kuntz's nose. Standing over him, gun in hand, Adam asks what he did to his wife.

Scene by scene

1. Adam's right hand is free.
2. Chris escapes through the window, maybe hit.
3. Adam hides under the stairs.
4. Gabrielle pleads; she is killed.
5. Adam dives for Merton's gun; Kuntz kicks it away.
6. Chris kicks Kuntz through the window; Kuntz fires out.
7. Adam swings the chain, punches, bear-hugs.
8. Sirens; kidney punches.
9. Adam bites, takes the gun, strikes Kuntz.
10. What did you do to my wife?

Who's here

Adam Price	Fighting for his life.
John Kuntz	The gunman.
Chris Taylor	Escaping, then helping.
Gabrielle Dunbar	Killed.

Thirty questions

1. How does Adam get free?
2. What happens to Chris?
3. What happens to Gabrielle?
4. How does Chris help Adam?
5. How does Adam disarm Kuntz?
6. What does Adam ask at the end?
7. **How does the chapter stage violence?** [book club]
8. **Why does Chris come back to help?** [book club]
9. **How does Gabrielle's death affect you?** [book club]
10. What does the bike chain become?
11. **Why does Adam ask about his wife first?** [book club]
12. How does the chapter use sound?
13. Is Adam heroic here?
14. How realistic is the fight?
15. What does biting suggest?
16. How does the chapter treat Chris?
17. What does the window represent?

18. **How does the novel treat the deaths of the group?** [book club]
19. What does Adam feel?
20. How does the chapter end?
21. Compare this fight with the novel's earlier violence.
22. What is the effect of the sirens?
23. Is Kuntz defeated?
24. What does Adam owe Chris?
25. How does the chapter use space?
26. What does Adam's question reveal about his priorities?
27. How does the novel use thriller conventions?
28. Did Adam want to kill Kuntz?
29. **How should the group be remembered?** [book club]
30. Predict what Kuntz says.

Close reading

1. Chaos

Find it: Chapter 53, opening: the shots.

1. Note Adam's free hand.
2. Note Chris's escape.
3. Note Adam's hiding place.
4. Note Gabrielle's plea.

How does the chapter convey chaos and horror?

2. Choreography

Find it: Chapter 53, middle: the struggle.

1. Note the gun under the drawers.
2. Note Chris's kick.
3. Note the chain.
4. Note the sirens.

How does the chapter keep a chaotic fight clear?

3. Priorities

Find it: Chapter 53, close: the question.

1. Note the bite.
2. Note the gun.
3. Note the blow.
4. Note the question.

Why does Adam's first question concern Corinne?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A pure action chapter, choreographed in short sentences. Every object (window, drawers, chain, stairs) becomes part of the fight. The final question turns physical victory back to the novel's mystery.

- [ ] **Choreography** (20 min) Analyse the fight's clarity.
- [ ] **Objects** (15 min) List objects in the fight.
- [ ] **Short sentences** (15 min) Analyse sentence length.
- [ ] **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Chris's POV.
- [ ] **Fight scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word amateur fight.
- [ ] **Final question** (15 min) Analyse the ending.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 52.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Analyse sirens.
- [ ] **Redemption** (15 min) Analyse Chris's kick.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Violence and its victims; the group's deaths; Chris's redemption-by-kick. The novel refuses to make the deaths glamorous; Gabrielle's plea is the chapter's moral weight.

- [ ] **Deaths** (25 min) Discuss the group's deaths.
- [ ] **Glamour** (20 min) Discuss unglamorous violence.
- [ ] **Chris** (20 min) Discuss his return.
- [ ] **Amateur hero** (15 min) Discuss Adam.
- [ ] **Priorities** (15 min) Discuss Adam's question.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "survival".
- [ ] **Thriller form** (15 min) Discuss conventions.
- [ ] **Mourning** (15 min) Discuss mourning minor characters.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Real fights are typically brief and chaotic; thrillers compress and clarify them. Police sirens vary in pattern. Improvised weapons such as chains appear in many crime narratives.

- [ ] **Real fights** (20 min) Research how real fights unfold.
- [ ] **Sirens** (15 min) Research siren patterns.
- [ ] **Self-defence** (20 min) Research self-defence law in PA.
- [ ] **Trauma** (15 min) Research acute stress.
- [ ] **Kidney punches** (15 min) Research kidney injury.
- [ ] **Bites** (15 min) Research human bites.
- [ ] **Crime scenes** (15 min) Research scene processing.
- [ ] **Survivors** (20 min) Research survivor guilt.
- [ ] **Police response** (15 min) Research rural response times.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Lee Child's Jack Reacher novels choreograph fights with technical precision. Coben's fights, by contrast, emphasise the amateur's desperation: Adam bites, flails and survives.

- [ ] **Reacher** (20 min) Read about Lee Child.
- [ ] **Deliverance** (20 min) Compare survival.
- [ ] **No Country** (20 min) Compare violence.
- [ ] **And Then There Were None** (20 min) Compare deaths.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare violence's cost.
- [ ] **Gone Baby Gone** (20 min) Compare climaxes.
- [ ] **The Woods** (20 min) Compare Coben's climaxes.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about survival.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

A cabin basement by a Pennsylvania lake: the novel's smallest and most violent space. Outside, sirens on the dirt road. The tracker has brought help, just in time.

- [ ] **Basement** (15 min) Map the basement.
- [ ] **Window** (15 min) Mark the window.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 53.
- [ ] **Chris's route** (15 min) Imagine Chris's escape.
- [ ] **Sirens** (15 min) Map the police approach.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Mark casualties.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Update the group network.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Chris as fugitive.
- [ ] **Lake** (15 min) Pin the scene.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Did the group deserve any of this? Their exposures caused harm, but none deserved death. Care ethics mourns them; justice condemns Kuntz alone.

- [ ] **Deserved?** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to the group's fate.
- [ ] **Self-defence** (35 min) Write 300 words on Adam's violence.
- [ ] **Chris** (15 min) Does the kick redeem him?
- [ ] **Mercy** (15 min) Should Adam spare Kuntz?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the Kuntz charges.
- [ ] **Gabrielle** (15 min) Write a memorial line.
- [ ] **Justice** (15 min) What justice now?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about mourning a minor character.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Kuntz disarmed; Gabrielle, Merton, Eduardo dead; Chris fled. Pin the casualties and the question Adam asks: what about Corinne?

- [ ] **Casualties** (15 min) Pin the dead.
- [ ] **Disarmed** (15 min) Pin Kuntz disarmed.
- [ ] **Question** (15 min) Pin Adam's question.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word aftermath.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark the climax.
- [ ] **Chris** (15 min) Pin Chris as fugitive.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A basement in chaos, broken window, a chest of drawers, a man standing over another with a gun: paint it with a flare of light from the window and red tones.

- [ ] **Basement chaos** (35 min) Paint it.
- [ ] **Window flare** (20 min) Paint light through a broken window.
- [ ] **Chain whip** (15 min) Draw motion lines.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a fight theme.
- [ ] **Stairs** (15 min) Draw under the stairs.
- [ ] **Memorial** (15 min) Design a memorial card for the group.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe sirens through trees.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the window.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food in a fight. Afterwards, survivors need water, warmth and something simple to hold. Think about what you would offer Adam.

- [ ] **Aftermath** (15 min) Plan what to offer a survivor.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record casualties.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Adam's question.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: how should fiction treat death?
- [ ] **Making: memorial candle** (15 min) Light a candle for the fictional dead.
- [ ] **Sweet tea** (15 min) Make sweet tea for shock.
- [ ] **Recipe of survival** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Broth** (40 min) Make broth.
- [ ] **Water** (15 min) Pour water.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Gabrielle pleaded and was killed. Write privately about how fiction should treat the deaths of minor characters, and whether you mourned her as you read.

- [ ] **Mourning** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Survival** (20 min) Write about surviving something.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What does Kuntz say?
- [ ] **Letter to Gabrielle's kids** (15 min) Write gently.
- [ ] **Letter to Chris** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Fight** (15 min) Write about fighting back.
- [ ] **Priorities** (15 min) Write about what you'd ask first.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

Choreography

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Incident Board

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Write.

The Group's End

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Write memorials.
- [ ] Reflect.

Chris Returns

Rooms: Law Office, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board

- [ ] Write his POV.
- [ ] Debate redemption.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Discuss.

Amateur Hero

Rooms: Library Stacks, Room 233, Law Office

- [ ] Read about Reacher.
- [ ] Compare.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write.

Aftermath

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Driveway, Lacrosse Field

- [ ] Make sweet tea.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Debate justice.
- [ ] Reflect.

The Question

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Driveway

- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Predict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 53 choreograph violence, and to what end?
2. Essay: Analyse the novel's treatment of the group's deaths.
3. Creative: Write the basement from Chris's point of view as he escapes and returns.

Further reading

- *The Woods*, Harlan Coben (2007). Coben's climaxes.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). The cost of violence.
- *Gone, Baby, Gone*, Dennis Lehane (1998). Violent climaxes.
- *Strangers on a Train*, Patricia Highsmith (1950). Strangers and murder.
- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). The aftermath of killing.
- *Suburbia*, Bill Owens (1973). Violence in nature.
- *Dare Me*, Megan Abbott (2012). Rash courage.
- *Fool Me Once*, Harlan Coben (2016). Coben's violence.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). A closed space and its secrets.

54. Beth Lutheran Lot

What happens

Local police arrive with Johanna, who called them in via Thomas. Adam answers only what he is asked. Kuntz turns out to be an ex-cop, head of security for a start-up with an imminent IPO, and the father of a sick child. Adam refuses the hospital. His car is evidence, so Johanna drives him home. On the way, she says they aren't done yet: she's worried about Corinne. Adam claims Occam's razor: Corinne needed time and will come back. The boys are resilient, he says. They are staying at Kristin Hoy's.

At home, Corinne's minivan sits in the driveway; it still smells of her. Adam had pocketed Merton's gun from under the chest of drawers while pretending to look for his phone; the phone turns up upstairs, battery removed. He writes an email to Gribbel marked not to be read until tomorrow morning, for passing to Johanna and Rinsky.

At the Beth Lutheran gym car park, Adam punches Bob Baime and puts the gun to his neck. Bob confesses: he hired his cousin Daz's firm, CBW, to dig up dirt on Corinne; Daz put her name out to unorthodox sources, which led to the group with its own rules. Bob is in despair (foreclosure, Melanie leaving, insurance that would leave the boys better off without him). He didn't steal the money: Tripp had warned him that Corinne meant to make him the scapegoat. Then something niggles. Tripp has five children, three boys and two girls. The text Adam got said the kids. Corinne always said the boys.

Scene by scene

1. Police and Johanna arrive, summoned through Thomas.
2. Adam answers only what's asked.
3. Kuntz identified: ex-cop, IPO security, sick child.
4. Johanna drives Adam home; she worries about Corinne.
5. Adam cites Occam's razor; the boys at Kristin Hoy's.
6. Corinne's minivan in the driveway, smelling of her.
7. The pocketed gun; the phone upstairs, battery out.
8. An email to Gribbel: not to be read until morning.
9. Beth Lutheran car park: Adam hits Bob, gun to his neck.
10. Bob hired cousin Daz's firm CBW to dig into Corinne.
11. Bob's despair: foreclosure, Melanie, insurance.
12. Bob didn't steal; Tripp told him Corinne would blame him.
13. Tripp has five kids; the text said the kids; Corinne said the boys.

Who's here

Adam Price	Armed and certain.
Bob Baime	Desperate, confessing.
Johanna Griffin	Worried ally.
Kristin Hoy	Minding the boys (offstage).

Thirty questions

1. How did police find Adam?
2. What do we learn about Kuntz?
3. Why does Adam cite Occam's razor?
4. What does Adam pocket at the cabin?
5. What does Bob confess?
6. What clue niggles Adam?
7. **Why does Adam lie to Johanna?** [book club]
8. What does the minivan's smell do to Adam?
9. **Is threatening Bob justified?** [book club]
10. **How does Bob's despair change your view of him?** [book club]
11. Why did Bob hire CBW?
12. How did Tripp manipulate Bob?
13. **What does the kids vs the boys reveal?** [book club]
14. **How does language become evidence?** [book club]
15. What is the email to Gribbel for?
16. How does the chapter shift the mystery?
17. Is Adam becoming dangerous?
18. What does the gym car park setting add?
19. **How does the chapter treat male despair?** [book club]
20. Why does Adam answer only what is asked?
21. Is Occam's razor right here?
22. What do you now suspect?
23. How does Tripp's family size matter?
24. What does Bob's insurance reasoning reveal?
25. How does the chapter revisit chapter 2?
26. Why does Adam not tell Johanna his plan?
27. What would you do with this realisation?
28. How does the novel use small verbal clues?
29. Is Bob a villain?
30. Predict what Adam does next.

Close reading

1. Concealment

Find it: Chapter 54, opening: aftermath and the drive.

1. Note what Adam answers.
2. Note Kuntz's identity.
3. Note Johanna's worry.
4. Note Adam's razor.

Why does Adam conceal his fears from Johanna?

2. Preparation

Find it: Chapter 54, middle: home.

1. Note the minivan.
2. Note the gun.
3. Note the phone.
4. Note the email.

What do Adam's preparations reveal?

3. A word

Find it: Chapter 54, close: Bob and the clue.

1. Note Bob's confession.
2. Note his despair.
3. Note Tripp's lie.
4. Note the kids/boys clue.

How does a single word become decisive?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

A chapter of quiet preparation followed by violent confrontation. The final clue is purely linguistic: a single phrase that Corinne would never have used. Coben has planted it since the text arrived, and the reveal rewards attentive readers.

- ☐ **Linguistic clue** (20 min) Analyse the kids/boys clue.
- ☐ **Planting** (15 min) Find where the text was planted.
- ☐ **Preparation** (15 min) Analyse Adam's preparations.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Bob's POV.
- ☐ **Confrontation** (35 min) Write a 300-word confrontation.
- ☐ **Concealment** (15 min) Analyse Adam's answers.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 53.
- ☐ **Smell** (15 min) Analyse the minivan.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the realisation.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Male despair, manipulation, and language as identity. Bob's collapse shows the private ruin behind suburban fronts; the kids/boys clue shows how intimately spouses know each other's words.

- ☐ **Male despair** (25 min) Discuss Bob.
- ☐ **Manipulation** (20 min) Discuss Tripp's manipulation.
- ☐ **Language** (20 min) Discuss language as identity.
- ☐ **Guns** (15 min) Discuss Adam with a gun.
- ☐ **Occam** (15 min) Discuss simple explanations.
- ☐ **Theme update** (15 min) Add "idiolect".
- ☐ **Suburban fronts** (15 min) Discuss private ruin.
- ☐ **Revenge** (15 min) Discuss revenge.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Occam's razor is attributed to William of Ockham. Forensic linguistics uses idiolect to attribute texts. Many US life policies have a two-year suicide exclusion. Foreclosures surged after 2008.

- [ ] **Occam** (15 min) Research William of Ockham.
- [ ] **Forensic linguistics** (20 min) Research idiolect analysis.
- [ ] **Unabomber** (20 min) Research the linguistic identification.
- [ ] **Foreclosure** (15 min) Research US foreclosure.
- [ ] **Suicide clauses** (15 min) Research life-insurance exclusions.
- [ ] **PIs** (15 min) Research hiring a PI.
- [ ] **Assault** (15 min) Research NJ assault law.
- [ ] **Scent memory** (15 min) Research smell and memory.
- [ ] **Men's mental health** (20 min) Research help for men in crisis.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Christie's A Murder Is Announced turns on a verbal slip. In Gone Girl, each spouse's words betray them. The Unabomber was identified partly through his idiolect, a real case of linguistic detection.

- [ ] **Murder Is Announced** (20 min) Read about Christie's verbal clue.
- [ ] **Gone Girl** (20 min) Compare words that betray.
- [ ] **Proust** (15 min) Read about the madeleine and memory.
- [ ] **Salesman** (20 min) Compare Bob and Willy Loman.
- [ ] **Revolutionary Road** (20 min) Compare collapse.
- [ ] **Pinker or linguistics** (20 min) Find a book on how we speak.
- [ ] **Caught** (20 min) Compare suburban ruin.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain poem about a voice.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

The lake cabin, the drive home, the Price driveway, and the Beth Lutheran gym car park: a return to Cedarfield's ordinary spaces, now charged with a gun and a plan.

- [ ] **Drive home** (15 min) Map it.
- [ ] **Gym lot** (15 min) Pin Beth Lutheran.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 54.
- [ ] **Kristin's** (15 min) Pin where the boys are.
- [ ] **Driveway** (15 min) Mark the minivan.
- [ ] **Case map** (15 min) Add CBW and Bob.
- [ ] **Network** (15 min) Draw Bob, Daz, CBW, group.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Bob now.
- [ ] **Next** (15 min) Guess where Adam goes.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is threatening Bob justified? Legally, no. Morally, Adam is desperate and Bob's actions led to deaths. The novel lets us feel the pull while showing the cost.

- [ ] **Gun to Bob** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Bob's hiring of CBW.
- [ ] **Bob** (35 min) Write 300 words on Bob's guilt.
- [ ] **Lying to Johanna** (15 min) Was Adam right?
- [ ] **Despair** (15 min) How should friends help Bob?
- [ ] **Court** (15 min) Update the money case.
- [ ] **Tripp** (15 min) Begin a Tripp file.
- [ ] **Revenge** (15 min) Where is Adam heading morally?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about a phrase you'd recognise.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

Massive clues: Bob hired CBW; Tripp manipulated Bob; the text's wording points away from Corinne. Re-pin the text from chapter 12 and look at the words.

- [ ] **CBW** (15 min) Pin Bob as the client.
- [ ] **Kids/boys** (15 min) Pin the word clue.
- [ ] **Tripp** (15 min) Pin Tripp's lie to Bob.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word realisation.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Rate Tripp.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Mark the turn.
- [ ] **Re-read** (15 min) Re-read chapter 12's text.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A church gym car park at dusk, one man pinning another against a car, a minivan in a driveway, a phone with no battery: paint the evening grey, then the car park lit by a single lamp.

- [ ] **Car park** (35 min) Paint the confrontation.
- [ ] **Minivan** (25 min) Paint the minivan at dusk.
- [ ] **Text bubble** (15 min) Design the text with one word circled.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick a song for the realisation.
- [ ] **Dead phone** (15 min) Draw a phone with no battery.
- [ ] **Email** (15 min) Design the not-until-morning email.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a church car park.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the circled word.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

No food, but the minivan smells of Corinne: scent as memory. Think about how a family's smells live in cars, coats and kitchens long after someone has gone.

- [ ] **Scent** (15 min) Discuss scent and memory.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record CBW.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Bob's confession.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: what phrase is uniquely yours?
- [ ] **Making: phrasebook** (20 min) Write a family phrasebook.
- [ ] **Madeleines** (45 min) Bake madeleines and discuss memory.
- [ ] **Recipe of a slip** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Coffee** (15 min) Make coffee.
- [ ] **Simple dinner** (30 min) Cook a simple family dinner.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Corinne always said the boys, never the kids. Write privately about a phrase someone you love always uses, and how you would know immediately if someone else were faking it.

- [ ] **A phrase** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Despair** (20 min) Write about a friend in despair.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What does Adam do?
- [ ] **Letter to Bob** (15 min) Write to Bob.
- [ ] **Letter to Johanna** (15 min) Write the email.
- [ ] **Scent** (15 min) Write about a scent of someone.
- [ ] **Revenge** (15 min) Write about wanting revenge.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Kids, the Boys

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse the clue.
- [ ] Re-pin chapter 12.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Bob

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss despair.
- [ ] Apply lenses.
- [ ] Write to Bob.
- [ ] Reflect.

Forensic Linguistics

Rooms: Records Room, Library Stacks, Room 233

- [ ] Research the Unabomber case.
- [ ] Read about Christie.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Present.

Preparation

Rooms: Law Office, Turnpike, Incident Board

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Map.
- [ ] Pin.
- [ ] Predict.

Scent and Memory

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Bake madeleines.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Read about Proust.
- [ ] Share.

Gun to the Neck

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Diner

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Verdict.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 54 use a single word to transform the mystery?
2. Essay: Analyse Bob Baime's confession and despair.
3. Creative: Write Adam's email to Gribbel.

Further reading

- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). Words that betray.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). A man's worth and despair.
- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). Suburban collapse.
- *Caught*, Harlan Coben (2010). Suburban ruin.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). Verbal clues.
- *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman (1985). Detecting lies.

- *Lying*, Sam Harris (2011). Truth and language.
- *Bowling Alone*, Robert D. Putnam (2000). Community and its cracks.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben's textual clues.

55. Mahlon Dickerson

What happens

Adam goes back to Tripp's office, a single shabby room with peeling wallpaper. He lays it out: Tripp stole the money. Tripp asked Corinne for more time, not the other way round; he set her up and told Bob she would blame him. Corinne thought Tripp had sent the stranger as a warning, and called him that morning to say she had had enough. Adam asks if she's dead. Tripp says Adam can't prove anything. Adam pulls the gun. Becky is due to arrive; Adam threatens an eye for an eye, and Tripp's mask slips: Adam wouldn't hurt her. To keep Becky away, Tripp agrees to show him the truth. Becky arrives cheerfully; Tripp lies smoothly about registering for a sixth-grade tournament and dinner at Baumgart's. Becky's smile falters. She asks them to give her best to Corinne.

They drive Route 3 to I-80, Route 15 and Weldon Road, then a dirt track into the Mahlon Dickerson Reservation near Lake Hopatcong, where Corinne's family once had a house and where Becky went with her in third grade; that is why Tripp chose it. Tripp warns Adam never to threaten his family. On the way he tells the truth about himself: he was laid off from Madison Avenue after five minutes; the family store's collapse left him broke. A donor, Sydney Gallonde, gave $100,000 for turf fields because Tripp worked on him. Tripp has an us-against-them philosophy: your kid's cleats matter more than a starving stranger's child. He confesses: he took the money meaning to repay it. Corinne found out; he begged; with his bookkeeping background he altered the books to point at her. He told Bob, Cal and Len; when Bob didn't believe it, he told Bob that Corinne would blame him. After Adam's confrontation, Corinne was furious and was going to tell. Tripp persuaded her to meet him at lunchtime at the Price house. She met him in the garage, refusing to let him in. He shot her.

Adam makes Tripp dig, with a shovel hidden there. They find Corinne's body. Tripp explains the frame he built: signs of a fight, blood traces in the garage cleaned with cleaner from under the sink, rags in the Prices' rubbish, the body in her own boot, Adam's shovel, office cameras showing Adam forcing Tripp out at gunpoint, the car left at an airport hotel to avoid airport cameras, the text sent from her phone, the phone tossed into a delivery truck bound for Pittsburgh. Détente, he proposes. Then Adam sees her earlobes are bare: Tripp stole her diamond studs. Tripp warns him again about going near his family. Adam shoots him three times in the chest.

Scene by scene

1. Tripp's shabby office; Adam lays out the theft and the frame.
2. Corinne thought Tripp sent the stranger; she'd had enough.
3. Is she dead? You can't prove it. The gun.
4. Becky is coming; Adam's threat; Tripp's mask slips.
5. Becky arrives; Tripp lies smoothly; her smile falters.
6. The drive to Mahlon Dickerson Reservation near Lake Hopatcong.
7. Why this place: Corinne's family house; Becky's childhood trip.
8. Tripp's truth: laid off, broke, the turf-field donor.
9. His us-against-them philosophy.
10. Confession: the theft, the altered books, Bob, Cal, Len.
11. Corinne in the garage; he shot her.

12. Adam makes Tripp dig; Corinne's body.
13. Tripp's frame of Adam, piece by piece.
14. Détente. Her earlobes are bare: the studs.
15. Another warning about his family. Adam shoots him three times.

Who's here

Adam Price	Grieving, armed, final.
Tripp Evans	Thief, killer, framer.
Becky Evans	Tripp's wife, unaware.
Corinne Price	Found.

Thirty questions

1. What does Adam accuse Tripp of?
2. Why did Corinne call Tripp that morning?
3. How does Adam force the truth?
4. What happens when Becky arrives?
5. Why did Tripp choose Mahlon Dickerson?
6. What is Tripp's philosophy?
7. How did Tripp frame Corinne?
8. How did he kill her?
9. How did he frame Adam?
10. What makes Adam shoot?
11. **Is Adam's act justice or revenge?** [book club]
12. **How does the novel use Tripp's ordinariness?** [book club]
13. **How does the us-against-them philosophy explain the whole novel?** [book club]
14. **Why do the earrings matter?** [book club]
15. Why does Becky's smile falter?
16. How does the chapter recast chapter 32?
17. What does Tripp's threat about family reveal?
18. **How does the frame-up mirror the novel's theme of appearances?** [book club]
19. Was Corinne innocent all along?
20. How does the chapter treat class?
21. What does the turf-field donation suggest?
22. **How does the novel treat Corinne's death?** [book club]
23. Why does Tripp explain his frame?
24. What does détente mean here?
25. Is Tripp a monster or a man?
26. How does Adam feel at the grave?
27. What does this chapter say about community?
28. Did Tripp want to die?
29. What would you have done?
30. Predict the aftermath.

Close reading

1. Masks

Find it: Chapter 55, opening: the office and Becky.

1. Note Adam's case.
2. Note Tripp's denial.
3. Note the threat.
4. Note Becky's faltering smile.

How does the chapter show Tripp's mask slipping?

2. Us against them

Find it: Chapter 55, middle: the drive and the confession.

1. Trace the route.
2. Note why the place.
3. Paraphrase his philosophy.
4. Summarise the confession.

How does Tripp justify himself?

3. The final detail

Find it: Chapter 55, close: the grave.

1. Note the digging.
2. List the frame elements.
3. Note the earrings.
4. Note the shots.

Why do the earrings, not the confession, trigger Adam?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

The novel's great unmasking. Structured as confrontation, journey, confession and grave, the chapter lets the villain explain himself at length, then turns on a tiny physical detail. The ending is abrupt, violent and morally unresolved.

- ☐ **Unmasking** (20 min) Analyse the structure.
- ☐ **Monologue** (20 min) Analyse Tripp's explanation.
- ☐ **Detail** (15 min) Analyse the earrings.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite from Becky's POV.
- ☐ **Confession scene** (35 min) Write a 300-word villain confession.
- ☐ **Masks** (15 min) Analyse Tripp's slip.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 32.
- ☐ **Ending** (15 min) Analyse the shots.
- ☐ **Frame** (15 min) List frame elements.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

Us-against-them morality, the ordinary villain, the frame-up, and revenge. Tripp embodies the dark side of protecting your own: the novel's question of how far you would go, answered monstrously.

- ☐ **Us vs them** (25 min) Discuss Tripp's philosophy.
- ☐ **Ordinary villain** (25 min) Discuss.
- ☐ **Frame-ups** (20 min) Discuss appearances.
- ☐ **Revenge** (25 min) Discuss Adam's act.

- [ ] **Corinne** (20 min) Discuss her innocence.
- [ ] **Theme update** (15 min) Add "how far".
- [ ] **Community** (15 min) Discuss the community that enabled Tripp.
- [ ] **Class** (15 min) Discuss Tripp's fall.
- [ ] **Seminar plan** (25 min) Plan a discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Mahlon Dickerson Reservation is a Morris County park near Lake Hopatcong, New Jersey's largest lake. Youth-sports embezzlement is a recurring real crime. Lex talionis appears in the Code of Hammurabi and the Hebrew Bible.

- [ ] **Mahlon Dickerson** (15 min) Research the reservation.
- [ ] **Lake Hopatcong** (15 min) Research the lake.
- [ ] **Youth-sport fraud** (20 min) Research real cases.
- [ ] **Frame-ups** (20 min) Research forensic evidence planting.
- [ ] **Lex talionis** (15 min) Research Hammurabi.
- [ ] **Murder law** (20 min) Research NJ homicide degrees.
- [ ] **Turf donations** (15 min) Research turf-field fundraising.
- [ ] **Earrings** (15 min) Research diamond studs.
- [ ] **Bookkeeping** (15 min) Research altering books.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

Shakespeare's Hamlet and the revenge-tragedy tradition; Dostoevsky's question of whether some people may cross moral lines for their own. Tripp's us-against-them creed echoes Raskolnikov turned suburban.

- [ ] **Hamlet** (20 min) Compare revenge.
- [ ] **Crime and Punishment** (20 min) Compare Raskolnikov.
- [ ] **Gone Girl** (20 min) Compare frame-ups.
- [ ] **All My Sons** (20 min) Compare a man who protects his own.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare revenge.
- [ ] **Strangers on a Train** (20 min) Compare murder logic.
- [ ] **Sandel** (20 min) Read on loyalty.
- [ ] **Source list** (15 min) Add two works.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain elegy.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

Tripp's Meadowlands office, Route 3, I-80, Route 15, Weldon Road, then a dirt track into Mahlon Dickerson near Lake Hopatcong: Corinne's childhood landscape becomes her grave.

- [ ] **Route** (20 min) Map the drive.
- [ ] **Reservation** (15 min) Pin Mahlon Dickerson.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (15 min) Add chapter 55.
- [ ] **Lake Hopatcong** (15 min) Pin Corinne's childhood house.

- [ ] **Garage** (15 min) Pin the Price garage.
- [ ] **Pittsburgh truck** (15 min) Trace the phone.
- [ ] **Airport hotel** (15 min) Pin the car.
- [ ] **Case map** (20 min) Complete the frame map.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Place Tripp finally.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Justice, revenge or murder? Legally, murder; emotionally, revenge; the novel leaves Adam's act unresolved. Each ethical lens gives a different verdict.

- [ ] **Shooting** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Adam's act.
- [ ] **Revenge** (35 min) Write 300 words.
- [ ] **Tripp** (15 min) Rate his guilt.
- [ ] **Corinne** (15 min) Rate her guilt now.
- [ ] **Court** (20 min) Write the charges Tripp would face.
- [ ] **Becky** (15 min) What does Becky deserve?
- [ ] **Us vs them** (15 min) Is protecting your own ever wrong?
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about forgiveness.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

All answers: Tripp stole, framed, killed and buried Corinne, then framed Adam. Pin the whole frame-up, and the earrings that broke Adam.

- [ ] **Solution** (20 min) Pin the solution.
- [ ] **Frame** (20 min) Pin every frame element.
- [ ] **Earrings** (15 min) Pin the studs.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word grave scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Final ratings.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (15 min) Tie off strands.
- [ ] **Clues** (20 min) Review planted clues.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Add to chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A woodland clearing at night, a shovel, a man with a gun, another digging, a lake glimpsed through trees: paint it with headlights and deep dark.

- [ ] **Clearing** (40 min) Paint the grave scene.
- [ ] **Earrings** (15 min) Draw diamond studs.
- [ ] **Office** (25 min) Paint Tripp's shabby office.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Use the Chapter palette tool.

- [ ] **Soundtrack** (15 min) Pick an elegy.
- [ ] **Becky** (15 min) Draw Becky's faltering smile.
- [ ] **Shovel** (15 min) Draw the shovel.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe digging at night.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (15 min) Add the clearing.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Tripp lies to Becky about a dinner at a family restaurant. Ordinary plans become cover stories. The chapter's only food is a lie told to a wife.

- [ ] **Cover story** (15 min) Discuss food as cover story.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Record the true ledger.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add Tripp's confession.
- [ ] **Table talk** (25 min) Ask: justice or revenge?
- [ ] **Making: memorial meal** (45 min) Cook a dish in Corinne's memory.
- [ ] **Tea** (15 min) Make tea for grief.
- [ ] **Recipe of a frame** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Bread** (60 min) Bake bread for mourners.
- [ ] **Water** (15 min) Pour water.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Adam shoots Tripp. Write privately about whether you could forgive such an act, and whether you think Adam should be punished for it.

- [ ] **Forgiveness** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Grief** (20 min) Write about Corinne.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Rate.
- [ ] **Prediction** (15 min) What happens to Adam?
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write as Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Becky** (15 min) Write.
- [ ] **How far** (15 min) Write how far you would go.
- [ ] **Revenge** (15 min) Write about revenge.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Log this session.

Cross-room projects

The Unmasking

Rooms: Law Office, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Pin the solution.
- [ ] Write privately.
- [ ] Discuss.

Justice or Revenge

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Library Stacks

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Debate.
- [ ] Read about Hamlet.
- [ ] Verdict.

The Frame

Rooms: Incident Board, Turnpike, Records Room

- [ ] Pin elements.
- [ ] Map them.
- [ ] Research frame-ups.
- [ ] Present.

Us Against Them

Rooms: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Driveway

- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Apply lenses.
- [ ] Write.
- [ ] Reflect.

Corinne Remembered

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Cook a memorial dish.
- [ ] Paint.
- [ ] Write a letter.
- [ ] Reflect.

Clue Review

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Room 233

- [ ] Review planted clues.
- [ ] Analyse fair play.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Score Coben.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does chapter 55 resolve the mystery, and what does Tripp's philosophy reveal about the novel's themes?
2. Essay: Is Adam's shooting of Tripp justice, revenge or murder? Argue with reference to the text.
3. Creative: Write Becky's evening after the office visit.

Further reading

- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). Crossing moral lines.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). Frame-ups and appearances.
- *All My Sons*, Arthur Miller (1947). Protecting your own at others' cost.
- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Revenge and its costs.
- *Strangers on a Train*, Patricia Highsmith (1950). Murder's logic.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Loyalty and justice.
- *Death of a Salesman*, Arthur Miller (1949). Failure and pride.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben's revelations.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). The unmasked killer.

56. Six Months Later

What happens

Six months later, the lacrosse season plays out under an inflated indoor dome. Thomas wears number eleven. Ryan watches his father as though he might vanish; Adam has learned that happiness built on untruths doesn't last. Johanna arrives. A coach from Bowdoin wants Thomas, a six-hour drive away, but Thomas wants to stay close. The Prices are staying in town: the boys' school, their friends, and their mother, as Adam puts it, in that house. Kuntz is sentenced tomorrow, and will get life. Adam was officially cleared last week. Chris Taylor is still on the run and would probably only get probation. Adam stands alone on the sideline: the dream is flimsy, a reminder.

Adam traces the ripples. Whom to blame: the stranger, Corinne, himself? There is only one person truly to blame, Tripp, and he is dead. Then the flashback: Johanna had followed Adam that night. After the shots, she put Adam's gun in Tripp's hand and fired three shots with his finger to leave residue, and scratched Adam with Tripp's hand for DNA under the nails. The story became self-defence; her testimony that she overheard the confession sealed it. There was no indictment.

Adam is haunted, yet feels a primitive satisfaction. Does he sleep okay? No, not really; but better than he would in prison. He wonders whether Tripp wanted to die: there was a death benefit, and the town rallied round Becky. Johanna notes the irony: the group set out to abolish secrets, and the two of them now guard the largest one of all. With thirty seconds left, Thomas scores the tiebreaker. Adam smiles; Ryan smiles. Johanna says Adam doesn't have to believe Corinne sees her boys smile, only that she would want to.

Scene by scene

1. Six months on: an inflatable indoor dome; Thomas, number eleven.
2. Ryan watches Adam as if he might vanish.
3. Happiness built on untruths is fleeting.
4. Johanna arrives; Bowdoin wants Thomas; he wants to stay close.
5. The family stays in town.
6. Kuntz sentenced tomorrow; Adam exonerated; Chris at large.
7. Adam alone on the sideline; the flimsy dream.
8. Who to blame? Only Tripp.
9. Flashback: Johanna staged self-defence.
10. No indictment.
11. Haunted, satisfied, sleeping badly.
12. Did Tripp want to die? The death benefit; the town and Becky.
13. Johanna: they now keep the biggest secret.
14. Thomas scores the tiebreaker; Adam and Ryan smile.
15. Johanna: believe only that Corinne would want to see them smile.

Who's here

Adam Price	Survivor and secret-keeper.
Johanna Griffin	Friend and co-conspirator.
Thomas Price	Scorer.

Ryan Price Watchful.

Thirty questions

1. Where does the final game take place?
2. What college wants Thomas, and what does he decide?
3. Why are the Prices staying in town?
4. What happens to Kuntz and Chris?
5. What did Johanna do after the shooting?
6. How does the chapter end?
7. **Is Johanna's cover-up justified?** [book club]
8. **How does the ending answer the novel's question about secrets?** [book club]
9. Whom does Adam blame?
10. **Did Tripp want to die?** [book club]
11. What does Ryan's watching mean?
12. **How does the indoor dome echo the novel's dream motif?** [book club]
13. What does Corinne in that house mean?
14. Why does Thomas want to stay close?
15. **How does the novel treat justice at the end?** [book club]
16. **Is the ending happy?** [book club]
17. What does Johanna's final line offer?
18. How have Adam and the boys changed?
19. What does Chris's freedom mean?
20. How does the town treat Becky?
21. What do Adam's sleepless nights mean?
22. How does the chapter treat irony?
23. What does the tiebreaker symbolise?
24. Is Johanna a hero?
25. How does the novel close its strands?
26. What remains unresolved?
27. How does the ending reflect on chapter 1?
28. What do you think of the ending?
29. Would you have kept the secret?
30. What will Adam's life be now?

Close reading

1. After

Find it: Chapter 56, opening: the dome.

1. Describe the dome.
2. Note Ryan's watching.
3. Note the untruths line (paraphrased).
4. Note Bowdoin.

How does the opening show a family changed?

2. The secret

Find it: Chapter 56, middle: the flashback.

1. Note Johanna following.
2. List what she staged.
3. Note the testimony.
4. Note the result.

How does the novel turn its heroes into secret-keepers?

3. Smiles

Find it: Chapter 56, close: the goal.

1. Note Johanna's observation about secrets.
2. Note the goal.
3. Note the smiles.
4. Paraphrase Johanna's last words.

What kind of consolation does the novel offer?

Activities by room

Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

An epilogue that loops back to sport and family, then delivers a final twist in flashback. The structure (present, ripples, flashback, present) lets the last image be a goal and two smiles, framed by a secret.

- ☐ **Epilogue form** (20 min) Analyse the structure.
- ☐ **Flashback twist** (15 min) Analyse the twist.
- ☐ **Final image** (15 min) Analyse the smiles.
- ☐ **Point of view** (30 min) Rewrite the flashback from Johanna's POV.
- ☐ **Epilogue** (35 min) Write your own epilogue.
- ☐ **Loose thread** (15 min) Analyse Chris's freedom.
- ☐ **Pacing** (15 min) Compare with chapter 1.
- ☐ **Dome** (15 min) Analyse the dome.
- ☐ **Last line** (15 min) Analyse Johanna's last line.

Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

The final irony: the group wanted to end secrets, and the heroes now keep the biggest one. The novel ends not with a verdict but with a question about how to live after the truth.

- ☐ **Final irony** (25 min) Discuss the biggest secret.
- ☐ **Justice** (25 min) Discuss the ending's justice.
- ☐ **Happiness** (20 min) Discuss untruths and happiness.
- ☐ **Grief** (20 min) Discuss the boys' grief.
- ☐ **Johanna** (20 min) Discuss her choice.
- ☐ **Theme update** (20 min) Complete your theme list.
- ☐ **Community** (15 min) Discuss Becky and the town.
- ☐ **Unresolved** (15 min) Discuss what remains open.
- ☐ **Seminar plan** (30 min) Plan a final discussion.

Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

Bowdoin is a liberal-arts college in Maine. Gunshot residue and DNA under fingernails are standard forensic evidence. Self-defence standards vary by state. Air-supported domes allow year-round play.

- [ ] **Bowdoin** (15 min) Research Bowdoin lacrosse.
- [ ] **GSR** (20 min) Research gunshot residue.
- [ ] **Fingernail DNA** (15 min) Research DNA evidence.
- [ ] **Self-defence** (20 min) Research NJ self-defence law.
- [ ] **Sentencing** (15 min) Research life sentences.
- [ ] **Domes** (15 min) Research sports domes.
- [ ] **Recruiting** (15 min) Research college recruiting.
- [ ] **Death benefits** (15 min) Research life insurance and death.
- [ ] **Fugitives** (15 min) Research how fugitives are caught.

Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

The final twist of a detective covering for a killer recalls Agatha Christie's Murder on the Orient Express, where Poirot offers a false solution. Mystic River ends with secrets kept in a community. Tell No One also ends with justice bent.

- [ ] **Orient Express** (20 min) Read about Christie's ending.
- [ ] **Mystic River** (20 min) Compare secrets kept.
- [ ] **Tell No One** (20 min) Compare Coben's endings.
- [ ] **Crime and Punishment** (20 min) Compare guilt.
- [ ] **Hamlet** (20 min) Compare revenge's aftermath.
- [ ] **Didion** (20 min) Read on grief.
- [ ] **Bok** (20 min) Read on secrets.
- [ ] **Source list** (20 min) Finalise your list.
- [ ] **Poems** (15 min) Find a public-domain elegy.

The Turnpike: Setting & geography

An indoor dome in Cedarfield, Bowdoin six hours north in Maine, the Price house, and somewhere a fugitive: the map shrinks back to home, with one thread still loose on it.

- [ ] **Dome** (15 min) Pin the dome.
- [ ] **Bowdoin** (15 min) Pin Maine.
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (25 min) Complete your journal.
- [ ] **Home** (15 min) Mark the Price house.
- [ ] **Fugitive** (15 min) Mark Chris unknown.
- [ ] **Case map** (20 min) Finalise the case map.
- [ ] **Network** (20 min) Complete the network.
- [ ] **Status** (15 min) Final status ladder.
- [ ] **Whole map** (25 min) Review the whole map.

The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

Is the secret justified? Consequentialism weighs the boys' future; deontology condemns the lie. Johanna's choice is the novel's final dilemma, and it is left to us.

- [ ] **The secret** (15 min) Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] **Five lenses** (30 min) Apply the lenses to Johanna's cover-up.
- [ ] **Verdict** (45 min) Write 500 words: justified?
- [ ] **Adam** (15 min) Should Adam be punished?
- [ ] **Chris** (15 min) What should happen to Chris?
- [ ] **Court** (25 min) Close every file.
- [ ] **Becky** (15 min) What does the town owe Becky?
- [ ] **How far** (20 min) Answer the novel's question.
- [ ] **Personal** (20 min) Write about what the lost would want.

The Incident Board: Writing craft

All strands closed except Chris Taylor. The final revelation (the staged self-defence) is the last secret. Pin it as the novel's ultimate twist.

- [ ] **Final twist** (15 min) Pin the staged self-defence.
- [ ] **Loose thread** (15 min) Pin Chris.
- [ ] **Scene** (40 min) Write a 300-word epilogue scene.
- [ ] **Suspicion meter** (15 min) Final ratings.
- [ ] **Strand braid** (20 min) Close all strands.
- [ ] **Fair play** (20 min) Score the novel's fairness.
- [ ] **Tension curve** (20 min) Complete the curve.
- [ ] **Chapter architecture** (20 min) Final architecture.
- [ ] **Pacing** (15 min) Complete the chart.

The All-Night Diner: Art & music

A white inflated dome glowing at night, a boy scoring, a father and a younger son smiling, a woman beside them: paint warm light inside a fragile shell.

- [ ] **Dome** (35 min) Paint the glowing dome.
- [ ] **Smiles** (25 min) Paint the two smiles.
- [ ] **Number eleven** (15 min) Design Thomas's jersey.
- [ ] **Palette** (15 min) Final palette.
- [ ] **Soundtrack** (20 min) Finish your soundtrack.
- [ ] **Cover** (30 min) Design the companion cover.
- [ ] **Six months** (15 min) Paint a calendar.
- [ ] **Sound** (15 min) Describe a winning goal.
- [ ] **Cover brief** (20 min) Complete the brief.

The Price Kitchen: Food & making

Sideline snacks at an indoor game: normal life returning. Make the snacks you would bring to a game, and toast the boys. Food at the end signals that ordinary days have returned, however altered.

- [ ] **Sideline snacks** (30 min) Make game-day snacks.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (15 min) Close the ledger.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Add the final secret.
- [ ] **Table talk** (30 min) Ask: would you keep it?
- [ ] **Making: commonplace book** (45 min) Compile your commonplace book.
- [ ] **Celebration dinner** (60 min) Cook a celebration dinner.
- [ ] **Recipe of an ending** (15 min) Write a recipe.
- [ ] **Toast** (15 min) Raise a toast to the boys.
- [ ] **Cake** (60 min) Bake a team cake.

The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

Johanna tells Adam he needn't believe Corinne sees her sons smile, only that she would want to. Write privately about what you hope someone you have lost would want for you.

- [ ] **What they'd want** (20 min) Write about it.
- [ ] **Secrets** (20 min) Write about a secret you keep.
- [ ] **Mood dial** (15 min) Final mood.
- [ ] **Retrospective** (25 min) Write how your predictions fared.
- [ ] **Letter to Adam** (15 min) Write to Adam.
- [ ] **Letter to Corinne** (15 min) Write as the boys.
- [ ] **Sleep** (15 min) Write about sleeping badly.
- [ ] **Smiles** (15 min) Write about a smile that healed.
- [ ] **Reading log** (15 min) Close your log.

Cross-room projects

The Biggest Secret

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Use the Dilemma scale.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write 500 words.
- [ ] Verdict.

Epilogue

Rooms: Law Office, Diner, Driveway

- [ ] Analyse.
- [ ] Paint the dome.
- [ ] Write your epilogue.
- [ ] Share.

Closing the Files

Rooms: Incident Board, Lacrosse Field, Turnpike

- [ ] Close strands.
- [ ] Close court files.
- [ ] Finalise the map.
- [ ] Present.

Commonplace Book

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Driveway, Library Stacks

- [ ] Compile.
- [ ] Write a reflection.
- [ ] Finalise sources.
- [ ] Export.

Fair Play

Rooms: Incident Board, Law Office, Room 233

- [ ] Review clues.
- [ ] Score fairness.
- [ ] Discuss.
- [ ] Write a review.

Game Day

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Room 233

- [ ] Make snacks.
- [ ] Design a jersey.
- [ ] Discuss sport and grief.
- [ ] Celebrate.

Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: How does the final chapter resolve, and complicate, the novel's treatment of secrets?
2. Essay: Is Johanna's cover-up justified? Argue using at least two ethical frameworks.
3. Creative: Write a scene one year later.

Further reading

- *Mystic River*, Dennis Lehane (2001). Secrets kept in a community.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Justice bent for love.
- *Crime and Punishment*, Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). Guilt after killing.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). Secrets and their uses.
- *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, Agatha Christie (1926). Endings that reframe.
- *Justice: What's the Right Thing to Do?*, Michael J. Sandel (2009). Justice and loyalty.

- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). Spouses and survival.
- *The Sportswriter*, Richard Ford (1986). Sport and grief.
- *The Rock (choruses)*, T. S. Eliot (1934). The epigraph's source, for your own reading.

Your pages

Commonplace pages

For your own notes, in your own words.

Notes

Notes

Notes

Notes

Notes